

伪像报告

须尾俱全



虚伪聚钱®

伪像报告

Contents

- Chapter 1 — Mai Minghe: I Want to Pick More Daisies
- Chapter 2: Mai Minghe Rescued from Hallucination?
- Chapter 3: The Sweet Illusion in Mai Minghe's Hospital Ward
- Chapter 4: Mai Minghe Seizes a Second Life
- Chapter 5 — Sydney Ginn, the Hunter Plagued by a Stalker
- Chapter 6: Sydney Ginn's Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion
- Chapter 7 – Sydney Ginn: The Hunter's Life Is No Easy Living
- Chapter 8: Sydney Ginn's Blackmoor City Transportation and Tourism Map
- Chapter 9 — Goodbye, Sydney Ginn
- Chapter 10: A Gathering of Heroes at Mai Minghe
- Chapter 11: Mai Minghe's Rock-Paper-Scissors
- Chapter 12: Mai Minghe's Comedy Horror
- Chapter 13 — Mai Minghe: The Way Things Tend to Go
- Chapter 14 — Chase, Where the Sea Meets the Sky
- Chapter 15: Chase, Hunter Among Men
- Chapter 16 — Chase and the Artifact Submerged in the Metropolis
- Chapter 17 — Chase: The Hunted Hunter
- Chapter 18: Mai Minghe's Fourth Person
- Chapter 19: Mai Minghe's Reproductive Unit
- Chapter 20 — Mai Minghe and the Jonah Who Begged for Help

Chapter 21 — How Can You Tell If I'm Making Excuses?

Chapter 22: Sydney Ginn, After Life and Death

Chapter 23 – Sydney Ginn: If the Mountain Won't Come to You

Chapter 24 — Sydney Ginn's Altered History

Chapter 25 — Sydney Ginn, Latest Version, Present Day

Chapter 26 — Sydney Ginn's Choice at the Crossroads

Chapter 27: What?! I've been an ungrateful wreck since April 23rd?

Chapter 28 — Hello everyone, your Southern Airlines Ambassador here

Chapter 29: The Attack Pattern of the Sydney Ginn Resident

Chapter 30: The Way Sydney Ginn Fights Back, and Establishing True Identity

Chapter 31: All Those Chapters Before Sydney Ginn Are Gone

Chapter 32: Chase's Underground Pursuit

Chapter 33: The Form of Chase's Artifact

Chapter 34: Chase's Logical Story

Chapter 35 — Folks, Grandmas, I'm Home

Chapter 36 — Chase Searches for the Passage Artifact

Chapter 37: The Thing Chase Hates Most

Chapter 38: Chase's Second Memory

Chapter 39 — The First Resident Chase Ever Saw

Chapter 40: Chase Is Very, Very, Very Simple

Chapter 41: Chase, Did You Think the Rumor Had Stopped Spreading?

Chapter 42: The Root of the Chase-Sydney Enigma

Chapter 43: Sydney Ginn's Original Plan for the Artifact

Chapter 44: Sydney Ginn Buys Things and Of Course She Pays for Them

Chapter 45: Sydney Ginn Pays Taxes and Launderers Money

Chapter 46: Sydney Ginn's Grape Soda

Chapter 47: The Strange Detail Sydney Ginn Had Overlooked

Chapter 48 — It's on the shelves, and here I am perched on them with a few words to say

Chapter 49: The Secret Behind a Qidian Author's Fake Gathering-Money-and-Being-Unfilial Act for Over a Month

Chapter 50 — Some Q&A on the World-Building Behind the Artifact Reports

Chapter 51: Mai Minghe Has No Home to Return To

Chapter 52: Mai Minghe Cannot Be Found by the Morgan House Faction

Chapter 53: Mai Minghe Between a Rock and a Hard Place

Chapter 54: The Correct Response of a Vagrant Named Mai Minghe

Chapter 55: Mai Minghe and Taylor Ford's Interrogation

Chapter 56 — Taylor Ford and the Morgan House Faction Contract

Chapter 57: What Taylor Ford and Wellesley Know

Chapter 58: Taylor Ford Isn't the Only One Lying in Wait

Chapter 59 — Taylor Ford's Stakeout for Two

Chapter 60: Taylor Ford, This Matter, and Its Connection to Key House Faction

Chapter 1 — Mai Minghe: I Want to Pick More Daisies

When Mai Minghe woke, the room was dim and dark, and the light seeping in beneath the curtains was still the light of night.

She was a light sleeper, waking several times each night, but tonight the reason was different. A small, hard sound had pulled her from sleep, rising out of the steady "whooo—whooo" of the background noise that filled the room.

What was making that noise?

She was groggy with sleep, her mind slow to catch up.

The metallic scraping and clinking went on, until finally there came a sharp snap—the lock tumbled—and the door was pushed open with a long, creaking "squeeeak." The hinges had gone years without oiling; stiff and dry as an old person's joints, they sliced a sharp wound through the silent night.

Oh. Someone had broken in.

If her mother ever found out, there was no telling what kind of scolding was in store—a young woman living alone, and she couldn't even think to prop a chair against the door at night?

Her mother had always been uneasy about the world: checking the gas four or five times before leaving the house, peering into the back seat before getting into a car, never once letting her return a stranger's nod or smile.

Mai Minghe had always thought her mother was a bit too anxious—but here she was, someone actually breaking through her front door tonight.

The sounds that followed were hard to make out, but vaguely, a figure moved inside. Through the crack under the door, a beam of light swept back and forth—a flashlight.

Unfamiliar footsteps padded softly around the living room, occasionally drawing out a creak, and Mai Minghe knew: that was the wooden floorboard just outside the kitchen. A pipe had burst one year, and the boards there had warped from the soaking, ever since voicing their shrill complaints underfoot.

Having a burglar was actually a rather unusual thing.

She closed her eyes again and listened carefully to the burglar's movements.

He opened the door to the next room first—a very small, narrow room that had never really been used. It had once been painted as a nursery, then briefly served as a study, then been converted into a wardrobe room, yet not one of those purposes had ever truly been fulfilled; now it was simply a dusty storage room piled with clutter.

One glance would be enough to see that the room was heaped with nothing but junk, not worth rifling through—and sure enough, the footsteps retreated almost immediately, and the door was shut with a dull thud.

Honestly, if you searched the whole building, you'd probably struggle to find anything of real value.

Things did go missing often enough in this low-rent apartment building; once, when Mai Minghe hadn't latched her door properly, she came home to find a pair of ankle boots gone from the shoe rack by the entrance—it had infuriated her enough to knock on every neighbor's door, but nothing came of it. Still, lost things were one matter; it was rare for an outside burglar to actually pick a lock and go to all this trouble over people with so little to their name.

How funny—such a trivial thing, and she remembered it so clearly. Those boots had been calfskin, a smooth, polished brown, sharp-looking; she had never managed to find a pair she liked as well after that.

Whatever he wanted to take, let him take it—she didn't have anything worth making a fuss over anyway.

The burglar made his way to the bedroom doorway, pushed the door open, and the flashlight swept in, finding Mai Minghe at once.

The harsh white light pressed through her eyelids and lit up her face, yet she remained perfectly still, keeping her eyes shut, feigning sleep.

An unfamiliar voice let out a surprised "Huh?" as though actually taken aback.

Mai Minghe held herself still and kept quiet.

The burglar's footsteps thumped into the room; he circled around the bedroom, didn't even open the nightstand drawer, and went back out again.

Stealing things so carelessly—what could he possibly hope to find? Mai Minghe almost felt anxious on his behalf. You had to have a little patience in whatever you did, a willingness to see things through properly.

A minute or two passed, and he came back in, stopping at the side of Mai Minghe's bed; the warm, living breath of another person hovered in the air just above her.

"Hey," a man's voice said, and a hand gave Mai Minghe's bony shoulder a nudge. "Hey, wake up."

There didn't seem to be much point pretending to sleep any longer.

Why wake her up? If he was looking for something valuable, couldn't he just look for himself? Not only was he stealing things, he was being lazy about it too—people these days, honestly.

Mai Minghe opened her eyes. A dark silhouette was hunched over her at the bedside, looming above her head.

The flashlight was angled down along the edge of the bed, so the burglar's face was lost in shadow; at the rim of the light, she could just make out a pale throat, the Adam's apple rising and falling with each word.

"Don't be afraid, I just want to ask you something. Is there someone here by the name of Mai Minghe?"

"...That's me. Do we know each other?"

The man drew a breath and straightened up, taking in the shape beneath the covers.

"You—you're her?" He seemed unwilling to believe it, and raised the flashlight to sweep it over Mai Minghe's face several more times, without any ceremony.

She hadn't looked in a mirror for a long time and had no idea what she looked like now—certainly nothing good.

"What is it?" she asked quietly.

The man stood there with his mouth half open, as though still digesting something.

He didn't want her to be Mai Minghe—that much she could see; because he immediately asked again, as if she might not have heard him clearly: "Mai—the 'mai' in wild wheat. Mai—Ming—He."

"It's me," Mai Minghe said with a faint smile. "There's no one else."

The man stared at her.

After a few seconds, he asked: "Old lady, how old are you?"

How old was she? Even Mai Minghe had to stop and think.

She couldn't remember, from some year onward, how old she was—sometimes she even mistook herself for a young girl.

A year per year of age: it didn't sound like much, yet those years were like snowflakes falling thick and countless, each one an infinitesimal moment; without her noticing, they had accumulated into a lifetime.

Scoop up a handful of snow, and you don't know when it fell. A passage of life rises to the surface, and she has forgotten how long ago it came from.

The social worker had said that at her age—eighty-six—Mai Minghe's mind was still fairly clear, unlike some elderly people...

"Eighty-six?" Mai Minghe asked the social worker in her memory. "You must be mistaken. I'm not nearly that old."

The room fell quiet again, and the steady "whooo—whooo" of background noise rose once more.

The burglar seemed to notice it only now. He pointed at the small plastic tube inserted in Mai Minghe's nose and asked, "Is that... are you on oxygen?"

"Hm?" Mai Minghe sometimes forgot. "Oh, yes. It's quite a nuisance."

The burglar let out a sigh. He set the flashlight down on the edge of the bed, its beam casting a circle of light on the opposite wall, splitting the room—cutting out a bright ring of warmth, and leaving the rest to dim, heavy darkness.

"Look at me, I forgot to ask. Would you like some tea?" said Mai Minghe. It had been so long since anyone had visited that she had quite forgotten to be a host. "It's hard for me to get up... there's tea and biscuits in the kitchen, please help yourself."

The burglar shifted uncomfortably, as though he hadn't expected this turn of events.

"No, I'm fine," he said, hesitating a moment before adding: "But... would you like some? I can bring it to you."

Mai Minghe declined and thanked him; host and burglar exchanged polite pleasantries for a little while.

The burglar clasped his hands together and stared at the television in the corner of the room for a long moment before asking it: "Your health isn't good?"

"I'm quite all right—I can still get out of bed and walk on my own."

"...What about meals? Does a son or daughter come to bring you food?"

"I don't have any children," she said with a small smile. "And I don't eat much—anything simple will do... the social worker brings me vegetables and eggs now and then."

"A social worker? Do you have no family in Blackmoor City?"

"I'm used to it," Mai Minghe said. "I never had many relatives or friends to begin with, and they've all died before me. Dear, would you like to watch television?"

The burglar seemed to find the question absurd. He was silent for a moment, then suddenly took out his phone and glanced at it, and walked quickly out of the room.

"Hello?"

So he was taking a call.

"Yes, I've found her... no, I haven't done it yet." The burglar paused here, faltering. "The thing is—did you know she's an old woman? Eighty-six years old. That wasn't in the file."

The reply from the other end was brief, because the burglar spoke again almost immediately.

"Yes," the burglar said, not bothering to lower his voice—perhaps he felt there was no need. "But... does it have to be hers? She's not the only one with a passage. And besides, we don't even know what her passage is like... taking it would be hard on a young person—what about her? What if she can't hold on and dies?"

The person on the phone was very displeased; even Mai Minghe seemed to catch the faint sound of a raised voice.

The burglar bore it in silence for a time, and at last, like a student admitting a mistake, said: "No... I understand. I'm sorry. I'll get it."

Mai Minghe sometimes startled herself at the sight of her own hands.

Thick, wrinkled skin, layer upon layer draped over each bone, blue veins and blood vessels standing out in ridges, almost cold to the touch—nothing like the hands she remembered as her own. They belonged to two different people.

With that hand that seemed not to belong to her, she fumbled beneath the covers for a moment and found the pendant resting on her chest, closing her fingers tightly around it.

This time, the burglar came in and spoke at once: "I'm sorry, old lady. I need to take something from you."

She could just make him out now—he had a bright, regular sort of face, somewhere in his twenties or thirties, still young; if you didn't know, you'd never think him capable of harm.

"What would you like?" Mai Minghe asked. "I don't have much use for things anymore—take them. There's a silver brooch in the drawer..."

"No, I don't want valuables," the burglar interrupted. "I need to take something from your body."

"Is it an organ?" Mai Minghe asked, curious. Her organs hardly seemed worth taking.

"No, no, stop asking. You wouldn't understand even if I explained."

"Then... will I die?" Mai Minghe asked. "You said so just now."

The burglar was caught off guard; he went still for two seconds before saying, "I don't know... possibly."

Mai Minghe quietly studied the cracks in the ceiling for a while.

"If you need to take it, take it," she said softly. "It's just... before you do, could you grant me one wish?"

At some point the burglar had come to stand beside her.

"What wish?"

"I used to work at a library. The pay was very little, but I loved the library—I was happy there... Once, when my shift ended, one of the librarians told me there was an old book they were retiring; it hadn't sold at the clearance price, so they gave it to me to take home and read."

The burglar rested a hand on her pillow.

At his feet was a dark, bulky shape—some kind of machine—that seemed to have been brought in at some point without her noticing; Mai Minghe was only seeing it now.

"I looked, and it was a poetry anthology; I flipped through it idly when I got home," Mai Minghe murmured. "I read a little, put the book down, and later even lost track of where it went. But somehow... these past few years, I keep thinking back to one poem that was in it."

"Which poem?"

"You young people—don't you all have those... smart telephones?"

"Smartphones," the burglar corrected.

If she had a grandchild, she might have been corrected just like this.

"They say you can find anything on them?"

"...More or less."

"Could you look up that poem for me?" Mai Minghe asked. "I want to hear it one more time."

The burglar looked down at her, and something in his expression shifted—a sudden unease. He pulled a tissue from the nightstand box and pressed it into her hand. While Mai Minghe stared at it blankly, not understanding, he said: "All right, stop crying. I'll find it for you. Do you remember the title?"

She was crying?

So even at this age, she could not accept death.

Or perhaps it was that, even at this age, she had not yet had the chance to truly live.

"It's called... something with Daisy in the title." Mai Minghe deliberately left out half the title.

Smartphones held a great deal, but searching for a poem was no easy matter—and daisy was such a common image in poetry—so it took a good while, as she expected.

After finding several poems that weren't right one after another, the burglar finally lost patience: "Old lady, if you don't remember the name, that's not my fault. I still have to get back and hand in the job—you—"

"I've remembered," Mai Minghe said quickly.

This young man who had come to take something from her—he was likely the last person in her life who could let her hear a poem one more time.

Even if she could no longer put it off—even if she had to face death—it would still be a good thing to hear a little more poetry first.

"I Shall Pick More Daisies'... I think that's what it's called."

The young man glanced at her, said nothing, and tapped his fingers across the screen a few times.

This time, he quickly found the poem that Mai Minghe had kept returning to.

"I found a read-aloud video for you," he said, setting the phone on the edge of the bed.

In the quiet room thick with the smell of medicine and decay, the advertisement before the video burst cheerfully to life, announcing a deal at Little Caesars Pizza.

"The ad's almost done—you just listen. You listen while I work."

He bent down and pulled a tube from the dark, squat machine.

...If I had my life to live over,

I would try to make more mistakes.

I would relax.

I would be more limber.

I would be sillier than I have been this trip.

Mai Minghe felt the side of her face grow damp.

She had spent her whole life in anxious calculation, just as her parents had. During wartime inflation, she painstakingly rationed every meal; in peacetime, she kept a household ledger every week. When she was a child, her family ran a small shop, and no matter how desperately she wanted to, she never once dared to steal a single candy from the shelves.

As she grew older she came to many crossroads thick with wildflowers, but she never set foot in them.

People are strange—everyone knows they only have this one life, yet every single day is lived as though there is infinite time left, as though it can all be done again.

The thief lifted the blanket and pressed a cool tube against Mai Minghe's chest, and she dimly realized that the thing looked rather like an old-fashioned vacuum cleaner.

"What's this?" The thief picked up the pendant at her chest, glanced at it, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to answer, pushed it aside from the mouth of the tube. Young people generally didn't recognize it—had no idea what the thing was for.

Lucky for her that he didn't.

Amid the poem, he pressed the mouth of the tube against Mai Minghe's bony chest. He switched on the machine, and a low hum unlike anything she had ever heard slowly spiraled through the room.

...If I had my life to live over, I would travel lighter than I have. I would start barefoot earlier in the spring and stay that way later in the fall.

If I had my life to live over, I would go barefoot through the long springs and autumns.

I would play hooky more.

I wouldn't make such good grades, except by accident.

I would ride on more merry-go-rounds.

I would pick more daisies.

In the final instant that the darkness of death closed over Mai Minghe, she faintly heard the front door of the apartment burst open, and hurried footsteps and voices came rushing in together.

Carried to term for years, and at last delivered a homely child...

"I Shall Pick More Daisies" is a real poem. The poet wrote it when she was eighty-five—one year younger than my daughter. The inspiration wasn't actually the poem itself; it was only after I'd started writing that I suddenly remembered it and thought it fit perfectly.

My, it's been so long since I've updated or rambled on like this—I'm almost embarrassed, and I'm not quite sure what to say.

Thank you for coming back.

Chapter 2: Mai Minghe Rescued from Hallucination?

"You live alone,"

the social worker unfolded a small brochure to show her and said, "If you fall, no one would know—it's too dangerous. Best to get one you can wear around your neck; it won't get in the way. What do you think?"

That was many years ago now.

Mai Minghe still remembered that brochure. The product's name was blunt and to the point: "Life Alert."

The image showed a white-haired woman collapsed on the floor, with two lines of small text: "Help! I've fallen and I can't get up!"

Her older cousin had shattered her pelvis in her eighties and never got out of bed again; once you're bedridden, your days are numbered.

What year had she passed? Mai Minghe couldn't remember anymore.

The legs that had once carried her leaping onto rooftops and running wild—in the blink of an eye, even getting out of bed now required guarding against their betrayal.

The body that had followed her all her life had slowly become something foreign; she was like a stiff wheel turning slower and slower with each revolution, powerless to stop it.

"The Emergency Response System is available twenty-four hours a day, every day of the year," the social worker explained, worried she couldn't make out the text on the brochure. "No matter what the emergency, one press and someone will come... let me see—oh, they promise a maximum response time of thirty minutes, and there are participating hospitals nearby."

Mai Minghe took the brochure and studied the pictures for a moment.

She had scraped and saved every penny her whole life, but now money had suddenly lost its weight; prices were nothing but curved little symbols.

"I'll take this one," she said, pointing to the third model. "This one's the nicest-looking. Like a pendant on a necklace."

The social worker let out a laugh. "Great—it'll look lovely on you, I'm sure."

Though it looked nothing like a necklace, she wore it like one anyway; she'd been wearing it that way for years, and the first time she ever pressed the Life Alert was the night the thief walked into her living room to make a phone call.

The thief probably hadn't expected that the "necklace" on her chest was an alarm—the young and the old live in two worlds that are nearly sealed off from each other; unless you have regular reason to deal with elderly people, few know what their lives look like, let alone what things they see and use day to day.

Starting from when she'd made the thief hunt for the poem... she'd tried every trick she could think of, and had bought herself more than ten minutes by now.

No one had come yet, and she was on the verge of losing consciousness.

For some reason, the cold tube defied gravity—it stood straight upright on her chest with no one holding it. The machine hummed steadily, the sound of the poem grew more and more distant, and she sank into wave after wave of dizzy darkness, going deeper and deeper.

From the depths of that darkness, fragments of hallucination floated up like the shards of a dream.

Strange—they say that when a person is dying, they see the memories of their whole life; but all Mai Minghe saw was another version of herself, a tube connected to her chest just the same, walking step by step toward the television, then suddenly lunging forward and crashing into the screen.

She was startled by her own actions, and dimly heard a dull, wet sound from somewhere inside her chest.

With eyes half-open and half-closed, hallucination and reality overlapped; her hallucinated self slammed into the old television in the corner of the room again and again, and the screen erupted into spider-web cracks each time.

The hallucination was finally shattered by a sharp shout—an unfamiliar, low, rough voice called out: "What are you doing? Who are you?"

Mai Minghe jolted, and her eyes opened slightly.

Through her blurred vision, she saw an ink-black, lustrous tube standing upright on her chest—it seemed more alive than she was, pressing down on her with a heavy weight and pinning her to the bed.

The next moment, the tube vanished.

The thief snatched the tube behind his back, and despite his panic, kept his wits about him; he turned the question on the two people who had just burst into the bedroom: "Who are you? Why are you suddenly barging into my grandmother's house?"

Two people strode briskly in through the doorway, switched on the lights, and drove out the night; the room blazed white and bright, revealing a bedroom filled with decay, the smell of medicine, cracks in the walls, and the steady whoosh of an oxygen machine.

They were both wearing blue-and-white uniforms—nurse aides.

"Your grandmother?"

The male nurse aide looked at Mai Minghe, then turned a skeptical eye on the thief. "Her? She's your grandmother?"

"I'm two generations mixed—it doesn't show." The thief seemed to realize the difference in their skin tones and ethnicity, and reacted quickly. "Look, I have dark hair. Who are you people?"

"We're emergency-response nurse aides; we came because we received an alert signal—we thought she had an emergency." The other, a woman's voice, explained. "According to our records, she lives alone."

The thief had already composed himself completely.

"Yes," he said, giving Mai Minghe's arm a gentle pat as if to reassure her, and then addressed the nurse aides: "You responded very quickly—thank you for coming so fast. But there's been a small misunderstanding. I'm in Blackmoor City on a business trip and I'm staying with my grandmother for the time being. She's getting on in years, her mind isn't always clear, and she forgot I was coming—she probably thought I was a stranger and triggered the alert. She's fine."

The female nurse aide walked to the bedside, lifted Mai Minghe's eyelids, examined her, and asked softly, "Ma'am, are you all right?"

Mai Minghe opened her mouth to say something, but only the faintest breath passed between her lips. The female nurse aide had seen this many times before and was not surprised that she couldn't speak; she began listening to her heartbeat.

"Would you mind showing me some identification?" the male nurse aide asked the thief, still a little uncertain.

"Of course," the thief said, and right in front of the nurse aides, coolly and openly kicked the black machine with the tube attached to it under Mai Minghe's bed, muttering as he did so: "Why is the vacuum cleaner sitting there...? One moment—I'll go to the next room for my wallet. My driver's license is in it."

The bed she was lying on now was a hospital-style care bed with four wheels; the space underneath was empty and just right for storing things.

"Oh, my phone—" the thief had only taken a couple of steps before he turned back, smiled at the female nurse aide who was still examining Mai Minghe, and said: "I almost forgot. My grandmother sometimes gets frightened for no reason; I have to play poetry or music for her to calm her down."

The female nurse aide's gaze crossed over Mai Minghe to sweep over the phone screen, and her expression relaxed another degree.

Mai Minghe thought: a thief who breaks in and plays poetry for the homeowner—who would believe that if you told them? It looked far more like a devoted grandchild.

Since she was still alive, that meant the thief hadn't yet managed to take whatever was inside her, right?

Right—otherwise he wouldn't still be here playing the dutiful grandson.

Though if the nurse aides had come a few minutes later, he would have succeeded.

No one knew that death had just been sitting right beside her, leaning over and gazing down at her; she had never been this close to death before, and this was the first time she had ever had a dying hallucination...

That's right—the television!

Even Mai Minghe herself hadn't expected it, but the moment she thought of the hallucination just now, a sudden urge arose out of nowhere: she wanted to roll out of bed and go touch the television.

She had to get over there—had to get over there and look, quickly...

Driven by wave after wave of urgency crashing through her, Mai Minghe was so anxious she nearly cried out.

The dark, black television screen had become the only thing in the world with any weight to it—it pressed heavily into her field of vision and drew her toward it; the room, the nurse aides, and the thief were about as substantial as sheets of paper, and seemed on the verge of floating away.

Mai Minghe strained to lift her hand toward the television.

"Ma'am, what's the matter? What do you need?" The female nurse aide followed the direction of her raised hand, turned to look, and asked, "Do you want to watch TV?"

The door to the storage room next door opened and closed again, as if the thief had actually gone in to retrieve something. He had just returned as the female nurse aide spoke, handing his ID to the male nurse aide; the latter looked it over, and when he spoke again, both his tone and his posture had eased.

Mai Minghe let out a sound from her nose—a syllable of negation—but kept her hand pointing at the television.

"I'll turn it on for you," the female nurse aide said; though puzzled, she was kind about it, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to respond, switched the television on.

The television was replaying a daytime news commentary program; the host was going over and over the sudden death of Blackmoor City magnate Wellesley from the day before, recounting his business triumphs and charitable works.

"No... no." Mai Minghe finally found her voice again, which was a quiet relief—good, she could speak; her strength was coming back.

The thief quickly swept his gaze over her.

He immediately turned back to the male nurse aide, picking up the thread of what he'd been saying: "...My grandmother is getting on in years—the more confused her mind gets, the more stubborn she becomes. There's no family in Blackmoor City who can look after her..."

Such a young age, and already spinning one lie after another.

Telling them this person wasn't her grandson would probably do no good. An ordinary thief wouldn't stay on the scene to negotiate; from the nurse aides' perspective, between him being a thief and her being a senile old woman, she was the more likely candidate.

Never mind that—the television was more important and more urgent than him right now.

"Help me... help me over there." Mai Minghe pointed at the television and said quietly to the female nurse aide: "Please."

The thief glanced at her again, then looked at the television.

Before he could get a word in, the male nurse aide's question pulled away his attention: "When we arrived, you were hunched over holding a tube—what were you doing?"

"You don't have to go over there—you can watch it from here." The female nurse aide was a little hesitant.

The thief was explaining: "My grandmother cried out in the middle of the night and woke me up; I came to check on her and found the vacuum cleaner hose had fallen onto the bed."

"Please," Mai Minghe gripped the female nurse aide's hand tightly, fixed her eyes on those brown eyes, and begged: "Help me over there. Please. I... I just want to sit there for a moment."

She was coming across more and more like a muddled old woman.

"All right, I'll help you." The female nurse aide gave in. "Can you get up?"

"Yes, yes."

The thief glanced at Mai Minghe once more and, seemingly out of concern, came over on his own initiative to support her—also conveniently extricating himself from the male nurse aide's questioning. "Grandma, what do you want to go over there for? You can take a look, but then you have to come back and sleep, all right?"

Mai Minghe ignored him. He seemed like such a decent-looking young man—what on earth was he doing?

With both of them supporting her, she shuffled unsteadily to the television set; her own pale, ghostly half-reflection floated on the screen, then disappeared as the broadcast cut to footage of the Wellesley Family Estate.

She understood now.

So there really had been a reason for the hallucination after all, Mai Minghe thought.

No wonder she had felt such urgency to come over—well, she should have thought of it sooner; at her age, her mind really wasn't what it used to be.

"I'll get a chair," the female nurse aide said, and let go of Mai Minghe.

That left only the thief holding her. He held her thin, dried-up arm in a loose, light grip, as if he didn't dare exert any force.

"If everything's all right, then we'll be on our way." The male nurse aide stood in the doorway and asked the thief, "Can you get her back to bed on your own in a bit?"

The thief exhaled in relief. He nodded repeatedly and said, "Of course—sorry for making you come all the way out here..."

While he was speaking, Mai Minghe suddenly pulled her arm free, let her body fall backward, and toppled toward the television screen.

She should have thought of it sooner—her hallucination had been telling her how to save herself.

If she fell against the television right in front of the nurse aides, they would have no choice but to send her to the hospital—no matter what the thief claimed to be, right? At the hospital, with plenty of people around, she would be safe.

From the corner of her eye she saw the thief's head snap toward her, but he was a beat too slow and couldn't make it in time; Mai Minghe heard the dull, heavy crack of her skull against the television, and then the room erupted with startled cries and the sound of rushing footsteps.

The female social worker seemed to call out something from very far away, but Mai Minghe couldn't make out the words—

"Where did she go?"

Posted yesterday

but I didn't expect to actually start the book

It's only two chapters—no rush to collect on that debt yet, let's wait and see; what if the later chapters aren't good? Qidian doesn't do refunds on tips, you know.

The same goes for 95, 秋水不染尘, 相声福晋, 绾瑾, 颖佑, 西下有木名栗, 039追女娲? , 卡夫卡, and everyone else—are you all angel investors? I'm flattered and terrified...

Full disclosure: the book launches on the 12th, and I have to leave town on the 14th... My stockpile of advance chapters definitely won't survive the combination of travel chaos and bonus-chapter donations—looks like I'll be pecking away at the keyboard on the plane again.

PS: I saw some readers asking why this is posted on the male-frequency channel when it's a strong-female-lead feature. The editors have their reasons, actually—a large portion of male-frequency readers are women who don't visit the female-frequency side, so a strong-female-lead feature on the male channel is meant to draw them in; think of it as poaching readers for the female channel's benefit (?).

Chapter 3: The Sweet Illusion in Mai Minghe's Hospital Ward

As the world spun around her, Mai Minghe instinctively grabbed at a white shape nearby, but still couldn't steady herself—she stumbled and sat down hard on the ice-cold tile floor, letting out a hoarse groan.

This is bad. Could she have broken a bone?

The pain blurred her vision completely, and she couldn't even tell which bone it was that might be the death of her—one single fall was all it took to shatter her, scatter her into pieces across the floor.

After a fall like this, the nurse aide should have taken her to the hospital no matter what; yet as she caught her breath, the nurse aide who should have come rushing never appeared, and no one asked if she was all right.

What was going on?

Mai Minghe narrowed her eyes and looked carefully, and couldn't help but freeze.

...This wasn't her room.

The room was dim and murky; by the thin sliver of white light seeping in under the door, she could vaguely make out that it was a very large space. In front of her and behind her stood an empty narrow bed on either side, and what she had grabbed turned out to be a corner of a bed sheet.

She let go of the sheet and looked left and right.

A row of wheeled care beds, each with a small bedside cabinet, each with a curtain divider—this was clearly a hospital ward. She had been hospitalized several times before and could recognize one at a glance.

How strange.

How had she ended up in a hospital ward? The nurse aides must have brought her here, right?

But how could she have completely forgotten the whole process of being sent to the hospital? It was as if it had never happened—as if a black hole had opened up in her memory.

Mai Minghe suppressed her panic and pain, and no matter how hard she tried to think, the last moment she could recall was still slamming into the television; she remembered the world tilting in the midst of searing pain, and then the next second, she had fallen onto the hospital ward floor.

It was as though she had fallen straight from her home into the hospital—but that was impossible.

Had she lost consciousness at the time and forgotten because of that?

"Is anyone there?" Mai Minghe called out in a hoarse voice. "Nurse? I've fallen..."

In the cold, silent ward, her cry for help was like a chip of broken ice slowly sinking into a cold river, as if it had never existed.

Whether from pain or cold, she trembled uncontrollably in waves. If this went on, something would surely go wrong—she had to call the nurse quickly. Right, there was usually a call bell at the head of the hospital bed.

Mai Minghe struggled to push herself upright, trying to stand, but the pain in her leg bones wouldn't allow it; her hands and feet went limp and weightless, and she slipped, nearly falling again.

There was nothing else for it—she had no choice but to crawl inch by inch toward the bedside cabinet, prop herself against its edge, stretch her arm out as hard as she could, and just barely graze the call bell button with her fingertips.

"If I were you, I wouldn't press that."

The man's voice came out of nowhere and sent a jolt through Mai Minghe's chest; her blood rushed up as though it might burst her brain.

She steadied herself through the dizziness and turned her head toward the sound, only then noticing that there was another bed behind her.

The bed curtain was drawn, but not all the way—a pair of feet belonging to the patient in the adjacent bed were visible.

Those feet were bare, nothing on them at all, snow-white as if dusted with heavy powder, the toes curled ever so slightly, not moving at all.

Mai Minghe couldn't help but feel a rush of relief—thank goodness, there was someone else in the room.

"Are you—are you also a patient here?" she asked, still breathless as she spoke; even as she spoke, she reached toward the call bell again.

"You really want to call the nurse?" the patient behind the curtain asked in return.

"Yes... I've fallen and I have no choice but to call."

For something minor, she wouldn't bother the nurses in the middle of the night if she could help it—Mai Minghe actually understood the adjacent patient's concern.

She pressed the call bell, and not a single sound rang out in the room.

"There, you went and pressed it anyway."

The patient in the adjacent bed knew all the same, and laughed—a stiff, flat laugh, as though each contraction of the diaphragm were deliberate and conscious, every segment precisely equal in length.

Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and slowly slid down to sit on the floor, her entire body sinking into exhausted helplessness; but she quietly stole a glance at the curtain from the corner of her eye.

"Won't listen to advice... people really do get more stubborn as they get older. I was saying it for your own good."

"What... do you mean?"

The other person laughed again, two stiff and measured bursts, but gave no answer.

Something felt off, though she couldn't say exactly why.

Mai Minghe was still hesitating over whether to ask again when a deafeningly loud broadcast suddenly tore through the dead-silent corridor outside—an electronic female voice blared and echoed, reverberating through the ward door: "Room three, bed 03, calling nurse. Room three, bed 03, calling nurse!"

The broadcast gave her a fright, and a terrible jolt burst through her chest; she pressed one hand tightly over her heart—relieved that someone was coming, yet unable to stop a creeping unease from rising.

...Strange—normally, after pressing the call bell, would a broadcast go off? This loud, in the middle of the night—weren't they afraid of disturbing people's rest?

Could this be some new rule at hospitals these days?

The broadcast stopped.

In the silent room, for a moment there was nothing but Mai Minghe's trembling breaths.

"Please be advised," the broadcast suddenly blared again at the same staggering volume, startling her once more: "A figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at Room Three within five seconds. Countdown: five—four—three—"

Mai Minghe froze.

She must have been going deaf and blind, mishearing things—otherwise why would she think the broadcast had said "a figure disguised as a nurse"?

The patient in the adjacent bed began to chuckle again, the laughter chopped into segments.

"What the broadcast just said..."

Before Mai Minghe could finish the question, there came a sudden bang—the ward door was slammed hard into the wall, the ear-splitting crash making her chest tighten with a deep, dull ache.

As the ward door flew open, white light from the corridor poured in; standing in that white light was a thin, elongated, extremely tall dark shape, its head cut off by the doorframe above.

The shadow rotated its right shoulder, stepped forward with its right foot—as though its joints were misaligned and stiff—and lurched crookedly one step through the doorway, its head still left outside.

That could not possibly be a nurse.

The thought sharpened the radiating pain pulsing outward from her left chest in waves, her entire left arm as though someone had seized the tendons and was pulling them free; soon she felt herself unable to breathe.

"Oh? It's one of those?"

The patient in the adjacent bed began to laugh with rhythmic contractions of the chest, the snow-white feet beyond the curtain still utterly motionless.

"Say you're unlucky, and yet what came isn't a Resident; say you're lucky, and yet... at this exact moment, you've gone and had a heart attack—so you still won't make it out alive."

The shadow rotated its left shoulder, stepped forward with its left foot, its head swaying and scraping along the wall as it entered; angling its body, it took another step toward bed three.

From far beyond the wide-open door, someone bellowed in fury: "Who's closest?... Get to Room Three now and cut them off! Don't let whoever pressed that bell escape—the nerve, stealing our things!"

...What was happening?

Would she survive this day?

The shadow was backlit, and no matter how much Mai Minghe squinted, she couldn't make out its face. It walked with both arms and legs on the same side swinging together, and though it seemed to take only two or three steps, it had already reached the foot of the bed, trapping her between the two beds.

She wanted to ask who it was, but she could no longer speak.

Someone was sprinting down the corridor toward her, the pounding footsteps growing louder and louder until she could almost feel the floor shaking; the shadow paid no heed to the noise outside and swayed steadily closer until it loomed directly before Mai Minghe.

Was this... a person? she wondered dimly, at the edge of death. That couldn't be, could it?

Before she could understand, this life of hers was about to reach its end.

The shadow slowly bent down toward her.

Though her consciousness was fading, Mai Minghe finally saw clearly the first face she had encountered since entering this hospital.

Beneath a mass of wild dark hair, what extended from the neck was an oval, smooth, hard mirror-surface. Below the mirror, there was nothing but darkness.

It was not a person wearing a mirror over their face.

Where a face should have been, there was not the slightest contour of features or bone—only a mirror in its place, grown out from the surrounding flesh, angled directly at Mai Minghe.

Her aged, withered face was reflected in the mirror, and in that moment, it was as though the one bending down toward her was Mai Minghe herself.

Was she inside a dream right now? A mirror for a face, a heart attack—it was all a dream, surely.

Before dying, she had actually seen something so... extraordinary.

Dream or reality, this was at least the first time in her life she had glimpsed something beyond the ordinary—and it would be the last.

Mai Minghe made no expression, yet the old face in the mirror smiled faintly, the way a person smiles when they have reached a point of helplessness and have no other choice.

The reflection of her opened its mouth, lips parting and closing, speaking soundlessly to the Mai Minghe outside the mirror.

If I could live again...

I would ride the merry-go-round to my heart's content,

I would go everywhere, try everything,

...I would pick more daisies.

Mai Minghe could not move at all—whether her mind had been stilled by some outside force, or whether her old, exhausted heart, on the verge of sleep, could simply no longer be roused.

The lips in the mirror grew more and more indistinct, harder and harder to read; the shadow continued drawing slowly closer, and finally enveloped her completely.

...If you were given the chance to begin again, what would you do with it to make this new life worthwhile?

The thick, tangled, coarse black hair pressed against Mai Minghe's forehead; she was submerged in dense darkness, unable to see anything. Two arms, grotesquely long, wound around her body again and again, pulling tighter and tighter, until it felt as though the bones inside her would be snapped one by one—

"Let go of me,"

Just as the breath in her chest was about to be cut off, Mai Minghe finally struggled and shoved with both hands—but she met no resistance as she had expected, and her hands pushed

through empty air.

She quickly steadied herself and scrambled up from the floor, only then realizing that there was nothing before her at all—the shadow had vanished.

Wait...

It dawned on Mai Minghe belatedly.

She had just jumped to her feet—easily, cleanly, without any difficulty at all?

Mai Minghe raised a hand and pressed it to her chest; the pain was as though it had never existed, and from deep within, there came a steady, familiar rhythm.

Her hands... seemed a little different.

Mai Minghe raised both hands and found that the skin was full and smooth, the nails clear and lustrous, without a single fold of excess wrinkled skin. She lowered her head and stared blankly at what showed below the hem of her pajama pants—a pair of legs, evenly fleshed, fair and strong.

She had to have gone mad.

Youth, it turned out, was a sweet illusion—fierce and full to bursting, so overwhelming it left one at a loss.

For a moment she forgot everything, and frantically explored her own body: her fingers plunged into thick, abundant hair; her arms and thighs had the firm muscles she had long been without; her back had straightened, her height risen... Mai Minghe let out a breathless "ha" of a laugh, her voice trembling.

A clear, young voice she hadn't heard in at least several decades flowed into the cold air of the ward.

From the other side of decay, darkness, and ash, she had somehow been released—born into the world a second time—but wait, was any of this real?

"In here!"

A sharp shout rang out at the doorway, and Mai Minghe jolted upright, lifting her head.

Her vision was no longer clouded and grey; even in the dim light, she could clearly see a man burst in through the door, his face filled with deep wariness.

"There's a woman in here, but I don't see the Artifact."

The man fixed his eyes on Mai Minghe and called out to his companions behind him, then snapped at her: "Which House are you a Hunter for? You've got the item on you, don't you? You have the nerve to steal the Artifact Mr. Wellesley wants?"

"What?" Mai Minghe asked blankly, her mind a tangled mess of confusion—the man's question, rambling as nonsense, had to seep through the cracks of that tangle before even a little of it could reach her.

The man was about to step inside when his eyes swept to something beside her and he stopped dead in his tracks.

"Get in here, all of you," he called to those outside the door. "There's a Resident in Room Three!"

A Resident? What was he talking about?

From that brief glance just now, it seemed like there was something in the room—not far from her at all.

Mai Minghe turned his gaze in a daze and found that the originally empty Bed No. 3 beside her had its curtain drawn at some point.

The curtain wasn't fully closed, revealing a pair of feet so snow-white they looked as though they'd been dusted with powder; the toes were splayed out to either side, frozen still, not moving at all.

...Huh? Wasn't he on the bed next to her just now?

When had he moved over to Bed No. 3?

"Calling you 'old lady' wouldn't be right anymore," the patient behind the curtain said with a laugh. "I should be calling you 'young lady' now. Young lady, what you just got your hands on is a rare and wonderful thing. How about letting me take a look?"

I'm boarding a flight today—the pressure to update has kicked in, so I'll have to write on the plane. I just hope whoever sits next to me isn't one of those screen-peekers. One time I was writing an apocalypse story on a plane, and the guy one seat over suddenly grew five centimeters of neck, like a crane, and twisted it all the way over to ask me: "You writing a novel? What's it about?"

Makes you wonder if nearsightedness really isn't widespread enough.

(Why do I keep catching flights and going on long trips—truly an unsolvable mystery…)

Chapter 4: Mai Minghe Seizes a Second Life

By any reasonable logic, three to five tall, built, hostile strangers pouring in through the door should have been the most alarming threat, right?

No matter how you looked at it, they were still more dangerous than a patient lying in a hospital bed.

And yet, somehow, Mai Minghe couldn't help but fix her gaze on the pair of white feet peeking out from behind the curtain. Her heartbeat thundered in her ears like rolling drums; her palms were cold and clammy—and she couldn't spare so much as a glance for the strangers.

She was wedged between the Bed 03 patient and Bed 02, with the bedside cabinet and wall at her back. The path ahead was blocked by the intruders, and there was no way out.

She stole another glance at the patient in the next bed.

Compared to when she had first seen them, the feet looked slightly different now—she couldn't say exactly how—but looking at them now triggered something instinctive, something biological, a revulsion so deep she almost wanted to open her mouth and heave out everything: the sight before her eyes, the air she'd breathed that had touched those feet, along with every organ in her body.

Looking up again, she could tell the strangers might be feeling the same way: for all their ferocious swagger when they'd barged in, their eyes were now drifting upward, not one of them willing to lower their gaze to the feet on the bed—at a glance, they looked exactly like a group of blind men who had all just taken off their dark glasses at the same moment.

Mai Minghe wiped her nose.

Perhaps terror and tension had wound too tight, and her nervous system was seeking release; perhaps the return of youth carried an intoxicating, surging magic that even fear couldn't dispel; or perhaps it was simply that the people across from her looked too comical—whatever the reason, she suddenly couldn't hold it in, and burst out laughing.

"How did you manage that?"

She stifled her laughter, not wanting those people to think she belonged in a psychiatric ward. She turned to the patient in the next bed and said: "I don't know why, but one look at you and my

guts start churning. You'd make a great side job here at the hospital—stomach-pumping."

The red-haired man who seemed to be the leader didn't say a word, but the expression on his face said everything about what he thought of Mai Minghe—not quite right in the head.

"Miss,"

the male voice from behind the curtain was like a bag of stones clogged with thick phlegm—hearing it was indescribably unpleasant. "This is your first time in the Nest, isn't it?"

Since just moments ago, Mai Minghe had heard a string of incomprehensible terms: a figure disguised as a nurse, Hunters, Artifacts... and now another one had been added—the Nest.

"This isn't a hospital?" Mai Minghe asked.

Though it was a question, she already had the answer clear as a mirror in her mind: of course this wasn't a hospital.

She had somehow ended up in this place called the "Nest"; and that "somehow," it seemed, had a great deal to do with her falling onto the television set.

"But it is a hospital—why wouldn't it be?" the patient behind the curtain answered, in a tone that was almost friendly. "A hospital inside the Nest is still a hospital."

Mai Minghe stalled for time, thinking as she spoke: "You say this is the Nest, but you don't look much like a chicken to me."

The red-haired man let out a sound through his nose—something he'd tried and failed to suppress—and covered it with a cough.

"Doesn't even know what the Nest is," one of the people by the door muttered to a companion in a low voice. "Really is her first time in. No wonder she's still in her pajamas."

"But if it's her first time here, how could she have gotten hold of an Artifact?" another murmured.

"Wait and see," the red-haired man instructed. "Be ready—if she can't hold on, we'll have to take it from the Resident."

As they spoke, they treated Mai Minghe as though she barely existed—or rather, as though she were something that was about to cease to exist very soon.

In the span of just a minute or two, far too many incomprehensible things had happened; right now, Mai Minghe could only hold tightly to two facts.

First, after entering the Nest, she had regained her youth. Second, the thing that had restored her youth seemed to be the objective both parties were after.

Even knowing nothing else, she knew that she was like a child carrying a fortune through a busy marketplace—more like a ghost market—and that was not a good position to be in.

Behind the curtain, there was dead silence; two bare feet, pale-blue and white, rested with their toes hooked over the footrail of the bed.

"What do you want?" Mai Minghe stared at the feet behind the curtain and asked, knowing full well the answer. "How about this—you tell me what's going on, and I'll give you whatever you want. Nice and peaceful, wouldn't that be better?"

The patient behind the curtain considered for two seconds.

"Feel around on your body," his voice had calmed somewhat—less painful to listen to than before—though he still refused to explain further, only saying: "You should be able to feel something. Take it off and give it to me."

Mai Minghe reached her hand inside her pajamas and felt along her back and lower abdomen; the moment she touched it, she flinched.

Slightly raised, ice-cold, band-like things wound around her torso in layer after layer—to the touch, it was exactly like a great snake coiled around her body.

Right—that dark shadowy arm from earlier had seemed to wrap around her just like this, in ring after ring.

"Found it, haven't you," the patient in the next bed suddenly hissed, mucus churning in his throat. "Give it to me."

Mai Minghe traced the edge of the "snake-band" and felt that it seemed deeply reluctant to separate from her skin; she would have to use some force to wedge her fingertips between the band and her flesh.

"Alright, alright, I know, I'll give it to you." It could indeed be removed—she lifted her hand, and had already peeled the "snake-band" up slightly.

She thought of another question.

"I had a heart attack just now, and it only stopped after this thing appeared. Once I take it off, will the attack come back?"

"For someone your age, your mind works fast. I don't think so. What it reversed was aging, not illness—the illness disappearing was merely a side effect, and doesn't necessarily come back along with the aging."

The patient in the next bed's voice was thick and viscous. "Of course, I could be wrong—but besides being optimistic, you have no other choice. Now then, take it off."

As he said, she had no other choice.

"Fortunately, I've always been an optimist." Mai Minghe let out a breath, first peeling the "snake-band" away from her lower abdomen, then following it all the way around to her back, working it off her body bit by bit.

The tail of the pitch-black "snake-band" slipped softly out from her pajamas and hung suspended in the air, swaying gently back and forth, as though it were alive.

"Wait—don't give it to him," the red-haired man suddenly barked, stepping forward and spreading both hands wide. "Give it to me—if it comes for me, it'll leave you alone!"

He used the pronoun "it"?

The thought flashed through Mai Minghe's mind; she had no time to dwell on it, but she had already realized this was a lifeline—in this brief sliver of an opening, she might be able to escape the ward and get out alive. Mai Minghe seized the moment and immediately shouted to the red-haired man: "Catch!"

She swung her arm and pulled a dark shape from behind her back, hurling it toward his raised hands.

It may have been her imagination, but Mai Minghe could have sworn that for one fleeting instant, the patient behind the curtain in the next bed was also drawn away for a split second of distraction.

With a smack, the dark shape landed in the red-haired man's hands at the very same moment Mai Minghe seized her chance: she rolled across Bed 02 and dropped to the ground on the other side—the body of a young person was truly so strong, agile, and balanced; the movement was smooth and effortless, so exhilarating that for one brief instant she nearly forgot she was fleeing for her life.

The dark shape, soft and puffed-up, was nestled between two hands, surrounded by a ring of faces staring intently at it.

"A pillow?"

The red-haired man blinked in surprise once he saw what it was, then flung the pillow—which Mai Minghe had taken from Bed 02—onto the floor, and snapped: "Do you want to die at a Resident's hands?"

Mai Minghe had no time to reply; she had only just found her footing when she turned her head and found that the patient had followed—the curtain around Bed 02 had been drawn shut.

But not fully.

The curtain seemed to have been pulled a little wider; at some point, a pair of lower legs had extended out from it, the two knees pressed tightly together, bending over the edge of the bed and hanging down.

The patient in the next bed was lying flat, with only their legs lowered—that in itself was not strange; what was strange was that those bare feet, pale-blue and bloodless, planted flat on the floor, had rotated a full turn at the ankle and were now facing directly toward Mai Minghe.

This felt too much like an absurd dream; if she were to open her eyes in the next moment and wake up in a hospital bed, Mai Minghe would not have been at all surprised.

"Get back,"

the red-haired man said, his face taut, retreating further from Bed 02 along with the others behind him.

It was as though even the air was slowly tightening, thinning out; as though they were wild animals long accustomed to these surroundings, and had sensed the danger one step before Mai Minghe, who understood nothing.

She thought for a moment, then asked the patient in the next bed: "Did you come into the hospital for a broken ankle?"

As she spoke, Mai Minghe had a vague sense of something pulling at her waist.

"Or... you really aren't human?" She called out to the red-haired man: "Hey, young man—if it's not human, what is it? Really a chicken?"

Everything was so unbelievable that she found she'd lost her capacity for shock, and simply wanted to understand what was happening—after all, no one can keep startling themselves too frequently.

The red-haired man didn't answer her.

He and the others behind him were all staring at the lower legs dangling from beside Bed 02 and at the floor, as though Mai Minghe had already been erased from the situation—she just didn't know it yet.

The curtain rustled with a soft shushing sound; someone was slowly drawing it open.

Mai Minghe did not want to see what lay behind the curtain—it couldn't be anything good.

She quickly lowered her head again; when her gaze fell on the pair of feet before her, she noticed that the patient in the next bed's left foot had, at some point, stepped forward.

Though she herself hadn't moved at all, her own left foot had also stepped forward.

Like two old acquaintances reuniting, walking toward each other.

No wonder it felt like something was pulling at her waist...

Strange—why was it that simply seeing the other's feet caused her own feet to move beyond her control, mirroring the other's movements—no, this was not the time for puzzling and reflection.

Even with her head lowered, she could sense from the corner of her eye that the curtain had been drawn open.

On Bed 02 beside her, a long human-shaped shadow lay dimly on the mattress.

Mai Minghe drew a deep breath.

If this had been the Mai Minghe of before, she might have chosen to keep the peace and put self-preservation first, handing the "snake-band" over to it; the first time you're alive, you're always afraid that one wrong move will lead to irreversible, unbearable consequences and make this life a miserable one.

Later, when she had grown old, she found that her decades of life had been filled with nothing but loneliness, regret, and wishes long past their expiry date—not much of a good life after all. Opportunities no longer came calling, and she had run out of strength.

This "snake-band" could be the last great adventure in her eighty-six years of life; but it could also be the first choice of her life yet to come.

She wanted to try.

Mai Minghe knew that pressing the call button would not break the dead silence in the room with any sound.

"Ward Three, Bed 01 is calling for a nurse!"

The broadcast's sharp, almost piercing female voice shattered the room's silence without warning.

Before anyone had time to react, Mai Minghe pressed the call button several more times in quick succession.

The intercom, as if galvanized, announced down the corridor in increasingly urgent tones: "A figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at the ward within five seconds—a second figure disguised as a nurse is about to arrive—a third figure disguised as a nurse—a fourth figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at the ward within five seconds!"

Amid the announcements, each more urgent than the last, Mai Minghe thought she dimly heard the red-haired man curse "Are you insane!"; immediately after, a flurry of retreating footsteps receded rapidly, as though the group, seeing things had gone south, had fled the ward ahead of everyone else.

She had not lifted her head the entire time.

Mai Minghe felt the dark shape beside her rising up joint by joint: thighs lifting off the mattress, hips suspended halfway in the air, upper body still flat on the bed.

In the dim residual light, that head turned toward Mai Minghe, and spoke in a voice utterly unlike any human sound: "For an old lady, you've got quite the nerve."

At that very moment, something heavy was suddenly hurled across the room and slammed down hard between her and the patient in the next bed—landing with a thunderous thud, the nightstand instantly smashed to pieces—the shadow tumbled to the floor, and when it scrambled up against the wall, it turned out to be the red-haired man; finding himself wedged squarely between the patient and Mai Minghe, he swore under his breath.

Mai Minghe didn't look at him.

She kept her gaze fixed on the doorway of the ward, and said quietly: "Look again. I'm not an old lady anymore."

Not now. Not tomorrow either.

She would seize this second life—truly seize it—for herself.

By the time you see this chapter, I should already be on the plane—this chapter was set on a timer—having a backlog really gives you confidence! You can even schedule posts! Back when I was writing the apocalypse story, it was feast or famine!

Unfortunately, the backlog, all told, is barely enough to last a little over a week... hopefully I can manage to write at least one chapter on the plane, so once I land I can start bonus updates to pay off my debt.

Speaking of debt—dear readers, aren't you being a little too swift and decisive? The Artifact Report just came into the world and you're already stuffing in red envelopes—what if the child grows up to be the Hunchback of Notre Dame?

It feels like every time I blink, another debt appears...

Aiya, boarding time is almost here, there's a super long line at the gate, and here I am sitting cross-legged typing away—just wait until I've landed, and then we'll properly tally up how much more I owe.

So what if I'm a pack mule—I've been in this business for a hundred years! I'll gather coins with my donkey tail!

Chapter 5 — Sydney Ginn, the Hunter Plagued by a Stalker

Sydney Ginn stood before her own memorial portrait, ears ringing.

A funeral wreath was blocking her front door; open it, and the first thing you'd see was her own smiling, blurred face. The black-and-white portrait photo was crooked-nailed to the center of the wreath, and a line of savage crimson letters — "BITCH" — tore across her smile.

It was the first time in her life she had seen, in person, the kind of wreath used at Asian funerals; and even as fury and shock surged through her, some small part of Sydney found herself marveling at how authentic it looked — identical to the ones on TV — wondering where on earth someone would even get one made.

As for who had left it there, she wasn't curious, because she already knew.

Sydney kicked the wreath over, slammed the door, and walked toward the elevator, pulling out her phone as she went.

"Get up here right now and take a look at what's been left in front of my door."

She had lived in this building for three years, and today was the first time she had ever raised her voice at the building manager like this — before now, she had always been too afraid to be rude.

"What gives you the right to charge such high rent and management fees? This is supposed to be the most expensive address in Blackmoor City? Your security staff — did you borrow them as mummies from the National Museum next door? Are they all dead? I told you, didn't I, that there's been a creep following me lately — why wasn't security tightened? How did he even get the chance to reach my front door?"

When Sydney had first moved into this building, she had been deeply insecure about it.

By any normal trajectory, someone like her — born to an ordinary immigrant family, with no impressive credentials and an equally unremarkable job — could spend a lifetime saving for rent and still never pass the application screening, never gain entry into this century-old landmark, already designated a historic site.

The layered barriers of class and social networks made it difficult even for many newly minted tech millionaires to lease a unit here, let alone buy one.

Not long after she moved in, she had once encountered a woman in the elevator who struck up a very friendly conversation with her, which quietly pleased her; just before the elevator reached the lobby, the woman smiled and asked, "Who do you work for? We happen to be interviewing for household staff at the moment."

It took her several seconds to realize the woman had mistaken her for a maid.

Even dressed in much the same way, something — she couldn't say what — still allowed others to see at a glance that she didn't belong to this class. The building manager on the phone was one of them.

"Miss Ginn,"

the manager explained in a tone that bordered on sympathetic condescension, "I also feel very sorry about this. But you may not be aware that we generally prefer not to interfere in our residents' personal affairs — that has always been our policy.

"The people our residents typically associate with are all respectable individuals of standing, so this sort of thing is happening for the very first time. According to security, he said he wanted to give you a surprise, and he was carrying flowers, so we couldn't quite tell — it seemed like perhaps you and your boyfriend had some kind of romantic dispute..."

"It's not a romantic dispute, it's stalking and harassment!" Sydney snapped, too furious to even register the implication buried in the word "respectable." "And he's not my boyfriend — what he was carrying was a funeral wreath!"

The man had been on a few dates with her and had indeed visited before, having been granted entry each time; it was precisely after seeing her home and her lifestyle that he had begun repeatedly demanding money and gifts from her, and only when she could no longer bear it had she decided to cut off all contact.

She had never imagined that a simple "no" could ignite such an unhinged, consuming hatred.

"Of course, of course, I'll have someone remove the wreath right away. Security isn't like you — they wouldn't recognize that kind of wreath, which is understandable, and I hope you can appreciate that." The building manager continued, "That said, Miss Ginn, I'd also like to ask you to try to communicate with him and calm the situation down. After all, our residents here tend to prefer things quiet and low-key; they don't care for this sort of disturbance..."

"So I'm the one who should be apologizing to you?"

Sydney was too furious to catch anything else the manager said, hung up the call, and kicked the elevator door hard.

When she left the building, she didn't ask the doorman to call a car for her, and walked absentmindedly out into the Blackmoor City streets, where the morning sun was blazing.

Sydney could file a police report, apply for a restraining order — but neither was a sure thing.

For all she knew, the police wouldn't act until she'd already become a victim; and a restraining order might deter a sane person, but how much effect would it have on someone unhinged?

For an ordinary woman, there was little left beyond reporting it to the police, staying on guard, fleeing somewhere far away, and praying — but what that Anthony probably didn't know was that what Sydney could actually do went far beyond any of that.

She wandered for a while, made up her mind, and flagged down a taxi.

The timing worked out perfectly; when she reached the Buluan district, "Between the Backlight" had just opened its doors.

The bar's entrance was hidden behind a short staircase that descended from the sidewalk into the ground, and people walking past could hardly see its sign light; though in Sydney's memory, the sign light had never actually been on — so it hardly mattered whether any passerby could see it.

She pushed open the faded wooden door, and to the dry creaking of the door's hinges, stepped into a cramped, dim basement.

In the murky darkness, chairs sat upside down on tabletops, and cardboard boxes were stacked in the booths. The air was stale and cool, drifting with dust, the smell of alcohol, and a faint trace of vomit.

"You're here this early?"

The back door was pushed open, and a man peered in, then walked behind the bar. He had the face of a Shar-Pei, all drooping brows and downcast eyes, and yet, like a dog, his expression was somehow warm.

He switched the television on for Sydney and gestured toward the bar. "Sit down, I'm still tidying up."

The television mounted in one corner of the bar's ceiling lit up with the midday news. A baby elephant had been born at the Blackmoor City Center Island Zoo, and the female anchor was beaming.

"Any news?" Sydney sat down and asked. "I'm planning to head over in the next couple of days."

"There's a team that's temporarily short-handed and wants to hire an experienced Hunter with no House Faction ties. I thought — isn't that you?"

The bartender's Shar-Pei face remained buried behind the bar counter; he seemed to be scrubbing the cabinet door on his knees, and said over the shushing sound of the cloth: "Not much money — three thousand dollars, departing next week. And of course, whatever comes out of it at the end has nothing to do with you."

A few years ago, three thousand dollars would have lit her eyes up like flashlights; but now, it wasn't nearly enough to make it worth her while.

"I can't work with a group right now — I've got some personal business this time. Are there any other commissions?"

"Then there's nothing—"

He'd barely gotten the words out when the television suddenly rang out with a sharp, urgent chime, making Sydney glance up at the screen — breaking news.

"We have just learned," the female anchor said, her expression grave, "that Wellesley, founder, shareholder, and CEO of the Qunmu Consortium, was found dead this morning at his upstate estate, at the age of fifty-nine. The cause of death is currently suspected to be sudden cardiac arrest, and police have opened an investigation... Mr. Wellesley was also a state senator, a philanthropist..."

Sydney startled. "He's dead?"

The Shar-Pei face emerged from behind the bar, watching the screen. "Did you know him?"

"No, not personally. But I have a client who had some dealings with him... I thought maybe I'd be able to do business with him someday. Pity." Sydney said, and set aside the death of Blackmoor City's richest man. "No other assignments?"

"You could wait a few more days — something might come up." The bartender went back to polishing the beer taps. "When are you planning to go?"

Sydney took out her phone, intending to check the time, but found over twenty text messages on her screen, all from an unknown number; even without opening them, she could tell at a glance they were a mix of pitiful pleading, filth, and threats and curses.

She had already blocked four or five numbers, but it didn't seem to slow the harassment at all.

"I'm going tonight — no assignment, forget it." She put her phone away, her tone cooling. "There's a problem that's not huge but is deeply unpleasant, and I need to go make a trip and bring something back to deal with it."

The bartender nodded and asked, "The usual drink? Or should I pack it to go?"

"Yes," — just mentioning the drink, Sydney was fairly sure the color drained from her face — "I didn't bring a cup, just pour it into a couple of plastic bottles, whatever you've got."

The moment she thought about the drink he prepared for her, even before it was down her throat, her stomach started to heave, as though every organ in her body wanted to empty itself out in advance.

No matter how many times she drank it, Sydney could never get used to the taste of alcohol. She had been forcing herself to drink for the past several years, and she seemed to be turning into Pavlov's dog — sometimes just catching a whiff of alcohol on someone else was enough to make her legs go weak and her head swim with nausea.

"Only the drink you mix has the effect I need. If I drink anything else, my mind goes numb all right, but my limbs get heavy and sluggish, and the moment I close my eyes I fall dead asleep — that's just playing with my life."

A smile flickered across the bartender's face. "But it's still not efficient enough, is it? I'll keep an eye out and see if there's a suitable medication for you."

If she could pop a pill and get the same effect, that would be wonderful. But until she had that pill, she had no choice but to grit her teeth and force the drink down.

If she still wanted to keep living this life.

When night fell, Sydney changed into running shoes and athletic wear and pulled her hair up into a tight bun.

She packed all her usual gear into a bag — not an ordinary backpack, but a half-body-height hiking pack of the kind trekkers used, big enough to stuff a sleeping bag into.

Though she didn't plan to stay long, Sydney didn't dare be careless, and still brought a hunting knife, a ladies' handgun, and a can of bear spray.

What a shame — with real-world laws to contend with, none of these things could be used directly on the stalker; in the end she still had to go the long way around.

The time on her phone ticked over to 9:43 PM.

Harassment messages — each from a different number — kept flooding in without pause, piling up at the bottom of the screen, not a single one swiped open; the unread message count had already reached 129.

Sydney had discovered a few hours ago that the stalker had posted her number on dozens of yellow websites; since then, the messages coming in were not only nauseating but impossible to block fast enough.

She simply shoved the phone to the very bottom of her backpack, out of sight, out of mind.

Night had dyed the entire floor-to-ceiling window black; she sat on the floor before it, as if suspended in midair, adrift among Blackmoor City's skyscrapers and countless lights.

The neon glow, bright as scattered diamonds, would persist through the deep of the night and into the dawn. This city — the largest and most prosperous metropolis on earth — never slept, never rested.

The drink the bartender had prepared for her, she forced down sip by sip, enduring the discomfort, until her consciousness was soon scorched into something light and floating, her blood churning and bubbling; even though the apartment was perfectly quiet, she seemed to hear a hum coming from somewhere.

The primal fear honed by millions of years of evolution was not something that could be habituated to or overcome simply by trying again and again.

If she didn't drink large quantities of alcohol, if she didn't dull her mind into a hazy stupor, Sydney didn't even have the courage to walk to the edge of the balcony — she had always been severely acrophobic; she wouldn't even ride roller coasters at an amusement park.

She gripped the balcony railing with trembling hands, drew a breath, and stepped up onto the chair she had prepared.

The backpack hung heavy from her shoulders, and as she pushed herself up to sit on the railing it caught and scraped against it; the lurch of her body nearly sent both her heart and her stomach sliding up her throat, and it was only with great effort that she steadied her breathing, her palms soaked through with cold sweat.

Even drunk, she still dared not look down, keeping her gaze fixed on the city skyline.

Far away between the buildings, rivers of traffic flowed, countless headlights blurring into bright smears in the fine drifting rain. The cool, thin rain fell in close, slanting lines against her skin, and Sydney felt a vague worry that the cold rain might sober her up, stripping away the blessed numbness.

...Time to go.

She sat on the railing, her back to the neon lights of Blackmoor City, watching her reflection in the glass door and the faint outline of the living room beyond it.

"I'll be right back," Sydney Ginn said softly to the apartment. "Wait for me."

She closed her eyes, leaned back, and fell straight down into the cool early-November night wind.

*I'm back, everyone — first thing I did was eat until I couldn't anymore, god it felt like getting out of jail, I nearly cried over the food — wait, no, what am I saying, the first thing I did was sit my butt down and write, for real!

Hehehe I just posted four chapters and already swapped away from Mai Minghe — sorry about that. The worldbuilding needs multiple perspectives or it'll be confusing for too long, which isn't great. I won't be switching POVs that often going forward.

I should have given a heads-up at the end of the last chapter, but I forgot... donkeys have bad memories, and apparently so do I — you all are hippocampi, I'm a hippo-donkey, the pirated version glitches out, but paying readers will definitely forgive me (right?).

I've always thought one of the big reasons Western fantasy is hard to get into is the names... so I've given all the Western characters in this story names that Chinese readers can actually remember. Take Sydney Ginn — her name is translated as 金雪梨 (Jin Xuěli). If I'd called her 西

妮 · 洁, who would even know who that is, right? I picked up this trick while writing Milady, and it really works — solid 4.8 stars on the reviews.

*Why am I sticking this ramble at the end of the main text? Because the author's note section ran out of space, and I just can't bring myself not to ramble. This chapter is free anyway, so you can't say I'm padding the word count.

Let me see which impatient grannies have made themselves my creditors this time...

Alright, I now honorably owe Tiánxiá one bonus chapter (how does it always end up costing me more than it saves?), owe Magical Grey Feather one big healthy bouncing baby of a bonus chapter (didn't I just say don't be in such a rush?! I actually feel bad), and owe Yīngyòu one big healthy baby (I'd be better off going to stake out the maternity ward at People's Hospital — faster that way)... what are you all doing, you're already here, you didn't have to bring gifts too (lol.

Thank you Tángmián Yè, Shí Zhī Yōulíng, Please Call Me A-Qī, and 锦o (maybe I'll scrape together one kid for the four of you — go home and split it into four pieces, my stockpile is already shivering with cold sweat)

Thank you Péng Xiǎoxī, Pūpū Hāhā, Mí Miēmiē, Mò Yuān (pronounced Black Bird), Fēitiān Dàdào Zéi, Déyún Fūjìn, Kafka, A-Shí qwq, Sān Xī Yī, Yūki Akinana, Qīngqīng Jiǔ, Me and Honeydew Are Mortal Enemies (Melon!!), Jiāng Lù Jīng Lúfù, and Today I Had a Roasted Sweet Potato — what's the rush, grannies, isn't it nicer to let this relationship flow gently like a stream? What if it turns out not good, I'm already second-guessing myself.

Counting the grannies from before, how many bonus chapters do I owe now? Five?

...Five?????

.....????????

Time flows like a river — and by "time," does that mean my stockpile?!

Chapter 6: Sydney Ginn's Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion

She had lost count of how many times she'd fallen from a great height.

Sooner or later, between the alcohol and the repeated falls, her heart would slam against her sternum one final time—and then Sydney Ginn would cease to exist.

But at least this time, she was still alive; even as the blood her heart was furiously pumping surged in waves through her skull, sending wave after wave of dizziness crashing through her.

The hot alcohol turned to sweat and burst from her pores, and the needle-sharp burning across her back faded into a cool, damp chill.

Sydney Ginn would perhaps never stop fearing the fall; but after so many jumps, she had at least learned to land without screaming—there was only her breathing now, ragged and heavy, nearly a whimper; fear like a centipede, crawling and scratching inside her chest and throat.

She had landed in the same old place again.

The room was adrift with the smell of stale dust, the kind that called to mind old cardboard boxes; dim and cool and dark, but not a deep darkness—more like a half-drawn curtain that you could push aside with one hand and find someone hiding behind it.

Sydney Ginn didn't move.

The alcohol still rolled through her like waves born inside her body, rocking and pushing at her.

Something must have been watching over her, because no matter what position she jumped from, she always landed on her feet, like a cat blessed by the heavens.

She crouched in place for a few seconds, then reached out her right hand into the darkness to feel for the wall. Every time she landed, the alcohol left her unsteady on her feet, and she would brace herself against the wall on her right—if someone shone a flashlight on it, they'd probably see the wallpaper gleaming where it had been soaked through with the oils from her hand.

The moment her hand touched something smooth, flat, and square—a plastic panel—she yanked it back as if electrocuted, cursed under her breath, and felt a cold wave of belated terror prickle across her skin.

...Impossible to guard against everything, she thought. Last time she was here, the light switch definitely hadn't been on this wall.

Fortunately, her hand hadn't had enough weight behind it to press down that eager, impatient light switch.

Sydney Ginn moved slowly into the corner and felt her way to the same spot where the faucet always was, then turned it on. She cupped her hands and drank several large mouthfuls; the faucet squeaked and squeaked as it turned two full rotations, then fell silent again.

Unlike food, water in the Nest was generally safe.

Sydney Ginn pulled a flattened fried doughnut and a can of coffee from her bag.

Drink before the jump to numb the fear with alcohol to its limit; after landing, wash the alcohol out with fried food and coffee as best she could—every single time Sydney Ginn entered the Nest, she had to go through the same routine.

She leaned against the corner of the wall and, though she had no appetite at all, forced herself to finish eating, then carefully packed the empty can and paper bag back into her backpack.

Never leave personal belongings behind in the Nest—not even if it's trash. That was a Hunter's first lesson. When she had learned it, Sydney Ginn couldn't remember anymore.

On the far side of the sink, there was a locked storage cabinet.

She fumbled in the dark for several tries before finally fitting the key into the lock; from behind the silently swinging cabinet door, she felt out a radio—cool, heavy, square, and solid.

The static crackle of electricity rose from the depths of the darkness and settled beside her; as she turned the dial searching for the channel, the static slowly resolved into a man's voice.

"Welcome to Nest Radio 173," the man's voice said quietly, as if he were about to begin telling a story. "This is the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion. I am your host."

No name—only "your host."

His—or perhaps its, since no human could live in the Nest—entire identity seemed to exist solely in relation to the radio station.

No matter when Sydney Ginn turned on the radio, the first words she heard were always "Welcome to Nest Radio 173"—as if the host were waiting at all times, and a listener turning on

the receiver was what switched him on.

"Today is Monday, November 16th, 2026."

Time in the Nest moved at the same pace as in the outside world; Sydney Ginn glanced at her phone and confirmed it once more.

On the phone screen, over a hundred ugly unread messages were frozen in place; no signal, no new texts coming in.

"First, let's bring you the Nest news."

In the darkness, Sydney Ginn listened while she waited for the coffee and food to take effect. This hideout should be known only to her, so there was no need to worry about anyone barging in.

In the Nest, where a single moment of distraction could mean the difference between life and death, she sat perfectly still listening to the radio—when she thought about it, she found it a little funny herself.

She was a solo Hunter, without the backing of a House Faction, and the Artifacts she'd managed to get her hands on in the past had all been bottom-tier; by rights, she had no room to be choosy—she should take any Artifact she could get, sell any Artifact she had.

But this one radio—this, she would never sell to anyone. It was her lifeline.

"...We trust that all Residents who truly love the Nest will be very pleased? A great threat to the Nest had only just begun to take root, yet it was swiftly stamped out through the combined efforts of all parties. We hope everyone will share this good news with friends and family—if you haven't already made them into dinner."

Sydney Ginn listened with only half her attention. Honestly, she hadn't understood it; and she had no idea what "great threat" referred to.

The broadcast wasn't made for humans; the host's audience was the Residents of the Nest, so out of every ten sentences, there were about eight that she couldn't follow.

As long as it seemed to have nothing much to do with her, Sydney Ginn couldn't be bothered to puzzle it out; the curiosity she'd felt when she first got the radio had, after nearly dying once, long since vanished completely.

She understood barely half of it, yet she listened anyway.

"A Toyota with the license plate MKA-388 has been parked at the entrance of the Buluan District Public Library for more than seven days. The owner is requested to move the vehicle as soon as possible, or it will be added to the library's vengeance list."

The license plate sounded like a real Blackmoor City plate... could a Hunter really have driven a car in here?

If it had been sitting there that long, the owner was probably dead.

The thought passed through her mind and left no mark.

Being an Artifact Hunter meant racing against the darkness; the Hunters who had been swept under by its black waves and sunk forever into the depths of the Nest were beyond counting by now.

Sooner or later, she would sink down too; she just didn't know what form her grave would take when it finally appeared before her.

"...Next, we'll bring you traffic conditions and map information."

Sydney Ginn snapped to attention, the effects of the alcohol fading considerably, her mind sharpening. She quickly pulled out a pen and a brand-new Blackmoor City tourist map, clamped her phone between her teeth, and used the faint glow of its screen to spread the map out on the concrete floor.

"First," the host said, as though even he understood the importance of this information, slowing his pace, "streets from Fifth to One Hundred and Ninetieth remain unchanged and are accessible as normal today."

She let out a breath of relief.

Whether it was a good thing or a bad thing was unclear, but the Nest seemed to have a life of its own—always slowly mutating.

Before she got the radio, every time Sydney Ginn opened a passage and dropped into the Nest, she had to brace herself mentally—even a location she'd explored more than a hundred times, the next time you pushed open the door, you might still step into a room you'd never seen before.

The Nest resembled Blackmoor City's layout, but in a distorted, off-kilter kind of way—as if the Nest were a slanted, warped mirror image, twisted by light and shadow, breeding from the

gaps and crevices of shade things that did not belong to this world.

Was this a crack in the universe, a legendary hell, or the delusion inside the mind of a madman?

Sydney Ginn had come here more times than she could count, and still didn't know the answer.

After listening to enough broadcasts, she had worked out the patterns.

"Currently undergoing construction/renovation/repair"—this meant the area was in the process of changing.

"Attracting a large number of visitors / a great weekend destination"—absolutely do not go near it; you had to give even the surrounding area a wide berth.

"Unchanged, accessible as normal"—exactly as it sounded: as long as you had previously scouted the terrain and assessed the risks, you could still trust your last experience.

The thing Sydney Ginn had prepared to deal with her stalker was hidden on 99th Street, which happened to fall within an area showing no unusual changes; if everything went smoothly, the journey from her landing spot to 99th Street would take only two days, and she could retrieve the item and return to Blackmoor City.

Two days... she couldn't help letting out a self-deprecating laugh.

By distance alone, it was at most fifteen kilometers between the two points; but in the Nest, covering fifteen kilometers in two days counted as remarkably smooth going.

By the time the traffic and map report was finished, Sydney Ginn's map was covered in circles of all sizes, along with annotations like "DANGER!" "GO STRAIGHT" and "Bus available, but don't talk to the driver."

Based on the experience she had bought with her life over and over again, the broadcasts could be trusted.

If she ever decided to retire, this radio could probably fetch her at least a million dollars.

But Sydney Ginn knew she could never retire—even with a million waiting for her, she couldn't bear to stop being a Hunter—there were too many things in this world worth trying, her desires ran too deep, and a million was far from enough.

"I'm doing him too much of a favor," Sydney Ginn thought, growing more irritated the more she dwelled on it. "What kind of rat crawls out of the gutter thinking he deserves me to bring back an Artifact just to deal with him..."

She put the map and pen away and was just about to pick up the radio from the floor—which was currently playing "Nest's Hottest New Songs Chart No. 1," a track that wasn't actually too bad, sounding like a howling wind through a forest with faint, drawn-out human shrieks woven through it—when the "music" suddenly paused and stopped.

Then again, with something like drawn-out human shrieks, who could ever tell which one was the last?

"What a soothing and melodious song," the host murmured. "I just received a listener call-in, so I'll be adding a special emergency broadcast segment."

Sydney Ginn's breath caught.

A "special emergency broadcast"—since she'd gotten the radio, she had only heard it twice.

The first time, the special emergency broadcast had helped her find a fixed, hidden, and private landing spot—the very small room she was in right now.

She hadn't even known before that, that a human could bind a landing point within the Nest.

In the past, every time Sydney Ginn opened a passage and dropped into the Nest, she had appeared in a public landing point like everyone else—City Hall, the Contre-Jour Garden, St. Louis Hospital, and so on—surrounded by Hunters, Residents, and countless other unknowns, she hadn't even dared stay in one place long enough to finish a coffee.

The second time, the Artifact she obtained through the special emergency broadcast had bought her that apartment in Blackmoor City—the kind of place an ordinary person couldn't get close to in a lifetime. Beyond the payment, the buyer had also signed an open-ended contract: for as long as Sydney Ginn lived, she would have permanent right of residence in that apartment.

Now the third time had finally come.

In that moment, Sydney Ginn's entire field of vision narrowed to the radio on the floor; she forgot to breathe, every ounce of her focus sharpening into a hook, clamped tight around every single word coming through.

"...After entering through Door D of the Museum of Modern Art, take the elevator on the left down to basement level one."

The host's voice flowed slowly from the radio, as if projecting the interior layout of the building inside her mind. "Remember—you must take the first elevator on the left. If the doors of any other elevator open, do not get in, do not look, and no matter what happens, pretend you don't notice."

Although the broadcast audience seemed to be Nest Residents, there were always these small details that made Sydney Ginn feel as though the host was issuing instructions to her specifically—or rather, to whatever Hunter happened to be listening.

"The 'Candlefall' in the first basement exhibition hall is something you'll want to keep in mind. From what I know, it only recently became an Artifact—and some might say it is one of the most powerful Artifacts the Nest has ever produced."

The host paused, as if he could sense the thudding of Sydney Ginn's heartbeat.

"To anyone thinking of going to take a look—take my advice. Human fate is as thin and fragile as a cotton cloth. The floods of this world are too many, too unpredictable—they surge and crash without mercy. A person can only be torn apart and swallowed up in the churning currents, flung by forces far greater than themselves toward a future they cannot see clearly.

"And an Artifact... is a mountain torrent and a tidal wave, a storm and a towering wall of water. It is the genie that grants your wishes, and the god that heeds no pleas..."

He got this far, and then, as if what came next was too difficult to say, he trailed off involuntarily.

The darkened room fell silent for a moment; the host had no breath—Sydney Ginn had realized that long ago.

In the room there were only four or five breathing sounds, including her own, rising and falling together in the dark.

"Dear listeners, that's all for today's broadcast. Please stay safe, everyone—until next time."

Sydney Ginn stood there in a daze for a few seconds, then grabbed the radio and stowed it away again. Feeling her way to the door handle, she cracked the door open and slipped out.

The Museum of Modern Art was in the direction she was already heading.

Go to the museum first to see the Artifact the broadcast mentioned, then head to 99th Street to get what she needed to deal with Anthony...

A day or two's delay was no big deal.

Sydney Ginn only has one chapter, there's nothing in the drafts.

I've seen people asking what Mai Minghe's English name is—Mai Minghe is actually ethnically Chinese, so her Chinese name is just Mai Minghe; but of course she does have an English name, and it's one I'm quite proud of, so pretty that I regret giving it to her—River Rye.

I kind of want to take it back for myself lol.

What's wrong with that? A daughter giving her mother a little tribute is only right, isn't it.

For minor supporting characters like that nuisance Anthony, I'm not going to bother Sinicizing the names—if you can't remember them, you can't remember them; coming up with names that sound both good and distinctive is such a headache.

Writing on an iPad while away from home is such a pain, ugh, it's really affecting my output.

Now I want an e-ink tablet again lol.

Chapter 7 – Sydney Ginn: The Hunter's Life Is No Easy Living

Night in Blackmoor City is also night in the Nest.

Wind tumbled down through the cracks between heaven and earth, tossing her bangs astray. If she squinted and peered out through the shadow of her lashes, Sydney Ginn could barely tell whether she was in the Nest or in Blackmoor City.

A Blackmoor City abandoned and desolate, its shadows twisting, every detail more unsettling the deeper you looked—at the intersection ahead, the green light on the traffic signal had gone dark, replaced by a purple one, blinking on and off; the surface of the empty road was seized by the purple light, then released, seized, then released.

Only sound was truly honest: she couldn't hear car engines, rolling tires, or honking horns; no voices in conversation, no dogs barking, no video blogger narrating into a selfie camera. At this moment, the only sound Sydney Ginn could hear was a steady footstep, one after another.

A soft "tap"—her left foot meeting the ground; before she could even lift her right foot, she heard another "tap."

The footsteps behind her had been following her for several minutes now.

Whoever it was didn't seem much like a Hunter; Hunters who crossed paths in the Nest tended to keep their distance, sizing each other up with cautious wariness—the ever-present threat of extreme danger kept everyone's nerves wound tight, and nobody wanted to invite extra trouble.

If it wasn't a Hunter, then it was a Resident.

Should she pretend not to notice?

Sydney Ginn opened her phone's camera, held it flat against her chest, angled it slightly up over her shoulder, and snapped a photo—quick and discreet.

She quickened her pace to put some distance between them, then darted a glance at the screen.

In the photo, a warped, grinning version of Sydney Ginn's own face was staring back at her.

The teeth were white and enormous, packed so densely they could barely fit inside the mouth, the lips nearly insufficient to contain them. The figure looked to be resting its cheek on someone's

shoulder, flashing a "yeah" hand sign.

Sydney Ginn recognized it at once—that shoulder was her own.

What rotten luck.

"Get lost!" Sydney Ginn hissed without turning around, slashing her hunting knife backward to drive the thing back a few steps. "Who do you think you're dealing with? You think I'm not long for this world?"

Silence from behind. A few seconds of stillness, then she heard her own voice let out a low, tittering "heh heh."

...So it wasn't going to leave on its own.

Annoying as it was, her luck wasn't entirely bad—whatever had latched onto her wasn't especially dangerous.

This type of Resident was common in the Nest. When they set their sights on someone, they would wrench their face into that person's likeness, though the result was always slightly off—an extra eyeball in the right eye socket, a single black hole in place of nostrils, or, as now, a mouth so crammed with teeth it could barely close.

They simply followed their target wearing the target's face, and while deeply unsettling, they posed no immediate threat.

Only after a target met with danger and died would this type of Resident pounce, coiling and writhing and feeding upon the corpse, until when it finally raised its face, it had become an exact, flawless replica of the original. Some said it was perhaps because they longed to return to the human world that they wished to impersonate humans and slip back into Blackmoor City in the original's place—though that was just hearsay, not worth taking seriously.

In other words, they were like vultures over a desert, perpetually circling above animals on the verge of death.

This particular Resident had probably caught the smell of alcohol on Sydney Ginn, noticed the faint sway still in her step, and decided she wouldn't last much longer.

Its technique wasn't up to par with its kind, though—ordinarily, a "Vulture" trailing someone wouldn't let the Hunters notice at all; this one was stomping along quite audibly.

Still, harmless as it might be, knowing that thing's face was hovering just over her shoulder was irritating enough.

She listened carefully, gauging the distance between footfalls with her attention, calculating whether she could create an opportunity to shake it—when a thought suddenly broke through: something's wrong.

Sydney Ginn's whole body jerked. She stopped dead in her tracks, and before she'd even gotten a clear look at the ground ahead, she threw herself sideways off the path, her back hitting the railing with a loud clang.

That noise—who knew whether it would draw other Residents now...

But this wasn't the time to worry about what came next—she'd almost fallen for the Vulture Resident's trick.

"Sydney Ginn" was still standing just a step or two away, watching her, the lower half of its face all smiles and teeth. But the eyes grew deeper and deeper, darker and darker, until they resembled a pair of holes poked by a child's finger into dough.

Sydney Ginn did her best not to look at it, and swept a glance at the ground she had almost stepped onto.

A long chalk-drawn hopscotch grid stretched out ahead, extending far beyond what she could see, covering the entire width of the sidewalk.

The chalk had faded, submerged in the dim yellow glow of the streetlights and the shadows cast by the trees along the roadside; if you didn't look carefully, it was nearly impossible to notice.

The first row had four squares. The first three were blank; only the last one, at the edge, had writing: "Right foot."

"Damn it all, waiting here for me, were you."

Sydney Ginn wiped the cold sweat from her neck with her sleeve, and hissed at her other self: "No wonder your footsteps were so clear, deliberately falling in the gaps between mine, just to make sure I heard you..."

It had been deliberate.

It had wanted Sydney Ginn to fix all her attention on what was behind her, her mind occupied with the question of "how to shake the Vulture"—and there were only so many ways to

shake someone following close behind, and whichever method she chose, she would have ended up breaking into a run and stepping straight into the chalk-drawn hopscotch grid.

If she hadn't stepped into the square marked "Right foot" with her right foot, she would have been in serious trouble.

"November 17th, the Nest, Colorado Avenue. A chalk-drawn Hopscotch has appeared here."

Sydney Ginn opened her voice memo app and briefly described what had just happened, then said, "Although the 'Vulture' did not directly harm anyone, it has shown signs of luring targets into a trap... This is a new behavioral pattern, worth noting."

She had never joined a Hunter House Faction, so when it came to gathering and updating intelligence on the Nest, she naturally couldn't match the systematic, organized approach of House Faction Hunters.

But she had her own way of surviving: she would bring whatever valuable information she'd collected to the bar called "Against the Light," where the owner—whose face looked like a Shar-Pei—would exchange a different set of information in return. He was like a human information exchange board, or a primitive version of LinkedIn.

She put her phone away and looked around, almost wanting to sigh.

To the right was a row of stone-brick townhouses; short flights of steps climbed up to each front door. Between the staircases, clusters of trees separated one from the next, and the railing she'd just slammed into stood just outside the tree line.

Never mind that she was trying to get to the Museum of Modern Art—even if she weren't, she absolutely could not just wander into a Nest building.

To the left, the road was empty; all she had to do was step off the sidewalk and walk along the street to go around the chalk house—under normal circumstances, that would have worked, but not now, because the traffic light was still purple.

"If it weren't for all this garbage, why would fifteen kilometers take two whole days to walk..."

Sydney Ginn muttered under her breath, tucked away her knife and phone, adjusted her trail pack, cinched it tight around her waist, and stepped her right foot into the square.

She stood in the square on one leg like a crane, the alcohol not yet entirely faded, rolling and pushing against her ankle in waves; Sydney Ginn broke into a cold sweat all over, swaying unsteadily, one hand gripping the railing.

The square said right foot only, so she absolutely could not add a left foot.

The smile on "Sydney Ginn's" face froze rigid, then, starting from the cheekbones, began slowly contorting. One cheekbone jutted further and further out, while the other gradually slid downward.

Was it about to give up, seeing that she hadn't taken the bait?

As a rule, when a Vulture saw that "replacing" its target was hopeless, it would abandon the target's likeness—either shifting into someone else's face, or retreating into the shadows and vanishing.

Watching your own features, your own face, warp and melt off another face the way ice cream melts on a summer day—other Hunters had said it was an unexpectedly unpleasant thing to witness.

"Get lost now, and I won't kill you."

Sydney Ginn threw out a hollow threat, turned back, switched to her left foot, and hopped to the middle square of the next row; the moment her single foot landed, the trail pack dragged heavily downward, as if someone had jumped onto her back.

Her hands spun around like a windmill several times before she finally steadied herself, and in her mind she had killed the harassing lunatic Anthony back and forth ten times over—naturally, everything bad was his fault.

But if something good came of this trip, like getting her hands on a rare Artifact, that would obviously be entirely thanks to herself.

She just had to wait for the purple light to go out, and then find a moment to jump off the sidewalk.

The first four or five rows of squares were still reasonable: though hopping forward one foot at a time with a pack weighing more than ten kilograms on her back and alcohol still in her system was exhausting work, at least it wasn't impossible.

At some point—she lost track of which square—the writing inside the squares was no longer just "left foot" or "right foot."

"Left hand," read one square.

The squares on either side of it listed penalties—"Lose consciousness," "Lose all red blood cells produced in the past year," "Visit No. 87 Colorado Avenue."

Fortunately, there was a utility pole right beside that square.

With great difficulty, Sydney Ginn hugged her pack with one arm, braced her feet against the pole, and tipped herself upside down, pressing her left hand into the square—she felt like a circus acrobat, stretching one leg out far behind her, her whole body a trembling, lopsided "Y," barely managing to land on the next square.

"Exchange food for the right to stand," said another square.

That was nothing; Sydney Ginn had no shortage of food in her pack, and good food at that.

She stood on the spot she had purchased with a beef sausage, rested her trembling limbs for a moment, then looked up—and stopped cold.

Every single square within sight ahead was covered in the same three words, packed in densely.

Copied copied copied copied copied copied copied copied

...All penalties?

Copied? What would happen if she stepped on one—

A chill shot through Sydney Ginn. She slowly turned her head, and there on her shoulder she saw a chubby-cheeked profile, flush and round.

Somehow, at some point, it had crept back up without a sound.

She was only about a hundred meters from the traffic light now, yet the purple glow kept blinking on and off, as if it had absolutely no intention of leaving.

The road to the Museum of Modern Art had barely begun, and already she was at a standstill.

Sydney Ginn thought of "The Nest's Current No. 1 Hit Song."

Truly, no exaggeration—the only "song" that could express and carry what she felt in this moment was one of long, drawn-out human howling.

Only six days in and I've already slipped up—can't keep the 10:15 update time anymore...
Whatever, I posted today! Deal with it!

Typed the whole thing with my head drooping, and now my neck is killing me (at home my computer sits on a stand at eye level, so my neck doesn't get tired).

I don't have much neck to begin with—what happens if I lose what's left.

Feeling a bit dizzy and awful, let me go eat something first, then I'll organize everyone's names from the patron list...

(Let me know when you think would be a good time to tell my mom she's suddenly got a lot of new moms.)

Chapter 8: Sydney Ginn's Blackmoor City Transportation and Tourism

Map

"What I'm about to say may be hard to believe. I find it hard to believe myself.

"I'm still standing inside the chalk-drawn hopscotch grid, and I have nowhere to go. I can't go back—I've tried. Behind me, two rows away, there's a square with 'left hand' written in it. When I came through, I could use a utility pole to do a one-handed handstand, but going back, I can't reach that pole anymore."

Carrying a heavy backpack while doing a one-handed handstand on her weaker left side—Sydney Ginn couldn't manage it. Hunters had a passage and could enter the Nest, but that didn't transform them or grant them supernatural strength.

What's more, the Resident's breathing floated constantly at her ear; in the corner of her eye, her own face lingered, vaguely distorted, like a reflection sunk deep underwater, watching her.

She had been gripping the hunting knife again for quite some time now.

Sydney Ginn closed her eyes, then opened them. On the road to her left, the silence continued to be split open—sliced through again and again by flashes of violet light, like wet viscera exposed under an X-ray.

"It seems like Hopscotch and the 'Vulture' Residents have developed a kind of... cooperative relationship."

Sydney Ginn murmured into her phone's voice memo: "I can't think of a better explanation than that they're working together."

The Vultures had tried to drive her into the hopscotch grid, and the grid had returned the favor—once she'd gone deep enough that she couldn't turn back, it had written "Copied" as the penalty in the squares ahead of her...

If she had actually stepped on one, the Resident following behind her would probably become a second Sydney Ginn.

And what would happen to her then?

The original hadn't even died yet, and a Vulture had already become the target itself—she had never heard of such a thing.

"Maybe I'm overthinking it... The traffic light on the road hasn't changed color for nearly ten minutes now. It's been purple the whole time, keeping me trapped on the sidewalk. Could it also be part of this trap? It's hard to imagine... Unlike Residents, other things don't have intelligence. How would they work together?"

The information recorded in the voice memo served more than one purpose, beyond being exchanged as intelligence later.

If she could never leave the Nest and ultimately died here, she could at least imagine that someday her phone would be picked up by some Hunter.

Who she was, where she died, the last moments of her life—none of it would sink with her into the depths of the Nest.

Perhaps somewhere in this world, another person would hear the last few words of her life and know that a Sydney Ginn had once existed. Even if in the very next moment, like wind scattering smoke, her name dissolved with a single turn of that person's thoughts.

Sometimes when she thought about it, she found it strange: someone like her, bursting with desires and devoted to pleasure, was ready to die at any moment, anywhere.

Perhaps without that readiness, you couldn't make it as an Artifact Hunter.

She put away her phone and looked at the traffic light again.

She didn't really need to look up to know the purple light was still on; but what else could she do besides staring at the traffic light over and over?

The buzz of the alcohol had mostly worn off, but her energy and stamina seemed to have evaporated along with it, seeping out through her pores, leaving behind a body that felt loose and heavy; the muscles in her legs trembled, as if they couldn't hold on to the bones.

The square read "trade food for the right to stand"—it said nothing about sitting, so Sydney Ginn didn't dare sit down; the backpack, weighing some ten-odd kilograms, she kept on top of her feet, not daring to let it touch the chalk drawings.

"Just you wait," she said quietly to the Resident beside her. "I don't believe that purple light can stay on for seven days straight."

The Resident didn't respond. It probably knew, too, that Sydney Ginn was just bluffing—even with food and water, standing for seven days straight without sleep was enough to kill a person.

Well, this was exactly why most Hunters, after a few solo runs into the Nest, would put in applications to the major Hunter House Factions... Even someone like Sydney Ginn, who hated taking orders and couldn't stand being managed by others, found herself sighing: it would be nice to have a partner watching her back right now.

She stood in one square of the chalk hopscotch grid as the night wind grew increasingly cool; the longer she stood, the more foolish she felt—what was she even doing here?

She'd survived a fall from a great height, only to stand here like a human post?

After racking her brain for a while, running through every option including climbing a tree and walking a tightrope, only to have each one shot down by reality, Sydney Ginn had even screwed up her courage and, with a what-have-I-got-to-lose attitude, shouted "someone help!" twice—whether it was good luck or bad, nothing came out of that row of stone-brick Western-style houses in response.

She'd tried several plans and was back to her old standby of being a human post.

It would've been nice if the broadcast had given a heads-up—had she known, she never would have taken this wretched road.

That said, Sydney Ginn also knew it was far too much to ask.

If the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion were to introduce the road conditions on every single street in the Nest, by the time it finished broadcasting, she'd have already gone back to Blackmoor City and there would be nothing left to do.

Thinking of the broadcast made her think of her own map, covered in annotations—wait, what if those annotations could actually be useful?

Sydney Ginn glanced over at "Sydney Ginn."

It was still standing two steps away, but it was looking more and more repulsive—when she'd turned her head just now, it had mimicked her, rolling its dark irises to the right so the whites showed, and then staying like that for a long time, unable to roll them back.

That was her own face. She'd have nightmare material for a week.

Sydney Ginn slid the hunting knife back into its sheath at her waist, took the map out of her backpack, shook it open, and studied the annotations carefully by the flickering violet light and the murky yellow glow of a streetlamp.

A few minutes later, she looked up from the map and snapped a sharp curse at the Resident beside her: "Son of a bitch!"

"Sydney Ginn," unaware it had been cursed at, stared at Sydney Ginn with rapt, entranced attention, and its lower lip suddenly drooped crookedly, as if it were trying to mimic the shape of her mouth.

"Get over here!" Sydney Ginn had found nothing useful on the map, and her anger was surging. "They all say Residents can't be killed—so you won't mind if I stab you a few times, will you? Get over here!"

"Sydney Ginn" simply would not come over.

The more she thought about it, the more furious she got. She pressed her lips tightly shut, worked her tongue around for a moment, gathered up a mouthful of spit, and "ptoo!"—spat it all out onto the chalk square at "Sydney Ginn's" feet. Not that whatever penalty the square handed out was any of her concern.

Unfortunately, the square wasn't about to be washed away by spit—though it would have been wonderful if it could—that patch of foamy wet stain dried in the blink of an eye, as if absorbed by the floor tiles, leaving the chalk drawing completely unchanged beneath.

As a result, "Sydney Ginn" mimicked her: pressed its lips tightly shut, and its tongue seemed to stir as well.

"Oh, you've got to be kidding me,"

Sydney Ginn finally panicked a little, and quickly raised her backpack, ready to use it as a shield against the Resident's spit—but thankfully the Resident seemed to be physiologically different on the inside, and when it opened its mouth, it was just a dark, dry hollow. Nothing came out.

The interlude was over, and she was still at a complete loss.

Sydney Ginn stared at the words "Blackmoor City Tourism and Transportation Map" and had no idea what to do. Her eyes lingered on the map, but her thoughts had drifted away, wandering blankly to some unknown place.

By the time she came back to herself, she realized she had been staring at several rows of small print in the lower right corner of the map's reverse side for several minutes already.

Sydney Ginn slowly narrowed her eyes.

The tourism and transportation map included a great deal of additional information—emergency numbers, police numbers, tourism website URLs, travel insurance details... Among all those rows of small print, her gaze snagged on one thing in particular.

The taxi service hotline for Blackmoor City.

Of course, this was a phone number from the real world.

She was currently inside a delusion-like, nightmare-like mirror world, where there wasn't even a phone signal...

A mirror world...

The yellow taxi—one of Blackmoor City's iconic symbols, the yellow taxi that appeared in countless films and television shows—would it also cast its mirror image inside the Nest?

The thought was like a hand placed at the back of her mind, nearly impossible to ignore.

Sydney Ginn was inwardly laughing at herself for having an overactive imagination, for being driven by desperation into wishful thinking, and yet she once again reached for her phone without meaning to—and of course, the upper right corner showed "No Signal."

She hesitated, but in the end entered the service hotline number digit by digit and pressed call.

There was no harm in trying; even if it didn't work, was she really afraid of being laughed at by "Sydney Ginn" standing next to her?

In her taut, tense anticipation, from beneath the night sky sliced into black and violet, came the sound of a dial tone—"beep—beep—beep—"

"Hello," a woman's voice came on. "Do you need a taxi?"

She stood there with her mouth half open, dumbstruck and silent. Was this a hallucination?

"Do you need one, or not?" The woman's voice wasn't impatient—it asked the question matter-of-factly, like a machine.

"I—I do!" The words were out of Sydney Ginn's mouth before a new wave of anxiety hit her. "Wait—are there any conditions for calling a taxi? What do you pay with? I do have to pay, right?"

"Of course. Please note the following Passenger Rules," the woman's voice said flatly. "One, tell the driver the address you wish to go to. Two, do not look at the driver. Three, sit in the back seat. Four, lower your head and lean it between the driver's seat and the passenger seat. Five, recall a recent experience in your mind. Six, do not panic when the driver collects payment."

"...Recall?" Even with all her Nest experience, Sydney Ginn was sometimes still thrown by its strangeness.

"Yes. Please note the following fare requirements. One, the recalled experience must be from within the past month. Two, the scenes and events in the recollection must be continuous. Three, the experience being recalled must have lasted at least three minutes when it originally occurred. Four, the driver only accepts the first experience that comes to mind automatically—deliberately screened or selected recollections are not accepted."

"Is that all? Just a memory—nothing else? I'll arrive safely at my destination and get out safely?" Afraid the other party might play word games, she went through every loophole she could think of and plugged them one by one.

"Correct."

"That works perfectly," Sydney Ginn let out a long breath. "Send a car right away!"

Never mind the past month—even going back ten years, there wasn't a single memory she'd rather die than give up; and besides, it was only three minutes.

"I'm on Colorado Avenue," she gave her address, then suddenly remembered something and quickly asked: "Can you have the driver open the car door for me when he stops?"

She looked at the square beneath her feet, then at the road beside it, and measured the distance with her eyes. That gap—she could lunge across it.

It was just that "landing" would be considerably more difficult than a normal landing; she couldn't land on the sidewalk, and she couldn't land on the road either—she'd figure out the specifics once the car arrived.

Almost too smoothly to be real, the woman's voice replied, "Yes."

Sydney Ginn's sudden rescue made her heart leap with joy; she hung up the phone, and the screen reflected half of a face pressed right up against hers.

The duck was about to fly right out of reach—it must be getting anxious too, right?

"Back off,"

Sydney Ginn used the same method as before, swinging the hunting knife in wide circles to force the Resident back a few steps—and when she came back to her senses, she was sitting in the back seat of a taxi.

...Huh?

The taxi, gradually picking up speed, glided smoothly through the purple traffic light, the numbers on the meter perfectly still. A human-shaped silhouette sat in the driver's seat, a leather glove on the hand resting on the steering wheel.

"...Where are we going?"

The question was barely out of her mouth before she realized she was breathing hard, her heart pounding—as if she had just been through a burst of intense physical exertion.

"The Museum of Modern Art," the voice seemed to be the driver answering, but no matter how she listened, it sounded like it was coming from beneath her feet.

Sydney Ginn decided not to look down.

Though she couldn't remember how she'd gotten into the cab, a little reverse reasoning made it easy enough to figure out—the first memory that surfaced in her mind was apparently something that had just happened when she boarded: the process of giving the driver the address and having her memory taken had already been handed over as the fare.

Well, that worked out; she'd turned misfortune into a stroke of luck, and could ride all the way to the Museum of Modern Art in one go.

She turned and glanced back at the other "Sydney Ginn" she was steadily leaving behind.

Even from a distance, she could tell the Resident was furious: it flailed its arms like one of those long inflatable tube men outside car dealerships, thrashing wildly, and every so often it threw its head back and let out a long howl—yet another new behavior.

Hopscotch, the Resident, the taxi... everything she'd encountered tonight was brand-new intelligence.

The Nest seemed to be changing; she just didn't know whether the changes were still within normal range.

But Sydney Ginn couldn't summon the energy to write any of it down just yet—she slumped in her seat and let out a long, slow breath.

Before the next crisis came along to torment her, all she wanted was to rest properly for a moment.

I'm dying—suddenly going back to cranking out daily word counts is a bit much... after all, my one-week stockpile of chapters took three months to write.

My update pace is probably a really bad fit for the male-demographic channels—is there a disabled-friendly channel somewhere? Maybe I should go there.

Chapter 9 — Goodbye, Sydney Ginn

"Thank you for riding,"

The driver's silhouette didn't move an inch—the one absolutely motionless object in the moving cab from start to finish. "You have arrived at your destination."

Sydney Ginn stood on the street beside the Museum of Modern Art; with a "thud," the car door closed behind her.

When she instinctively turned to look, she caught a glimpse of the yellow taxi's red taillights gliding into the fog that rose from the depths of the night and the white steam curling up from the drain grates, blurring into the distance.

...She seemed to have forgotten something.

Sydney Ginn stood in the street and watched the taillights until they vanished into the dark night, the foggy blue, and the smoky white—though she couldn't say why she kept staring after them.

She knew, of course, that a stretch of her memory had been collected as the fare, and no amount of trying would ever bring it back.

But Sydney felt that what she'd forgotten lay beyond that taken memory—as if there was something she should have noticed but hadn't. It was like the feeling she sometimes got before leaving the house, a vague suspicion that she'd left something behind; like a layer of cloud covering part of her mind, impossible to brush aside, the moon nowhere to be seen.

At times like these, no amount of thinking ever helped; you had to wait until you were already out the door and the moment actually came, and then you'd slap your thigh and suddenly understand.

Oh well—she'd gotten off the car with all her limbs intact and her head still on her shoulders, so whatever she'd forgotten clearly wasn't a matter of life and death. She'd remember it sooner or later.

She pressed herself against the glass door of Entrance D, peered inside first, then carefully pushed it open little by little.

Unlike Blackmoor City, buildings and facilities inside the Nest were almost never locked. If you came across a door that wouldn't open, it usually meant there was a Hunter inside—the faint comfort of a lock seemed to be something people who ventured into these strange and treacherous depths clung to all the more tightly.

After all, people can't survive without at least a little illusion of safety. If everyone knew exactly what was happening in the world at every moment, would anyone dare step out their front door?

Sydney held the door open with one hand but didn't go in. She waited a few seconds, and when silence held on the other side, she stepped inside as soundlessly as she could, placing her foot on the floor.

Even deep into the night, the museum had half its lights on, and the hallways, galleries, and elevator lobbies were all soaked in a white light that looked like it had been sterilized.

Perhaps because it was a museum of modern art, the lighting design and architectural style always left one with a sense of vast emptiness and coldness. Walking between the still white walls and white light, she felt almost too "alive"—too warm, too much, entirely out of place.

Following the signs, she quickly found the elevator lobby.

The broadcast had given three main instructions: one, "take the first elevator on the left"; two, "do not look at the other elevators"; three, "go to the basement level"—none of them complicated. Fortunately, the fare she'd paid getting into the cab hadn't been this particular memory, or she'd really have been in trouble.

Sydney pressed the button, planted herself in front of the first elevator on the left, and stared straight ahead at nothing.

This wretched place—sometimes it wasn't surprising in the least; when a clear "ding" shattered the still air, sure enough, the elevator that arrived first was the one on the right.

A dead silence held for a breath, then, like a zipper being slowly undone, the elevator doors parted.

Sydney didn't look, but every hair on her body stood up like a tiny antenna. Her eyes were locked rigidly on the closed elevator doors in front of her, and she had a vague sense that the elevator on the right wasn't empty—there was something in there.

Let it come, she'd made up her mind long ago—never mind a Resident, even if a flood of cash poured out of that right-side elevator, she would not turn her eyes so much as a fraction.

"How wonderful, there's someone out here..."

A woman's voice threaded out of the elevator like a strand of silk, drawn by some invisible hand, trembling in the air. "Listen to me—I came down from the third floor. Something very serious happened up there..."

Don't talk to me, Sydney told herself silently. I'm deaf and blind.

The display above the first elevator on the left glowed with a blood-red "28"; this building had only three floors above ground.

"Don't be afraid,"

The woman's voice, which had started out thin as a thread, was gradually thickening, as if voices, too, had roots. Or perhaps the woman herself was crawling out of the elevator inch by inch, and the source of the sound was drawing closer to Sydney.

"I'm a Hunter from Blackmoor City too—I came in to retrieve an Artifact I'd hidden... but after I got in, I lost track of time... What's today's date? The day I came in, Reagan was giving his victory speech."

I'm blind and deaf, I'm deaf and blind—Sydney repeated it to herself like a chant.

She shifted a step to the side as if by accident—but not too far, in case the elevator doors opened and she couldn't dart in at the first moment.

"Whatever you do, don't get on that elevator,"

Now that the voice was closer, it no longer sounded like silk thread—it had become sewage gurgling up from the mouth of a dark pit. "I never should have listened to the host... The first two times I got what I wanted and that made me overconfident; the third time it led me straight to my death. Lucky I reacted fast enough..."

The moment the words "the host" reached her ears, Sydney almost couldn't suppress the urge to turn her head. She still kept her eyes fixed on the elevator, but her heart lurched as if it had been jabbed, beating nearly out of her control, the sound of it hammering over and over in her ears.

Her gaze was propped in midair, too afraid to drop; yet a dark shadow had slowly risen from the floor and stilled at chest height beside her, as if it were listening with its head tilted.

...Did a racing heartbeat count as a response to the woman?

Sydney didn't dare make any reaction at all. Her breathing and the dark shadow at her chest held each other in a frozen standoff for a few seconds in the cool, silent elevator lobby—until another elevator arrival "ding" finally broke the stagnant air.

The door of the first elevator on the left opened.

Wait—the woman was stopped right in front of her; to get past, she'd have to go around it. But if she went around it, could that still count as ignoring it?

But if she didn't go around it, she couldn't very well walk right through it either.

Sydney watched the door part little by little, revealing an empty elevator car; just as she couldn't make up her mind, she felt the dark shadow at her chest suddenly flinch to one side and pull back.

"Annoying..." the woman seemed to mutter.

Sydney never stopped to wonder why good things happened to her when they did, because good things were fragile, and they couldn't withstand being examined too closely.

The moment the shadow stepped aside, she immediately strode into the elevator and slapped the door-close button over and over—"thwack thwack thwack"—as if she meant to punch through the panel; the whole time, her gaze stayed turned to one side, never once looking toward the doors outside.

But even without looking, she could feel it in the corner of her peripheral vision—a shadow on the floor, its limbs swaying against the ground like some enormous lizard, slowly crawling away into the distance.

Only when the elevator doors finally shut completely, grumbling as they carried her down into the basement level, did Sydney let out the breath she'd been holding clenched inside her chest.

So far, she'd followed the broadcast's instructions to the letter—nothing should go wrong again—

"...The first two times I got what I wanted," the woman's voice suddenly echoed back in her mind, "and the third time led me straight to my death."

Sydney rubbed the corners of her eyes and decided to push that nagging, distracting thought aside for the moment.

The Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion was meant to be heard by the Nest's Residents—it was no surprise at all that the woman knew about the host.

Compared to the lizard-like Resident in the elevator lobby, she still trusted the broadcast host a little more; that "trust," of course, carried within it three parts doubt, three parts wariness, and three parts scrutiny.

Yet the next few minutes seemed to prove that the broadcast host hadn't said a single false word. In the dimly lit basement gallery, she found the exhibit named "Candlefall" with almost no effort—honestly, it would have been harder to miss it.

Sydney stood before the exhibit and stared, dumbfounded.

Because the exhibit named "Candlefall" was a colossal white candle—roughly her height in diameter and easily tens of meters long—lying horizontally on the floor.

If not for its unmistakably waxy, milky-white surface, smooth and faintly lustrous, and the black wick the length of an arm drooping from one end, it would have looked more like a giant's roof beam. The candle rested on a series of iron frames specially built for it, beneath which ran a row of metal troughs whose purpose she couldn't make out.

"This thing is an Artifact?"

The candle was so enormous that Sydney walked around it for a while and still hadn't made it all the way. "Hard to say how powerful it is, but the size alone is really something..."

This big—how was she supposed to bring it back on her own? Would cutting off a piece work?

She couldn't even tell what this Artifact did, let alone whether cutting a piece off would work.

Ordinary art exhibits always came with a brief introduction to the piece and its creator; from experience, if there was detailed information about an Artifact, it was likely in the write-up.

Sure enough, when Sydney walked around to the other side of the candle, she found that the introduction for "Candlefall" covered half a wall of text.

"Some say time is like flowing water; some say time is speed. But artist Judy Picault believes time is wax... The time we are living through is a candle slowly melting away, giving us the

illusion that its form is still within our grasp; yet the moment it passes, it becomes hardened candle tears, fixed forever in the shape of history.

"...The artist's interpretation of time ultimately gave form to the exhibit 'Candlefall.' The colossal candle visitors see before them represents a long, primordial span of time.

"It is an interactive artwork. Visitors may build a fire beneath the iron frames to heat the candle, watching it gradually deform and shed its candle tears."

Among the neat rows of printed black text, there were lines of handwriting scrawled in—crooked, lurching strokes, as if whoever had originally printed the introduction for "Candlefall" had deliberately alternated one passage of orderly reason with one passage of wild, crumbling madness.

"It's an Artifact okay Artifact Artifact an Artifact that melts time"

"Melt time and you free history from its chains! Go look at your own history don't accidentally kill your past self put me inside, what do you say, put me right beside your past self"

The next passage returned to normal.

"Once the candle grows transparent from the heat, visitors will notice the contents the artist has embedded within the wax. They represent historical events that occurred within the span of primordial time. By re-melting the hot wax and reshaping it—altering the contents inside—visitors can change 'what originally happened.' The artist believes..."

Reading this far, Sydney could no longer hold back; she turned to look at the enormous milky-white candle behind her, and for a moment simply didn't know how to process the shock.

You could melt and reshape this candle to alter time—no, to alter history?

Was she understanding this correctly?

If she was, then being called "one of the most powerful Artifacts in existence" was a title it had well and truly earned.

She would need to study the specific instructions more carefully, and ideally try it herself once. She'd also need to figure out what effect it might have on the future.

She had to form a basic understanding first before she could think about next steps. Cutting off a piece to take away probably wasn't going to work; even with other Hunters to help carry it, it

couldn't be moved, since everyone's passage was different and they couldn't go back together. It seemed the only option for now was to hide it somewhere...

That was the last thought passing through Sydney Ginn's mind before she turned around and a hunting knife was driven into her throat.

After half a year off, everything else aside, my typing speed has practically gone in reverse... I've realized there's a kind of resolute beauty in all of you—I clearly have no resemblance to a donkey that cranks out twenty thousand characters a day and pays off a debt in a month, and yet when you all pledged your support, you were so decisive about it that I, a trembling donkey, was left humbled and awed.

For example, Wanjin... if you won't feel sorry for me, who will? Can't we let our bond flow on gently, like a slow stream? Alright, that's a sixth big fat baby owed. And then there's 95 — she really isn't my alt account, and I have no idea what potential she saw in me, sending people and money and effort and support my way. Alright, that's another big fat baby...

Buwenhuakaijiv, Grandma, don't you already know what I'm like — and then there's Changgoagao's Fish, Always on the Side of the Egg, Linze, Shimodege — you're all Grandma's readers, and we can really take it slow. Can't keep shearing the same flock of sheep forever, can I?

I also want to thank Haiyan Qifeng, Love Letter W0ZV, nestea, Fengyin (you two seem like new readers? or just the quiet type?), Dongxie (somehow you all feel like a matching set?), Banxia Jiejie, Jianbing Fujin (please for the love of god stop), Kafka, Qiti, Junmi xi, Xuanfeng Feiwanr, Qiwu, Weba de Qingjiatiao (did you flip it backwards?) and everyone else for all your support and encouragement... The word "thank you" in Chinese feels like I've worn it down to a nub from overuse! I haven't written anything that good either — it's really not worth all this!

Seven — seven chapter update AAAAAAAA

Maybe I should just go catch all seven Calabash Brothers instead

PS: This one definitely won't take as long to write as Doomsday! Even an eighteen-year-old values her life! Two or three years, I say with the reckless confidence of youth.

Chapter 10: A Gathering of Heroes at Mai Minghe

Mai Minghe had never heard of the Nest, and had no idea what a "Resident" was or how dangerous one might be.

But she figured that no matter how strange things appeared on the surface, nothing could ever violate the internal logic governing it.

The hospital inside the Nest seemed to operate by the same principles as a real hospital: press the call button, and a "nurse" would come—or rather, someone "disguised as a nurse" would come—and that someone's target would be whoever had pressed the button.

The only difference was that nurses in a real hospital came to take care of patients; what the "nurses" here intended to do... she didn't let herself think any further.

If she couldn't escape the ward, she was about to find out firsthand anyway—why waste the energy thinking about it?

To get out, she needed to create a few evenly matched rivals for the patient in the next bed.

There was one truth that held both inside and outside the Nest: only when multiple blades clashed against one another would gaps appear; a single blade would pass through her without any distraction.

The real question was: could she slip through the narrow gap between those blades?

Clearly, the red-haired man had figured out the thinking behind her pressing the button.

The moment he steadied himself, he drove his foot hard into Bed No. 2—its locked wheels grinding harshly across the floor—sending the patient and the whole bed crashing into the cabinet and beds behind him; amid the impact, he shouted without looking back: "Even if you wanted to draw the Artifacts out, you didn't have to press the damn button four times!"

He had a point; to be honest, Mai Minghe was feeling a little regretful herself right now.

She had just rolled off the bed again, hoping to use the moment the red-haired man was blocking her to drop down on the other side of Bed No. 1 and make a run for the door; but before Mai Minghe could even swing her leg across the mattress, she stopped dead.

On the other side of Bed No. 1, a nurse was already standing there.

What filled her field of vision was the hem of a light-colored nurse's uniform.

She froze on the bed, staring at that patch of fabric, and realized that in just a few seconds the room had filled with people.

One human-shaped shadow after another, like trees sprouting from the floor, far more than four of them, stood silent and still in the dim ward.

In her peripheral vision she couldn't make out their faces—only the vague impression of round, oversized heads, all exactly alike, every single one turned to face the corner of the room where two living, breathing people remained.

How had so many of them come?

"...Everyone's so kind. I'm actually feeling much better," she said flatly. "Why don't a few of you head back?"

As the "nurse" beside the bed slowly tilted its neck down toward her, Mai Minghe closed her mouth.

A flurry of fragmented, terrifying guesses raced through her mind; but she hadn't expected that when the figure lowered its head, she would find herself looking at a perfectly normal, healthy face.

"Where does it hurt?"

It was a young, soft round face. It—or should she say "she"?—spoke with a slightly drawn-out southern accent, as if she hadn't been on the job long enough to lose it.

If she looked only at the nurse's large eyes with their slightly drooping outer corners and ignored the round heads one after another in her peripheral vision, ignored the slender black silhouette several meters tall rising from behind the red-haired man, Mai Minghe might truly have believed everything just now was an illusion, a dream she'd been having while lying in a hospital bed.

"Get away from that nurse!" the red-haired man suddenly shouted.

Mai Minghe startled and instinctively glanced toward him—somehow the red-haired man had managed to half-climb the wall, like a knockoff Spider-Man who hadn't quite mastered his powers and looked a bit awkward about it.

The moment he climbed up, what had been behind him was exposed: the slender black silhouette with its head pressed against the ceiling was walking toward Mai Minghe, one step at a time.

On the left and right of the bed, Residents; the only way out was at the foot—

As if heaven had heard her thoughts and set out to grant her wish, Mai Minghe suddenly felt a tightening around her ankle, as though something had seized it and gave a sharp yank; she was pulled helplessly down onto the bed, the nurse's face and the ceiling sweeping past her eyes as she was dragged straight toward the foot of the bed.

Cold and hot sweat broke out all at once; Mai Minghe frantically reached out both hands and grabbed the edge of the bed, but all that accomplished was leaving her palms burning raw—it did nothing to slow her at all.

Whatever was gripping both her feet from beneath the bed and dragging her toward the foot possessed a strength no human could match—never mind Mai Minghe, even a Marine would be no match for it; in her desperation, she called out: "My ankle!"

The little nurse tilted its head.

"My ankle hurts!"

Even as those few words left her mouth, most of her body had already been hauled off the bed, her feet nearly touching the floor.

The slender shadow that had come down from the neighboring bed was standing at the foot of the bed, waiting for her.

It was nothing like what she had planned—the thing wasn't interested in where Mai Minghe was about to be dragged at all: because as she was being pulled off the bed, her pajamas had ridden up, exposing her lower abdomen—and the coils of "snake bandage" wound around it.

The slender shadow reached its hand toward her stomach.

"Oh?" The girl's southern drawl stretched long and warm: "If the ankle's gone, it won't hurt anymore."

Every word she had ever been told a proper young lady shouldn't say made a lap through Mai Minghe's mind.

At the same moment, the slender shadow made contact with her abdomen.

The instant those ice-cold fingertips touched her skin, Mai Minghe nearly lost consciousness.

It was as though the fibers of her skin, her blood vessels, her fascia—all of it seized and twisted together at that icy touch, tying itself into knot after knot; her mind could not endure the agony of her nerve endings knotting up, and darkness was already rising before her eyes.

The little nurse wasn't stopping the slender shadow, her ankle looked like it was about to be lost, and all the while she was still sliding down toward the floor beneath the bed...

Just as Mai Minghe thought all hope was gone, in a flash she heard a screech erupt from beneath the bed.

The emotions that screech stirred in the human ear were almost impossible to describe: the closest comparison would be discovering that your jackpot lottery ticket had fallen into the toilet—watching a winning ticket spiral away with the waste, that gut-wrenching feeling was more or less what it felt like to hear the screech from under the bed.

But regardless, her feet were finally released.

The little nurse let out a small "Hmm?" It had been standing by the side of the bed just a moment ago, yet somehow had already moved to the foot of the bed as well, crouching down to examine Mai Minghe's ankle.

"There's something on your ankle," the little nurse said. "I didn't get through it just now—let me try again."

As it spoke, it raised its hand—and it was the first time Mai Minghe got a clear look at that hand: extending from the wrist was not a hand at all, but a dense cluster of thick, silver-bright steel needles.

In that instant, she thought she understood.

The nurse had jabbed its needles at her ankle, but a pair of hands was gripping that ankle, so the needles had naturally gone straight into those hands instead...

Mai Minghe understood now, but with her elbows propped on the bed and her feet on the floor, even without anything restraining her, she could barely hold herself up enough to keep from sitting down on the ground—she couldn't move at all—because the slender patient was standing right in front of her, body half-folded down, long fingers slowly peeling away the "snake bandage."

Every time they touched, that agony of knotted blood vessels and nerves left her unable even to breathe, let alone walk or run.

"My stomach," she stared at the countless densely packed needle-tips, forcing the words out: "my stomach hurts now... stick it in my stomach..."

The little nurse seemed unable to see the other Residents, or if it could, it paid them no mind; it glanced down at Mai Minghe's abdomen, raised the needle-cluster high, and jabbed downward.

The slender patient finally stopped peeling away the "snake bandage," and suddenly flung its arm in a sweeping swipe at the little nurse—its arm unfolding joint by joint through the air as if it had an unknowable number of joints hidden within it—it sounds slow described like this, yet in the blink of an eye, a curtain was pulled from nowhere, and the little nurse and its steel needles were blocked behind it.

What kind of strange trick was that?

Mai Minghe certainly wasn't going to sit there and wait to see if the little nurse could get out from behind the curtain.

She seized the opportunity, leapt up, darted past the slender patient, and sprinted for the ward door—from the moment she had first spotted the little nurse to now, only a few seconds had passed, and already she felt like half her life had been used up.

"Keep it up," a round-headed figure said from the darkness.

Do I need your encouragement?

"Duck," said another round-headed figure, still in place, in a flat tone.

Who would duck at a time like—

Mai Minghe slammed to a halt and dropped into a crouch. She immediately felt something whip past just above her head—and something went thud against the doorframe of the ward.

She was only five or six steps from the door now, yet she had no choice but to turn back; unwilling to give up, she shot a quick glance—there seemed to be a pale white hand embedded in the doorframe, attached to an impossibly long arm.

A spiderweb of cracks spread across the wall around the doorframe.

If she hadn't ducked, that hand would have landed squarely on the back of her head and smashed her against the doorframe like a fly.

Well. She really did need the round-heads' encouragement after all.

"Hey!" Mai Minghe ran toward the cluster of motionless round-headed figures and called out: "What's the deal with all these big heads?"

From behind one of the round-headed figures, a shadow suddenly stirred—Mai Minghe had barely startled before she heard it suck in a sharp breath, as if fighting through pain, and answer: "I've never seen this kind of Resident before. I don't know either."

Apparently the red-haired man had come down from the wall at some point and seemed to have been injured in the process; probably to avoid the slender patient, he had also moved close to this cluster of round-headed figures in the center of the room, separated from her by several shadowy forms.

Mai Minghe badly wanted to keep asking him what Residents he had seen, and what Residents even were, but this was clearly not the time—the slender patient had already turned its head in this direction, and the sound of its crown scraping against the ceiling made a soft, rasping hiss.

As if terrified of the slender patient getting close, the red-haired man quickly threaded himself between the round-headed figures; his face was ashen, slicked with sweat, as he edged sideways in small steps through the crowd toward the door, not daring to brush against any of the round heads.

Mai Minghe followed his lead and quickly stepped into the forest of round heads as well.

The moment she got a clear look, it felt as though every organ inside her had lost its support and dropped deep into her gut.

The reason they had all looked identical was that in the dimness, every head appeared swollen and round and enormously large; but up close, the round-heads were actually of all kinds—men and women, old and young, their features all different.

Yet what should have been normal human skulls had every bone separated—the facial bones, the cranium, all of it—and some gas-like substance beneath had inflated the skin outward, forcing the shattered bones and human skin together into a perfect sphere: the fragments of bone shattered beneath the skin were still recognizable by their shapes, calling to mind the continental plates drifting on the surface of the earth.

The eyes, one on each side, were set separately into either side of the skull, like two blisters risen from the flesh, swiveling to follow Mai Minghe's footsteps; the nasal bone had been split cleanly in two down the middle, pulling two crooked, elongated nostrils open across the "face."

The mouth, at least, was normal; beside the corners of the mouth, across every face, long lines of deep-purple sunken grooves ran everywhere—the marks left by skin stretched until its fibers had torn.

A guess suddenly surfaced in Mai Minghe's mind. "Could these originally have been people?"

The red-haired man rounded the last round-headed figure, stepped clear of the cluster, and strode toward the door. "Sorry—you're the Resident's target, and there's nothing I can do about that. If I ever get the chance to see your body again, I'll bring it back to Blackmoor City for you."

He truly wasn't the target; he was nearly at the door of the ward already, and the slender patient paid him no attention whatsoever.

At this point the nurse was still standing blankly behind the curtain, only its shoes visible below; the two hands reaching out from under the bed were also motionless.

Only the thin, elongated patient drifted slowly back and forth before that cluster of round-headed silhouettes, as though waiting for an opportunity to strike at Mai Minghe.

"It can't get in," said one of the round-headed figures standing to Mai Minghe's left, almost as if to reassure her.

The one on the right said, "We'll all surround you,"

A round-headed figure behind her finished the thought: "and walk together toward the door — you'll be able to get out."

Ugly as these things looked, they had a surprisingly good heart, and their idea wasn't bad either — Mai Minghe lowered her head, staring at the floor, and a thought that had surfaced not long ago flickered through her mind again.

No matter how bizarre the surface appeared, nothing could ever violate the inner logic by which it operated.

She snapped her head up and called out, "Hey, young man — stop right there, don't you dare step outside!"

Honestly, I was perfectly comfortable in the women's fiction side of things, and it was never my intention to come stir up the men's fiction scene... The numbers on the women's side aren't great, sure, but it's a nice little space for a small community to enjoy themselves. The mood is calm — everyone's numbers are more or less the same, there's no real difference between first place and tenth, and it's all very harmonious.

Men's fiction is a different story. The vibe feels anxious and high-pressure, like everyone's grinding out ten-thousand-character daily updates trying to blow up and dethrone the kings, chasing votes, chasing tips, rushing the plot, fast-forwarding to the power fantasy moments... I don't have that kind of firepower. Looking at all the rankings and charts and votes, I don't know how to put it — it feels like being swept into a roaring current, and it wouldn't be surprising to sink to the bottom any moment.

I still hope to work slowly and carefully, and write as well as I can. I also hope everyone will feel free to ask me to take days off — I'll absolutely say yes, every time.

Chapter 11: Mai Minghe's Rock-Paper-Scissors

In truth, Mai Minghe didn't really expect that the red-haired man, upon hearing her shout, would immediately pull back his foot and not step outside.

With an escape route right in front of him, who would hold back from taking that one step?

So what happened next truly exceeded her expectations by a wide margin: the red-haired man urgently pulled back the foot he'd been about to step into the corridor with, the motion so sharp he nearly lost his balance; he pressed one hand against the wall, hopped back two steps on one foot, and stopped in the doorway between himself and the round-headed figures, letting out a curse.

"How did you know?" His gaze passed over the round-headed figures one by one and landed on Mai Minghe.

The room was packed with "Residents" ready to move against them, yet at this moment there was a hairline gap between the knife's edges—a rare opportunity to exchange a few words.

Mai Minghe answered immediately: "I don't know what's going on exactly—I only know we can't go out there. What did you see? You didn't stay in just because some elder told you to, did you?"

"Don't talk down to me like you're my elder." The red-haired man rubbed his face irritably and said, "There's a Resident at the doorway."

The ward door stood wide open, revealing a hollow, brightly lit corridor; in the corridor's light, there was not even a shadow on the floor tiles.

"Really? Well, that's something—don't tell me it knows how to turn invisible?" Mai Minghe said, surprised, and couldn't help marveling, "Have they actually made that work? I remember back in '75 or '79, some scientist said they could use electromagnetic waves or something..."

"Stop rambling about nonsense," the red-haired man cut her off, his expression darkening further. "How did you know we couldn't go out?"

Mai Minghe first glanced at the tall, thin patient.

In her youth she'd stood five foot eight, yet even then she could only have seen the tall, thin patient's navel; the hospital gown was far too short, hanging at chest level, and there was a dark,

gaping hole in its stomach—she didn't dare look long, and quickly averted her eyes.

Mai Minghe hadn't forgotten that inexplicable step she'd taken outside.

The tall, thin patient still seemed unwilling to give up, but just as the round-headed ones had demonstrated, as long as she was surrounded by them, it appeared to lack the nerve to come inside.

She had a moment to catch her breath, though she had no idea how long it would last.

"These things came here to harm people, didn't they?" Mai Minghe explained. "They're so eager to help me get out—that means we definitely can't go out."

The red-haired man paused, as though Mai Minghe's words were a handkerchief stuffed into his mouth. "...That's it?"

"There are two other reasons, actually," Mai Minghe said, a little sheepish. "I don't know if you'll agree. You seem familiar with the Nest—take a look: are there a lot of lines on the faces of these round-headed ones?"

The red-haired man gave a nod—only half his attention was on Mai Minghe; the other half kept shifting back and forth among the round-headed figures, the tall, thin patient, and the empty doorway, staying alert.

"Same principle as stretch marks," he said in a low voice, "except they've grown on their faces."

For someone who didn't look like a married man, he knew a fair bit about that sort of thing; Mai Minghe couldn't help thinking that in the old days, if a man knew too much about women's bodies, it was somehow considered shameful.

Young people nowadays seemed different—though she wasn't sure how much things had really changed.

"Right. Their heads have been stretched as full as a nine-month belly, so it's no wonder they've developed those marks—but marks like that only appear when the fibers of living human skin are pulled apart and torn.

"It occurred to me: the bird-like Residents inside the Nest aren't human at all, so why would they bother growing stretch marks? If the round-headed ones were once living people... what on earth turned them into this?"

A bubble-like eyeball swiveled around and looked at her.

The red-haired man kept his gaze on the doorway, nodded, and said, "Makes sense. It means whatever turns people into Residents like this hasn't shown itself yet—it's lurking somewhere."

Even though it was invisible, the thing was right there in the doorway; thinking about it that way, no wonder the round-headed ones were all gathered in the center of the room, leaving the door clear instead of blocking it.

If Mai Minghe hadn't pressed the call button four times, if the thing hiding in the doorway were the only Resident she'd summoned, she would surely have woven past the figures in the room and made straight for the exit—and in that situation, she would almost certainly have walked straight into its hands.

From below the ceiling came the tall, thin patient's voice: "Had enough of the deduction game?"

The voice slid into her ears with a sticky, slithering quality, and Mai Minghe was hit by another wave of dizziness—nauseated to the point of retching—the biological instinct to expel invading pathogens and toxins from the body.

The tall, thin patient slowly bent at the waist; its face was about to emerge from the darkness and into the light of the doorway.

The red-haired man suddenly cried, "Don't look at it!"—Mai Minghe instantly turned her gaze away, retreating behind one of the round-headed figures, her heart hammering again. She noticed her mouth had gone dry and bitter; she didn't know how long it had been.

"Give it to me,"

The tall, thin patient was bent over, its skull hovering above Mai Minghe, its voice echoing and dripping down, so that one almost had the illusion that the sound itself carried slime and shreds of flesh.

Its hand circled above the crowd several times as though trying to grab Mai Minghe, yet it never reached down; it only howled: "Give it to me! Give it to me give it to me give it to me give it to me!!!"

Mai Minghe hunched over, her stomach acid surging up without control, spattering onto the floor.

Dizzy and weak-legged, she reached out and grabbed one of the round-headed figures by the arm; the round-headed figure immediately began to moan softly, murmuring, "It hurts... it hurts so much..."

Your skull is splitting open and you don't call that pain, yet me grabbing your arm for support is?

Mai Minghe steadied herself, straightened up, and let go; the round-headed figure fell silent.

"Damn it, this thing is dead set on getting the Artifact." The red-haired man stood against the wall, staring at the tall, thin patient. "Residents inside the Nest who want Artifacts are actually pretty rare—and of all things, you ran into a troublesome one."

Even without looking at it or going near it, the mere sound of the tall, thin patient's ceaseless howling was unbearable; if Mai Minghe kept vomiting, she would be dehydrated and unconscious before long, left as helpless as a fish on a chopping block.

The red-haired man had more than just experience—he probably had a way to deal with this too. She was about to ask him what to do when she heard him speak again: "...Rock, paper, scissors."

What?

A rustling sound came from below the ceiling, and even the elongated patient seemed to turn its head toward him.

"Are you casting a spell?" Mai Minghe asked with a wry smile.

"No, I just suddenly thought of that game." The red-haired man pressed his back against the wall, standing in a spot far from Mai Minghe and all the Residents, and said, "Think about it—why does the tall thin one want to grab you, but won't actually reach out and do it?"

"It's... wary of something?"

"Right, it doesn't dare touch the round-heads. The round-heads said it themselves—they counter it. So it won't make a move on the Residents by the door either, because the moment it turns around, the round-heads behind it can pounce." The red-haired man continued, "As for exactly why, I don't know either. And then the tall thin one counters you—no question about that —"

Hearing this, Mai Minghe understood.

"Like rock, paper, scissors, where each one beats another in a cycle," she said, cautiously reaching out toward one of the round-heads. "So next would be... I counter the round-heads?"

The moment she touched its arm, the round-head immediately began buzzing and moaning, its legs even starting to tremble and shake.

"I don't understand why they're afraid of you either," the red-haired man said.

"It's not fear, though..."

The elongated patient laughed in halting, staggered bursts, as if it had realized it could torment Mai Minghe with its own voice—and it had to be said, it had found the right approach.

"These humans—after being caught by the thing at the door, it pumps its own bodily fluids into them, turning them into flesh tentacles, each one standing upright from the ground, used specifically to deal with other Residents."

Mai Minghe wanted to hear more information; she just wasn't sure whether her insides would hold out.

As the elongated patient spoke, she stood half-bent over, feeling as though some great beast were churning deep in her abdomen, trying to force its way up her throat; all she could do was curl like a shrimp, wracked with spasms—she was completely helpless.

"A person has to be alive to serve as a flesh tentacle. When stimulated by another living person, the anesthetic effect of the bodily fluid diminishes, and the flesh tentacle risks regaining consciousness, separating from the host, and dying." The elongated patient explained with almost patient deliberateness. "When you touch them, it's the same as waking them back up—dragging them into unimaginable pain."

"Shut up," said one of the round-heads at the front, in a flat tone.

Mai Minghe was of the same mind—please, shut up.

"So that's how it is—the situation's at a stalemate." The red-haired man let out a small sigh of relief and said, "If the flesh tentacles attack the tall thin one, they have to move, and the moment they move, they expose you. If the tall thin one seizes the chance to grab you, it can use you to make the tentacles wake and detach, and in the end the two of them destroy each other. But that has nothing to do with me—getting dragged into this is a real injustice."

No one, human or Resident, paid him any attention.

...He had probably already made his plan—to use the moment the Residents came for him as a chance to escape.

Mai Minghe was furious, nauseated, and envious all at once, wishing desperately she could trade places with him.

"We can take a page from the human spirit of negotiation. Give me the person," the elongated patient said, not the least bit concerned about whether Mai Minghe would vomit up her stomach, "and give me the Artifact."

That was bad.

"How do we give her?" one of the round-heads asked.

"You have the flesh tentacles part," said the elongated patient. "I take the Artifact off her, then toss her to the door—toss her right into your mouth."

"And you guarantee it?"

"Of course. I have no interest in her."

The round-head was silent for a moment, then answered: "Agreed."

Mai Minghe felt very much not agreed.

But cold sweat was already breaking out across her back, and she had no idea how to stop this. Even if she could counter the round-heads, so what? Could she actually bring herself to wipe out her only line of defense?

Sure enough, the round-heads began to part in front of her, and all she could do in that moment was follow along behind them—wherever they retreated, she retreated too. For a moment, it was almost like playing a deadly game of duck-duck-goose.

"If you'd just given me the Artifact at the start, I might have let you live out your days as a little old lady," the elongated patient said, utterly unbothered by her stalling and resistance, laughing in a flat, measured way. "But you had to be clever, and in the end you'll only bring about your own ruin..."

It hadn't even finished speaking when Mai Minghe involuntarily doubled over again in another round of dry heaving. She had already emptied everything there was to empty; her consciousness was swimming and dim, and she could feel the round-heads hurrying away from her side.

No good—she had to stay with them—

She had no time to straighten up before the elongated patient reached down one hand and closed it tightly around her calf.

1. A stockpile of saved chapters is like snow under the summer sun—every glance shows there's less of it, and sooner or later it runs out completely... Last chapter I saw how enthusiastically everyone was asking me to take a day off. In male-oriented fiction where even one chapter a day can get you cursed out, isn't that something of a revolutionary force? It'll happen, it'll happen—I'll make sure everyone goes home happy, welcomed in like guests, cozy and chatting away.

2. I'm getting on a plane again on the 23rd—this year's theme is just one long haul after another. By my count, over the next few weeks I'll have spent thirty or forty hours in total curled up on planes. Every airline would find life a little emptier without me.

3. The world of the Artifact Report has a lot of settings and details to cover from every angle, plus the shifting POV format—I'm not sure how you all are finding it so far? Does the worldbuilding need to be laid out more plainly? Even though it's a modern Western setting, it doesn't feel like too much to swallow, does it? I stuck with Western-style translated names for the locations—otherwise Sydney Ginn getting into trouble on Red Flag First Street would feel like a completely different show.

4. I just love rambling. After all, a mouth is a mouth—when I'm bored it's either eating or talking, and talking nonsense doesn't put on any weight.

Chapter 12: Mai Minghe's Comedy Horror

In the instant the world tilted, Mai Minghe remembered only two things.

The first was sharp and overwhelming, driving away all capacity for thought and conjuring a warped hallucination before her eyes—for some reason, she found herself thinking of a time more than forty years ago, when she had gone on an outing in the countryside and seen a large tree.

It was the ugliest tree she had ever seen in her life: infected by some fungus or virus, the entire trunk was covered in gnarled, knotted burls, one piled on top of another, galls and warts crisscrossing every which way, so that at first glance it looked almost nothing like a tree—more like one great mass of brown, misshapen, overgrown flesh.

In cold sweat, trembling, and pain, she looked down at where her right calf should have been, and had the illusion that she was looking at that tree from forty years ago again—she hadn't even noticed when her head had struck the floor.

Thin, sickly fingers wound around her calf, joint by joint, long and slow.

The second thing was not really a feeling at all—it was a dull thud she heard, as though some heavy object had struck something, not far from her.

When she first heard it, Mai Minghe's mind had been wiped blank by the onslaught of pain, and she had not thought at all about what the sound might be; but something—whether it was the slick floor beneath her palm, or a flicker at the edge of her vision—struck her like a bolt of lightning through her hazy consciousness, and her mind suddenly lit up.

...So that was it.

Because the Slender Patient had been deliberately tormenting her, she had barely done anything since this all began—she had been doubled over retching amid the circle of Round Heads, unable to do much else; but no one in the ward had anticipated that this torment would bring with it another entirely unexpected consequence.

Which was that the ceramic tile floor of the ward was now smeared everywhere with slick, sticky patches of vomit and stomach acid.

In the "eagle catches the chicks" game just now, five or six pairs of feet had tramped back and forth through this slippery filth, spreading it all over the place—which meant that anything

walking on two legs faced a very real risk of slipping and going down hard enough to knock its teeth out.

No matter how strange a flesh-tentacle thing might be, if it walks upright on two legs, it still has to eat dirt when it slips—right?

The moment that thought came to her, strength surged from Mai Minghe's battered body; and as the Slender Patient's shadow loomed over her, she wrenched herself around with all her might and saw it.

Not far away, one of the Round Heads had indeed just fallen to the floor and was flailing, feet skidding, trying to get back up.

In that moment, if Mai Minghe could have laughed, she would have laughed out loud—think you can run?

No matter how bizarre the surface might be, the underlying logic could not escape; it seemed that the basic laws of physics applied to the strange things inside the Nest just as well.

In that moment, Mai Minghe forgot the Slender Patient entirely, lunged forward, stretched out her arm, and grabbed that Round Head by the ankle.

At the same moment, the Slender Patient's hand touched her abdomen again.

It would not have been strange at all if she had lost consciousness; what was strange was that she didn't.

The Slender Patient's shadow loomed high above her, and she still did not dare look at its face—her eyes fixed only on the ankle gripped in her left hand, staking everything on it.

Through the pain that blurred her mind, through the growing emptiness and dread as the "Snake Band" was peeled away from her body inch by inch, Mai Minghe held on to that Round Head's ankle without loosening her grip one bit—and then a pained groan that did not belong to her shuddered through the room.

"Tell it... tell it to get lost..." she wheezed, her words barely intelligible. "Otherwise I won't... I'll never..."

She didn't finish the sentence, but it didn't matter—the Resident at the door understood perfectly well.

Within a few seconds, one of the distant Round Heads said aloud, "Let her go!"

The Slender Patient appeared not to hear, still peeling the "Snake Band" away little by little, its movements slow and careful, almost gentle—yet no matter how delicate its touch, the pain it inflicted was still enough to blacken her vision.

"Hurry up,"

all the Round Heads urged in unison, striding toward the Slender Patient in perfectly synchronized steps. "A mature flesh-tentacle can't be lost—make her let go, or—"

"I know," said the Slender Patient, which was indeed wary of the Round Heads; seeing them all advance together, it finally released the hand gripping Mai Minghe's calf—its other hand still held the "Snake Band," and it clearly was not willing to let go of the Artifact.

The moment it let go, blood began to return to her calf, and what had been a knotted, tumor-covered tree slowly became a flesh-and-blood limb again.

But it was too late for that to help her.

Mai Minghe watched as a long, ghastly pale hand drifted through the air above her, its fingers unfurling joint by joint—how many joints were there?—and swung down toward her arm; never mind how much it would hurt when it connected, she had no confidence whatsoever that she could withstand that sweeping blow without having her hand knocked away.

If her hand was knocked away, wouldn't all her effort be wasted?

Before it could reach her, Mai Minghe shoved off the floor, barely managed to twist her body, and shot her right hand out toward the Round Head's ankle—if one hand wasn't enough to hold on, would two do?

She knew this idea was perhaps naive. She knew she had been driven into a corner that an ordinary human could not fight their way out of.

The world seemed to run its wheel over a person again and again, all just to make you bow your head, make peace with it, and swallow your resentment; she didn't know how she had lived through eighty-six years of it. The days that had felt endless at the time, like she could never endure them to the end—they had all passed in a flash.

If she had pushed back a little more often, resisted a little longer here and there, perhaps she wouldn't be carrying so much regret today—too much to bring herself to think about.

Compared to all the tangled suffering that people in this world had made for one another, these strange creatures were refreshingly simple and direct—almost endearing in their straightforwardness.

All she had to do was reach out one more hand. She could do it.

She could definitely—

The thought hadn't finished forming when a brief darkness swallowed Mai Minghe's mind and she knew nothing at all.

When the shapes around her came back into focus, she found herself lying on her side, both hands slack and empty against the floor.

The Round Head had long since scrambled up and retreated; the Slender Patient was peeling the last section of the "Snake Band" from her back—just one more coil and it would be gone from her entirely.

...She had failed?

Even two hands hadn't been enough to keep hold of the Round Head.

Mai Minghe lay on the floor smeared with her own stomach acid, her body seeming to have gotten a head start on returning to her eighty-six years, all weak softness and heavy weight.

The Slender Patient extended two fingers—long enough to skewer a person clean through—and flipped Mai Minghe over like a lump of dead meat, laying her flat on her back, then continued to peel away the final stretch of "Snake Band."

Being flipped like that, Mai Minghe's right hand flopped softly onto her own chest.

...Hm?

Her fingertips were wet—she didn't know if it was blood or filth; her nail beds especially were thick with it, a heavy, uncomfortable layer.

Wait.

...Blood?

The thought that surfaced in her mind sent a shudder through her whole body; as though driven by pure survival instinct, without thinking, she raked her hand down at the Slender Patient's arm.

Every time she had touched the Slender Patient before, the pain had been unbearable—so the Slender Patient had probably never imagined that Mai Minghe would willingly reach out and touch it. But there was something else it had imagined even less.

The instant Mai Minghe's fingernails made contact with the Slender Patient, it burst suddenly into a great churning mass of billowing shadow.

It was as though her touch had been an agony beyond all measure—so painful that the Slender Patient hurled the Artifact away, its long body writhing and shuddering, like a plume of grey-white, startled mist rising in the dim air.

...Just as she had thought.

Mai Minghe did not dare waste a moment; she immediately pushed off the floor and hauled herself upright, and the "Snake Band," as if alive, wound itself around her body again in coil after coil.

Once she was on her feet, she quickly stretched out her hand and flicked the liquid from her fingertips hard toward the Slender Patient—and as she flicked, she thought it over, and couldn't help but start laughing between gasps, the sound like broken glass, halting and sharp and bright.

It wasn't that she had a strange personality, laughing in circumstances like these—it was that the scene was actually funny: a spindly shadow with its head pressed against the ceiling, writhing and rolling, arms and legs flailing; and next to it, a woman flinging her hand at it in tremors so violent they looked like a stroke—one person, one ghastly thing, both looking like they'd grabbed a live wire.

Anyone who saw it would have to agree: even if you'd blundered into a horror film, this was a comedy horror.

"What's happening?" the red-haired man asked blankly from the other end of the ward. "Did it take the wrong medication? Did you?"

He was standing beside a hospital bed, pushing it toward the door, and at the sight of the Slender Patient's condition he had stopped moving altogether.

The moment Mai Minghe saw him, she understood immediately what he was doing, and called out at once: "Wait—take me with you!"

Even as the words left her mouth, she had already skirted around the Slender Patient and sprinted toward the bed; before the red-haired man could react, she leaped onto it and rolled on,

crying urgently: "Go, go, go—it's not dead yet!"

The red-haired man looked like he wanted to curse, then seemed to realize he had no time for it.

"You've got a nerve, hitching a ride—"

He bit off his complaint halfway, gripped the bed rails, and broke into a run, pushing the bed at full stride; just before they reached the doorway, the red-haired man grabbed the side rail, shoved off with one foot, and jumped onto the bed—and with the momentum already built up, the bed went rattling and rolling straight out the door, carrying both of them with it into the corridor.

"Don't touch the floor," the red-haired man shouted, kicking off against the wall to send the bed sliding farther down the corridor. "That Resident is underneath the floor!"

"It really is under the floor?" Mai Minghe gripped the bed tightly and said, "I told you not to go out the door because I'd noticed what looked like lots of fine lines drawn on the floor tiles between the Round Heads—I knew something was off about that. Thank goodness it wasn't invisibility."

"Invisibility has nothing to do with it!"

As the bed slid past the doorway, the floor tiles seemed to sense something; blood-red threads suddenly seeped up through them, like the countless red veins that appear in an eye filled with urgent fury—but both of them were seated on the bed, not touching the floor, and the "eye" could only watch helplessly as they glided away down the corridor, bed and all.

"What made that tall skinny one suddenly go berserk?" the red-haired man asked, pushing off the wall to move forward, not forgetting to ask.

The explanation was actually quite simple: when Mai Minghe had made that grab for the Round Head just now, she hadn't caught it, but her right hand had scraped open the skin of its ankle.

Before falling into the Nest, she had been a bedridden old woman whose fingernails had gone uncut for a long time and had certainly never been filed smooth—that desperate, clawing grab had dug deep enough to break the skin, and her nails had come away coated in the Round Head's blood.

"...Doesn't the Round Head counter it?"

Mai Minghe gave the wall a kick as well; the bed advanced through the corridor in a Z-pattern, and with each lurch as it struck one wall, it jolted whoever was speaking mid-syllable.

"Then whatever's inside a Round Head's body must counter it too—right? So I smeared that bit of blood on its hand. I really didn't expect it to have such a big effect."

The red-haired man couldn't help but smile. "And this is really your first time in the Nest? Well done."

"Are they going to catch up?" Mai Minghe asked.

"Very likely," the red-haired man glanced back down the corridor—still empty for now. "Get ready—we'll slide a bit farther, then we'll have to jump off and run."

As they spoke, the bed carrying the two of them glided past the window of one of the rooms.

In the glass, Mai Minghe caught a fleeting glimpse of her own reflection: hair in disarray, face pale, one side smeared with filth...

But a smile played at the corner of her mouth, and she looked the very picture of someone in the prime of their life.

Tomorrow I have to leave for the airport at five in the morning, and there's another flight the day after landing — absolutely exhausting. Watching the last little bit of my stockpiled chapters about to run dry, I feel like a wastrel who's squandered his inheritance: my ancestors left me a thousand taels of silver and ten thousand acres of farmland, and I've gambled it all away. It's over!

Before I board the plane, let me take a moment to sincerely thank the following new patrons:

Thank you Haynes for feeding me McDonald's (I already know exactly what I'll spend it on) — your support will surely be converted into body fat, keeping me company on my person, possibly for the rest of my life...

Thank you Ironclad Baitang for the several cups of coffee you gifted (you're back for the new book! Coffee is the only thing in the world keeping me from turning into a zombie) — if you ever catch a whiff of coffee in a chapter from now on, part of it is thanks to your support;

Thank you Weibaodeweimaor for the Minoxidil gift; why, you ask — seeing your username gave me quite the illusion that I'm Sun Wukong, as if plucking a hair and blowing on it would summon an enthusiastic reader to support me. What a bargain that would be. I want to grow more fur.

I also want to thank vitang for the sweets (my life ambitions really aren't all that grand), and to thank Kankankǎn Sherlock, Miemie's Little Fatty Soap, and the whirlwind Feiwán who treats gifting like checking in daily — thank you all for the encouragement. See you after I land!

Chapter 13 — Mai Minghe: The Way Things Tend to Go

"We've been through life and death together — I saved you, and you saved me."

The red-haired man was covered head to toe beneath a white sheet, and his voice came out muffled when he spoke.

In the room thick with the smell of disinfectant, an old incandescent bulb began to hum the moment it was switched on; Mai Minghe opened her eyes, only to find a white cloth draped over her face, her whole field of vision a murky, dim white.

"With that in mind, I won't go after the Artifact on you — for now. But if you run into any of my other Hunters, and they come for you, I certainly won't stop them. This is our mission, after all, and my people risk their lives to enter the Nest — I have no right to ask them to give that up."

"...That part I can live with,"

Mai Minghe spoke from beneath the white sheet, a warm, damp breath of air trapped between her and the fabric. "What I want to know is why we're lying in the morgue pretending to be corpses."

A few minutes earlier, the two of them had decided they were far enough from the Residents below, and had leapt off the hospital beds and bolted, desperate to put as much distance between themselves and the ward as possible and shake the Residents for good.

But as Mai Minghe ran, she had glanced back in a hurry, and in the distance she caught a dark shape flashing across the doorway of the ward — it looked like a Resident had given chase. The red-haired man noticed too, and hissed under his breath: "Running isn't going to work. We need to hide — follow me!"

The Spindly Patient was three or four meters tall and could stretch its body further still; if that was the one chasing them, there was truly no outrunning it.

What Mai Minghe hadn't expected, though, was that the red-haired man would lead her straight into a stairwell, clatter down to level B1, and then push open a door marked "Morgue" as if he'd done it a hundred times before.

When she hesitated in the doorway, he turned and shot her a glare. "Get in here — what are you standing around for? Do you want the Residents to catch up?"

Easy for him to say — who sees the word "Morgue" and feels any urge to rush inside?

Still, when she saw that her only living companion in this godforsaken place had already stridden in, it became clear that staying outside wasn't really an option either.

The moment she stepped through the door, an involuntary shudder ran through her; the temperature inside the morgue was at least three or four degrees colder than out in the hall.

"Find an empty bed," the red-haired man said, switching on the morgue light. He lifted a white sheet off one of the beds, lay down on it, and pulled the sheet back over himself. "Do what I'm doing — cover yourself head to toe, and don't move. If a bed already has someone in it, leave it alone; it'll be fine."

Mai Minghe stared at the gurney in the corner of the room — the white sheet draped over it rose and fell in the shape of a human body. The light flickered on and off, and she couldn't make out whether the figure beneath it was breathing, let alone whether it was a person, a corpse, or a Resident.

At any rate, whatever lay under that sheet hadn't exploded upright to greet them when they walked in, which was probably a good sign.

"Um..." She pointed at the gurney, only managing two words before the red-haired man, already flat on his back and fully covered, prompted her from beneath the sheet: "Hurry up."

In the span of a moment, the entire morgue had come down to one living person still standing — Mai Minghe — and two figures shrouded in white.

As she climbed onto the gurney and pulled the sheet over herself, a faint sense of unreality washed over her: an eighty-six-year-old woman, first admitted to a hospital ward and then ending up in the hospital morgue — it really was very much in keeping with the way things tended to go.

The whole night felt like a metaphor; for what exactly, she wasn't wise enough to say.

The red-haired man let out a sigh beneath his white sheet.

"First-timers in the Nest are nothing but trouble — they don't know anything," he said, dropping his voice. "Training new recruits is one of my least favorite parts of the job."

"It's not as though I wanted to lie in a morgue either," Mai Minghe replied. "You can't get through life without doing things you'd rather not do."

Including playing dead.

"Don't be so put out — the morgue is the 'door of life' in this hospital. Sounds ridiculous, right? How can a place for dead people be a door of life?"

Mai Minghe made a sound of agreement right away.

"The Nest contains countless locations, and each one has its own distinct terrain, dangers, and opportunities. St. Louis Hospital is a location my House Faction knows fairly well — this is my third time here. In St. Louis Hospital—"

"Wait, this is St. Louis Hospital?" Mai Minghe couldn't help cutting in. "You said this was the Nest — but St. Louis Hospital isn't far from my home at all."

She had been to St. Louis Hospital a few times before, and she'd never seen anything like this.

"No — the one you're thinking of is St. Louis Hospital in Blackmoor City. What we're in right now is the St. Louis Hospital that exists within the Nest.

"The Nest exists entirely outside the human world."

The red-haired man was quiet for a few seconds, as if giving those words time to truly sink into Mai Minghe's understanding.

"Perhaps the universe cracked somewhere, and the shadow that Blackmoor City cast into that crack became this Nest — a place full of danger and strangeness, an otherworld that only a handful of people can enter. Any place name you know from Blackmoor City, you can find here in the Nest as well, though it will almost always be a twisted, darkened version of itself."

As if afraid she might interrupt again, the red-haired man pressed on: "Long story short — we've found that when a person encounters a danger they can't shake inside St. Louis Hospital, say, when a Resident has set its sights on us, the morgue acts as a kind of 'reset' point."

"Reset?" Mai Minghe was working hard to absorb what he was telling her, and whatever she couldn't absorb, she fixed firmly in her memory.

She wasn't always up on the words young people used; smartphones — or was it "smart phones"? — had taken her quite a while to figure out too.

"Right. Simply put: you come to the morgue, pull the sheet over your face, lie still for a bit, and in the eyes of St. Louis Hospital, you've 'died.' The person the Residents were chasing is dead, so naturally they stop chasing. When you walk back out, you're a brand-new living person — nothing's after you anymore. It sounds absurd at first, but think it through and it actually makes

sense, doesn't it? Someone who's ended up in a hospital morgue — of course the hospital forgets about them quickly enough."

"It's the same in ordinary life," Mai Minghe murmured. "It's not only hospitals that forget you."

"Which is exactly why I brought you here," the red-haired man concluded. "Count yourself lucky — if you were a Hunter from any other House Faction, I would never have brought you along so easily."

"Why not?"

"Rivals don't do each other favors."

Mai Minghe understood, more or less. These people called themselves Hunters, and the Hunters were apparently divided into many House Factions; they had no way of knowing whether other factions had discovered that the morgue was a reset point, and if they hadn't, there was naturally no reason to give away something so valuable.

"But why do you all come to the Nest in the first place...?"

"Come on," the red-haired man gave a short laugh. "Feel the Artifact on your stomach and think about why. The effects Artifacts can produce are endless — from raising your IQ by five points to overturning fate itself, nothing is beyond them; they can even bring the most impossible human fantasies to life. But Artifacts only exist in the Nest. Back in Blackmoor City, there's no shortage of powerful people in politics and business willing to pay a fortune for them. Where there's demand, there's supply — economics is what leads us all into the Nest."

He paused, then said: "That's why we're called Artifact Hunters."

Artifact Hunters...

In the very city where she had lived her whole life, there was apparently a whole world of people chasing and trading in things as fantastical as something out of a dream...

And now, through her own carelessness, she had stumbled into a world beyond the world, and been given a second life.

Mai Minghe lay on the gurney, her heart thudding.

What surprised her was that she felt no fear right now, no urge to flee back home; instead she felt rather like a child who had wandered into an amusement park in the dead of night — the

darkness was its own domain, and the unfamiliar, eerie silhouettes of the park in the dark were as irresistible as they were vast and wondrous.

The Nest... in the deep blackness of a shadow-filled night, a fairground where she could climb onto a spinning carousel horse and ride toward the extraordinary.

"I never imagined... that I would ever fall into a place like this," she said softly.

Set against tonight, all the years before seemed to have suddenly shriveled and gone dull.

"It's understandable that you didn't know the Nest existed before now. Without someone experienced to guide you, finding your passage by sheer luck and stumbling into the Nest on your own is not something that happens often—"

"Passage?" Mai Minghe seized on the word, nearly bolting upright like a corpse reanimated. "After I ran into the television screen, I fell straight into the ward. Does that mean the television screen is my 'passage'?"

The red-haired man considered this and gave a low "hm."

"So that's how you got in... You've never run into a television screen before, have you?"

Of course not — nobody goes around headbutting televisions for no reason.

"Every Hunter's passage is different." The red-haired man gave a quiet laugh and said: "Of all humanity, only one percent are born with a passage that can lead them into the Nest. The conditions vary from person to person, and most of them are pretty strange and demanding. So even within that one percent, who knows how many people live out their entire lives without ever opening their passage — never even knowing the Nest exists..."

Wasn't that exactly her situation? Eighty-six years, right up until the night a thief broke through her front door—

Mai Minghe gave a start.

...Right. That thief was an Artifact Hunter too.

"Some people have relatively ordinary passages," the red-haired man went on. "I've heard of someone who could enter the Nest simply by sitting down in a full bathtub. Not that his luck was anything to envy, mind you — the first time you take a bath, you're small and young and bare and you haven't brought anything with you. What are the odds you make it back out of the Nest alive?"

"Then there are people whose passages are more troublesome — standing in the toilet bowl while flushing, opening a door in an abandoned building, and so on and so forth, the list goes on. The conditions for simply opening a passage are already so exacting that a huge number of people are eliminated right there; and on top of that, there's one more important requirement for entering the Nest."

"What requirement?"

"Your passage can only be opened in a city with a population of over ten million. We don't fully understand why, but..."

The red-haired man lowered his voice. "The general belief among Hunters is that the Nest is a byproduct born once human civilization reaches a certain scale. So the most densely populated places are the ones connected to the Nest."

Mai Minghe lay quietly for a moment.

Every word he had just said was like a piece of a puzzle, slowly assembling in her mind into a deep world she had never imagined existed; she very much wanted to reach up and press her fingertips to her temple — the spot swollen from hitting the television screen — just to confirm she wasn't dreaming.

"All right,"

There was a rustling of fabric nearby, the sound of the red-haired man lifting the sheet and sitting up. "That should be enough time — the reset ought to be complete. If you want to hold on to that Artifact, you'd best not let any of my companions see you."

The young man did have a decent streak in him after all.

"The Artifact I'm carrying — are you planning to hand it over to Wellesley?" Mai Minghe asked.

"That's right, he's the one who hired us," the red-haired man said, startled, turning to look at her. "You know about that too?"

"He's already dead — he can't buy the Artifact anymore." Mai Minghe thought back to the news that had been running nonstop on television for the past two days and asked, "Haven't you heard yet? When did you all enter the Nest?"

The red-haired man gave her a skeptical sideways glance, then looked away.

He clearly didn't believe her.

The Artifact Wellesley wanted had happened to land in her hands, and the moment it did, she was already saying Wellesley was dead and couldn't buy it anymore — it was a little too convenient a coincidence, no wonder he didn't buy it.

"Ha — he's not about to die. Those Artifacts he has on him are so powerful that—" The red-haired man stopped himself mid-sentence, rubbed his nose, and let the thought drop. "Dead or alive, I've already said I won't make a move on you. My advice is to get back to Blackmoor City as fast as you can."

"How do I get back?"

Though the Nest was both terrifying and captivating, Mai Minghe's best move right now was to get out while she could—for the Artifact's sake.

"Haah, this is really..." The red-haired man let his shoulders drop, looking a little deflated. "In for a penny, in for a pound—I'll take you to the exit. But let's get one thing straight: the moment a House Faction Hunter spots us, I'll have no choice but to join them in taking the Artifact from you."

Hello, friends—what you're seeing now is yet another message from on high; I have ascended the throne, so doesn't that practically count as a divine decree?

Day after day it's nothing but power struggles—one minute crowning myself, the next getting knocked off the pedestal.

I have a question rattling around in my stomach (sorry, it's not a baby): I've seen readers mention that Qidian now puts a lot of weight on something called "chasing-read" numbers—what's that? Does it literally just mean the number of people following the updates? What happens if it's too low? What counts as enough? Can I count myself as one... Writing a novel has me on edge every single day.

Chapter 14 — Chase, Where the Sea Meets the Sky

"...AED defibrillator, cardiac stimulant, epinephrine,"

The brilliant neon lights on the distant shore fell into the water and were jostled by the waves, gradually dissolving into patches of dim amber and murky green ripples that rocked along with the hull atop the pitch-black swells.

"Last one — broad-spectrum antibiotics, in case we need to be out here for a while."

Once each item had been introduced, a silver-white medical case snapped shut with a sharp clap; a large hand with long fingers reached under the seat and pulled out a black cylinder.

"This is a cauterizing gun. It can seal large wounds, sear through blood vessels and nerves, and keep a person from bleeding to death — very handy."

Accompanied by a cheerful voice, that large hand gave a hearty slap on the shoulder of the man in the white coat sitting beside him.

"Let me introduce you — Dr. Nate, a decent man. Not only has he supplied me with everything, he's also willing to come in person to handle any unexpected situation... For instance, after I cut off your limbs, he can guarantee you'll neither die nor lose consciousness."

Dr. Nate didn't say a single word. His lips were pressed tightly together, his face contorted, a sickly pallor washing over him — he looked like a wisp of fog floating in the night.

The cauterizing gun was set down, and a pair of hands clapped together loudly. "Come now, say thank you to Dr. Nate."

What answered him was a muffled, incoherent cry — a man with his limbs bound behind his back, wrapped from head to toe in tape so tightly that only his eyes and nostrils were exposed, thrashing desperately, rocking the small boat back and forth and stirring up soft lapping waves.

"I'll speak for Dr. Nate — you're welcome, it's the least I could do."

The man in the expensive suit, tall and broad, his smile never wavering, leaned in and gave the bound figure a friendly pat.

His black hair was combed back, sleek and neat, catching faint glimmers of light in the night above the sea.

"Don't be impatient — I haven't finished making introductions."

He spread his pale hands wide, and with a flip and a grab of his right hand, effortlessly pulled a heavy weight plate from under the seat. "Each arm and leg, once severed, will be tied to a twenty-five-kilogram plate. You'll be able to watch your own limbs go plunk — sinking to the bottom of the sea..."

He let out a low whistle, his fingers swaying nimbly from high to low, like fish gliding down into the depths.

"...Just like that."

The man mummified in tape let out another garbled, heavy groan, like a wild animal trapped in a bag and unable to break free.

The suited man leaned back in his chair, studying his captive with an air of leisurely amusement.

"Ready to start talking?"

The bound man twisted and writhed furiously: "Mmph, mmph!"

The suited man flicked open a knife, gauged roughly where the mouth was, and drove the blade in a deep slash across the tape — blood and a shriek of pain erupted together into the night.

Slender fingers worked into the blood-slicked slit in the tape and pulled out a large wad of medical cotton.

The moment it left his mouth, panting and retching poured out of the man in broken spurts: "You — who are you? What do you want..."

The suited man leaned in close, fixing his gaze on his prey, his eyes so dark they reflected not a single glimmer of light.

"I'll cooperate with whatever you want — there's no need to be this brutal..." As the bound man spoke, the wound on his lips tore wider, and the pain twisted his face; in the darkness his face was slick and wet. "I'm nobody — I'm nothing to anyone..."

"That's the wrong thing to say."

The suited man raised one index finger and cut him off. "A nobody who's nothing to anyone — like an extra in a movie, they die and they die, and no one cares. If you want me to let you go, you first need to make me care about you. Isn't that right?"

The bound man was taken aback.

"You're probably wondering — how do I get you to start caring about me? Well, I'd have to understand you first, empathize with you as a person."

The suited man laced his long fingers together, forming something like a pale bridge in the dark of the night. The face of his watch caught a faint, thin arc of light in the darkness.

"Come then — tell me. Who are you?"

"I... my name is Ivan. I'm twenty-nine years old, I'm originally from—"

"No, I don't want a résumé — that's boring." The suited man cut him off, his tone encouraging. "I want to know: what hopes do you carry in your life? What has left you disappointed? What are your dreams?"

Ivan stared, his face streaked with blood and tears. "My... my dreams...?"

"Yes. Surely you don't plan to be Wellesley's bodyguard for the rest of your life?"

Ivan gave a start, and a flash of sudden comprehension lit up his eyes.

"Could this have something to do with Mr. Wellesley—"

"Furthermore," the suited man continued, deaf to the remark, "Wellesley died a violent death yesterday, and today you can barely save yourself — you weren't much of a bodyguard. No great loss giving it up."

"I don't know anything..."

"Don't waste your energy." The suited man's thin lips curved into a smile like a knife's edge. "A character who can't move me is just a sack of skin — I don't care how many pieces of it end up on the ocean floor."

Silence fell over the boat for a few seconds.

"Speak."

It probably never crossed Ivan's mind, not even in his wildest dreams, that he would find himself in a situation like this, baring his innermost thoughts.

"I... I understand. My dream is to become someone like Mr. Wellesley..."

"The wealthiest man in the city? A state senator? Recipient of the Distinguished Contribution Award on Climate Issues?" The suited man asked with a smile: "...Or the true power behind

Blackmoor City?"

Ivan only nodded without speaking. He stared vacantly at Blackmoor City in the distance — at the neon advertisements on shore, the skyscrapers. Across the central bay lit up by countless lights, dark waves gently lapped and rocked the small boat.

"Good." The suited man nodded. "What have you done to pursue that dream?"

"I haven't done anything," Ivan snapped back to attention and said quickly, "Mr. Wellesley's death has absolutely nothing to do with me..."

"Wrong direction." The pale hand waved through the darkness with the air of a director giving notes to an actor. "I didn't say you had anything to do with his death — but after he died, you took no action at all?"

"I don't understand..."

"With nothing but ambition and no action to back it up, a character that spineless is impossible to empathize with." The suited man seemed nearly exasperated. "If you won't even help yourself, why on earth should I let you off the hook?"

Ivan's bleeding mouth hung open. After a moment's hesitation, he finally ventured: "After Mr. Wellesley died... I didn't leave. I stayed. Does that count?"

"Oh?"

"Mr. Wellesley had dismissed me the night before," Ivan said quickly. "I was supposed to leave, but I didn't want to go, so I didn't tell anyone."

"Why did he dismiss you?"

"It was just bad luck." Ivan's wet, glistening lips went still. After a moment, he said quietly: "I hadn't done anything seriously wrong... I only tried on a pair of trousers..."

The suited man raised one eyebrow and the corner of his mouth. "Trousers?"

"Yes, yes... once you hear it, you'll understand." He paused, then said suddenly: "Do you know that Mr. Wellesley had a very soft voice? When I first started working for him, I was surprised — a man of such importance, I'd imagined he would speak loudly."

Ivan's teeth were stained blood-red, but he seemed to have forgotten his wound; once he started talking, he couldn't stop.

"Later I came to understand: because his voice was soft, everyone else had to give him their full attention when he spoke. When he opened his mouth, he wasn't concerned about whether others could hear him — that was the listener's problem to worry about.

"You see, even the way his voice rose and fell had its purpose, had its wisdom... So in my free time, I gradually began to carry myself the way Mr. Wellesley did, to dress the way he dressed. I even wore a cologne with a similar scent, and I felt like people looked at me differently when I went out."

The suited man held out a cigarette to Ivan.

He took a drag; in the murky darkness above the sea, the tip of the cigarette flared red; pain made his cheek twitch again, but his tone and composure steadied considerably.

"During this period, Mr. Wellesley and a number of us staff had all been staying at the estate in the Upper District. The night before last, he went to attend a banquet, while I was off duty and didn't go with him. When he came back unexpectedly early, I happened to be in his room putting on a pair of trousers, and he caught me right in the act.

"He probably thought I was having an affair in there... his face turned purple. But how could I possibly be doing something like that? He didn't believe me — he shoved me aside and went through the bathroom and dressing room from top to bottom before he was finally convinced I'd really been alone..."

Ivan gave a bitter laugh: "Then he noticed I was wearing his trousers. I only wanted to know what it felt like to wear them... but he flew into a rage and fired me on the spot, told me to pack my things and leave the next morning."

The suited man threw his head back and laughed, the sound deep and resonant, crashing against the night.

"Amusing — but that's all." His large hand patted the cauterizing gun. "You want to reach the pinnacle of wealth and power, and the action you took was secretly trying on someone's trousers? With that, what could you ever amount to?"

"It's not that simple, obviously,"

Ivan was stung into a flash of anger, and blood sprayed as he argued back.

"Dressing and carrying myself like him was only one part of it — I never let slip an opportunity for action either. The moment I heard yesterday that Mr. Wellesley had died in his

study, I immediately realized: word of my dismissal hadn't spread yet. Only Mr. Wellesley and I knew, and with him dead, as long as I said nothing, it was as if I'd never been dismissed — no one would ever know.

"So I rushed to the study door at the first chance. On the surface I was pretending to guard the scene while waiting for the police, but in reality I was secretly—"

Ivan suddenly stopped.

In the darkness, there was nothing left but the sound of waves and his own heavy, ragged breathing.

The suited man fixed his eyes on Ivan, slowly leaning his body forward, like a great python lowering itself inch by inch from a branch.

"So... you went inside the study." He said quietly.

Ivan seemed to realize it then — that when an interrogator conceals their true purpose, the person being interrogated ends up committing mistakes they didn't even know they shouldn't commit.

"...And what happened after you went in?"

Seeing that Ivan refused to answer, the suited man raised both hands. In the darkness between sky and sea, they looked like two vague, enormous white fans — each one large enough to cover an adult man's entire head and face.

"Strange, isn't it? I introduced you to all the first-aid supplies, yet I never showed you what I'll use to sever your arms and legs. That's because I only remembered when I got on the boat — I forgot to bring the electric saw. Fortunately, I have some confidence in the strength of my hands... nick an opening in the skin, and I can peel you apart layer by layer. The bones are easy enough — wedge them against the side of the boat and one stomp will snap them."

In the darkness, the suited man broke into a silent grin, his white teeth bared in even, gleaming rows.

"Why did you go into the study?"

This time Ivan answered quickly. "I — I just wanted to see if there was anything worth taking... in case there was something valuable. I saw a watch..."

"Why did you go into the study?" The suited man's hand came to rest lightly on Ivan's arm.

Ivan swallowed a mixture of blood and saliva.

"You likely know as well — what went missing from Wellesley's study does not belong to this world. Those who had no business touching it yet touched it anyway will only end up as you are now: swept under and swallowed by the fate it carries. An endless sea with nowhere to turn."

The suited man closed his eyes, drew a long, slow breath through his nose, pulling in the salt-smell of the sea, the petrol fumes from the boat's engine, and Ivan's fear — all of it drawn deep into his lungs.

When he spoke again, his voice had gone hoarse.

"The Artifact from the study — where have you hidden it?"

The mega-ordeal begins today... Yesterday, the moment I landed, I got a text saying my connecting flight had been cancelled, so I scrambled to refund and rebook—only to find no flights available, leaving me no choice but to travel to Guangzhou today to catch a flight out. A huge detour added for no reason, and a huge chunk of time lost.

The days ahead are going to be stressful, chaotic, and miserable. Adjust for jet lag? What a luxury that would be—a blink counts as sleep at this point.

Ugh.

All I want is to go home and hole up for a solid year, ideally with a new e-ink tablet in my arms.

Chapter 15: Chase, Hunter Among Men

Chase drew a silver comb from his suit pocket and slowly combed a loose strand of hair back behind his head.

The comb was small, its inlaid emeralds casting a deep, crystalline light that sank into the black hair and shattered between the strands.

Luxurious and precious things exist in this world to be used. Chase would never lock a comb away in a jewelry cabinet just because it was a valuable antique.

"I stripped his clothes off with my own hands."

Chase leaned back in his chair and said, "I don't mind finding a new use for the cauterizing gun, but Dr. Nate was afraid I'd be too rough and puncture his intestines, so he handled the search himself. I watched the whole time—I can confirm there was nothing on that bodyguard."

Rolan Key, sitting across from him, made a low sound of acknowledgment.

He was past sixty, his hair faded to iron gray, like the heavy fog of a cloudy morning. Wrinkles carved out a hard face with few expressions, and his pair of pale blue eyes always seemed to be watching people from a great distance, as if peering through deep mist.

In his presence, Chase sometimes still felt like a small child.

"What about his home?"

"I only got back from his place this morning—there isn't a single unbroken tile left." Chase thought for a few seconds and continued, "I searched the car too. Nothing. I also checked the driving records and surveillance footage—after he left the estate, he drove straight home and didn't go out again before I found him. Aside from a pizza delivery driver, he hadn't met with anyone. If he hid the Artifacts at the estate—"

"Not a single one left at the estate," Rolan Key said quietly. "The newly arrived Hunters have already scanned it."

Chase nodded, his thick dark brows knitting together.

"Out of the four Artifacts that went missing from Wellesley's study, the bodyguard didn't take a single one?" Rolan Key asked.

Chase stared at the ceiling and thought for a moment.

"No," he murmured, "he got one... he got at least one."

"How do you know?"

Chase straightened up, a hint of irritation in his movement, his two large pale hands clasped tightly together, tendons rising on the backs. A thin line of dark reddish-black stain still lingered in the creases of his fingernails—he hadn't yet had the chance to clean them.

"I searched every place I could think of to hide something, and there were no Artifacts anywhere. The man couldn't take pressure—all it took was one broken left arm and he was already begging me to search his home, his car. He didn't even wait for me to ask before giving me the address of his sister's place outside the city."

He pulled out a few banknotes, folded them into two stacks, rolled them up, and used their sharp corners to slowly clean out the stains from his fingernails.

"My search was thorough—I'm confident I missed nothing. But as I watched him on the boat, a feeling gradually took hold of me... I can't explain it, but I just knew." Chase stared at the dark reddish-black on the corner of the banknote and said, "He got an Artifact."

Ivan had been terrified and in agony, willing to do anything to escape the small boat and escape Chase—and yet there was something... something indescribable, like bone itself, that held up the man who was weeping and convulsing and howling, and made him grit his teeth and keep the secret.

Someone who had seen another world seemed to gain a certain distance from the reality before their eyes. Even bodily pain, at first, felt as though it were filtered through a layer of cotton.

This was a feeling Chase had encountered before, in Hunters who had just returned from the Nest.

Ivan was not a Hunter; he had only come into contact with another reality through an Artifact, and so carried only a faint, vague trace of that same quality.

But on his own, he wouldn't have been able to hold out for much longer.

The moment Chase thought of this, his hands wrenched together with a sharp, restless twist.

No matter how precious an Artifact, it could not be worth more than life and limb; even a rare Artifact capable of granting someone supreme wealth and status would not be worth

becoming a human torso.

In the deep of the previous night, Ivan had sat naked in a pool of blood, shaking violently in the cold sea wind, his arm snapped in several places and dislocated at the shoulder where a bloody hole had torn open, hanging a full length longer than his right arm.

Looking at him, Chase had known that even without resorting to real measures, the man was not far from his breaking point.

By any standard, Ivan was not a man of iron will.

A few more minutes, and he would have talked—but it was exactly at that moment that a light suddenly pierced the pitch-black curtain of night over the distant sea; the roar of a large speedboat's engine carved through the waves, pushing its light steadily into Chase's field of vision.

Dr. Nate snapped his head up and said under his breath, "Is that the—the Coast Guard?"

From what Chase knew, the Coast Guard didn't usually appear in this location at this hour, but out of caution he still dropped the bloodstained dumbbell plate he was holding; it landed with a heavy thud, making the hull shudder faintly.

"Get down," he ordered the bodyguard, then said, "Doctor, hand me the cover cloth under the seat."

The cloth normally used to cover the boat was thrown over Ivan hood-first, concealing pale flesh and dark crimson blood all at once.

Chase stepped over the trembling, rustling cloth in one stride, took a can of beer from the liquor cabinet, tossed it to Dr. Nate, and said, "Drink."

The crisp crack of the pull-tab was swallowed up by the engine sound growing ever closer; Chase could already make out, faintly, that the approaching vessel was a large speedboat very much resembling standard Coast Guard craft—by the look of it, within a few minutes it would come crashing through the waves and pass right in front of them.

"Great, the taxes I pay, coming to get in my way."

Chase muttered as he sat down and picked up a fishing rod from the boat, not even casting the line into the water.

That night the clouds were thick and formless, with no stars or moon to be seen, and visibility on the sea was extremely poor—a few meters out and one's gaze seemed to tumble into a black

void.

If the other vessel didn't shine a searchlight on them, they wouldn't be able to tell how many people were on the boat, let alone spot a fishing line; the cloth, the beer, and the fishing rod were prepared purely as a precaution.

Boats out night-fishing at two or three in the morning were rare enough, but the central bay was never short of private pleasure craft, and the Coast Guard seemed to have a different target altogether—it plowed straight past them without the slightest interest in Chase's small boat, not even slowing down.

The large speedboat racing past threw up wave after wave, tossing the small boat up and flinging it back down, again and again—and in the midst of the rocking, Chase suddenly cursed under his breath, leapt to his feet, and lunged toward the cover cloth.

He lost his footing and slammed into the railing from the pitching of the boat, but he seemed to feel nothing of it; he swept out an arm, and a large hand with long fingers closed around the cloth.

"What's wrong?"

Amid Dr. Nate's startled cry and the crash of waves against the hull, Chase pressed down on the cloth that was heaving and shifting beneath him, and closed his fist around it—Chase was confident in his grip; if he locked his hand around someone, they couldn't get free unless they pulled a gecko and shed a limb.

And yet Ivan had slipped away all the same.

At the time the whole thing happened so quickly that it was only afterward, thinking it over, that Chase was able to piece together how Ivan had escaped.

Taking advantage of the boat's pitching in the waves, Ivan had crawled from under the cloth toward the railing, trying to jump overboard while Chase was distracted; Chase had noticed in time, lunged over, and grabbed him, yanking him back—but in the rocking of the waves, with the cloth between them, Chase hadn't anticipated that what he'd grabbed was the very arm he himself had broken and torn open.

As the bodyguard's shoulder was wrenched by that pull, the wound that had just been cauterized and sealed tore open again, deeply; a long cry of agony rang out from beside the railing, piercing sharply into the night.

Along with that cry, a gush of fresh blood poured from the body.

The pain was unbearable, but it was precisely the flood of blood that acted as lubrication—and so Ivan finally managed, in a sway of the waves, to wrench out his broken arm by sheer force and roll overboard off the small boat. All of this happened in the span of two or three seconds; but by the time Chase rushed to the railing and swept his gaze around, the bodyguard had already sunk below the surface and was nowhere to be seen.

The night was dark and the sea was vast; even with a flashlight, one could only see a few meters of churning water.

Though the bodyguard was dragging an injured arm, if he held his breath and swam underwater for a while, moving beyond Chase's range of visibility was not difficult.

"He thought he could swim back to Blackmoor City with an injured, bleeding arm?"

Chase tried to smile, but found the muscles of his face too heavy to move. "He most likely died in the central bay long ago—who knows where the current will carry him. I'll keep an eye out over the next few days for any reports of a body being found."

"You're going to wait for news of a dead man before you know how to proceed?" Rolan Key smiled slightly and asked.

"No... of course not, Uncle Key."

Chase couldn't help it—even his voice dropped lower. "I'm planning to go find his sister, and the pizza delivery clerk."

Rolan Key, however, seemed to have no interest in his next steps. He took a sip of black coffee and said, "Anything left in plain sight for you to see isn't where something is hidden."

Chase made himself swallow those words.

He had nothing to say to that.

Before Ivan had jumped off the boat, Chase had already gotten hold of his keys, phone, documents, and even important passwords—all that had escaped was a bare body. In principle, even if the bodyguard had gotten away, as long as he'd hidden things somewhere he'd been, Chase should sooner or later be able to find a lead.

But Chase had searched every inch of every hiding place he could think of, and had still come up empty.

Just where had he missed?

Chase's hands had been unconsciously twisting and grinding against each other all this while; only now did he notice that the banknotes he'd used to clean his fingernails had been reduced to a scatter of fine shreds, drifting down into the carpet—he felt a sudden flush of embarrassment.

"Uncle Key, let me get the vacuum. Is the handheld one still in the usual spot?"

He had barely risen to his feet when Rolan Key said, "No rush. Sit down."

Though puzzled, Chase sat back down.

"Force cuts both ways," Rolan Key said slowly. "The full weight of a punch thrown at someone else inevitably reverberates back into one's own bones and heart. That's why interrogators who use violence either start out numb and dull, or gradually become numb and dull through violence."

A warm, tingling sensation spread from his palms to his chest.

"I'll be careful, Uncle Key," Chase said, with genuine gratitude. "It's just blood. I can handle it."

"That's not what I mean."

Chase's heart suddenly sank. He waited for what Rolan Key would say next, the way one waits for a punch that is about to land in the gut.

"A numb, brutal enforcer is the most worthless thing in this business," Rolan Key said. "You grew up at my side. I thought you would conduct yourself with more intelligence than this."

It was only after a brief moment that Chase's breathing returned to normal.

"For a Hunter House Faction to grow, the Nest is merely the foundation. What truly matters is how we establish ourselves and act in the human world—how we build influence. A truly powerful Hunter House Faction holds dominion over the 'reality' that every one of us must live within."

Rolan Key gave a low, slow chuckle from the back of his throat.

"...And yet dominating 'reality' cannot be achieved through violence and bloodshed alone. Don't tell me that's the only card you have."

Chase hadn't known his own head could feel so heavy; for a moment he wanted nothing more than to drop it into his hands—and it wasn't because he hadn't slept all night.

He knew that Rolan Key had not grown angry, but he would have preferred the man to lose his temper—to question him, scold him for failing to get things done.

Chase stood a full head taller than Rolan Key now, trained and formidable, a man even Hunters were wary of. And yet when Rolan Key was disappointed in him, Chase still felt that drowning sensation of sinking into ice water—because he could not stop being disappointed in himself.

He stared at his own hands; faint white scars ran across the backs, extending until they disappeared behind his watch and cuffs.

In his youth, trying to locate his own passage, Chase had run many experiments on himself and left all manner of scars and hidden injuries on his body.

Only 1% of humanity possessed a "passage"—a channel through which they could enter the Nest; but no one knew what their own passage was until they tried every method one by one. He had tried every known method of opening a passage, yet still stood in the mortal world, unable to see the Nest.

Now he was thirty years old, and he still could not forget the moment when Uncle Key finally accepted the truth that he had no passage—the way he had lowered his eyelids and said nothing.

Like watching a work of art shatter on the ground, revealing the foam padding inside.

The scar on the back of his hand was not from the experiments. It was from after the experiments—Chase had cut it himself with a hunting knife, and he didn't know why; perhaps he had believed, in that moment, that he could cut open a passage that way.

"I understand." Chase said it, then noticed his voice had gone hoarse, and cleared his throat. "Uncle Key, I made you a promise—everything on this side of the world, I will deliver to you."

He could not enter the Nest, but he could become a Hunter in the mortal world, seizing every scrap of power and wealth that could be taken and bringing it into the Key family's hands.

Because what Uncle Key truly wanted, he could never give him.

Chapter 16 — Chase and the Artifact Submerged in the Metropolis

"According to the surveillance footage we obtained,"

Chase said as he drove, "Ivan left the gates of the Wellesley Family Estate at 7:21 a.m. on November 16th, and never looked back."

The bodyguard naturally had no intention of going back; the moment he'd stolen the Artifact, he put his job out of his mind without a word to anyone and headed straight for Blackmoor City.

"What about his movements after leaving the estate? How do you pin those down?" The young woman in the passenger seat wore her hair in long, thick dreadlocks dyed a deep violet, and when they fell over her shoulders, they looked like a great cascade of flowing lavender.

"His GPS records are in my hands. The route we're driving right now is the same one he took on the 16th."

The young woman paused at that and glanced over at him.

"I know," Chase said, his expression unchanged. "The fact that a route is logged in his GPS doesn't mean he actually drove it."

"Right — I've heard you'd need to pull the route data from the manufacturer to know exactly where he went," the dreadlocked woman replied. "That'd be hard to manage without police resources, wouldn't it?"

Generally speaking, that was true.

But Chase had always had good luck.

He quickly discovered that a grocery store sat across from Ivan's apartment building — since people lived on the second floor, the owner had installed a smart security camera out front that recorded all comings and goings.

Posing as a police officer, he smoothly pulled up the time window he needed: at 10:47 a.m., Ivan's car had turned onto the street, circled for a bit, and snagged a parking spot.

That day was a Saturday, with no rush-hour traffic. Ivan had taken 3 hours and 26 minutes to get from the Upstate District to Blackmoor City — only thirteen minutes more than the GPS

estimate. Given the overcast, rainy weather, a discrepancy of a few minutes was not significant at all and fell entirely within the normal range.

"If he'd taken a different route, the timing wouldn't have lined up so neatly."

Every other GPS route would have added at least twenty minutes, making the timeline impossible; and besides, Ivan had been fleeing with the Artifact — by all logic, he'd want to move as fast as possible and wouldn't take the long way around.

This meant the possibility that Ivan had made a detour en route — to his sister's place, for instance, or a rented storage unit — and handed the Artifact off to someone else for safekeeping was virtually nonexistent, because a few minutes' discrepancy simply wasn't enough time for any of that.

But what if Ivan had called ahead and asked his sister to wait for him somewhere?

As he drove past, all it would take was passing a package through the window — a delay so small it would never show up in the driving record.

That theory, however, was quickly dismantled by Chase himself.

He had everything of Ivan's in his possession, and he easily pulled the call records from the carrier, finding that Ivan hadn't made a single outgoing call that morning, and hadn't been in contact with his sister in the days before or after, either — in fact, Ivan's entire call log for the 16th contained only two entries: the first was a call from the head of the bodyguard team, demanding to know why he had quit without authorization; the second was a call that afternoon to a pizza place, ordering one large pepperoni pizza.

Surely no one would hand over a priceless Artifact to a complete stranger making a delivery.

If the two knew each other, that would be one thing; but according to the Hunter sent to investigate, the delivery driver had no connection to Ivan whatsoever.

It was possible he had used someone else's phone — there was just no evidence to support that at the moment — and Ivan didn't seem like the kind of man capable of thinking that far ahead.

Regardless, Chase still had to exhaust every possibility.

He had to bring back what Uncle Kai wanted for the House Faction; before that single objective, no obstacle could be allowed to remain one.

"Mr. Monroe, I have a question—" the young dreadlocked woman began.

"Just call me Chase," he cut her off. "When other Hunters call me Mr. Monroe, it means they know they're in trouble."

Kingsley had not been with the House Faction long — she'd previously been an unremarkable Hunter of no particular renown — but recently her reputation had suddenly soared and she'd become a sought-after talent. Since she'd been recruited into the Key household, today was the first time Chase had actually met her in person.

As far as Chase knew, this kind of transformation in a Hunter wasn't all that unusual.

The Nest took on a thousand forms, strange and fantastical beyond all imagination; aside from the Artifacts that could be brought back into the world, Hunters might encounter creatures, rules, domains, or things that defied all definition — their interactions with such things produced no telling how many kinds of consequences and effects. Not all of them, of course, were good.

The vast majority were not good.

But occasionally, a lucky soul like Kingsley would draw the winning lot — returning from the Nest one day in possession of abilities she'd never had before.

"Chase," she corrected herself, then said: "I swept the Wellesley Family Estate. I can confirm there isn't a single Artifact left inside or outside the grounds. All along the road we drove in on, I didn't sense any Artifact presence either. That supports the idea that the bodyguard took the Artifact and carried it straight to Blackmoor City without stopping — that part is still easy enough to follow.

"But why did he lock himself in his apartment after he got home? If he went to the trouble of stealing an Artifact, he must have understood what it meant and what it was worth — he'd know people would track him down. If it were me, I'd go home, grab what I needed, and run — actually, I might not even go home at all. I'd leave everything behind."

Before answering, Chase lifted his chin toward the window.

Outside, a heavy, overcast sky hung there grey and sullen, brooding with the constant threat of rain; beneath it, a dull, dark-green blur of trees streamed steadily past.

"Well? Are you getting anything?"

Kingsley furrowed her brow, paused for two seconds, then said, "It overlaps quite a bit with my last detection range... still no Artifact."

Chase glanced at the time and said nothing.

He had no idea what method Kingsley used to sense things.

For a Hunter, the ability to "detect Artifacts" was fundamental and invaluable — but the problem was that Kingsley's detection precision was truly terrible.

He had been driving at fifty kilometers an hour for several minutes, and they still hadn't left the range of Kingsley's last sweep.

By rough calculation, her Artifact detection range was about a five-kilometer radius — as for exactly where within that five-kilometer radius an Artifact might be hiding, only heaven knew.

With a sensing method this vague, was she really a prize worth poaching for a Hunter House Faction?

Chase had never set eyes on the Nest himself, so he didn't know the answer to that question.

"That Ivan — he had a bit of cunning about him."

He pulled his thoughts back to the present, fixed his gaze on the road ahead, and said: "He knew people would track the Artifacts that went missing from the study, so he gambled against fate — he bet he could slip through the cracks."

"Slip through the cracks?"

"If Wellesley's former bodyguard fled the moment he died, everyone would have known immediately that something was wrong with him. Never mind that no one even knows yet whether Wellesley's death was natural or not. If it was murder, running would tie Ivan to it as well.

"If Wellesley was murdered, a fleeing Ivan would draw the attention of three different parties.

"First, the police investigating the cause of death; second, whoever killed Wellesley, who wouldn't want any loose ends discovered; and third, the various Hunter House Factions suspecting he'd stolen the Artifacts."

Kingsley nodded. "That makes sense... he'd be better off acting like he didn't know anything. Even if he planned to run, he should at least lay low through the first few days and not attract attention."

"Exactly. He couldn't stay at the estate, because the estate would be the first place anyone searched for Artifacts. Wellesley had fired Ivan before he died — as long as he used that as his excuse, he had a reason to leave. And since four Artifacts went missing, and he'd likely only taken one, if he kept a low profile, there was no guarantee anyone would come looking for him specifically."

"So how did you find him?" Kingsley asked with genuine interest.

"...I got lucky."

"Lucky? I don't believe in luck," Kingsley said, looking at the road ahead with a smile.

"Everything I have, I earned for myself."

What a young thing to say.

The Nest was not a primary school teacher; the Nest did not reward sheer effort — but Chase kept those words to himself.

"Is that so? Then I suppose you wouldn't care about what the other Hunters say about me."

"What do they say?"

"That the reason I have such good luck is that I draw the good luck away from the people around me."

Kingsley probably thought he was joking and started to laugh, glancing over at Chase as she did — then, like a cloud shadow passing overhead, her smile dimmed and faded quickly, leaving her quiet.

Anyone who became a Hunter had sharper instincts than the average person, to some degree or another.

Following the GPS route, Chase exited the highway and entered Blackmoor City proper.

A forest of modern towers built from glass and steel, classical buildings that had stood and settled over centuries past, neon advertisements layering light and shadow over one another, office workers striding briskly down the streets, tourists perched atop red double-decker sightseeing buses with their phones held aloft — like pieces of a puzzle, it all gradually assembled before his eyes into the most prosperous, vibrant, and diverse metropolis in the world.

Chase had lived in Blackmoor City for thirty years, yet everything he'd learned about it probably didn't amount to the tip of the iceberg; accompanying its vast and endlessly varied

population was an unknowable quality — the sense that no one could predict what the next moment might bring. Chase had never wanted to leave Blackmoor City, and beyond his ties to the Key household, it was because he needed that unknowability, the way he needed air.

If every day of his life were the same as the last, he would be as good as dead already, just waiting to be buried.

To minimize distractions, Kingsley closed her eyes and rolled down the window, as though listening to the pulse of the city.

"Nothing... nothing... up ahead is Buluan 5th Street?... nothing there either."

"Are you sure?"

Kingsley's eyes snapped open. "Wait!"

Chase lifted his foot off the accelerator. The moment the car slowed, a wave of irritated honking erupted from the line of vehicles behind them.

Blackmoor City residents were not known for their patience or their courtesy.

"Got one!" Kingsley's eyes went wide as she twisted her head left and right, scanning around — yet a shadow of puzzlement wouldn't leave her face. "Hold on, let me just—"

"Where?"

Kingsley seemed not to hear him. She craned her head out the window, held still for a few blank seconds, then dropped back into her seat with a thud.

"It's gone," she said quietly. "I thought there was an Artifact nearby... but it's strange — the feeling flashed past, and by the time I focused and tried to sense it again, it had vanished. I swear my instincts are usually spot-on; I've never run into anything like this before..."

Flashed past?

The car crawled along, and the honking and shouting from behind had been completely shut out of Chase's mind.

His attention spread outward like a searchlight sweeping in all directions: the road, the streets, the buildings, the pedestrians, the signs — scenes he had passed by countless times before all registered in his mind one by one, sharp and vivid, as though he were seeing them for the very first time.

An Artifact that "flashed past" within a range this large — a full five-kilometer radius...

His eyelids gave a sudden twitch, and his gaze landed on a round sign in the distance bearing the letter "D."

A thought occurred to Chase.

He looked over at the oncoming lane, waited for a gap with no approaching cars, then gave the steering wheel a sharp turn, cut across half the road, and swung onto the other lane.

Amid the shriek of brakes, blaring horns, and furious curses, he pressed down on the center of the steering wheel and leaned on it without letting up, while the car had already mounted the sidewalk; the pedestrians who scattered to either side in fright were like waves the car had thrown up in its wake.

Kingsley gripped the overhead handle with both hands and cried out, "What are you doing? Where are you going? You're going to hit someone!"

With one set of tires on the curb and the other on the road, the car tilted forward at an angle; they tore past a row of storefronts, startling a customer who had just stepped out and sending coffee splashing all over him.

The chaos and commotion outside the car meant nothing to Chase.

He kept his eyes fixed ahead and said, "I know where the Artifact is."

Friends, yesterday I got up early in the morning and headed out to take care of some things — I even sent the chapter from the car. Chapter numbers, author's notes, none of that was on my mind; I just needed to get the food on the table first, and if I remember the cutlery later I'll bring that too. For now just eat with your hands, we've been at this long enough, we make do.

As for what I'm doing today — as I write this, I'm once again on my way to the airport. If you went to the headquarters of every major airline right now, you'd find my portrait hanging there. Seriously, go look if you don't believe me.

As for writing author's notes, I have mixed feelings — I can't bring myself to leave out all this pointless rambling, but whenever I do write them, I always end up seeing comments saying the notes are better than the actual chapters, and honestly I don't know whether to be happy about that. Maybe after the novel goes on the paid roster I'll just post nonsense — sound about right?

Chapter 17 — Chase: The Hunted Hunter

Ivan was either a genius or an idiot.

No, Chase thought, perhaps he was a mixture of both; they say that when an idiot has a flash of brilliance, even the smart ones can't compete.

"Are you trying to get yourself killed? Don't drag me into it!" Kingsley forgot to be polite to her superior in her panic and cried out, "This isn't the Nest — this is the real world! There are consequences for driving like this. You hit someone, you go to prison — do you not hear the sirens behind us?"

It had only been a few minutes since he'd blown through a string of traffic laws before he heard the sirens.

The wail of sirens carved through the sky behind them like circling knife-tips, slicing again and again; sometimes growing more distant, making Chase think he'd shaken the last patrol car, only for them to close in again as new ones joined the chase from other directions.

But the patrol cars never managed to cut him off, because they couldn't do what Chase did — tear across sidewalks, drive the wrong way through red lights, and blast through intersections as if the road were empty.

Along the way, he lost count of how many pedestrians he saw throwing themselves to the side of the road in frantic panic, and lost count of how many times he heard the sharp screech of tires grinding against asphalt.

Wherever the car went, chaos followed — running, honking, screaming; and by some miracle, by the time Chase finally straightened out and roared down the open road, he had only knocked a side mirror askew and caved in one headlight, without causing any truly irreversible damage.

"Hold on," he said, glancing back at the vast sweep of flashing red and blue lights behind them. "I'm going to accelerate."

"More? You—"

Kingsley didn't get to finish — the car surged forward and the force of inertia drove her back into her seat.

Chase spun the wheel; the car twisted around the vehicle ahead, then cut sharply in front of it, drawing a chorus of furious honks. "The search I had you run earlier — you still have it open, right?"

Kingsley let out a sigh and brushed her lavender hair back from her face.

"It's open," she said, holding her phone up into the edge of Chase's vision; the screen was indeed lit up with a map app. "Fine — it's not like I'm the one driving. Where exactly are we going?"

"Buluan Community College," Chase answered briefly, blasting between two more cars.

"...Why?"

"When you sensed the Artifact flash by, I caught a glimpse of the subway sign for 'Fullington Station' on Line D. Buluan Community College is the terminal station for Line D in that direction."

Kingsley absorbed this, blinking several times in quick succession.

"Wait — you're saying you think that bodyguard hid the Artifact at Buluan Community College Station?"

"No," Chase said. "I think he hid the Artifact on the subway."

Kingsley's jaw dropped. Two seconds passed before she pulled it back up. "The subway? Blackmoor City's subway? You — he — is he out of his mind?"

Somehow, she had the feeling that what she'd originally meant to say was something more like "are you serious."

Blackmoor City's subway could be called world-famous — just not for being busy or crowded.

Beyond ordinary commuters and tourists, the cars were always filled with cult members recruiting followers, vendors selling fake newspapers, people announcing the deaths of public figures who were still very much alive, prophets warning of the coming apocalypse, performers changing clothes in public to beg for money — an endless parade of strange and colorful characters.

People often said that to tell whether someone was a true Blackmoor City native, all you had to do was watch them on the subway — if they could sit there, completely unfazed, from the moment they boarded to the moment they got off, then they were the real thing.

Anyone's first instinct, if they needed to hide something, would not be to hide it in a place like that.

And besides — once the subway pulled away, how would Ivan ever retrieve it?

"There's a lot I don't understand," Kingsley said, thinking it through. "Ivan stopped the car on his way into Blackmoor City, went into the subway station, and came back out quickly — that part makes sense, and he would have had time for it. But how do you know he hid it on the subway?"

"You said the Artifact 'flashed by,' right? If your detection method is really as reliable as you say, then it means that at the moment you sensed it, it was at the very edge of your detection range, moving forward at high speed, and left your range an instant later.

"In other words, before you began detecting, it had already been traveling through your detection range at a certain speed for some period of time — that's exactly why, at the moment you started detecting, it happened to be right at the edge of your range, and ultimately 'flashed by' like that."

Her detection range was enormous. Pedestrians, bicycles, even cars moving at city speed limits — if they weren't moving fast enough, they couldn't leave her detection range in any short span of time.

Based on the picture they'd pieced together so far, Ivan had not been in contact with anyone; and within the city, what could travel continuously at high speed without being restricted by traffic, carrying the Artifact out of Kingsley's detection range?

When Chase's gaze had landed on the "D" sign, it came back to him: Fullington Station was right nearby.

While they'd been searching without finding anything, deep beneath their feet, a subway train had been thundering off into the distance — with the Artifact on board.

The possibility that another Artifact had simply happened to appear along Ivan's route was something neither of them had stopped to consider — "possibility" and "probability" are two entirely different concepts. Even with any number of Hunters tirelessly trying to carry Artifacts out into the world, the total number of Artifacts in existence remained very small.

Kingsley glanced back at the cluster of patrol cars refusing to give up the chase, and resigned herself to her fate. She gripped the overhead handle and said, "No wonder you cut across the

streets and didn't hesitate to drive against traffic and over the speed limit — you're racing the subway, and just taking a regular shortcut probably wouldn't be enough. Though this is actually terrifying. If I don't die in the Nest but end up dying in a car crash, that would really be too ironic."

Chase didn't respond to that. He glanced at the time and said, "When you detected the Artifact, it was around 10:03."

He had an obsessive habit — no matter the situation, he had to know the time, and it had to be precise to the minute.

The habit had held for over twenty years; now, even without checking his watch, his internal clock was nearly flawless. Before he'd even looked, he already knew it was 10:13 — he had been speeding through the pursuit and blockades of patrol cars for nearly ten minutes.

Ahead of him, there were still any number of red lights waiting. Every one of them was a choice: stop and get caught by the police? Run it, and get split in two by oncoming traffic?

He needed to think of something — how to carve an empty road out of Blackmoor City's sea of traffic?

Chase asked, "What's the current interval between trains on Line D?"

Kingsley glanced at the map app on her phone. "Seven minutes," she answered.

"Check your navigation — how many minutes until the next train departs from Fullington Station? And how long does it take to reach the terminal?"

"The next train departs in two minutes. It takes thirty-five minutes to reach the terminal."

As Kingsley said this, she caught on as well, her eyes gradually lighting up. "Ah — the train with the Artifact on it will reach the terminal station at 10:36! We just need to get to the platform before 36 minutes past."

People who could treat "entering the Nest to hunt" as a career rather than a final hobby before death were never slow on the uptake.

If the next train departed at 10:15, then the ones before it had left at 10:08 and 10:01 respectively. When Kingsley had started detecting at 10:03, the subway that had left at 10:01 was just about to leave her detection range; by the time it traveled from Fullington Station to the terminal, it would be exactly 10:36.

"But I still have one question," Kingsley said, frowning. "How do you know that subway was heading toward Buluan Community College Station and not going the other direction?"

"I don't," Chase said.

Kingsley's head snapped toward him and she stared.

"I only know one thing," Chase said — he was more patient with Hunters from his own House Faction than with anyone else, and he explained: "When you go down into Fullington Station, the platform on the first underground level is the one heading toward Buluan Community College Station. The second underground level is the one going in the opposite direction."

"Oh," Kingsley's frown relaxed and she nodded. "So you're betting that the bodyguard just got on the nearest available train. That tracks — he only took thirteen minutes more than the GPS-estimated route; factor in the time to park, get out of the car, and wait for the train, and it means he didn't linger in the station at all. He was in and out."

Ivan only needed to ride one stop — once he'd hidden the Artifact, he could get off at the next station and, without even waiting, cross the platform and catch the subway going the other way.

"Still, to know a random subway station has two platform levels," Kingsley remarked, "you must have been born in Blackmoor City. You know this place so well."

Chase didn't answer. He simply said, "Make a call. Report it to the police."

Kingsley blinked twice, unable to help glancing back at the patrol cars behind them. One had gotten very close; the spinning flicker of its lights cast blue and red across the rear window glass.

"We're not short on police," she pointed out.

"Don't waste time." Chase kept his foot steady on the gas, continuing toward the intersection ahead where the light was red. "Call it in — tell them you're on a speeding car, and have them seal off the area from Columbia Avenue and East 106th Street to Cherry Street within ten minutes."

"You're the boss either way." She muttered as she opened the dialer.

Kingsley had barely finished pressing the three digits when her eyes yanked away from the screen — from the road on their right, a large truck had just crossed through the intersection and was now rumbling toward them, on a direct collision course to slam into the black Mercedes broadside.

"The truck—"

Chase didn't brake — he accelerated, flooring the gas pedal level with the floor, and the engine let out what sounded almost like a cry of desperation as the car shot straight ahead at breakneck speed.

Kingsley's involuntary scream filled and echoed through the cabin, then was swallowed by the thunderous crash that struck the rear of the car — though only the corner of the tail end was clipped, the impact wrenched the entire vehicle hard to one side, nearly spinning it to a sideways stop in the middle of the intersection.

Two large hands wrenched the steering wheel hard over, and amid the shuddering groan of metal and engine, the car broke free of the intersection and pulled out onto the road ahead; behind them, the truck slammed on its brakes and skidded diagonally across the road, and a chain of rear-ending cars piled up in an instant into a steel serpent, blocking the pursuing patrol cars on the other side.

"I joined the Hunter House Faction for more security," Kingsley cried out, still reeling from the shock. "Not to put my life on the line at work! This isn't the Nest—"

"911," a woman's voice came from below the seat. "What is your emergency?"

"Hurry," Chase kept his foot on the gas, snapping his fingers in front of Kingsley. "We might not be so lucky at the next intersection."

"Hello — hello!" Kingsley scrambled to pick up her phone. "I'm in the car that's been barreling through the Buluan District!"

She rattled off Chase's instructions at speed, then paused, glanced at him, and said, "...You want to know who I am? Well, I've been — been kidnapped into this car. He's pointing a gun at me and making me make this call. He says if they don't block off the road... he'll throw a bomb into the traffic."

Chase shot her a sideways glance and broke into a grin, a flash of white teeth.

"I'd say it's been a pleasure working with you," he said quietly, after Kingsley hung up, "but our work together has only just begun."

My stockpile of chapters is almost gone after tomorrow, aaaaaahhh

And I've been running around like crazy these past few days and haven't had time to check who the new sponsors are — the bonus chapter debt is still at 7. Well, as long as I don't look, it stays at 7... No, I mean, I will definitely write those bonus chapters. I promise.

Today is packed again — Qidian in the morning, errands in the afternoon, and then some unexpected last-minute event tonight that I absolutely cannot skip... I had no idea this thing was happening, and my suitcase only has jeans, sneakers, and T-shirts, so they might not even let me in the door — hey, if they don't let me in, doesn't that mean I get to come back and write? See, I'm such a responsible, work-minded person.

PS: Prices are going to be the death of me... Especially to my friends in Shanghai — how do you people survive? I was absolutely floored by the prices. I paced back and forth in front of a single bottle of mouthwash four times, like I was working up the nerve to propose to it. The store clerk was already staring at me before I finally steeled myself and grabbed it. A small bottle of mouthwash is like under ten yuan anywhere else, right?! What is Shanghai mouthwash made of — can you drink it after rinsing for beauty and wellness benefits or something?!

Chapter 18: Mai Minghe's Fourth Person

The exit of St. Louis Hospital (Nest version), according to the redhead, was inside the guardhouse outside the hospital building.

To get there, they had to go up to the first floor, cross the lobby, and walk out the main entrance—and the whole way, they'd have to avoid not only Residents, but also the redhead's companions; without someone to lead the way, it was a actually thorny problem.

Mai Minghe was grateful.

"Young man, what's your name?"

She smoothed the white sheet back into place—a habit she had kept for seventy or eighty years; even after climbing down from a mortuary slab, she still had to leave it neat—and sighed: "What a shame we don't know each other back in Blackmoor City. Otherwise, no matter what, I'd have knitted you a sweater and sent it over. Look at you—you didn't dress warmly enough today. It's November and you're still wearing short sleeves."

The redhead glanced at her as though she were the strangest thing in the entire Nest.

"...It's not like you're my great-aunt," he finally muttered after a long pause. "My name's Jonah. But I'd advise you, once you're back, to keep pretending we don't know each other. Don't let my House Faction find out about you."

She still had countless questions and very much hoped she could ask Jonah in a safe environment—but he was right; none of those questions were as important as the Artifact.

Questions about the Nest she could slowly tease out, bit by bit, in time.

"Let's go," Jonah said. "We reset, but it's still safer not to take the same route back."

As the two of them left, Mai Minghe switched off the light on her way out. In the instant before the light died, the body lying beneath the white sheet in the corner of the morgue swept across the edge of her vision one last time—and then was swallowed by the darkness.

The morgue door was heavy; left unbraced, it swung shut on its own, closing behind them with a heavy thud.

Mai Minghe followed behind Jonah, turning down the other end of the corridor, and for reasons she couldn't quite name, her mind felt hazy and unsettled.

Her thoughts kept drifting back to that silent, sheet-covered shape in the morgue—it struck her as a truly genuine corpse: no reaction when Jonah turned on the light, no reaction while the two of them talked, and no reaction when they left.

"Do they actually use the morgue to store real corpses?" Mai Minghe asked. "The moment I think about how we might have been lying right next to an actual dead body just now, my heart just—it gives me the creeps..."

"Hm?" Jonah answered absently. "Just now? A dead body?"

She swallowed back a sentence that had nearly slipped out, and raised her eyes to look at his back.

Jonah's red hair was cut very short; below the neat line of his hairline at the back, there was still a faint dusting of light-orange fuzz that hadn't been shaved clean, hovering like a mist across the nape of his neck.

Something stirred and settled uneasily in her chest, and she could hardly have said what she was thinking—she said vaguely: "Right... just now."

Jonah was quiet for a second or two.

In the rhythm of their footsteps, he said, "I don't know—maybe someone would do that. It is a morgue, after all."

Mai Minghe gave a low "mm" to show she'd heard.

She turned to look behind her; at her back stretched a straight corridor, leading to the staircase they had come down earlier.

If she turned and ran from here, she had nowhere to change direction—fleeing in a straight line, it would be very hard to shake off a pursuer... No, no, maybe she wouldn't need to run at all?

Maybe she was overthinking it?

Right—don't rush, think it through first, Mai Minghe told herself.

1. The morgue was a "reset" location: a person went in, lay down, and played dead; after enough time had passed, the hospital Residents would forget them.

2. Before they entered, someone was already lying in the morgue—or at least something person-shaped.

3. After they came out, Jonah had clearly forgotten that someone was still lying in the morgue.

Goosebumps rose in waves across the skin of Mai Minghe's thighs, every pore seeping cold.

Reasoning from these three known facts, there was only one conclusion to draw: Jonah was a Resident.

But that conclusion was absurd—he was plainly a flesh-and-blood living person, and he had saved her. She must have missed something; she needed to think it over again.

Jonah's pace was fast, and after following him at a brisk stride for a while, Mai Minghe found they had climbed up a staircase on the other side of the hospital and emerged onto the first floor, not far from the emergency room.

The hospital corridors and waiting areas were all brightly lit, but the nurses' station was completely empty.

Aside from the all-round emptiness, this place was an exact replica of the real human world. On the surface of the nurses' reception desk, there was even a paper cup—only without anyone to drink from it, as though the apocalypse had arrived without warning and humanity had abandoned the place.

Along the corridor they were in, there were several examination rooms; some doors were shut tight, others stood half-open, revealing a sliver of impenetrable dim darkness.

The whole way, there was nothing to be heard but their own footsteps and breathing. Jonah had chosen a very good route—not a single Resident encountered, every danger avoided.

"There's often something in the emergency room," Jonah crouched behind a wall, carefully peered out, surveyed the space for a moment, then said to Mai Minghe: "When we pass through, we have to stay absolutely silent."

Mai Minghe nodded, but a thought forced its way into her mind.

...But when they were playing dead, they hadn't needed to stay silent?

She actually knew nothing about the Nest or about "life gates," but thinking about it logically, she felt that when a person was pretending to be a corpse, they shouldn't be chatting and

laughing back and forth the way the two of them had just been doing.

A corpse—shouldn't it be like the figure lying in the corner... motionless, utterly silent, no matter what happened?

What if the person in the corner was a Hunter who was truly in the middle of resetting...

Then had she actually reset successfully?

Mai Minghe looked down at her fingertips.

As for how to verify whether Jonah was a Resident or a living person—when she thought carefully, she actually did have a way.

Although she had wiped most of the blood off onto the lanky patient earlier, a thin line of dark blood still remained deep under her fingernails, not entirely cleaned away.

Mai Minghe used the nail of another finger to work out a little of the dark red residue and held it between her fingertips. When Jonah stood up and said quietly, "Let's go," she immediately reached out and grabbed his arm, calling out: "Wait."

Fortunately, he was wearing short sleeves; the dark red blood on her fingers transferred cleanly onto Jonah's skin.

Nothing like the writhing and thrashing the lanky patient had shown happened at all.

"What is it?" Jonah half-bent, stepping back behind the wall. "Did you spot something?"

He looked a bit pale—but who could look rosy-cheeked in a situation like this; Mai Minghe suspected her own complexion was worse—yet apart from that, he seemed completely normal, no pain, no reaction, not even noticing that the round-headed one's blood had gotten on his arm.

It seemed he wasn't a Resident after all. Mai Minghe quietly breathed a sigh of relief.

There was probably some other explanation for what had happened in the morgue, even if she couldn't think of it at the moment—but she wasn't God; how could she possibly account for every single thing without a gap?

From now on, she'd just have to stay a little more careful and watchful.

"Say something."

"Mm... I was thinking," Mai Minghe, under his stare, needed an excuse, and hemmed and hawed: "Once we get out of here, isn't it going to be pretty dangerous? We should find some useful

weapons before we head out."

Jonah frowned, thinking it over. "We don't have much time. Who knows how long this corridor will stay safe? As long as we're fast enough—rush to the exit before danger closes in—weapons aren't strictly necessary."

It had only been meant as an excuse, but now that he put it that way, Mai Minghe actually felt that finding a weapon was necessary. In this life, no matter what you're doing, being prepared does no harm; a youngster like Jonah, brimming with confidence, was perfectly normal—but she couldn't just go along with his overconfidence.

"How about this—when we pass the nurses' station, I'll duck in and take a quick look around. It won't waste any time."

To leave the building they had to pass the nurses' reception desk anyway; if she went in one end and came out the other, it would only take a few glances.

Jonah wasn't thrilled, but he didn't argue.

"Then I'll come in with you," he tilted his chin in indication. "If there's nothing strange inside the nurses' station, it's actually safer than being out in the open—gives us some cover."

Decision made, the two immediately crouched low, moved lightly on their feet, and slipped out from behind the wall.

Scanning left and right as they went, they hurried toward the nurses' station—like two frantic beetles, four legs rustling and scraping across the floor—and slipped behind the partition of the nurses' station.

The nurses' reception desk was rectangular, with entrances on either side directly facing each other. Mai Minghe was perpetually afraid that the moment she looked up, a face would appear at the opposite entrance; so, almost compulsively, every few seconds she had to sweep a glance over before she felt at ease.

On the side facing the lobby were three nurses' workstations, fitted with computers, office chairs, telephones, and various odds and ends like folders and forms—if not for what she had just experienced, she could hardly believe this wasn't the real St. Louis Hospital.

How could there be phones and computers in the Nest? Who had brought all this in?

The letters on the keyboard had worn white, as though someone had actually typed on it for years; a small cactus—real or fake, she couldn't tell—sat grey and dusty in the corner of the desk.

For a moment she almost forgot her objective entirely, caught in the strange wonder of a TV viewer first setting foot on a film set—even the most mundane, unremarkable things, the duty roster and the ballpoint pen, seemed to take on a fresh novelty that made them worth a second look—but unfortunately, she couldn't find anything that might serve as a weapon.

Mai Minghe had just stretched out her hand, wanting to listen for a dial tone on the phone, when Jonah immediately stopped her.

"Don't touch anything that could make contact," he warned her in a breath. "There's no telling what it might attract."

He had probably been traumatized by her pressing the call bell four times in a row—his whole face read: "Have you learned nothing?"

Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and thought for a few seconds.

"There's nothing here," Jonah crouched behind the workstation; that way, no one looking in from outside the nurses' station would see anyone inside. He pointed to the entrance on the other side and said, still in a whisper: "Let's go, don't waste any more time."

"Okay."

When Jonah crouched low and moved to the front of the entrance, he suddenly stopped and looked back at Mai Minghe. "What are you just standing there for? Come on."

Mai Minghe pulled out an office chair; the four wheels rolled and rumbled, breaking the quiet, and stopped in front of her.

She bent slightly forward, both hands pressed on the back of the chair, looking at the face across from her.

Jonah looked no older than thirty—as a grown adult, he had barely begun his journey in life. His eyes were a little red, his lips dry, his body carrying a faint shimmer of warm sweat—very human.

She didn't know the truth of it, but she couldn't help feeling sad. Like a conditioned reflex, she felt sad for a child so young, and sad for the mother who had raised him little by little.

"You go ahead," Mai Minghe said, her voice a little hoarse. "I'm not going with you."

Jonah furrowed his brow, stared at her for a moment, as if he thought she was talking nonsense.

But after two seconds, his brow relaxed.

"...You noticed something?" He no longer seemed to care about being seen—he straightened up beside the nurses' station entrance and flashed Mai Minghe a bright smile. "Tell me about it."

"Not counting the lanky patient who was already in the room,"

Mai Minghe said quietly: "After I pressed the bell four times, a nurse came—plus the pair of hands under the bed and the underground Resident controlling the round-headed one... that's three 'figures disguised as nurses' in total. The fourth one to enter the room was you."

Truth be told, I thought that after posting the Mai Minghe and Sydney Ginn sections, someone would definitely spot the foreshadowing about "the fourth person" and "the exit" — but nope! (In Sydney Ginn's section, it was mentioned that returning to Blackmoor City also goes through the passage.) So this round goes to me — anyone who goes back to leave a comment about it now doesn't count!

I suppose my dear readers took pity on me and let me have this one win — after all, I've had such a rough time lately, running around exhausted and stressed and irritable every single day... Ugh, I won't get into the unpleasant stuff.

My backlog is gone. Starting tomorrow I'll have to live by my wits and perform for you all on the spot (not really) — I opened the Artifact Report page and took one look: variety arts, miscellaneous rambling, stand-up comedy (not actually).

First I lured everyone in with a novel, and now that the stockpile's dry, I'm putting on a ballet called **Swan Lake: Wielding a Broadsword** to pay back what I owe my dear readers — is that okay? Quite the innovative scam operation we've got here.

Chapter 19: Mai Minghe's Reproductive Unit

Looking back on it now, Jonah had kept quite a close watch on her.

He would turn his head every so often to check whether Mai Minghe was keeping up, and whenever she hesitated or slowed down, he would urge her to keep moving. Even for someone actually warm-hearted, his concern for her safety seemed almost excessive—not only was he willing to forgo the Artifact, he was even ready to abandon his companions for her sake.

Of course, all of this reflection on Mai Minghe's part was hindsight.

"You're that sure about it?"

Jonah still kept his voice low—no longer a whisper exactly, but as though he didn't want anything else to hear him either.

"This is your first time in the Nest. How can you be so certain that ringing the bell would definitely bring a Resident out? What if one of them didn't go, or went but found they couldn't outcompete the others and simply didn't enter the room?"

"If I really am just a Hunter who got caught while trying to escape and was thrown into the ward, yet you're this suspicious of me, wouldn't you just be throwing away a valuable ally for nothing?"

"...So are you?" Mai Minghe asked quietly.

Jonah licked his dry lips, thought for a moment, and smiled.

"...No."

The word had barely left his mouth before Mai Minghe had already kicked a chair, sending it flying straight at him.

She didn't wait to see whether it connected—she spun around and ran immediately. A clang rang out, as though the chair had struck something hard, sending a heart-stopping echo through the empty, silent waiting hall.

It didn't sound like it had hit a human body, but Mai Minghe had no time to look back and find out. She burst out of the nurses' station, sprinted across the hall, and charged toward the

corridor she had come from—she remembered there were several examination rooms along it, their doors left ajar, and if she could dash into one and lock it, she might be able to hold Jonah off.

A sharp whistle pierced the air behind her, followed immediately by Jonah's voice: "Come!"

What was he calling?

Mai Minghe forced herself to pump her legs even faster, twisted around a corner, and plunged into the quiet corridor—strangely, not a single footstep sounded on the floor behind her, as though Jonah hadn't given chase at all.

She couldn't suppress her curiosity and shot a quick glance back over her shoulder.

The corridor was empty, pale light soaking into the desolate silence.

Jonah really hadn't come after her.

Never mind why he hadn't; she'd already run this far—even if he started chasing now, he probably couldn't catch up, could he?

Should she still duck into an examination room?

The question flashed through her mind, and she made her decision at once: yes.

She knew nothing about this St. Louis Hospital inside the Nest, and running around blindly might land her in any number of dangers. She had at least glanced into the examination rooms as she passed—they weren't entirely unfamiliar territory.

The door of the first examination room was firmly locked; she tried the handle and found it wouldn't turn, so she immediately ran toward the next room, whose door stood half-open—it was a heavy sliding door sheathed in a steel panel. The moment she got a clear look at it, she cursed under her breath and kept running.

Fortunately, the next examination room wasn't far, and its door hadn't been shut all the way either, leaving a gap; she gave it a quick push, only to find it wouldn't budge more than a fist's width, as though something was jamming it.

"Why didn't you go into that last room?" Jonah's voice asked.

Mai Minghe's heart skipped a beat.

She slowly raised her head and followed the sound, and there, wedged in the angle where the ceiling met the wall, she saw a human face hanging upside down.

Of course—Jonah had climbed the walls before. He had crawled along them to get here; no wonder she hadn't heard any footsteps.

Jonah's abdomen faced the ceiling, his hands and feet clinging firmly to the plastered wall like some enormous insect. She had no idea when he had gotten above her, nor how he was managing not to fall.

His neck bent downward, his eyeballs drooping, fixed on Mai Minghe with a wide expanse of white showing—Jonah at this moment reminded her of a certain kind of doll whose eyes open and close with gravity, the kind that always made her feel, whenever she held one, as though she were holding a living thing pretending to be lifeless.

She also understood now why the door wouldn't open.

One of Jonah's hands wasn't gripping the ceiling at all—it was thrust into the gap in the door, clamped firmly around one corner of the panel so she could neither push nor pull it.

"Don't be in such a hurry—just wait a little longer,"

Just as the question surfaced in Mai Minghe's mind, Jonah opened his mouth; his upper teeth, upside-down, flickered in and out between his lips. "My child is almost here. Reaching full maturity still depends on you."

What child?

Mai Minghe stepped back sharply from Jonah, then quickly cast a glance down the depth of the corridor.

What came around from behind the corner was a very small shadow. Had it not been crawling toward her with a faint rustling sound, Mai Minghe might never have thought it was alive.

At first glance it looked like a ball, or a crumpled plastic bag; but within a few seconds she could see it clearly—it was roughly the size of two fists, a wrinkled mass of pinkish flesh, and along both its sides, numerous slender legs were moving in rapid alternation, blurring into a smear of shadow.

What on earth was that thing?

The thought had barely crossed her mind when she felt a sudden chill on both her cheeks; two hands dropped down from the ceiling, fingers like iron claws, locking around her skull.

Mai Minghe jolted in fright and struggled with everything she had, fists pounding up against those arms again and again, each blow landing with a dull thud against hard muscle—but it didn't loosen the grip by a fraction. The two male hands pressed deep into her cheeks, seized her jaw, and forced her mouth open.

The wrinkled pink ball of flesh seemed to grow suddenly excited, crawling faster, several tentacle-like legs climbing up along her pajama pants.

Never before had she wished so badly to have a weapon in her hands—anything at all, even a length of pipe would do; but she had spent the first half of this night as a bedridden old woman, and aside from the clothes on her body, she was completely empty-handed.

"Don't be afraid," Jonah's voice soothed. "Look—am I not perfectly fine right now? As long as memory endures, a person isn't really dead. After I entered Jonah, his memories as 'Jonah' are still continuing, which means 'Jonah' is still alive... there's simply one more symbiote, that's all."

No wonder the round-headed one's blood had been useless against him—because the blood had been smeared on Jonah's body, not on the Resident's true self.

Mai Minghe flailed and swept her hands frantically across herself, trying to knock the thing off, but the flesh-ball moved like a nimble cockroach—its legs scuttling lightly and swiftly, darting away from her palms again and again, pressing ever forward toward her head.

"You could try covering your mouth the way Jonah did at the time," said the Jonah above her head.

What kind of advice was that—utterly insincere?

Now that he had said it, she honestly didn't know whether she should cover her mouth or not—or was that precisely the effect he was going for?

Mai Minghe truly regretted pressing the bell four times; since falling out of the hospital bed, she had lurched from one danger to the next, each situation more unpleasant than the last.

In that moment of hesitation, the thing had already crawled up to her chest, and up close it looked more and more like some hybrid of a brain and an insect—a raw, icy smell rose from her chest, five or six thin legs stepped across her collarbone, and an ugly, slick, wrinkled thing, its folds of skin layered over one another, appeared in Mai Minghe's field of vision.

Mai Minghe suppressed the instinct to raise her hands, twisting her head desperately to dodge, and rapidly pulled off her outer robe—the older you got the colder you felt, and she was no

exception; she slept in several layers, and the outermost one had its buttons undone, so she could yank it off in one go.

Two long, slender legs had already crept into her mouth—revolting, and maddeningly itchy.

Mai Minghe forced her gaze upward, fixed on her target, swung her arm, and with a sharp crack lashed her robe across Jonah's eyes with all her strength.

If he was using a human body, surely he couldn't escape the limitations of human physiology?

Who could stay perfectly still and composed after taking a hit straight to the eyeball?

Sure enough, Jonah let out an involuntary cry of pain, and the hands gripping Mai Minghe loosened slightly.

The moment she felt the hold slacken, she immediately bent low, pulling her head free from Jonah's reach; at the same time, Mai Minghe wrapped her hand in the robe and grabbed the thing that had been crawling into her mouth, pulling it out.

Thank goodness the skeletal patient had already wrung her dry of anything to vomit, because if she hadn't been, the sight of that squirming ball of flesh thrashing its limbs right in front of her face would have made her retch all over again.

Mai Minghe wrapped it in the robe, gripped it in her hand despite the revulsion, and ran.

She couldn't afford to be choosy this time; when she realized she had run back to the steel-paneled sliding door, Mai Minghe suddenly had an idea. She charged inside, immediately spun around by the door, and sure enough saw Jonah on the ceiling, eyes half-narrowed and blood-red, crawling rapidly toward her with his face twisted in fury.

"You slippery old woman—"

Mai Minghe kept her face expressionless and pulled the door with one hand.

These Residents.

"I told you, I'm not an old woman," she said quietly, and tossed the ball of flesh to the ground, landing it right on the sliding track. She pulled hard on the door, and it pressed down onto the flesh-ball.

Jonah's scream sounded as though it might tear his throat apart: "No, wait!"

The heavy sliding door, made of lead sheathed in steel plate, came crashing down on the wrinkled flesh-ball just as it hit the floor, before it could steady itself. Without so much as a cry, it was crushed and burst open, blood and shredded flesh spattering in all directions—in an instant, all that remained between the door and the wall was the largest fragment, a flat piece of flesh, its thin legs still twitching.

Before she could kick the remains aside and shut the door all the way, a hand covered in bulging veins slammed against the door frame with a crack.

Through the gap in the door, half of Jonah's face barely looked human anymore; his nostrils flared open and snapped shut like a pair of bellows that had opened on his face.

"My child!" he shrieked.

Mai Minghe braced against the door with all her strength, not daring to let him wrench it open and come through, while at the same time she swept a quick glance around the dim interior, then couldn't help letting out a quiet, resigned sigh.

Just as she had expected, this room was a medical imaging room.

Rooms for X-ray scanning required radiation shielding on the doors and walls, and few hospitals would install windows in an X-ray room—not because special shielded windows didn't exist, but because they were expensive and not cost-effective—which meant that once you were chased into an X-ray room, you were a turtle in a jar with no way out.

That was also why Mai Minghe had passed this door without entering the first time: if she went into an ordinary examination room and locked the door, she could still escape through a window, but in an X-ray room that would be impossible.

"Does something like you really need to pass on offspring?" Mai Minghe said through gritted teeth, still straining against the door. "This is the Nest—you don't need to go in for ecological reproduction here, do you?"

"Once I've killed you," Jonah's words came out in a wet, rasping hiss, as though each syllable was sticking to the next. "Your corpse will dissolve in the Nest, and from your constituent units, I will rebuild my child..."

"You mean, using my flesh and blood to rebuild your child?"

Mai Minghe leaned against the wall with her whole body braced against the door, muscles trembling, still unable to force it completely shut. She scanned the room for anything that might

serve as a weapon while buying time with conversation: "My flesh and blood probably aren't disgusting enough to make one."

Jonah suddenly burst out laughing.

"Flesh and blood? I don't want your withered old flesh and blood at all! As long as you have ever given thought to the matter of 'reproduction,' your mind and body have already been marked. The you who once considered 'reproduction' is still a part of who you are today, and as long as I can obtain that part—"

Mai Minghe froze.

She hadn't expected that, here and now, she would be pulled back into memories from years ago: the anxiety over her day-by-day declining fertility, the confusion over what choice to make, the unease about the prospect of old age...

Without realizing it, her grip loosened slightly.

Jonah caught it.

The sliding door was shoved open with a sudden, forceful push—she had barely startled when a red-haired head poked through the gap.

Digging a saved draft chapter out of my iPad, I've scraped by another day—it feels just like finding a thousand yuan in the pocket of a winter coat!

Chapter 20 — Mai Minghe and the Jonah Who Begged for Help

The shock hit Mai Minghe like a thousand volts crackling through her body all at once; she threw every ounce of strength she had into pushing the door forward—and she was fast enough that the sliding door clamped tight around Jonah's neck just before he could squeeze himself through.

If she could simply choke him out that way, things would have been simple.

Unfortunately, the door was pressing against the side of his neck, over the carotid artery—enough to flush his face deep red and make his breathing labored, but not enough to crush his windpipe fatally; as long as he could still breathe, he still had strength, and one hand hooked around the door's edge as he shoved hard back toward Mai Minghe.

The man could even talk.

"Did you know?"

His breath was ragged, but his words came out clear and complete: "...Anyone who lingers in the Nest for more than seven days, or who dies within it, is not merely broken down in body—their mind, their memories, their emotions, their experiences, even a single passing thought, are all dismantled piece by piece and transformed into other forms, becoming part of the Nest. You've lived a long life, haven't you? Quite a few experiences. And no shortage of wicked thoughts too, I'd wager. When you die here, I wonder what extraordinary things will emerge... People who die in the Nest at seventy or eighty years old are very rare indeed."

She half understood, and half did not.

After death, emotions, memories, and experiences would all become part of the Nest? What did "part of it" mean—would her own memories each become a Resident?

As if he had heard her thoughts, Jonah laughed, his breath hoarse: "What things will come walking out from eighty-six years of a life... I'm so looking forward to it."

Was this speech of Jonah's meant to shake her again, the way it had before?

Mai Minghe braced against the door with everything she had, teeth clenched, thinking: then he had miscalculated.

"Is it because Jonah always has to train new people that you can't help trying to enlighten me too?"

Even as her muscles trembled and her whole body shook, she still had no trouble finding words; she said, her voice quivering: "You live inside someone's body like a roundworm in an intestine—you have no experience of human life. What person makes it through this life without setbacks and hardship? But the thing is, life always finds a moment you least expect to offer you a little light and warmth.

"Even if you kill me here today and use me as raw material to produce a Resident, I won't be in pain, and I won't be angry. I didn't have many days left to begin with—lying in bed day after day, like a dried-up husk. The best of it has been gone forever. But before my life ended, I got to be young again, to live again, and to die in the image of myself as I was in my memories—who could be lucky enough for that? This is the gentleness Heaven has given me. I'm quite happy about it."

"Shut up!" Jonah couldn't get a word in, and he let out a hoarse shout: "Shut up!"

"When a person gets older, they can't help rambling a bit—once they start talking, they just can't stop."

Jonah seemed actually furious; he led by example and shut his own mouth first, pressing his lips into a tight line; a person and a disembodied head then engaged in a silent reverse tug-of-war for a while, accompanied only by each other's heavy, labored breathing.

Mai Minghe, true to form, could not hold herself back, and spoke again.

"You've burrowed into Jonah's body—doesn't that mean he has no independent will left at all? Hey, young man, are you still in there? Get a handle on that brain-worm of yours—this can't go on."

Jonah's face had long since burst into patches of broken capillaries from the pressure, covered in large, vivid blood spots all across his skin, like a swollen purple grape—yet he seemed entirely unbothered, showing no reaction to Mai Minghe's words at all, and kept pulling at the door.

People were dangerous when they went down a dead end, but it turned out that something that wasn't a person, going down a dead end, was just as hard to deal with...

Mai Minghe knew her own physical strength was no match for Jonah's.

Even if she had recovered her youth and regained a strong body, that was only in comparison to her eighty-six-year-old self; Jonah was powerfully built and had routinely walked the line

between life and death, and the two of them had never been on the same level to begin with—and what was more, the elderly had poor appetites, and in the day before she fell into the Nest she had eaten only a few crackers and a little egg, all of which she had vomited back up, and now, looking at the mutilated remains of the "child" on the floor, she was actually beginning to feel a faint twinge of hunger.

That she had managed to hold on this long was purely due to the advantage of her position; if the stalemate continued, she was bound to lose sooner or later.

Mai Minghe glanced once more at the remains of the "child" on the floor and suddenly sucked a sharp breath through her teeth: "Hm?"

The flicker of startled suspicion was enough to involuntarily slacken her grip.

Jonah reacted at once, and sure enough followed her gaze, glancing downward—Mai Minghe had been waiting for exactly this moment; she immediately seized the chance, threw her full body weight behind the door, and slammed it forward with all she had; a dry, cracked screech tore out from between the door and the wall, as if a frail, crumbling rubber tube had been caught in the gap.

"A child's trick, and it actually got you to look down," Mai Minghe said—though inside, she cursed under her breath.

She had hoped that while Jonah looked down, she would have a chance to slam the door shut completely.

Now, of course, the situation was hardly any different from before, and there was no telling how much longer the stalemate would drag on.

Air passed in and out of Jonah's throat in fitful, broken intervals, as though each breath was harder than the last.

Had it caught on his windpipe?

Because he had turned his head, she couldn't quite tell from her angle.

"I... I..." Jonah's face was to the wall, and his voice came out muffled and hoarse—less like speech, more like a balloon slowly leaking air. "I'm... a Hunter with Morgan House Faction..."

Now of all times, he was still bothering to introduce himself?

The doubt had barely formed in Mai Minghe's mind before a sense that something was different came over her; she kept listening.

"My name is Jonah Janko... This is already my fifth day in the Nest..." he said with great difficulty. "I beg you... go to Morgan House... ask for rescue..."

A layer of goosebumps prickled softly across Mai Minghe's skin.

Whether it was because the door had caught something critical and temporarily severed the Resident's control, she couldn't say—but the one speaking to her now was not the Nest's Resident bent on killing her, but Jonah, a Hunter from Blackmoor City, begging for his life.

"Where are your companions?" Speaking was a strain for Mai Minghe too at this moment. "Can't you call them here? You can see my situation—I can barely keep myself alive."

Her limbs had long since begun going weak in waves; all she could do was keep telling herself "one more second," and when that second passed, "one more second," and that was how she had held on until now.

"Get out of the Nest... get out now..." Jonah was still speaking in broken fragments.

"I can't get out," Mai Minghe cut him off. "Can you keep control of your body and stop the Resident from coming after me? From here to the exit of the Nest is still a long way—"

"No, no... it lied to you."

Mai Minghe snapped her mouth shut, and her teeth clicked together with the force of it.

"However the passage brought you here... is how you go back..." Two rattling clicks came from Jonah's throat, and then silence.

Just as Mai Minghe's heart clenched and she thought the Resident had wrested back control, he spoke again without warning: "Fell in through the television... the television... go back that way. You've already passed through the passage once, so when you see it again, you'll feel it..."

"But the moment I let go, the Resident will regain control of you, won't it?" Mai Minghe couldn't fully conceal her agitation. "Never mind that I might not even make it out—even if I could run, I don't know if I'd find the tele— before it catches me—"

The word "vision" lodged itself in her throat, unfinished.

Her gaze came to rest on the far end of the room.

After a few seconds, Mai Minghe asked in a low voice: "When I see the passage, I'll know that's what it is—is that what you mean?"

Jonah's throat hissed faintly, as though he could no longer answer her.

Mai Minghe couldn't help swallowing, her heartbeat loud enough to hear inside her own ears.

In the dimness, she could just barely make out, at the far end of the room, a small door.

Although the medical imaging room had no outward-facing windows, a small room had been partitioned off inside it, and that door led to the small room; beside the door was a glass window facing directly toward the X-ray machine.

When she had been searching for a weapon, she had only looked at what was close at hand, so she had noticed the small door and the glass window without thinking anything of them; but now she suddenly realized something—when she used to go for X-rays, the doctor would always sit in that little room.

Why sit in there?

Because the doctor had to operate the equipment and view the images.

From the edge of the window, she could now make out the shadow of half a computer screen; with no light, everything was blurry and indistinct, and if one hadn't specifically looked for it, one might not have registered it as a screen at all.

The screen was used for viewing medical images and was quite large—and the feeling she'd had back then, lying in the bed and desperate to get to the television, suddenly ignited inside Mai Minghe like a wildfire, burning brighter and brighter.

Could it be that her passage was not a television set, but simply a "screen"?

But then—when she had passed the nurses' station and seen the computer screen on the counter, why had she felt nothing?

That question didn't matter right now, and this was not the time to think about it.

"Hey, Jonah?" Mai Minghe called out. She wanted to confirm her guess with him, but from Jonah's throat came only a low, wet gurgling.

"How am I supposed to find Morgan House Faction? Do you have... do you have their phone number?"

You wouldn't find a Hunter faction in the Yellow Pages, would you—oh, right, there were no Yellow Pages anymore. People in the old days had worried about no one being able to find them, so they'd list their home numbers in the public phone directory; people nowadays were exactly the opposite, as if what they feared most was something called "a privacy breach."

The world had changed.

How was she supposed to find "Morgan House Faction"? Would it be on a smartphone? She couldn't let a perfectly good young man be done in by some rotten worm.

But Mai Minghe called out to him a few more times, and Jonah gave no response whatsoever.

She looked at the screen in the small room, and inside her chest the wildfire burned.

If her guess was wrong and she made a dash for the small room only to find she couldn't return to Blackmoor City, that would certainly mean death; but if the stalemate dragged on indefinitely, death was just as inevitable.

Since danger lay on either path, she might as well act.

Mai Minghe took a long, deep breath, and lowered the foot she had been bracing against the door.

She let go; the moment the pressure on the door eased, the Resident snapped awake. At the very instant Jonah's shoulder forced the sliding door open, Mai Minghe took a step and broke into a run toward the small room.

Today is another day I find myself on a plane; by my estimate I'll have to fly at least three more times in the next two weeks—all the major airlines are popping champagne right now, except for China Eastern.

Just seeing the words "China Eastern" when I'm booking tickets is enough to make me feel unwell—I have to scroll past it immediately. There's a saying that people won't remember what you said or what you did, but they'll always remember the way you made them feel. That's exactly how it is with China Eastern and me—I've long since forgotten what it was that disgusted me in the first place, but that disgust has weathered the passage of time and stands unyielding to this day. The mere thought of China Eastern can make me motion-sick sitting on the toilet, so I'd rather take a Southern Airlines flight that doesn't arrive until eleven at night than give a single cent to an afternoon China Eastern flight.

Chapter 21 — How Can You Tell If I'm Making Excuses?

Friends, grandmas, extraterrestrials — honestly, I don't know myself whether this counts as a fake excuse note or not.

Grandma, put the shoe down first, let me explain for a moment, and then see if you can hold back from swatting me like a cockroach.

I was originally supposed to fly out yesterday. I checked the weather in the morning, Shanghai was clear and sunny, I was pretty happy about it — trotted off to Pudong Airport, figured I could sneak in some writing in a quiet corner while waiting to board. Had it all planned out; I was even willing to buy a lounge pass just to get some updates done.

After all that hassle getting there, I took out my phone and looked — well, would you believe it, the flight was cancelled.

Apparently all of Guangdong was under an orange weather alert — thunderstorms — which just goes to show how warmly my home province welcomes me back.

But I couldn't just strand myself in Shanghai forever, I still had to leave — so I immediately applied to rebook. The rebooking alone took a goddamn two hours, during which there were all sorts of phone calls, checking flight information... After two hours, I successfully got rebooked onto a 9:30 PM flight that same night — except it departed from Hongqiao Airport.

Fine. Off to Hongqiao.

Every DiDi driver in Shanghai must have me enshrined on their dashboard or something.

I got to Hongqiao Airport and looked at the departures board — there was an extra line of text. Above "Scheduled departure 21:35," a new line had appeared: "Estimated departure 23:35" — I ask you, is that how human beings communicate? What is this, a competition to see who knows the most synonyms? I already had a bad feeling at that point. After all, Guangdong's rainstorms don't play favorites. What was I supposed to do — I couldn't just sit in the airport waiting to see when the plane might eventually decide to fly. I'd better book a hotel.

It's not like I'm staying overnight anyway, cheapest one will do, maybe in a few hours I'll be on my way. I thought naively.

So I dragged my luggage into a cab and got ferried to a place that looked less like Shanghai and more like a county town. Got out of the car. It really was close to the airport — a jumbo jet thundered so low over my head it nearly blew my wig off (going so hard on the writing that I started losing hair at eighteen). I took a few pictures of the planes while I was at it. Couldn't come all this way for nothing.

Checked in, walked into the room, walked right back out — why? To go buy disposable toilet seat covers. That toilet seat was yellowed like old braised stock — one look and you knew it had been marinating in ancient piss for years.

Right. This is the hotel that still costs over three hundred yuan at the cheapest. I am indeed in Shanghai.

Well, would you believe it — the universe heard me say "not staying overnight." The second flight was delayed too. Delayed until five in the morning.

Even owls can't pull an all-nighter like that!!!

I rebooked a second time, to eleven o'clock this morning.

And then I just stood there in that hotel room, holding my bag, trapped and miserable, realizing I really was going to have to spend the night here. If I'd known it would come to this, why didn't I book somewhere decent? The heavens are out to get me. First I put the door chain on (I never normally bother with that), then I pulled back the duvet and inspected the sheets — the sheets were okay, at least they looked white.

By this point I'd been through the wringer and it was already evening. Having typed not a single word but feeling utterly drained in body and soul, I reached down to feel the mattress.

...Where is my mattress?

These individual springs, poking me one by one — what are they made of, diamonds? Don't mattresses usually have some kind of padding on top? Where's the padding?? I could feel every single spring through the sheet, like I was taking its pulse — WHERE IS MY PADDING?!?!?!?

I honestly felt like crying right then. You want to know how I slept that night? I spread the duvet back out flat and used it as a mattress. Lying on top of the duvet, the sensation was exactly like lying on a sidewalk.

Then I pulled one end of the duvet out, wrapped it around myself from the side, and made myself into a stuffed flatbread. That way I had both a mattress and a blanket at once — one item,

two functions — and only then could I actually sleep.

By this point I had typed all of three hundred words and was completely spent. I closed my eyes somewhere after nine. Going to bed that early was a form of disrespect toward the neighbors next door.

So around past ten o'clock, I heard it. You might think the sounds in a hotel are more or less the same few things. You'd be wrong.

I heard a pair of high heels going click-clack-click-clack down the hallway — at least twenty laps of it (no carpet) — then the door slammed, one loud bang, and whoever it was went inside. After that, someone began moving furniture.

Half-asleep, I was lying there thinking even in my dreams: how are you moving the furniture? The tables and beds in hotels are all bolted to the goddamn floor — so what on earth is that heavy thing scraping across the floor???

And why did it go on for half an hour?! Are you renovating the hotel??

What is everyone in this place here for???

Anyway, long story short, I made it through the night. Once I post this little account of the situation, I'll have to pack up all my bags again and head to the airport. I'm exhausted, worn out, and half-convinced I smell terrible (didn't dare shower here)··· Estimated landing time is around two in the afternoon. If the flight actually lands on time, there might be an update tonight. If there's another delay, I'm going to go jump in the Huangpu River.

After everything I went through on this trip to Shanghai — you think I'm done once I get home?

No. Business isn't finished. I have to come back again on the 8th, after the holiday.

Wonderful. I'm clearly here to build character and experience life to the fullest.

Chapter 22: Sydney Ginn, After Life and Death

They say that at the moment of death, a lifetime of memories passes before your eyes like a revolving lantern; Sydney Ginn now knew that this was neither entirely right nor entirely wrong.

She lay on the cold floor of the exhibition hall, and yet she felt like a small boat adrift—the ropes that had bound her to the world of the living had come loose, and she was slowly drifting out onto a river thick with fog.

Sometimes the fog thinned and parted, revealing the scene of her first arrival in Blackmoor City; back then she had split the rent on a semi-basement apartment, and looking out the living room window at the street, all she could see were passing shoes and trouser hems.

Sometimes she saw the client from her very first transaction, turning an Artifact over and over under a desk lamp, the light falling into their eyes and rendering both their pupils and their suspicion half-transparent.

The experiences closest to her—opening the passage, attracting a stalker, being killed—felt more like things that had happened to someone else, flat and bleached-out descriptions that the fog swallowed whole. The distant, long-ago moments were more vivid: carrying out the scallion-and-meat pie her mother had baked, going over to a classmate's house every week in seventh grade... open the door, walk inside, and she could go home.

Drawn along by those faraway memories, Sydney Ginn drifted further away; the faint, desperate rattling in her injured throat grew harder and harder to hear.

Her head lay submerged in a pool of blood, which spread out around her like a river of the dead.

"Go ahead and die," a voice floated from somewhere above, whispering in a hissing, leaking sort of way.

And yet it was this send-off that called Sydney Ginn partway back.

...How did it come to this?

She had called the taxi, paid the fare, followed every instruction to the letter without daring to step out of line, and had a stiff neck to show for it by the time she got off.

She had pretended not to see the female Resident crawling out of the elevator on her right, fought her way into the ground-floor exhibition hall with great difficulty, and held her breath in tense, coiled readiness the entire time...

She had done everything, done it all, and still ended up like this. How could she not be furious.

A dark figure stooped down, apparently kneeling on the floor, studying her face.

Sydney Ginn could no longer make out details; all she saw were blurry silhouettes: a rounder shape was a skull, connected below it was a neck, and jutting out from that neck was another dark shape—the hunting knife she had driven into the other's throat.

As the figure opened its mouth to speak, the knife buried deep in its neck trembled gently up and down with each word. The blade had cut through its windpipe, and between syllables it leaked air with a hiss: "...I really should thank you—you've reminded me what it was I forgot. It was the hiking backpack."

Even though Sydney Ginn still had thoughts, none of them showed on her face. Blood had stained her neck a black-red, as though her throat had been erased; her body had gone still, utterly motionless.

When she had leapt onto the first taxi, she must have accidentally stepped on the "Copied" square.

She still remembered the moment she lifted her foot—someone had given the hiking pack on her back a sudden violent yank, nearly sending her tumbling backwards; when Sydney Ginn caught herself and turned around, she was looking at her own face—no distortion of any kind, the features smooth and fine, like looking in a mirror.

She had frozen.

"When did you copy yourself into me?" that other "Sydney Ginn" demanded, glaring at her and getting in the first word. It seemed to want to shove her, but wasn't quite brave enough to make contact, and snapped: "Get away from me!"

So the square labeled "Copied" really just meant she would be copied, and nothing else?

That actually made sense—copying something didn't necessarily mean the original would be damaged...

Apart from the existence of a copy, Sydney Ginn felt, going over herself from head to toe, that nothing was wrong; if there was one thing that made her most uneasy, it was this—"Sydney Ginn" seemed to have inherited both her body and her mind simultaneously, and was now utterly convinced that it was the real one.

...Then how could she be certain, one hundred percent, that she wasn't the Resident? She, too, was absolutely sure she was the real Sydney Ginn.

No—no, that was impossible; the one in front of her was the Resident, and it was about to take her place and go to the Museum of Modern Art.

There was one key piece of evidence that proved she was the real Sydney Ginn—the backpack, the hunting knife, and her phone were all still on her, none of them copied into a second set; the other one had nothing on her, not a single thing.

"At the time, my mind was entirely on how to jump onto the taxi, so I forgot to take the hiking backpack. I was standing in the square the whole time—it was too heavy to keep on my back, so I'd set it down on top of my feet..."

The dark figure hovering before her, shaped like a human face, went on leaking air: "What happened afterward that made me fail to pick up the backpack—that I forgot, because I handed that stretch of memory over to the driver."

Even at this point, "Sydney Ginn" apparently still did not believe it was the Resident.

It paused there, as though something had occurred to it: "I'd actually meant to ask you—Passenger Rule number four: can you lift your head once the fare is paid? But you're a Resident; you don't follow the Passenger Rules, so what could the consequences possibly be... never mind, it doesn't matter. I made it off the taxi just fine either way. I didn't expect you to bring my things to me, though."

...How could she not be furious.

At the time she had not dared to keep fighting with "Sydney Ginn," afraid of stepping into some punishment square; so she had called another taxi, paid the fare with memories, rode the whole way with her head bowed, following behind "Sydney Ginn," and got off at the Museum of Modern Art.

Whatever it did, she did the same, until she finally followed it into the underground exhibition hall, seized her moment, and drove the hunting knife deep into its throat.

Sydney Ginn had heard that Residents couldn't be killed. Even if they died for a moment, they could regenerate somewhere else.

But Residents were bound by rules that went beyond life and death, so an attack could still have some kind of effect—what she hadn't anticipated was that driving a knife into a Resident's throat would only result in a leaking windpipe.

She had let go of the knife handle in a daze, staring at "Sydney Ginn."

When it tried to spit, nothing came out of its mouth, which gaped like a dried-up black hole; now with the knife buried in its neck, it only hissed and leaked air, unable to bleed.

The other stood motionless, its eyes rolling down to look at the hunting knife, then lifting back up to look at her.

For a second or two, neither of them moved.

"Sydney Ginn" slowly spread her familiar teeth at her in a grin. She had brushed every single one of them countless times, studied their color and shape in the mirror until she knew them at a glance—and yet here they were, in someone else's mouth.

...Disgusting.

"My neck has been stabbed with a knife," the Resident said, matter-of-factly, after that second or two. "Since you copied yourself into my likeness, your neck should be pierced as well."

The moment those words were spoken, Sydney Ginn's neck opened its mouth.

...Why? How could this be?

So this was how cold the outside world was; when the blood vessels and muscle were torn open in one stroke, it was like ice water being poured in along the wound—and the pain came only belatedly, trailing behind.

The sudden cold at her throat was instantly swamped by the scalding spatter of blood that splashed across the face of her "self" opposite her—Sydney Ginn pressed one hand hard against her gaping throat, instinctively trying to clamp the wound shut again, but blood kept bubbling up through her fingers.

With her consciousness shattering at the edge of death, she crumpled to the ground.

Her eyelids froze half-open, half-closed, and her soul drifted into the deep, dense fog.

Sydney Ginn forced down the crawling dread that raised every hair on her body, pressed one hand tight against her neck, and seized the hunting knife's handle with the other.

Her palms were slick with cold sweat; her legs had gone so weak she couldn't stand, and she could only slowly slide down until she was sitting on the floor. A few steps away, the corpse that looked exactly like her lay on the ground, its eyelids half-open, the pupils beneath already clouded over like a dead fish's.

"Sydney Ginn" hadn't driven the blade deep enough, and had missed the critical structures—perhaps the one small mercy in all of this.

She knew very well that when a blade penetrated the body, pulling it out would only deepen the wound and cause heavy bleeding; the first rule of first aid was "do not remove anything from a wound." Sometimes a blade lodged in the body could temporarily act as a plug, sealing the wound and reducing blood loss.

The reason "Sydney Ginn" had died from the same injury while she herself was still alive was almost certainly due to that one crucial difference—the hunting knife stanching the bleeding. So Residents weren't unkillable after all, at least not the "Vulture" kind.

The logic of killing it was just a bit convoluted: you had to let it copy itself into a second version of you first, then, after you received a fatal wound, remind it to copy the fatal wound onto itself—only then would it die.

Even a wound that merely looked fatal would do.

Even though she knew she wasn't going to die, having a knife lodged in her throat was a torment to every nerve in her body; and besides, she couldn't call an ambulance in the Nest, couldn't go to an emergency room, and certainly couldn't climb all the way to the top of a high-rise and jump off with a knife in her neck just to get back to Blackmoor City for medical treatment...

She would have to handle it herself.

She dug a spare T-shirt out of her backpack and wrapped it tightly around her neck and the knife, winding it so tight she kept seeing stars and gasping for breath. She felt along the skin for the knife tip, located it with her fingertips, and got ready—the moment the knife was pulled out, she would press down on the wound immediately; she couldn't risk a major hemorrhage.

Sydney Ginn knew the Nest was dangerous, and had no doubt given herself first aid more than a few times; but even with her self-taught basic first aid knowledge and her well-stocked pack, this kind of injury was truly beyond anything she had imagined.

Even she herself didn't know how she had managed to stop the hemorrhage and then clumsily sutured the knife wound closed—it was nothing short of a miracle.

Despite the successful "surgery," Sydney Ginn couldn't hold on any longer and lost consciousness for a while.

When she came to, the underground exhibition hall was still perfectly silent; she and the stiffened corpse of her dead self lay slumped on either side of the enormous candle, and if she cocked her ear to listen, the place felt like a tomb.

Sydney Ginn rested for a long while before she slowly climbed to her feet.

The serious injury, the lingering fear, and the exhaustion made her want nothing more than to go home, to curl up under her covers, breathing in the familiar scent of jasmine laundry detergent, and sink into a long, deep sleep.

But it wasn't time yet.

Sydney Ginn was also quietly astonished; she hadn't expected that, faced with an Artifact, she would show a toughness that seemed beyond ordinary human limits. With a knife wound to the throat, how could an ordinary person survive?

She walked step by step to the candle, hesitated for a moment, and placed her hand against its surface.

A small line of text immediately floated up beside her palm: 2009.4.22.

...So the history encoded at this position corresponded to April 22nd, 2009?

She was currently standing several meters below the top of the candle. Why did this particular spot represent April 22nd, 2009?

Sydney Ginn thought for a moment, walked to the very top of the candle, and reached out to touch it—and sure enough, she saw her own birthday: 1998.9.29.

So that was it... her gaze followed the length of the candle downward.

That meant the flow of time encapsulated within the candle ran from the day she was born all the way to the present day while she was still alive; the candle held no future.

Because the future was chaos, unfixed—and therefore could not be foreseen?

Though her greedy hope of glimpsing the future had come to nothing, which was a little disappointing, looking at it from another angle it was a strange kind of comfort: since fate was not already written, she could still choose what to do and where to go. A person wasn't a small insect sealed inside a transparent cage, every possible path already defined.

In this bewildering, disorienting world, a person still had this small measure of control over themselves.

Of course, Sydney Ginn wasn't arrogant enough to think the Nest had custom-built this Artifact especially for her—whoever touched the candle, it should show history beginning from that person's date of birth.

She walked on a little further and, judging the distance by feel, placed her hand on the candle again to search.

2026.5.2. She found without difficulty the moment she had first encountered the stalker Anthony.

Sydney Ginn had an idea.

She crouched down and found an ignition switch beneath the metal trough. With a *click*, flames ignited beneath the candle's base.

She wanted to try—to snuff this whole thing out before it could begin.

All the sleep debt I'd racked up from the exhausting scramble of recent days came knocking the moment I finally got back... No matter how much coffee I drank, I was drowsy from the moment I opened my eyes in the morning until I fell into bed at night... By eight o'clock I simply couldn't take it anymore and had to sleep...

Chapter 23 – Sydney Ginn: If the Mountain Won't Come to You

The exhibition hall was as dead-still as a cave, broken only by the soft crackling of the flame.

Sydney Ginn's nerves were strung as tight as a bowstring; every little crack of the flame was like a finger plucking that string.

She had read through the long description of the Artifact "Candlefall" in full, and stood there turning it over in her mind for a good while before she could consider it even halfway digested.

She walked another circuit around the underground exhibition hall, making sure nothing lurked in the corners and shadows ready to launch a second attack—being attacked by herself once was already more than enough.

When she passed the corpse, she quickened her pace to move past, then suddenly stopped and turned back.

The corpse of her dead self always made Sydney Ginn feel deeply unsettled.

She had no wish to look at it, and even less to be looked at by it, so she simply covered its face with a towel, smothering that accusatory, scrutinizing gaze her own eyes had fixed on her, and only then returned to the candle.

Using a small flame to heat such an enormous candle naturally took a good deal of effort.

She had completed a full circuit of the exhibition hall before the candle had at last melted enough to proceed to the next step: the section of wax representing early May 2026 was beginning to soften and slacken from the bottom up, drooping heavily toward the floor like a belly swollen with child—except that the "belly" was gradually turning translucent, dark shapes drifting and shifting slowly within it, as though it were pregnant with a womb full of ghosts.

Sydney Ginn hurried over in a few quick strides, bent down, and peered at the past world showing through the melted wax.

The first thing she saw was herself.

According to the Artifact's description, because she was the one who had touched the candle, what the wax revealed was primarily her own personal history—the reason for "primarily" being that no person can survive apart from their broader environment, so significant events in the world around her that had shaped her would also surface within the wax.

The exact words in the description were as follows:

"...In today's highly integrated world, the historical turning points that carry decisive influence are more often than not caused by a handful of people. The mass movements that occasionally succeeded in the past are now almost impossible to replicate.

"Yet the decisions of a small number of oligarchs can influence and reshape the fate of all humanity. By the same token, when applied to personal history, the candle will faithfully render the key figures and key events that influenced and reshaped the individual's immediate environment."

This passage had seemed somewhat obscure at first reading, but after watching the history in the wax for a while, Sydney Ginn understood.

For instance—why had she come to meet the harasser Anthony in early May?

The most direct cause was that a female friend had invited her out to a bar that night.

Amber was not a Hunter and had no passage, but she worked in finance for the Morgan House Faction and had crossed paths with Sydney Ginn a few times before; the two of them got along well enough. It was that very night, at the bar, that Sydney Ginn had met Anthony—all gilded surface and nothing beneath.

But thinking one step deeper: why had Sydney Ginn, who hated the smell of alcohol most of all, agreed to go to the bar with Amber that day?

Because at the end of April, a regional war that had dragged on for years—exhausting the entire world with inflation and wearing everyone to the bone—had finally ground to a halt after immeasurable bloodshed, ending in what amounted to a farce.

The outcome of the war was far from satisfying to anyone with a sense of justice—no matter which side their sense of justice supported—but after years of tragedies that had repeated themselves until people were nearly numb, the whole world had collectively let out a breath; on the day the war was declared over, there were no shortage of celebratory parades and spontaneous public festivities, and even the news anchors seemed somehow lighter.

Artifact Hunters had one foot in the Nest and one foot in the human world, and their outlook always kept them a few paces removed from worldly affairs; Sydney Ginn was no exception.

But even she had felt those days as if sunlight were falling warm on her skin, her mood as brimming and expansive as the approaching summer—when Amber suggested going out for

drinks to celebrate, Sydney Ginn thought she could always have fruit juice, and agreed without a second thought.

If the war had not ended, Amber would not have invited her to celebrate; without going to the bar, she would never have met Anthony; without him becoming her stalker and harasser, Sydney Ginn would never have entered the Nest, would never have had a knife driven into her throat, would never have been standing beside her own corpse—and would certainly never have found this giant candle.

Everything she had endured today, traced back to its root, had come about because of some bald old man on the other side of the world who had started a war... so how could the people and events closer to her—those that had shaped her—possibly not be enfolded into the candle?

"When you are reshaping what lies within Candlefall, you will find that the greater the physical distance between you and your target, the harder it becomes to alter their past."

Immediately following this, the description for "Candlefall" contained this passage:

"Someone standing right beside you can have their past changed with the utmost ease—simply reach into Candlefall and nudge or mold the wax itself, and you can shift their position, experiences, and actions; the past will change naturally as a result.

"Someone on the other side of the city can still be changed, albeit with difficulty—but you will find that the portion of Candlefall encasing them is somewhat stiff and uncooperative when you try to mold it. Fine details are hard to adjust; at most you can alter a rough outline—and as for how much of a difference that change will actually produce, that is even harder to say.

"And what of someone on the other side of the world? Regrettably, even if such a person appears within your candle, you cannot exert any influence over their past experiences."

That hardly mattered, Sydney Ginn thought, gazing at the still-slightly-hazy scene within the candle. What she wanted to change was about to come out through the bar's back door and step right up beside her.

The wax had turned transparent and become a pool of liquid that hung suspended just above the floor, as though it were a glimmering basin of water floating in midair. She reached out and touched it gently, and found it was not hot.

Reflected in that pool was a night in Blackmoor City blazing with countless lights; leaning closer, Sydney Ginn could even catch the distinct smell of the bar—alcohol, tobacco, and perfume

mingled together.

Within the pool formed by Candlefall, tall buildings, the bar, shops, and streets all looked like tiny miniature models. A figure the size of a fingertip—herself—stood at the bar's back door, gazing up at the starless night sky over Blackmoor City.

Right there.

There was no need to stir the wax and search for the right moment; she only had to wait—in this regard, working with Candlefall was a little like scrubbing through a video's progress bar: she could drag it backward or forward, or let it play forward naturally in time.

She remembered that before meeting Anthony, a motorcade of several black Mercedes SUVs had driven past nearby—every window reinforced against blast—and she had stared long enough to catch herself; shortly after the motorcade passed, the back door of the bar, painted dark red, had—

There it was.

The moment the bar's small back door was pushed open the tiniest crack, Sydney Ginn immediately extended her little finger and pressed its tip firmly against the door from within the Candlefall.

The shortest finger, and yet it was nearly as large as the bar door itself—pressed there against it, the sight was actually strange.

Through the door, Anthony shoved again and again, his force no more than a small insect kicking its legs against her fingertip; but how could someone so tiny within the Candlefall ever push open her enormous fingertip?

She leaned close to the wax and heard, muffled beneath the raucous music behind the door, a curse: "...This damn door—what is wrong with it?"

The tiny Sydney Ginn who had stepped outside the back door for some air paid no attention whatsoever to the enormous finger stretching across the air beside her.

When she heard the cursing from behind the door, she only glanced back briefly, then stepped a few paces away—a competent Blackmoor City resident always kept a certain wariness and cool distance from strangers, let alone a stranger who was cursing.

The would-be harasser behind the door shoved furiously a few more times, then finally gave up, and seemed to turn and walk away; quiet returned behind the door.

That should do it, Sydney Ginn thought, not quite daring to pull her hand back yet, still holding the door shut.

As long as they never met in the first place, none of what followed would ever happen.

The rage and indignation she had originally felt toward Anthony seemed, after witnessing "her own" death, to have been soaked through by a cold shiver, and was no longer as fierce; her first priority now was simply to use the candle to run the experiment—revenge had fallen to second place.

As for what effect changing history would have on the "present," the Artifact's description had offered a detailed explanation:

"...After the point where a change occurs, history will continue to develop naturally according to its own internal logic, and the person's 'present' will shift accordingly.

"There is a time-travel paradox that asks whether a person can go back and kill their own grandfather. Because if the grandfather dies, the person would not exist—but then no one would have gone back to kill the grandfather in the first place... and so a paradox is formed."

When it came to traveling through time and changing the past, it seemed there was always a great deal to explain—whether in film and fiction, or with Nest Artifacts.

"'Candlefall' will not fall into any such paradox. The candle constitutes a fixed segment of time—beginning from the birth of the person who touches it, and ending at the very moment they touch it. Therefore you cannot change the past before your own birth.

"However, changing history through 'Candlefall' will still affect the present. For example: if you melt open the wax for a month ago and crush your past self within it—at the instant of that crushing, you will also vanish from before the candle, and the candle will return to its original state.

"That is an extreme case. If you caused yourself to break your leg a month ago, then naturally, a month later, you would not have met a potential client on the ski slopes—correct? As stated above, history will always move forward according to its own internal logic and produce the consequences that naturally follow."

In other words, if she prevented herself from meeting Anthony that night, Sydney Ginn would also vanish from beside the candle—with no harasser, she would have no reason to enter the Nest; and having never entered the Nest, she would of course not be here now.

"However, to preserve the continuity of the timeline, memories of using 'Candlefall' and altering history will still be retained in full—they will not be lost because you have made changes to history."

In other words... if Sydney Ginn prevented herself from meeting Anthony, she would not be in the Nest today; and yet she would still remember that in the "previous version of history," she had met Anthony, entered the Nest, and altered history.

Retaining the user's memories was enough to preserve the continuity of the timeline? But why?

Sydney Ginn turned it over for a while, arrived at no answer, and let it go. Being able to retain her memories was a great boon; great boons don't hold up to scrutiny, so it was best to simply accept it without question.

Only by keeping her memories could she come back and find "Candlefall" again—and compared to such a precious Artifact, what did the nauseating memories Anthony had brought matter at all?

Within the Candlefall, the tiny Sydney Ginn stamped her feet, turned around, and seemed to be heading back inside the bar.

Sydney Ginn moved her little finger aside and watched that tiny version of herself pull open the door and disappear into the flickering lights and music on the other side.

Good—it was all done. She could extinguish the flame and let the candle solidify once more.

Only when Candlefall had solidified again would it set into the shape of a new time and a new history.

The pool of transparent liquid wax suspended in midair slowly turned white, grew cloudy, rose back up little by little, was drawn back into the body of the candle, and once again became smooth and unblemished—no matter how one looked at it, it was as though it had never melted at all.

Sydney Ginn took one last look at the shrouded corpse not far away, closed her eyes, and waited quietly for the brand-new "this moment" that would come after changing history.

After a little while, she opened her eyes.

She had not returned to Blackmoor City; she was still inside the Nest.

The pool of blood beneath the shrouded corpse had nearly dried to a dark, purplish-black; the candle stretched long and unbroken into the distance; the exhibition hall was utterly silent.

In her mind, the string of memories—being stalked and harassed by Anthony, entering the Nest, being copied by a Resident, melting the candle—were all there, clear and complete, exactly as the Candlefall's description had said: none of them had disappeared.

There was only one difference.

The place where she and Anthony had first met had changed from the back door of the bar to the front door.

These past two days have been absolutely exhausting... I overdid it a while back and still haven't recovered. We're 18 now, not 17 anymore—not as young as we were—and I'm really starting to feel the toll on my body. Sigh.

When you're this tired you can't tell if you're sleepy or just hungry, and you spend the whole day thinking about food, but the moment you eat anything you pass out right after—which only makes things worse... These past two days have really been... rough...

Chapter 24 — Sydney Ginn's Altered History

The wound on her neck had stopped hurting much. Her toughness and resilience truly surpassed her own expectations.

But Sydney Ginn's irritation only grew thicker, like a heart overrun with weeds that couldn't be pulled no matter how hard you tried.

Who would have thought history had such resilience — changing one small detail still couldn't alter the course of events. People always say that sometimes missing one turn can change your entire fate. What a lie.

A stalker, putting on the airs of destiny and fate — just thinking about it was nauseating.

Sydney Ginn glanced at the corpse.

She had killed a Resident for the first time — supposedly one that couldn't be killed — and she'd managed it only by talking her way through it, so she couldn't help feeling uneasy. She was afraid that in the blink of an eye it would stagger back up from the floor again, so every now and then she had to take another look.

But she was worrying too much. Death had already soaked through that body like cold water, fixing it completely in place.

After watching the corpse for a while, she finally relaxed a little and opened the fire trough again.

Time to try once more. This time, Sydney Ginn intended to cut off any possibility of the two meeting right at the root.

She melted the candle for the same window of time, watching the transparent Candle Tears fall and pool mid-air into a lake once more.

In the lake-like Candle Tears, a tiny Sydney Ginn and a tiny Amber stepped out of a miniature taxi together, laughing and talking as they walked into the bar — Sydney Ginn watched them enter through the front door, then shifted her gaze back out to the street, sweeping it up and down.

She clearly remembered that on that night, when the stalker Anthony had approached her, he'd said: "You must have arrived at the bar before me. Otherwise, when a girl like you walked

through that door, there's no way I would have failed to notice."

She couldn't take a pickup line at face value, but thinking back on it afterward, it did seem like Anthony had arrived a step later than she had.

Sydney Ginn pushed down the restlessness in her heart and kept her eyes locked on the bar's front entrance, not daring to look away for a second.

There had been a lot of people going to the bar that night, and in the span of just twenty or thirty minutes, four or five groups of strangers stepped out of several cars in succession — she had never seen so many miniature living people, clustered together in twos and threes, walking through the night under the lights, which made them even harder to make out; she stared until her eyes nearly blurred, and at last she spotted Anthony rounding the corner from down the street.

According to the description, "suicide" via the Candle Tears seemed to be possible — but it said nothing about whether it could kill someone else.

Sydney Ginn decided to try.

What could be more final than turning him into a dead man outright?

She had never been willing to kill lightly. In fact, ever since she had become a Hunter, although she had seen no shortage of dead people, not a single one had actually died by her hand.

But tonight, it was as if something inside her had cracked open, and something not quite the same as before was trying to push its way out.

Come to think of it, she had already killed "herself"; trying to kill someone from the past — a stalker, at that — what was the big deal?

If she couldn't kill him, she would think of something else — whatever the outcome, at least it would count as learning more about what the Candle Tears could do.

Sydney Ginn's finger hovered above Anthony's head, like a massive celestial body about to come crashing down on the earth and crush the dinosaurs.

He was still completely oblivious, hands shoved in his pockets, tall and loose-limbed, looking every bit like a decent man.

...Crushing him to death still meant washing her hands afterward.

Sydney Ginn curled her knuckles and brought them down hard on that carefully styled head.

She had expected the sensation to be something like squashing a large bug, but instead it was like pressing down on a slippery ball; the stalker stumbled, and her forceful strike had only shoved him half a step to the side — he quickly steadied himself, and not only was he still alive, he didn't even seem to feel any pain.

Anthony looked down, muttered a curse, and kicked a pebble away.

...Could it be that she couldn't reach in and kill someone else directly? That the only one she could kill was herself?

That was truly funny.

Despite her frustration, two more attempts seemed to bear out the theory: she tried pushing the miniature Anthony into the road, but an oncoming car swerved in time, leaving him with nothing worse than a few curses from the driver; she managed with great effort to knock a sign light loose, timed it carefully, but it bent in mid-air and crashed to the ground right in front of Anthony's nose.

The stalker was apparently no ordinary person — he brushed past danger several times in a row without anything happening to him, and walked into the bar as if nothing had occurred.

"One of the most powerful Artifacts" — the broadcast was full of hot air. It couldn't kill a person, couldn't prevent a meeting; what was the point of this broken candle containing the past at all?

In the end, wasn't everything exactly as it had been? Nothing had changed at all?

Suppressing her frustration, Sydney Ginn swept through the Candle Tears, searching for herself.

She had already grown quite practiced at working the Candle Tears, and quickly found the moment the two had met: a tiny Anthony pushed open the dark red back door, spotted a tiny Sydney Ginn, walked over to her, and struck up a conversation.

"I didn't have the courage to ask for your number at first — I'm not the type who goes around talking to girls," Anthony said with what seemed like genuine feeling. "But do you know what? On my way here just now, a sign light suddenly crashed right in front of me — this close... if I'd been half a step faster, I would have died. Thinking about how full of surprises life is, I couldn't bear to let this pass..."

She had actually helped him upgrade his material?

Sydney Ginn had played a computer game called The Sims as a child, and now, watching the two of them talk in the Candle Tears, a strange, hazy sense of familiarity came over her, leaving her somewhere between the urge to laugh and the urge to cry.

But this was not a computer game.

Sydney Ginn watched that tiny, oblivious version of herself exchange numbers with Anthony just as she'd expected, and could only sigh inwardly with weary irritation as she closed the fire trough — she needed to let the Candle Tears cool and solidify first, to let this chapter of history "set," and then melt it again before she could change it once more.

The tiny Sydney Ginn — she had lost count of how many times now — pushed open the back door and stepped out of the room thick with tangled music and the smell of alcohol, standing outside to get some air.

A convoy of all-black Mercedes SUVs rose silently out of the night; each vehicle, fitted with anti-terrorism and armored modifications, maintained an equal distance from the others as they passed in succession before the bar's back entrance.

As the last vehicle was about to drive past, Sydney Ginn reached out and flicked it toward the back door — the matchbox-sized SUV was caught by the force, lurched involuntarily, veered off the road, and with a shriek of tires slammed its nose squarely into the bar's back entrance.

The bar's back door, which had not been fully shut to begin with, now had its panel caved in and its hinges twisted by the impact, hanging crookedly at an angle — anyone could see at a glance that it would never close again.

The tiny Sydney Ginn stared at the SUV only two paces away, her face drained of color.

Oh — she had forgotten to protect her past self... Never mind, she hadn't been hit by the car, and alive was good enough.

It wasn't as if she had wanted to get so tangled up with a stalker in the first place — so why was she putting herself through all this trouble? Letting her past self get a good scare was no less than she deserved.

Sydney Ginn watched with a faintly disgusted indifference as that tiny version of herself hurriedly backed away a few steps and called out to no one in particular: "Someone help! There's been a crash!"

If the bar had to temporarily shut down because of this, it might scatter the two before they could meet —

Before Sydney Ginn had even finished the thought, the driver's door of the SUV was shoved open, and a man in a black suit half-tumbled out and quickly swung around behind the wide-open door, dropping into a half-crouch; his left temple had been split open by the impact, and blood, curls, and an over-ear earpiece were all tangled together in a matted mess.

But what stood out most was the 9mm pistol held between his two hands.

Nearby, the tiny Sydney Ginn's gaze landed on that black pistol, and her lips pressed together instantly.

After the vehicle was struck and disabled, his first move was to leap out — so he wouldn't be a sitting duck; he sheltered behind the car door to use it as cover against any potential sniper; even though he had clearly taken a significant blow, that 9mm was still held steadily in a position ready to return fire at any moment, his slightly bent elbow not trembling in the slightest...

Both the Sydney Ginn inside the Candle Tears and the one outside it could see it: this was a personal bodyguard with highly specialized professional training.

Then the other vehicles —

Sydney Ginn turned at once, and sure enough found that the convoy had not wasted a single moment — the other four SUVs had already split off in separate directions, each changing lanes and altering course in an instant before accelerating away, disappearing into the night and lights in every direction.

The level of professionalism here was very high, she thought.

At the exact moment the rear vehicle was struck and lost control, the convoy had immediately abandoned it and broken formation, each turning onto a different route and rapidly increasing the distance between them... this was clearly a contingency plan prepared well in advance.

Such a plan generally has only one purpose: to protect whichever vehicle in the convoy carries an important figure, so potential enemies cannot tell which car that person is actually riding in.

"...No, at present we cannot confirm what was done to the vehicle. Yes, no attacks so far."

The man in the black suit crouched behind the car door, speaking in a low voice into his earpiece: "The situation with the car is strange, but I've detected no signs of Artifact use in the

vicinity... Yes, there's a bar here, and there are witnesses nearby — they've probably already called the police."

Artifact? Had he just said Artifact?

Sydney Ginn's interest sparked immediately, and she leaned in closer — fortunately, the man in the black suit was nothing more than a tiny figure within the Candle Tears, unable to see that floating between heaven and earth above the car was a gigantic human ear, listening to every word he said.

"...Understood," the man in the black suit replied quietly after a few seconds. "In the negotiations and handling that follow, I will not mention Mr. Wellesley's name."

Mr. Wellesley?

Sydney Ginn froze.

An important figure, and surnamed Wellesley... could it be that the person so carefully protected by this convoy was Wellesley himself — Blackmoor City's foremost figure in both wealth and standing?

Wellesley was indeed a person of great status, but he wasn't a head of government; that his security should be this tight clearly meant he knew he was in danger...

Could it be that his death, not long from now, was not from natural causes but something deliberately brought about?

Had he noticed, months in advance, that someone wanted to assassinate him — and that was why he had taken such thorough and careful security measures?

Curious as she was, Sydney Ginn hadn't forgotten her original purpose, and glanced back at the back door.

The crash had drawn all the bar patrons outside — some were watching the spectacle, some were on their phones, and some were taking photos and posting on Twitter; the man in the black suit had a sharp read on the situation and, to avoid causing a scene, had already holstered the 9mm back beneath his jacket — though one hand remained pressed over it, ready to draw at any moment.

Among the crowd of onlookers, the tiny Sydney Ginn and Amber were speaking in low voices; a few steps away, the tiny Anthony was glancing toward them again and again.

Within seconds, he walked over and greeted the tiny Sydney Ginn with a smile.

Unbelievable — was there truly no way to keep herself from running into Anthony?

Sydney Ginn cursed under her breath, but after a brief consideration, she decided to set the stalker matter aside for now.

Wellesley appearing in her Candle Tears history meant that he and her fate were bound together in some way... and that was exactly what made it interesting: what possible connection could the soon-to-be-dead richest man in Blackmoor City have with her?

She set little Sydney Ginn and the stalker aside, and working backward along the timeline of when Wellesley's motorcade had appeared, she traced the thread until she had a rough location, then lit a new wax channel.

If she could keep an eye on Wellesley's history, she was sure to dig up quite a bit of information...

The more you wait for something, the slower it comes.

Sydney Ginn fidgeted restlessly—touching the melting candle one moment, adjusting the flame the next—impatient and anxious, her thoughts scattered; her gaze wandered here and there, yet it was only after quite some time that she suddenly realized two things.

First, the stretch of Candlefall from when she and Anthony had met due to the car accident had solidified again, setting into the latest version of history.

Second, the corpse on the exhibition hall floor had vanished at some point without her noticing.

I finally managed to recover a little today! But then I looked at the date—it's already the 5th, and in the blink of an eye I'm going back to Shanghai again...

Following those seven Calabash Brothers from a while back, I don't even know how many Minions I owe everyone now—let me check...

Okay, I'm back after checking, and I owe way too many—can't fit it all in the author's note, so I'll open a separate chapter tonight and thank everyone properly first (。

Thank you all for your enthusiastic support, darlings—I've already bought property in the OB/GYN department of Shenzhen Second People's Hospital, and I'll be living there from now on; everyone is welcome to visit bearing cakes and gifts.

Why is it always Shenzhen Second People's Hospital, you ask—because that's where I was born, and we like to keep things full circle.

Chapter 25 — Sydney Ginn, Latest Version, Present Day

Although the beginning of the story had been rewritten several times, the moment Sydney Ginn met Anthony had never changed:

On the eve of summer's arrival, in a soft and restless night, she ran into a handsome-looking venomous thing.

Of course, her eyes could not see through Anthony's smooth, attractive skin and hair to the dark, twisted liquid writhing deep inside his mind—and when a person feels they are getting everything they want, one by one, they are perfectly capable of being gentle and generous, attentive and considerate.

Especially at the very beginning.

"...That scared the life out of me just now," Sydney murmured to her friend. "He suddenly lost control—the car came straight at me. Lucky I've been keeping fit; my reflexes were fast enough that I threw myself out of the way in time... otherwise I'd be a human pancake sandwiched between his bumper and the wall by now."

Amber drew a sharp breath. "That dangerous? Thank goodness you always go to—"

She stopped herself, glanced over at Anthony, and corrected course: "Thank goodness you always go to the gym."

Amber wore her hair short, had a round little face, and a pair of ears that stuck out sharply from her straight hair like an elf's; her personality matched her looks—quick-witted and perceptive.

Sydney often told her it would be wonderful if she had a passage too, so the two of them could go adventuring together in the Nest—though she also knew that if Amber had a passage, she would be a Hunter for the Morgan House Faction, making the two of them potential rivals.

"You had a real brush with death there. Keeping up with exercise is never a bad idea."

Anthony suspected nothing; he fussed over Sydney with worried concern, the lingering fear on his face so vivid that it looked as though he himself had nearly lost his life just now.

In the space of a minute or two, his emotional range proved quite comprehensive—moving from worry to relief and gradually into righteous indignation, covering the full spectrum: "What

kind of driving was that? Was he drunk? Standing off to the side all sneaky like that, not even coming over to apologize! When the police come to take the statement, you have to spell out exactly what happened."

What would later feel false was, at the time, quite welcome. Sydney flashed him a smile and lowered her voice: "He wasn't drunk... he's probably a private bodyguard. I caught a glimpse of his sidearm just now."

"A bodyguard?" Amber slid a glance sideways and immediately let out an "Oh," her voice dropping. "No wonder he's been keeping one hand under his jacket the whole time... There's no one else in the car—did whoever he was guarding leave already?"

"Already gone," Sydney answered. "He had a whole motorcade ahead of him; the moment his car hit trouble, they all scattered immediately. No idea what went wrong with his car—why it would crash into the door like that."

The moment he heard the word "gun," Anthony's face tightened slightly. He hesitated, then reached out and pulled both women behind the bar's back door, saying repeatedly, "Better safe than sorry... what if he's not a bodyguard but some kind of lunatic? Should we go inside?"

At the time, Sydney thought he seemed quite steady and careful.

"I'd rather stand here a bit longer," Amber said, stealing several glances toward the black-suited figure behind the SUV. "I just love watching the drama unfold—you two don't mind, do you?"

Anthony glanced at her, then at Sydney.

Amber wasn't there for the drama—Sydney knew that perfectly well.

Compared to the everyday dealings of a Hunter's house faction, a car crashing into a door wasn't even interesting enough to bother mentioning.

Moreover, the look in Amber's eyes was nothing like someone watching for entertainment: a bright, focused light had settled in them, moving from the car to the figure beside it, as if that one point of light had already seized on something amid all the noise and confusion.

With a major Hunter house faction behind her, Amber had access to a remarkable amount of information. The Matthew Effect applied here as well: the more a person knows, the better they know where to look for more, and the better they know what actually counts as real "information."

Unfortunately, Sydney couldn't ask her directly what she had spotted—Anthony was right there beside them.

"Then I'll keep you company," she said.

Anthony showed no sign of reluctance.

"The public order in Blackmoor City really is getting worse and worse—I suppose even the wealthy are starting to feel the water heating up." He leaned against the wall and chatted idly with Sydney: "Ordinary people like us can't afford bodyguards; we can only look after ourselves... especially a young, attractive woman like you—you're more likely to become a target."

With his warm gaze fixed on her face, Sydney instinctively smoothed her hair and said with a smile, "I'm not particularly worried."

"Having a boyfriend is a lot safer," Anthony said. "Didn't your boyfriend come with you tonight?"

"I'm single."

Because she had a good impression of him, Sydney didn't bother taking offense at such an obvious fishing attempt; she thought for a moment, then added: "I can take care of my own safety perfectly well. Not to mention anything else—I have a small ladies' pistol at home, and a hunting knife I bought specially from Europe."

Anthony froze.

Something seemed to rise to his throat, then he held it there in his mouth without speaking, rolling the words around on his tongue. While he was sifting and weighing them, Amber gave Sydney a light tug and murmured, "His colleague just arrived."

Sydney's gaze cut through the crowd, and sure enough she spotted a car that had just pulled up; the driver who stepped out was dressed in the same black suit and strode over quickly to meet the bodyguard who had caused the crash.

Whatever had caused that bodyguard to crash earlier, the danger had long since drained away from the scene, replaced by curious bar patrons, the deeply frowning manager, and the emergency responders who had just arrived... The bodyguard had finally relaxed as well, and was now sitting in the driver's seat with the car door hanging wide open, answering questions from two police officers while letting the paramedics check his pupils.

"Dylan," the newly arrived black suit called out.

"Ivan?"

The crash-causing bodyguard looked up at the sound, startled to see who it was, and lowered the cotton pad he had been pressing against the wound on his temple. "Why are you the one who came?"

The second bodyguard, named Ivan, seemed to be lower in both rank and experience, and his manner was respectfully proper: "Something went wrong here, and the boss got a bit uneasy having to go pick something up in the middle of it, so they brought in quite a few extra people on short notice. Sister Mi was worried it would be hard for you to manage on your own, so she sent me over to lend a hand."

For some reason, his voice was pitched a notch lower than most people's. Sydney was quite certain that Amber, just like her, had been straining her ears and edging several steps forward just to catch the general gist of it.

Dylan showed little warmth or gratitude toward this reinforcement.

"Got it," he said, pressing the cloth back against his wound, looking like a man who had nothing more to say and wanted Ivan to stop talking as well—perhaps because there were police officers right beside them.

"We're still open for business as usual," a bartender called out loudly from the back door, apparently trying to remind the patrons to hurry back inside and keep spending money. "Don't worry, everyone—nothing's been affected!"

"Shall we?" Anthony tilted his head down and spoke to Sydney very gently: "Let's go back in and have a proper chat—let me buy you a drink."

Running into Anthony tonight had been a complete surprise; she found herself torn on the spot between "bodyguard crash" and "attractive man"—and it was Amber who smiled at her, tipped her chin toward the bar's back door, and said: "You go ahead. If anything interesting turns up, I'll tell you about it later."

Sydney had no choice but to remind her, "Come find me inside in a bit then"—and after Amber promised she would, Sydney went into the bar with Anthony.

As she settled into her seat, her thoughts flickered briefly to Ivan. He had said something about the boss "picking something up," hadn't he? Picking up what? And was it at all connected to

whatever had caught Amber's interest in the matter?

But she didn't let herself think too deeply about it. Because Anthony had settled in beside her, a lock of hair slipping down over his face, the light in his eyes rippling faintly beneath the shadow of his hair; as if she were some rare treasure the rest of the world had somehow inexplicably overlooked.

Later, Sydney reflected that no matter what the quarry is, a person who can be a Hunter needs a certain instinct—for instance, she hadn't felt there was anything particularly distinctive about her own appearance or dress, yet Anthony had still picked her out from among the crowd of bar patrons at a glance.

In the Nest, she was a Hunter. Back in the human world, she was the prey.

"What would you like to drink?" he asked.

"I absolutely hate alcohol," Sydney said—and hearing herself say it out loud inside a bar, she couldn't help laughing.

Using "not drinking" as a topic of conversation, she began her chat and first date with Anthony.

Over two or three months, they went from seeing each other occasionally to growing closer and closer; after Anthony visited her home for the first time, he became very nearly the most perfect boyfriend in the world—though that illusion didn't last very long.

At some point along the way—she couldn't remember which meeting it was—the two of them were talking and the conversation drifted to the black SUV that had crashed into the bar's back door in early May; it was only then that Sydney remembered she'd never gotten around to asking Amber what she had actually discovered that night—perhaps the whole thing had turned out to be not worth mentioning after all, which was why Amber had never thought to bring it up.

"By the way, I remember you said that night that you had a hunting knife you'd bought specially from Europe." Anthony's interest suddenly sparked, and he asked: "You can get hunting knives here too—what makes a European one special? Let me take a look?"

Sydney immediately leapt up from the sofa, retrieved the hunting knife, and launched into its brand, craftsmanship, and value; the more animated she became about it, the more Anthony's desire was kindled.

"I'm not trying to take it from you," he said, still performing a degree of embarrassment back then: "Could I borrow it for a while? I have a friend who specifically collects knives—I'd like to show it to him."

Sydney thought it over and figured she probably wouldn't need to enter the Nest again for the next two or three months. And even if she did, she had other weapons and tools. "Fine—just bring it back when I need it."

...She slowly opened her eyes, unable for a moment to tell whether the stiff, cold thing was her own body or the exhibition hall floor—the two had nearly fused into one.

Anthony never returned the hunting knife.

Sydney looked at the two threads of memory running through her mind, feeling both lost and bewildered, and suddenly, blindingly clear.

She turned her head without a sound, her gaze traveling across the floor and far into the distance, where it came to rest on the enormous candle lying across the exhibition hall—

And on her own back, seated before it.

So that was it.

In the second version of history—the one that had been altered for unknown reasons—Anthony had borrowed the hunting knife and never returned it; Sydney had entered the Nest without the knife, and had naturally been unable to drive it into the Resident's throat.

And so the Resident had not caused the same wound to appear on its own throat—

And so she had survived.

Today the May Day holiday ended and I went back to my usual chaos—spent most of the day running around outside, so the chapter's a bit late... I'm exhausted every single day, all I want is to go home and sleep properly...

This author's note is being typed on an e-ink screen! I keep buying them and returning them, buying and returning—I'm already on my third one. Will this one survive the 7-day no-questions-asked return window? Stay tuned... The first two I returned the moment they arrived.

(Okay, I can't break the em-dash rule, are you trying to finish me off—)

Chapter 26 — Sydney Ginn's Choice at the Crossroads

For the first few seconds, Sydney Ginn stared at the distant silhouette of herself crouched over a fire, her mind reduced to something like a battlefield after a nuclear detonation. Fragmented thoughts drifted like radioactive fallout—scattered, impossible to form into anything coherent.

Why did she have two separate lines of memory?

In the first memory line, the night she had encountered her stalker Anthony, there had been no car crash behind the bar; she had never mentioned owning a hunting knife, so Anthony had never "borrowed" it from her.

She had entered the Nest intending to retrieve something that could take care of Anthony, only for things to go sideways—at the Hopscotch grid, a Resident had copied her appearance and taken on her identity.

That Resident was utterly convinced that it was the real "Sydney Ginn."

Even the fact that it had no backpack, no phone, and no hunting knife had been explained away: a scuffle between the two of them just before they boarded the taxi had made it rush onto the cab, leaving her things behind.

The truly troubling part was this—if the Resident was so certain that it was the real Sydney Ginn, then by the same logic she could no longer rule out the possibility that she herself was the Resident. Sydney had originally thought that having her phone and hunting knife on her person was proof enough that she was the real one; but what if she had simply forgotten the moment when she had taken those things from the original?

After boarding the taxi, hadn't a stretch of her memory been taken away? If that missing memory happened to cover the moment when she, having become Sydney Ginn, had seized her things from the real one, then she had absolutely no evidence left to comfort herself with.

Between the Sydney lying on the floor and the one sitting before the candle—which one was truly the Resident?

No... that question was a bottomless rabbit hole; fall in and you'd never climb back out. She could set it aside for now. Better to treat herself as the real Sydney Ginn and trace the timeline from the beginning.

After the Resident left, she had called a second cab, carefully followed the Passenger Rules, and trailed the Resident all the way to the Museum of Modern Art. On the basement level, Sydney had found her moment and driven her knife into the Resident's neck.

Not one thing she had hoped for came to pass.

The Resident had stood where it was, both hands pressed over the wound; she had barely glanced at it and couldn't tell whether it bled at all—and she'd had no chance to look more carefully—because in no time at all the Resident had looked at her and smiled, baring a mouth full of teeth she knew too well.

"Since you copied my form, your neck should split open just the same."

The first memory line ended with her own throat suddenly splitting wide, blood spraying outward, her body crashing to the ground like a shattered stone statue.

Sydney Ginn knew she had died.

And yet death was not her ending; after death, she entered the second memory line.

On the night she had encountered Anthony, a black SUV had come barreling straight at her; she had barely dodged it before it slammed into the back door. Starting with the fact that the driver was a bodyguard, she had mentioned to Anthony that she owned a hunting knife—and not long after, he had taken it from her.

When she entered the Nest, Sydney had muttered a quiet curse—being down one weapon always left her feeling a little exposed.

From there, the second memory line was no different from the first: she heard the broadcast, stepped onto the Hopscotch grid, called a cab, and was copied by the Resident... The only difference, at the very end, was that when the second memory line terminated, she opened her eyes on the floor.

Staring at the silhouette before the candle, Sydney Ginn climbed to her feet as silently as she could manage. The floor tiles were smooth and cold, unstained by a single drop of blood.

The second memory line had overwritten the first, becoming the true, most recent version of history—so she had never stabbed the Resident, and had never had her throat cut by a single sentence.

She didn't dare stand up straight for fear the Resident would notice her, and crept on all fours back behind a pillar, holding her breath so rigidly that her chest began to ache—she had to keep it under control, because she actually feared she might start sobbing without meaning to.

...How could a single sentence cut someone's throat?

Compared to a mouth opening in her neck, she couldn't even say for a moment which frightened her more: being killed again without rhyme or reason, or discovering that she wasn't a real human being at all and would spend the rest of her existence wandering the Nest as a Resident.

If she wasn't a Resident, why had her neck so faithfully reproduced the wound on the other one?

Not a single one of these questions did Sydney Ginn have an answer for.

Her back pressed against the pillar, she squeezed her eyes shut and covered her mouth, wishing she could draw herself inward into a ball so tight the Nest would never find her again.

No—calm down first, think it through...

There were several pieces of circumstantial evidence pointing to the other one being the Resident: first, it had no phone, no hunting knife, and no backpack; second, according to what she had witnessed in the first memory line, it had boarded the taxi without following the Passenger Rules and had still gotten off without incident.

Third—and most compelling—the neck's skin was only a thin layer wrapping arteries, nerves, blood vessels, the trachea, and the esophagus; could a living person really perform first aid on a stab wound to the neck and carry on as though nothing had happened?

Sydney Ginn calmed herself a little and quietly peeked out.

The Resident was still seated before the candle, repeatedly adjusting the heat of the flame tray, looking visibly impatient for the candle to melt. The candle, growing gradually soft and drooping, had formed a pool of nearly transparent Candle Tears in midair; from this distance, Sydney could just barely make out what sounded like a voice inside the Candle Tears calling out "Mr. Wellesley."

The candle was surely the key—the reason she had come back from the dead and formed two separate memory lines.

The broadcast had said it was an immensely powerful Artifact, and that was clearly no exaggeration—something that could drag a person back from death was formidable by any measure.

But why was the Resident so keenly interested in it?

Sydney looked around and noticed that the far wall of the exhibition hall was covered in a dense block of exhibit text—Artifacts in the Nest were almost always accompanied by some form of "item description," and this had to be it.

The only problem was that the exhibit text was on the other side of the hall, and to reach it she would have to pass directly behind the Resident.

No matter how she thought about it, she had to deal with the Resident first.

Regardless of whether she was truly the real Sydney Ginn, once the "Sydney Ginn" beside that candle was dead, she would naturally become the "real Sydney Ginn" by default—right?

When survival was on the line, it seemed that even something fundamental, something principled, could be glossed over... Before today, Sydney Ginn had never imagined she would find herself thinking this way.

But if the Resident could kill her with a single sentence, how was she supposed to kill a Resident?

Sydney's gaze swept the room and landed on her hiking backpack slumped on the floor not far away, its mouth hanging open and lopsided, exposing a wadded hand towel and various odds and ends inside.

"Where did it go—"

In the distance, the Resident was still fixed on the Candle Tears, muttering under its breath, looking thoroughly impatient. "It seemed like he said something really important just now... didn't it? Where was it said..."

Taking advantage of its attention being entirely on the candle, Sydney quickly slipped off her shoes and padded toward the backpack in her sock feet, step by careful step—sure enough, she made no sound.

As she passed the backpack, she reached in and hooked out a long towel, then retreated quickly to the far end of the hall—she didn't dare stand out in the open of the sparse exhibition

space with her head tilted back reading the exhibit text, and instead slipped behind another exhibit at the far end of the hall; that piece was far enough from the candle, and was made of bundles of long wooden poles fanning outward in a spiral, which was lovely to look at even if she couldn't tell what it was supposed to be, but at least it was just barely enough to hide a woman crouching behind it.

The Resident would eventually notice that she had disappeared from the floor.

Even if its attention was fixed on the candle for now, it would soon enough discover that its neck was completely unharmed and that the wound had been erased. This was the only window she had to strike first—but how should she use it?

Should she use this chance to read the candle's description first, or make her move against the Resident first?

If she struck first, could the candle become the Resident's trump card to turn the tables on her? When she had her throat cut by a single sentence earlier—had that been connected to the candle?

Unfortunately, when Sydney had followed the Resident down here in the first timeline, she hadn't had a chance to read the candle's description carefully.

At every fork in the road, it's impossible to foresee the chain of dominoes that will follow one after another; just as Sydney herself had never imagined that entering the Nest to deal with Anthony would lead to news of an Artifact, and that searching for the Artifact would lead to being copied by a Resident.

Which path should she choose?

After a moment's hesitation, Sydney couldn't quite say what moved her to do it, but she took out her phone, silenced the shutter sound, aimed it at the exhibit text on the distant wall, zoomed in, and took several photos in quick succession.

Before she could even enlarge the photos to read the description, the Resident suddenly stood up—she contracted all over, seeming to shrink to half her size, and stared tensely at its silhouette through the gaps between the wooden poles.

It hadn't noticed anything was wrong yet. It seemed dissatisfied with the candle in front of it; it placed a hand on the candle, took a few steps as if searching for something, then crouched back down, and with a click snapped the flame tray open.

The flame swayed like underwater grass in the stirred air, casting light on the features that were hers.

Sydney let out a small breath of relief and enlarged the first photo, reading quickly.

The text in the first photo was the closest to her, and though the writing was blurry it was still legible enough to get the gist. By the time she finished reading it, her mouth had gone dry: no wonder she had been pulled out of the fatal ending of the first timeline—it turned out the Resident had accidentally altered history. She had never once imagined there could be something so inconceivable in the Nest.

If she could bring it back to Blackmoor City...

She tapped open the second photo, but the angle and distance were far less ideal than the first, making the specific text actually difficult to make out.

It didn't matter—the most important thing was already clear: though the candle was powerful enough to reverse history, it could not be used as a weapon.

Then she would proceed with the original plan.

Sydney Ginn made her decision, pressed her two fingers down, and locked her phone screen.

In the screen as it went dark, a second face looked back at her.

Lately it really feels like all my stats are kuacha kuacha dropping across the board... I guess this is the price you pay for writing niche stuff (not really lol)

Gotta get on another plane tomorrow ahhhhhh

When on earth am I going to be able to go home and just lie down in peace ahhhhhh

Chapter 27: What?! I've been an ungrateful wreck since April 23rd?

Time flies, the years rush by, and in the blink of an eye, those seven Calabash Brothers I owed you all have...

Never grown up, because I still haven't given birth to them...

I always felt like my last thank-you post to you all was just recently — but I just checked, and the last one was April 23rd?? So I've been heartless, shameless, and utterly without conscience ever since??

I'm so sorry, everyone. You've been supporting me and cheering me on nonstop, while I've been nonstop ungrateful... Let me take stock of the family ties and count how many of those original seven Calabash Brothers have turned into little Minions by now. Don't go flipping past this just because it's a thank-you chapter — what if your name gets called?!

I've been running around nonstop lately, and I figure I can't properly pay my debts until I'm back home. Fortunately, this stretch of running around looks like it's finally entering its last leg — Shanghai is the last stop. Once I'm home, I truly never want to leave again for the rest of the year. I love writing, writing loves me, and nothing can tear us apart.

(Unless someone warmly invites me to New York to gather material for an Artifact report.) (I could leave right now, seriously.) (What do you mean a side project — shouldn't I be working even harder on this one?)

The crowd waiting outside the OB-GYN department of SZ City Second People's Hospital to collect their babies has grown quite a bit:

Well, well — Bohemian Xiang (I dare not look too hard at that username) has shown up to offer their support. I figure quite a few of you still remember this legend... I've completely lost count of how many babies I owe you... Can we just call it one for now...?

A new legend has arrived: Gunsmith Rousseau. You alone added two spots to the baby quota, and I'll be honest, my knees are shaking a little... The username feels vaguely familiar, but I don't dare claim to know you. Are you a new reader who got lured in by the Artifact report? Or are you a blessing from my ancestors delivered via apocalypse (?)

姥姥 b111111111, I refuse to believe you got the number of 1s right the first time you typed that username! I figure you can't tell whether I've written too many or too few either (jk), but either way the baby debt is on the books (.)

Thank you to Yaoyao and Linlin for the KFC (yes, I've abandoned McDonald's — the Golden Arches have let me down, and did you know they've switched away from Heinz ketchup?), to Tie Jiǎ Bái Táng for the dessert (desserts are so expensive now — I nearly fainted seeing egg tarts going for 20-something yuan), and thank you to Chū Shí Qíng Zì Chán, Mò Yuān (pronounced "Black Bird"), and Yǐng Yòu — each of you snuck me a cup of milk tea (the flavors these days are so wild, who even comes up with them?). Haynes even treated me to dinner. You guys basically covered my entire day!

How many babies does that make — oh, I owe another five — so what!

Too many persimmons and your mouth won't pucker!

Thank you to Èr Shí Sì's QD for getting me a DQ (DQ is actually so good, and it was such a lucky buy), to vitang (you've already bought me two bottles of mouthwash — Shanghai ones, no less), to Fēng Yīn (did I still owe you from last time?), and to Joiiiiii for sending an opening flower arrangement...

And also to Lǐ Bāo Bāo de Bāo Bāo (oh my, I actually don't know the story behind that name — really, tell everyone), Zhǎng Gāo Gāo de Yú (this fish is truly very tall — I've been eating it since the last book), Jūn Mǐ Xī (all longtime readers~), Dōng Xiē (oh come on, you're too kind, hehe), and Ā Ā Ā Zěnmē Fēi Shì (how even)

And also Murakami's Kafka (no Consort to sit next to you this time), Sān Xī Yī (I think I saw your comment), Cīlè Mò (what did you say again — I'm just plucking a few sheep here), and Shí Wàn Fú Tè (were you the one who recommended the Northeast bathhouse?)

Thank you to Chén Chéng Yè (new reader?), Xiǎo Sūn Dài Nǚ Fēi (not a new reader), Liú Jǐn Qí (know you all too well), Parsons Yùbèi Shēng, Emmy 酱, whhit, MARGINAL Yú, Yǎ Er (nice to see you again), 书友20240202130643416 (I nearly died typing all those digits), 书友20230109114807508 (please, I'm begging you both to go change your names)

Let me catch my breath and keep going:

Sān Jiǔ's Exclusive Bandage (fine, you don't have to shower), Méi Tóu Nǎo Diū Diū, Xuán Fēng Fēi Wán who tips like it's a daily check-in, Yuè Zhuó Xǐ Huān Mào Xiǎn Gù Shì, Mǐ A Áo, Lín

Sān Jiǔ's Dog (?), Yú Xiā Xiè Wú Chù Bù Zài, Nǐ Yǒngyuǎn Shì Qiàn Tàiyáng De, mocaozy, yoleen Yú...

And to everyone who's sent monthly votes — I can basically see all of you, I just actually can't fit everyone in. I'm so grateful that you're willing to cast your monthly votes on a story this niche. I've actually started worrying a bit about the numbers lately, and seeing the monthly votes and readthrough stats is actually reassuring.

I've noticed that saving up all the tips and thanking everyone at once makes it look like business is booming (jk)... It's only 12 babies, right? Come on — let's run through all twelve zodiac signs (.

Chapter 28 — Hello everyone, your Southern Airlines Ambassador here

Welcome to the Southern Airlines Passenger First-Hand Experience Channel, where you can feel the full boarding experience in real time — no Wi-Fi, no social distancing, two hours of upright seatbacks with nothing to eat — all without leaving your home.

That said, I'm actually pretty content: the two girls sitting next to me smell nice, not a hint of anything unpleasant (if anyone smells, it's probably me — I've been running around all day), and the flight isn't even delayed!

What an honor!

Right now the seatback is digging into the back of my skull, the seatbelt buckle is jabbing my butt, my bag is crushing my feet, and the screen in front of me is showing a podcast called "Why We Love the Song Dynasty," while a faint whiff of something drifts over from up ahead (someone let one go a little too early).

I haven't even lifted my head since I sat down — racing against the clock to bring you this live flight report. Why, you ask?

Because

a wandering soul like me won't touch down until seven-thirty

and who knows

when this broken, rootless

update

will

go live in China time.

(continued)

A little poem, just for you — thank you all for tuning in.

Finished the poem and realized I have a tiny bit of time left, so let me ramble for another two cents' worth: the new chapter is five hundred words in! Still featuring the big-eared monkey (?) Sydney Ginn!

If the heavens would grant me two — no, three hours, I'd definitely get an update out today.

But who knows what time I'll reach the hotel... I'm landing at Hongqiao but staying over in Pudong... My biggest hobby in life is donating money to airlines and DiDi drivers as an act of charity.

Why do I always stay in Pudong? Because that's where the starting point of the Nest is.

I'm about to venture deep into their lair again!

(Can my editor see this? I am absolutely not calling you a Resident.)

What? What if it's too late by the time I get to the hotel?

Eat first, eat first — come on, fill up your cups, let's all eat and chat after, eat and chat after.

Chapter 29: The Attack Pattern of the Sydney Ginn Resident

The moment Sydney Ginn caught the first words spoken behind her, amid her terror, a faint flicker of relief managed to surface—

"I knew long ago that you came back to life,"

her own voice, thick as a miasma, drifted up slowly from somewhere above and behind her head. "You're so easy to fool—nothing like me at all."

Good, Sydney Ginn thought, pivoting on her knee and twisting her body around in the same instant, thank goodness its first words were a waste of breath.

So what if it had noticed early? Either way, the two of them were always going to end up fighting for their lives.

She had long since steeled herself for this—yet the moment "Sydney Ginn" flashed into view, she couldn't help but catch her breath, as though someone had shoved her from the front.

Compared to the "Sydney Ginn" she had seen in her memory, the Resident now looked somehow more vivid, more real: a forehead faintly glittering with beads of sweat in the firelight, a strand of golden-brown hair stuck to a temple; the fine down on a cheek, warm breath spilling from parted lips...

Those eyes, blazing bright as if nothing else remained.

This was Sydney Ginn—this was herself—and yet she herself was standing outside her own body, one arm raised high, bringing a dark shape crashing down toward her face.

At the last possible moment Sydney Ginn finally lurched sideways in time; a thunderous crash exploded beside her ear as the exhibit was bitten deep, gouging out a huge chunk; amid the shower of splinters, she squinted and rolled outward across the floor as fast as she could—her face and the backs of her hands already bristling with who knew how many wooden slivers.

"Just die already—there can only be one Sydney Ginn in this world!"

Her own voice, strange yet unmistakably hers, rolled in waves through the exhibition hall; "Sydney Ginn" strained and wrenched a fire axe free from deep within the exhibit of wooden strips.

When had...?

Before she could even finish the thought, Sydney Ginn sprang to her feet and bolted—but in her panic she had forgotten that she'd taken her shoes off earlier, and with nothing but socks on her feet, she had almost no traction at all on the smooth exhibition hall floor.

At the instant she was about to pitch face-first onto the ground, she flung herself forward in a diving posture instead—since she had opened her eyes again, she seemed to have spent more time sprawling and rolling on the floor than standing upright.

The fire axe struck the tile with a dull thud, biting deep—only one step behind her.

Sydney Ginn had never stripped off a sock so fast in her life.

While the fire axe was still stuck in the floor, she tore the sock off and hurled it straight at her other self's face, aiming for the eyes; just like any normal person, the Resident had no desire to let a sock hit its eyeballs, and jerked its head to one side.

Sydney Ginn would have loved to press her advantage, but she had no chance to pull off the other sock and throw it—the Resident had already closed the distance in one stride, raising the axe high above her.

Almost on pure instinct, she kicked hard at the Resident's ankle.

Once the Resident had copied Sydney Ginn, it was nothing more than an ordinary human body; kicked in the shin with full force, it stumbled back two steps in pain. Sydney Ginn seized the opening, scrambled to her feet, and ran forward—one foot steady, one foot slipping.

But as she ran, she found herself involuntarily replaying the sensation of that kick landing on the Resident's ankle.

She had never thought about it before: what shoes was the Resident wearing?

She already knew that when a Resident copied someone, it couldn't replicate their bag, phone, and other belongings. But what about clothes? What about shoes?

In that brief glimpse during the life-or-death moment just now...

"Wait!"

Sydney Ginn knew full well that with one bare foot she couldn't possibly outrun the Resident; and the more chances she gave it to talk, the more dangerous things became—she wheeled around and called out urgently: "What are you wearing on your feet?"

The other "Sydney Ginn," teeth clenched, bearing down hard behind her, startled at the question but wasn't distracted—it brought the axe down first; only after Sydney Ginn barely dodged did it laugh breathlessly: "Trying to say something useless to buy time?"

"A Resident can't copy a backpack, and it can't copy clothing either!"

Terrified it would catch up again, Sydney Ginn hurried on: "You copied my appearance, but the shoes you're wearing are still your own. You must have the memory of what I was wearing when I entered the Nest today, right? Look down, then think—do the clothes and shoes you remember match what's actually on your body?"

"Sydney Ginn" froze for a moment, and actually looked down at her clothes.

Even a Resident in the Nest couldn't go around naked—there was generally something on it.

This particular one, perhaps because it was a Vulture—always ready to become someone else at a moment's notice—was wearing plain, highly versatile black trousers and black shoes. One couldn't really blame Sydney Ginn for never having noticed its clothing; when a face identical to your own rises out of the darkness, you're not very likely to pay attention to what shoes it has on.

"That's exactly right," it said when it raised its head again, enunciating clearly. "When I enter the Nest at night, I always wear black from head to toe so as not to draw attention. If you think you can trick me with that, it's really quite laughable."

It hefted the fire axe in one hand and gave a small kick with the tip of its shoe.

"I can even tell you—I bought these shoes at Bloomingdale's during a sale, because I thought: anything I wear into the Nest just needs to be good quality; there's no point paying full price for something fashionable."

Now it was Sydney Ginn's turn to freeze. That line of thinking was unmistakably her own; she could even recall several pieces of clothing she had bought for exactly the same reason.

"And you?" The Resident smiled at her, a strand of hair sticking to its lips, framing its teeth. "If you truly have my memories, you'll find that it's your clothes that don't add up."

Sydney Ginn couldn't help but look down, her gaze dropping to the khaki joggers.

She remembered pulling on these exact pants before climbing out the window... but where had they come from?

Most people can recall, at least vaguely, where they bought their clothes—yet these joggers felt as though someone had pulled them onto her body mere seconds ago, so unfamiliar that her mind went blank.

Why was there no memory of buying these pants?

"It seems that after a Resident copies its original, it smooths over and lubricates the memories—patching up details that don't match reality, filling in the gaps... which is why you're so firmly convinced that you're the real me."

While she stood with her head bowed, staring blankly at the pants, the other "Sydney Ginn" had been slowly closing in; its voice, its breath, its smell, and its feet in their black shoes were gradually encroaching on her existence.

"Residents can't be killed—I've heard that."

It said quietly, "Still, I'd feel better once I've taken away your ability to move... I imagine there's a time limit on how long you can hold a human form? When the time runs out and you haven't returned to Blackmoor City to replace me, you should revert to your Resident form, right?"

Wait—what was it saying?

As though something had quietly pricked a point deep inside her mind, a grain-of-rice-sized point of light slipped through—but it flared for only an instant before heavier, more pressing shadows closed over it and blotted it out.

She neither heard nor saw anything—it was something beyond the five senses, some pure instinct, that made Sydney Ginn suddenly duck low and lunge forward the moment the fire axe swung down toward her forehead, wrapping her arms around the Resident and driving it off its feet.

The Resident's arm, tensed and swinging with full force, came crashing down hard against her ear and the side of her head; but the fire axe itself—the truly lethal part—finally glanced off her shoulder, slipped free, and clattered onto the tile a short distance away.

The two of them went down together, and the back of the Resident's head struck the floor with a sound that made every organ in the body clench.

"You copied my form," it still managed to speak with difficulty, "so you also—"

Before it could finish the sentence, Sydney Ginn had already pulled the towel she'd tucked into the back of her waistband and shoved it over its mouth.

The Resident twisted its head from side to side to avoid it, and though the towel didn't go in cleanly, it stopped the Resident from finishing what it was saying.

Sydney Ginn didn't dare let go; gritting her teeth, she endured the blows the Resident kept landing on her body, holding the long towel taut with both hands, and seizing the moment when the Resident's lips parted, she pressed it deep into the Resident's mouth—the towel ran like a rope across her other self's cheek, driving its tongue to the back of its throat, leaving it capable of nothing but muffled groaning, unable to form a single clear word.

"I... I think I understand..." she murmured, staring at the face distorted beneath the towel. "I think I've figured out your attack pattern. You really are the Resident."

Yesterday I arrived at the hotel, had dinner, typed for a while longer, and simply couldn't hold on—fell asleep... Woke up early this morning and kept going, otherwise I'd feel guilty.

This time the hotel stay was thanks to some perks from Qidian—you know they had that promotional event for the Joy of Life drama production, right? I'm not connected to that, but I tagged along and piggy-backed on it, sort of like sneaking in through a side door... How to put it—I keep having this guilty feeling like someone will audit the accounts afterward and make me pay for the room. Someone from Qidian told me Maoni was also staying there. Round it up and down, and you and Maoni are basically the same tier.

That's some seriously wide rounding—one step would carry you from the Huangpu River all the way to Tokyo...

Chapter 30: The Way Sydney Ginn Fights Back, and Establishing True Identity

Looking back now, it was probably because she had the "Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion" that Sydney Ginn had almost never truly gone head-to-head with a Resident—let alone fought one in a life-or-death struggle.

It was only after she was released from death once more that she finally arrived at a conjecture.

She knew that every Resident had its own distinct way of surviving and attacking.

But "attacking" alone was far too vague and broad a term: punching someone was an attack; splitting someone's throat with a single sentence was also an attack—and so, crowding out your existence bit by bit was an attack as well.

"You said it yourself—Residents alter memory details and fill in gaps and holes, which is why a Resident is absolutely, unshakably convinced that it is the real person."

Sydney Ginn was already struggling to keep the towel pressed down; if the strength the Resident beneath her was now using to thrash was actually her own, then all those years of keeping herself in shape had paid off quite well—well enough that her teeth were clenched and her arms were trembling, and she could be thrown off at any moment.

But not a single word of what needed to be said could be left out.

There could truly only be one Sydney Ginn in the world—the Resident was not wrong about that.

"When I think back, I find that I'm not like that. Ever since I discovered there was another 'Sydney Ginn,' I haven't been able to shake the self-doubt—especially after I came back from the dead... I can't explain why I would copy your wound onto myself, or why I can't remember where I bought those pants. If I were the Resident, I should have had a smooth answer to all of these questions long ago."

The "Sydney Ginn" beneath her had the towel shoved deep into her mouth; her lips were pressed into two long, thin, taut lines, teeth half-hidden and half-bared, saliva and drool and

retching sounds and her tongue all churning and struggling in the depths of her throat as though she still wanted to speak—her own face looking like that was almost unbearable to witness.

Sydney Ginn knew what it wanted to say.

"You want to say that precisely because I am the Resident, when I face questions I cannot answer, I take that as proof that I'm the real one—is that it?"

A muffled whine rose from its throat, something that sounded like an angry "Yes."

"Impressive... no matter what argument I raise, you can turn it into doubt I cast upon myself."

The Resident drove a fist into her side, and for an instant it was as if it had knocked the air and the light clean out of the room.

Sydney Ginn's vision went dark in waves; she bore the pain and kept pressing it down with all her strength, managing only to twist her body to the side and curl her legs up, using her thighs as a bulwark to absorb its pounding fists—her other knee still had to pin down its other arm, and the muscles were screaming.

"This is your attack pattern, isn't it?"

She had to say it out loud; only by saying it out loud could there be any chance of survival. "Between the two of us, you are the one with absolute, unshakable certainty, and I am the one filled with fear and doubt. It's that little seed of doubt in my heart that gives your words their power to wound—that's what turns them into reality."

The reason a single sentence had split her throat open was not because she was a Resident; it was because of that tiny sliver of doubt within her.

A Resident's weapon was "language"—but its method of attack was like a syringe filled with poison: it had to pierce the skin before the poison could take effect.

And that tiny grain of self-doubt was the entry point on the skin—without an entry point, a Resident's verbal attack would have no effect.

If the Resident had said that same sentence to Anthony, his throat would certainly never have split open, because his sense of self was perfectly clear and had nothing whatsoever to do with "Residents."

"...Your instinct is to crowd out my existence. So you keep reminding me, pointing out all sorts of problems and inconsistencies, trying to make me believe that I am the Resident. 'Sydney Ginn' is a seat—if I die, or disappear, the seat is vacated, and only then can you sit in it forever, and truly become Sydney Ginn.

"To that end, you split my throat open with a single sentence, and then you told me that a Resident's 'copying' has a time limit—even if no such thing is actually true, because you've said it out loud, after a while I'll gradually start turning into a Resident, won't I?"

The tiny sliver of doubt she had felt about herself just now had already served as an entry point, letting that sentence seep inside; the time left to Sydney Ginn was running short.

If she still hadn't dealt with the Resident before her in a little while, she was afraid she would begin to take its place and become the Resident herself...

Even though she felt she had worked everything out, the moment that thought arose, a small voice still surfaced from somewhere deep inside her: Was that really true?

When the time came, would she be "replacing" it as the Resident—or "reverting" to what she had been as the Resident all along?

...No, now was not the time to think about this; she was already struggling to keep "Sydney Ginn" pinned down.

Sydney Ginn shook off that voice from the depths of her mind and picked up her pace, wanting to pour out everything she had to say before the moment slipped away.

"When you said the 'Resident' has a time limit, that was actually what began to reveal the truth to me. Because the real 'Sydney Ginn' would have no knowledge of that piece of information whatsoever—I even doubt whether that information actually exists, or whether you invented it on the spot, just to make me take your place as the Resident."

The final syllable was stretched into a broken note.

With one violent lunge from the Resident that gave it more room to move, it slammed its fist into Sydney Ginn's temple; amid the clanging bells and white stars, by the time her vision cleared again, she found that at some point she had been thrown to the ground.

"Sydney Ginn" was climbing to its feet, dry-coughing as it did. The long towel had been soaked through with saliva, heavy and sodden, lying flat on the floor beside it.

"You're wrong," it said.

Its voice was hoarse, as though its lips and tongue were still numb and sluggish, not quite obeying. "...The real Sydney Ginn does know about that piece of information. Last month, when I was listening to the radio, the host mentioned it in passing as a rumor—I remembered it..."

Fire axe—three words leapt into Sydney Ginn's mind.

She couldn't let it get to the fire axe.

She couldn't stand up; she pressed her limbs to the floor and crawled in an unsteady wobble toward the fire axe. The Resident had clearly spotted her target too, and gave a soft, contemptuous laugh, turning as if to kick at her—just as Sydney Ginn scrambled to dodge and sat back down hard on the floor, the Resident strode toward the fire axe.

It seemed there was only one way left to slow it down.

Even if she could only buy herself a few seconds, just enough to catch her breath.

Staring at the back of another version of herself hurrying toward the fire axe, Sydney Ginn called out in a hoarse voice:

"Then why don't I?"

The other "Sydney Ginn" stopped dead in her tracks. It turned its eyes and looked at Sydney Ginn from beneath its lids.

"You said the real Sydney Ginn knows about that piece of information, right? If you're the original and I copied you, then naturally I should also have that information somewhere in my memory."

Sydney Ginn let out a low, dry laugh at her other self. Her throat felt as if it had just been rolled through sand and coated in a layer of grit.

"...When you brought up that piece of information, I suddenly realized—I don't have it in my head. I'm not the copy. You are."

The Resident stood there blankly, as if momentarily unsure how to react.

"Don't forget—there's one more key point."

Sydney Ginn didn't dare crawl toward the fire axe again; she was afraid of jolting the Resident out of its daze. The more confused it was, the better for her. "...Residents can't be killed,

can they? But I've died once—haven't I?"

The Resident lowered its head and shook it hard several times.

"No—you could be lying to me, knowing full well but pretending you don't. Wouldn't that be simple enough?"

It spoke in a voice that was almost a murmur.

If a voice could have a shape, it would be like a worm drilling endlessly into the darkness, never looking toward the light. "The idea that Residents can't be killed has always been just a rumor—before I killed you today, I'd never actually tried to kill a Resident before... its validity has always been up for debate."

"You see," Sydney Ginn laughed under her breath and said, "a Resident really will find all kinds of excuses and reasons to fill out its own memories and logic, to convince itself that it's the real person."

The words settled, and the hall was silent for a second or two.

She watched herself slowly lift its head toward her.

A person is not very familiar with their own expressions, unless they spend every waking moment looking in a mirror; so Sydney Ginn found it difficult to describe exactly what the look that flashed across that face meant—if she had to describe it, it was as though something that had been suspended high up in "Sydney Ginn's" mind suddenly came crashing down.

The next instant, she understood.

"No matter which of us is actually the Resident," that face—her own face—twisted slightly and said, "as long as I kill you, I'll naturally be the real Sydney Ginn."

Before the words even finished falling, it had already lunged forward, snatched up the fire axe from close by, and swung its gaze back toward Sydney Ginn—Sydney Ginn cursed her luck inwardly, hurriedly yanked off her remaining sock, rolled to her feet, and ran.

Truly worthy of being her copy: faced with the same problem, it had arrived at the same answer.

She had originally thought that once she punctured the Resident's confidence and sowed doubt in it, things would take a turn for the better—but whether the Resident was confident or not, it was still coming to kill her, so hadn't the situation remained fundamentally unchanged?

Worst of all, she couldn't kill a Resident, but a Resident could kill her—was there any way to win this fight?

The exhibition hall was large, but when someone behind you was chasing you with an axe, it suddenly felt far too small.

Sydney Ginn was barefoot and couldn't run toward the area covered in wood splinters and debris—if a splinter lodged in her foot and she couldn't run, she'd be leaving her life here; that left only one direction of escape open to her, which was where the enormous candle stood.

...And the flames dancing at the base of the candle.

The Resident hadn't put the fire out, and it hadn't let the candle solidify—the thought jumped into Sydney Ginn's mind.

When she had been watching from a distance just now, she had noticed that the section it had melted seemed to be not far from the time period when she had first encountered Anthony—in other words, about six months ago.

Wait—if the section from six months ago could be melted, then—

Before Sydney Ginn could finish the thought, her feet had slowed without her realizing it, her mind elsewhere.

A heavy, sharp pain cut through both her train of thought and her shoulder at once.

Friends, I'm sorry—I was completely exhausted yesterday. I am an extreme introvert, and these past couple of days I've unexpectedly turned into a social butterfly who's also been gaining weight (actually gaining weight—I've barely had a proper meal, and I'm already up to 125 jin), and yesterday I basically collapsed dead in bed.

But today I pulled myself together and mustered my motivation—can you guess where I finished writing this chapter...

I opened up a passage, entered the lair of China Literature, and wrote it to completion right there in their headquarters...

How do I put it—the pressure was very real, but you need pressure to get an update written... after all, tomorrow I, well, have to get on a plane again, so a little pressure is necessary...

(Honestly, this trip to Shanghai has completely unfolded into an entirely different storyline—I really never expected to have my cover blown like this. When I have a moment, I'll fill you all in

on the details.)

Chapter 31: All Those Chapters Before Sydney Ginn Are Gone

Two threads of memory were like neighboring rivers—after the banks dissolved, they were slowly beginning to converge. The surface of each reflected the other's ripples, until it was impossible to tell where memory ended and reality began.

Sydney Ginn lay collapsed on the ground, and above her field of vision loomed the belly of a massive candle.

For a moment she couldn't remember why she had fallen: had her left shoulder been cleaved off? Or had her throat been torn open?

All she knew was that she seemed to be losing blood rapidly.

With such grievous injuries, her body had not yet gone into shock, but her consciousness was already teetering on the edge of dissolution.

"I thought it over again, and I still think you're the Resident after all."

Her own voice rang out a few steps away, heavy with labored breathing. "I'm not sure why, but I feel like you weren't lying—maybe because I know myself. You said you had no information in your head about 'Resident copies having a time limit,' and I believe you. But there's one thing you overlooked. Do you know what it is?"

Sydney Ginn heard it, but it felt like there was a layer of something between her and the words—she listened through a fog and couldn't make sense of them.

She lay with eyes half-open, watching the candle not far away, as a transparent lake slowly formed across her body—as though the pool of blood beneath her were merely its reflection.

Perhaps this kind of death was fitting: watching another version of herself living and moving through a different time and place, oblivious and unaware, then slowly deciding when to close her eyes.

"When you got into the taxi, just like me, you gave up a stretch of memory. The memory you gave up was most likely the information about 'Resident copies having a time limit'—that's why you feel like you never knew it. And yet that was precisely what made it so convenient for you to latch onto my words, to treat them as a loophole, as proof that you were the real one..."

Even a dying Sydney Ginn understood that last sentence.

"So you're the Resident after all." Her other self concluded.

If I were the Resident, I wouldn't be dying here.

Sydney Ginn desperately wanted to say those words aloud, but her throat produced only a rattling sound. Her injured left shoulder seemed to have become a black abyss, and her focus, her consciousness, were draining away through it at terrifying speed—so much so that when she strained to turn her head slightly to the left, she didn't even dare glance at her own shoulder.

In her blood-stained field of vision, the other "Sydney Ginn" was bending down to pick up the fire axe.

The axe, still coated with her flesh and splinters of bone, had sunk too deep a moment ago and slipped from the Resident's grip, falling to the ground.

Sydney Ginn dimly recalled that after taking that axe blow, she had stumbled forward a few steps—at that moment, the fact of "shoulder severed" was still distant, not yet registered by her brain; her mind had been fixated on reaching the correct section of the candle.

That was why, when she could no longer hold on and finally crumpled to the ground, more than half her body had fallen beneath the candle.

"...Resident," she said softly, watching the silhouette bend down to lift the axe. "I'm not one."

"Ha."

The Resident didn't look up. It weighed the axe in its hand and let out a single syllable.

"Pants..." Each of her words was nearly weightless, barely even breath. "Taxi... took them."

Truly worthy of being another "Sydney Ginn"—it was like talking to herself; a few words that anyone else would have found incomprehensible made it pause, and it caught on quickly.

"You're saying that the memory the driver took from you in the taxi was actually the experience of buying your pants?"

To convey how absurd it was, it let out a deliberate laugh and said, "Are you delirious because you're about to die? This is the Nest—Hopscotch especially, strange and dangerous as it is. Right after fighting with me, when you got in the taxi and paid the fare, the very first thing that leapt into your mind was where you bought—"

It didn't finish the sentence. It stopped mid-word.

If this Resident hadn't copied Sydney Ginn, it would never have wasted half a second on such a ridiculous claim—it would have walked over, swung the axe, and ended her life.

But precisely because it had become "Sydney Ginn" completely and utterly, it suddenly froze, standing in place with the axe hanging at its side—and after two seconds, it looked down at the pants it was wearing.

A small sound escaped from its nose, like someone jarred awake early in the morning by an unwelcome phone call in the middle of a dream.

They say knowing oneself is the hardest thing in the world; but if a person has lived twenty-eight years without being utterly muddled and dull, they will have gained at least some degree of self-awareness.

Sydney Ginn shared one trait with a puppy not yet a year old—a pigeon flying past would make a puppy swivel its head, and a faint noise in the distance would make it prick its ears; Sydney Ginn was the same.

A neon sign with a letter missing a leg, the white feathers a bird flashed when it flapped its wings—both would intrude upon her attention, briefly stealing her focus away.

One of the Passenger Rules stated that you had to lower your head, hanging it between the driver's seat and the passenger seat.

What would happen after she followed that rule?

Sydney Ginn would find that part of her field of vision was her own thighs and pants.

"You're saying... you lowered your head, saw your pants, and involuntarily thought of the memory of buying them, and that was the memory the driver took?" The Resident stood in place, murmuring.

Sydney Ginn let out half a groan from her throat in answer.

"Absurd," said the Resident, standing still for a moment. "Impossible."

Even having made up its mind to kill Sydney Ginn regardless of who was real and who was false, it couldn't help but fall into thought—perhaps it was some part of Sydney Ginn's personality taking hold, or perhaps it was human nature, simply copied onto its body.

While it was lost in thought, Sydney Ginn had already made out the history unfolding in the Candlefall nearby. A tiny version of herself was giving instructions to a doorman: "...If anyone

suspicious shows up, don't let them ring my doorbell..."

She remembered—that was the day before she received the funeral wreath.

The Candlefall encasing that day was suspended just above her abdomen... the next day—today, the day she entered the Nest—would be right next to it, wouldn't it?

Sydney Ginn closed her eyes and imagined her right hand as a mole searching for its target, creeping along quietly.

Only by pretending it was not part of this body that was losing heat so rapidly could she manage to move it at all—only then could she feel her way forward and gently flip the next switch on the fire groove.

The left half of her body was flooded with a rush of cold wind; but the right half grew faintly, almost illusorily, warm.

She couldn't let the Resident notice what she was doing—otherwise it would know immediately what she intended.

The flame had only just leapt up, and the candle hadn't fully melted yet, but the Resident had already come back to itself, let out a breath, and spoken.

"Look at me, almost getting twisted up in your words. All this true-and-false, back-and-forth—I can't sort it out, and I don't need to. Same as before: kill you, and there's no problem left."

Buying a few seconds had already been difficult, yet it was still nowhere near enough; Sydney Ginn fought desperately against the dizziness, pulling her scattered consciousness together, while searching through the white fog of her mind for the next excuse.

She had to say something to divide the Resident's attention—fortunately, she was not someone who was hard to distract; that flaw had now become the very thing that might save her life.

"Can't..." Two words drifted from her lips, like dust disturbed by a breath.

The Resident walked toward her step by step, still carrying the blood-dripping fire axe, and asked, "Can't what?"

Sydney Ginn's mind was like a fire on the verge of going out; at the edge of losing consciousness, dizzy and faint, she let slip what was in her heart: "...Can't kill me."

The Resident let out a laugh, crouched down, and reached beneath the candle to grab her ankle. "And why not?"

Whether it was its hand or those words, something ignited a few bright red sparks in Sydney Ginn's mind.

She watched the large expanse of white wax on her body shudder and soften, slowly drooping lower, as if it were reaching down to close her eyes and spare her from further suffering.

"If I die... it proves you're the..."

The hand gripping her ankle paused.

The Resident let out a cold laugh from beyond the candle and said, "You want to say that because a Resident can't die, if you die, it proves I'm the Resident?"

She had never imagined that the one person in her life she could communicate with perfectly, without needing many words, would be a Nest Resident that had copied her own form.

Sydney Ginn narrowed her eyes, her trembling gaze settling on the Candlefall; a dark shape was finally beginning to emerge faintly within it, but not clearly enough—she wanted to see tonight's version of herself as soon as possible.

"The last time I killed you, I already understood. You are the Resident, but you don't believe yourself to be a Resident. You believe wholeheartedly that you are 'Sydney Ginn' herself—even the self-doubt you feel has become, in your mind, evidence that you are the real one.

"If we're talking about who believes it more completely, it's actually you, alright?"

"On the premise that you firmly believe you are the real person—if I inflict a fatal wound on your body, you will die from that wound. Haven't you heard of that experiment? A person's eyes are blindfolded, and they're told that a hot iron is about to be pressed against them; after artificially producing the sensation of pain, actual burn marks appear on their arm.

"That is the power of the mind at work. The reason I can kill you operates on exactly the same principle as that experiment."

"Sydney Ginn" spoke while dragging her; but one hand wasn't enough to move her, so she set down the fire axe and used both hands—Sydney Ginn slid across the floor like a heavy, lifeless piece of meat.

Inside the Candlefall, a tiny Sydney Ginn had just stepped out through a doorway. She was walking along Colorado Avenue, her steps still slightly unsteady from the alcohol that hadn't worn off, unaware that a human-shaped shadow had quietly fallen in behind her.

Just a little further—Hopscotch was almost visible.

That frantically struggling thought made bright red sparks flicker in the nearly extinguished fire of her mind; Sydney Ginn had no idea where the strength came from, but as she slid outward once more, she raised her hand and brushed it across the Candlefall.

She had watched the Resident manipulate the Candlefall and already knew how to adjust the timeline. Perhaps the heavens weren't yet willing to let her fall into a dead end here—in her dying struggle, Sydney Ginn adjusted the time to exactly the right moment: from within the Candlefall came her own voice cursing the Resident just before she got into the taxi: "Get lost!"

The sound rang out, and those hands loosened; her feet thudded to the ground.

"What did you do?" The Resident reacted instantly. "You want to keep 'Sydney Ginn' from being copied by 'the Resident'? You'll disappear—you're the Resident!"

It looked like it was about to lunge at her.

Sydney Ginn's right hand felt like an empty sack of skin, with no muscle, no blood, no strength; but she still gritted her teeth and shoved the tiny Sydney Ginn inside the taxi—her enormous fingers became a dividing wall, separating the tiny Sydney Ginn from Hopscotch.

Before Sydney Ginn finally lost consciousness, she saw through blurring vision that the tiny Sydney Ginn inside the Candlefall had not been copied.

The "Vulture" Resident within the Candlefall had not become another version of herself, either.

That meant... the stretch of history in which she had been "copied by the Resident" had been changed, erased, as if it had never happened at all.

Very soon, there would be only one Sydney Ginn waking up in the underground exhibition hall of the Museum of Modern Art.

And only when she looked back at the threads of memory in her mind would she know which Sydney Ginn had been the Resident, and which had been herself.

The flight was delayed again today—wasted my entire day. By the time I got home it was nearly nine at night, and I only just finished writing the update... Sorry for keeping everyone waiting so long.

There's actually a lot I want to share, but it's too late tonight—I'm dead on my feet. I'll save it for next time.

Because Sydney Ginn changed history, the seven or eight chapters before this have all disappeared—it's as if they never happened. Truly, go check if you don't believe me.

Chapter 32: Chase's Underground Pursuit

It was only after hanging up the phone that Kingsley thought of the one critical question—by which point Chase was still tearing through Blackmoor City like a man with a death wish, plowing through everything in his path as if the streets were empty.

Not that Kingsley could be blamed for the slow reaction: after watching a truck come thundering down on you, anyone who could immediately calm down and think clearly existed only in novels.

"Wait—you gave them the whole search area," she snapped upright with a start and said, "so when we reach our destination, won't we be walking straight into a police cordon?"

Chase had given a wide search area on purpose—to scatter the police and keep them from pinning down which direction he was actually heading; but on the whole, Kingsley's understanding was exactly right.

"Watch yourself," he said, wrenching the wheel into a hard turn and forcing the car off the main road into a dim, narrow alley. "You're talking like a criminal."

Kingsley quickly steadied herself and came back to her senses. "Oh, right—I was 'kidnapped' into this car..."

"Exactly. Remember that. In a little while, that's the only truth."

The other side mirror didn't survive either, knocked clean off against the alley wall; the already-dented Mercedes paid no attention to a row of trash cans blocking the way and plowed straight into them—clang—a can tumbled over the windshield, plunging the interior into momentary darkness.

Garbage bags split open; through a shower of flying trash raining down from every direction, the car burst through and came out filthy. The windshield wiper swept off a banana peel, but left a smear of sticky grime across the glass in its wake.

This car was finished anyway.

"What's your plan?" Kingsley asked.

"Open the glove box in front of you," Chase ordered. "There are zip ties inside—take them out and bind your own hands."

Kingsley raised her eyes, stared hopelessly at the sky for a few seconds, and finally resigned herself to it.

She fished out the zip ties, clamped them between her teeth, and with great difficulty managed to loop them halfway around both wrists—but couldn't fasten them, so she had to call on him for help. Chase reached back with one hand while still driving and pulled the zip ties tight.

When he drew his hand back, he couldn't help frowning—the zip ties were slick with saliva; Chase shot her a cold look and, with a firm backhand motion, wiped his hand hard on the shoulder of her denim jacket.

Kingsley let out a small, shameless laugh.

"This goes against every survival principle I've ever held," she muttered, raising her bound hands in front of her face like a bundle of tied flowers.

"You don't need to survive anything here." This wasn't the Nest.

"Fine, so what am I supposed to do in a moment? Stand there with my hands tied while you let yourself get caught, and I get dramatically rescued?"

"Stop talking nonsense."

Chase steered the car back onto a side road; the pursuing police cars were no longer visible behind him—but he knew that was only temporary. This area would already have police vehicles on patrol, ready to appear in his rearview mirror at any moment and lock onto him all over again.

"Almost at the destination," he said, eyes fixed on the road around him. "I'll slow down, but I won't stop. It's almost time—get ready, you may need to detect the Artifact at any moment. Do you want to be lightly injured or seriously injured?"

Kingsley stared at him. "I want to be not injured."

"If you think you can talk the police into letting you go with nothing to show for it—just with your mouth—then suit yourself. If you don't want to get hurt, it all comes down to how fast your reflexes are."

"What do you mean?"

The next moment, Kingsley understood exactly what Chase meant.

The moment the Brooklyn Community College Station sign came into view, Chase immediately slowed the car; he unbuckled his seatbelt, shoved the door open, and leapt out, rolling

off the road surface and springing to his feet in one motion, then broke into a full run toward the subway entrance—the driverless car immediately veered off course on the road, drifting toward the center of the lane.

"You just wait—when I'm back I'm demanding a contract renegotiation!" Kingsley swore and shouted from the car behind him.

A beat later, her voice rang out again: "It's here—it's really here!"

The Artifact had indeed entered Kingsley's detection range—it was on the next train, nearly at the station.

Chase didn't look back, but as he charged down into the subway station two steps at a time, he vaguely heard a dull impact from somewhere far up on the road.

The impact didn't sound serious—better than he had expected. It seemed Kingsley had managed to control the car in time, even with her hands bound.

Chase planted one hand on the subway turnstile and vaulted clear over the barrier, landing like a leopard; for such a tall frame—six-foot-five—his feet made only a soft thud on landing.

A few idle young men nearby who had been whispering to each other, passing something between them, looked up at him and burst out laughing, calling over: "Nice moves, man! But what—even guys in suits can't afford a ticket?"

Chase paid them no mind; within a few breaths he had already charged down to the platform, then immediately slowed his pace, glanced around once, and blended into the crowd of waiting passengers as if nothing had happened.

He checked the time: 10:33.

His suicidal driving had gotten him here three minutes earlier than the subway would have.

There would have been no shortage of witnesses to the moment he jumped out of the car and ran into the station; once the police arrived at the scene, they would immediately realize the suspect had gone into the subway, and the next move would naturally be to seal the exits and send people down to search—now all he could do was wait and see which came first: the train or the police.

He drew a long, slow breath and went over each step of what came next carefully in his mind.

One small slip, and he'd be trapped with no way out.

The first thing to deal with was...

Chase looked up at the security camera mounted in the corner of the platform.

Blackmoor City's subway system had been built and put into service around 1905, and most platforms still retained the look of the early twentieth century; the surveillance equipment installed in recent years always looked slightly out of place against the old station walls.

If he was caught on camera, even if he managed to shake off the pursuit later, it would be trouble down the line.

He reached into his jacket pocket and pulled out a remote control barely the length of a finger.

The remote had a small plastic display screen, currently lit with a single line of text—**【Countdown: 127 days, 21 hours, 36 minutes】** .

Below the screen were two buttons, one labeled "replace" and one labeled "cancel"; aside from looking cheaply made, they gave no indication whatsoever of what they were for.

Chase raised the remote, aimed it at his own throat, lightly pressed "replace," then slipped it back into his trouser pocket.

Not a single person waiting around him looked up; most had their eyes glued to their phone screens, and some had earbuds in, staring blankly at the tracks ahead, and at the platform on the opposite side of the tracks—which was empty, not a soul on it.

Even if someone had been watching Chase the whole time, they wouldn't have understood what he had just done.

The first time Chase had received this small remote from a House Faction Hunter's hands, he hadn't thought much of it.

Strangely enough, Artifacts from the Nest, no matter how unusual their appearance, seemed to follow rules similar to those of the real world: the more exquisite, valuable, and substantial something looked, the greater its power and purpose; if an Artifact felt like it was made of thin plastic, its functions were bound to be limited.

But that Hunter wore a smile of quiet confidence and said, "Try it and you'll see—the functions really are limited, but it's practical."

She took out her phone, opened the camera app in video mode, handed it to Chase, and stood in front of the lens herself.

Chase stared at the phone screen, watching as the Hunter leisurely picked up the remote, aimed it at her own throat, and pressed the "replace" button.

In the next moment on the screen, her entire head had transformed into a massive, snow-white goat's head; the goat's head wore a floor-length black robe, as if it had just stepped out of some medieval horror legend as a demon creature.

But looking at the Hunter herself, outside the screen, she was exactly as before: hair half-wavy and gathered behind her head, wearing outdated skinny jeans and a pair of sneakers—every bit the look of a middle-school kid's mom.

Most astonishing of all, even in the first few seconds of video recorded before she pressed "replace," the Hunter's face and head had already been replaced with the goat.

"Impressive, right?" said the goat's head on the screen, opening its mouth to speak. "Press the button, and your true face will never be recorded—on any device, all anyone sees is a big goat's head. And the effect can even be traced back one minute before you press it—so if you forget to activate it, you've got a full minute to cover yourself! An Artifact this thoughtful is rare in the Nest."

It was exactly what Chase had been looking for.

After a quick round of testing, he made his decision without hesitation: "The House Faction will take it—twenty thousand."

The one unfortunate thing was that this Artifact, once it left the Nest, could only exist for six months—which was also why Chase had valued it at only twenty thousand: by any measure, a six-month lifespan was simply too short.

"No need to feel bad about it," the middle-school mom said with a smile as she prepared to leave. "It's actually a blessing that Artifacts expire and disappear in the human world after leaving the Nest—that's exactly why we Hunters can keep doing this line of work indefinitely."

True enough.

Chase had no idea how many years the Nest had already existed, but the history was surely not short; generation after generation of Hunters had brought countless Artifacts back to the

human world, and if those Artifacts could exist forever, the world would have long since turned into a chaotic science-fiction film.

If someone were to review the surveillance footage afterward, they would find that at 10:33, on the departing-side platform, there had been a goat's head in a long black robe. It stood near the foot of the staircase, occasionally glancing up toward the entrance above, then lowering its head again, propping its face on one large hoof—looking for all the world like a pensive, deeply troubled goat.

That was Chase keeping his ears on the movements inside the subway station—as for the goat hoof, that was him raising his hand to cover his face.

After all, to everyone's naked eye he still looked like himself, so naturally the less he exposed, the better.

At 10:34, a faint stir of commotion drifted down from somewhere inside the station.

Hurried footsteps trod down from above the staircase; someone was asking "what's going on outside?", and someone else was asking, "is the subway still running?"

It seemed the police had arrived.

Chase glanced at the platform display screen: the departing train was also due to arrive at 10:36.

He drew a slow, deep breath—both the departing and returning trains arriving at the same time meant that a one- or two-second difference could mean the difference between his life and death.

10:35.

A group of people suddenly came barreling down the stairs with shouts and yells, landing on the floor and startling the passengers nearby—it was the same group of young men who had been whispering to each other at the subway entrance and had called out to compliment Chase earlier. One of them looked back and swore: "What are all these Blue Bags doing here?"

Chase moved to the far side of the staircase and stopped at the platform edge near the tracks. Blue Bags was slang, named for the blue color of the police uniform; some people also called them simply "bags."

He heard several sets of footsteps bearing down together—all keeping the same trained rhythm, urgent and heavy, mixed with the rustle of bulletproof vests and holsters—converging on the staircase all at once.

At most thirty seconds left until 10:36.

Wait one more second, he gritted his teeth and thought—one more second...

From the distant subway tunnel, a rumbling sound finally rolled back faintly—still far away, almost like an illusion, vibrating at the very edges of nerve and sense.

"Everyone on the platform," a voice suddenly shouted, "stay where you are! We are in pursuit of a dangerous driving suspect!"

Chase smiled.

The moment everyone's attention was drawn to the shouting figure, Chase leaped off the platform, landing lightly beside the rail—like a large cat sliding soundlessly off a rooftop.

By the time a passenger finally noticed and let out a low gasp, he was already sprinting across the subway tracks, lunging toward the platform on the other side—

"Stop!" someone shouted from behind. "Or I'll shoot!"

But the subway gave them no chance to shoot.

The train arriving at 10:36—the one carrying the Artifact—screamed out of the tunnel and hurtled toward Chase; its headlights blazed across half his body and the platform just a few feet ahead of him.

I've discovered that Shanghai has a certain force of gravity, best described as: easy to get in, hard to get out. The flattering comparison would be an American university; the unflattering one would be a cult—

Ugh, I still have to go back someday, so I'd better shut my mouth.

Anyway, I got to the airport at 11:30 last night and sat there until 4:30 in the afternoon before my flight finally took off.

At first I used my points to get into a VIP lounge—thought I'd only be waiting an hour, so sitting in the VIP lounge felt a little indulgent. Well, let me tell you, I have never in my life spent points so well; every single one came back to me threefold.

I sat there complaining to whoever would listen about how terrible the lounge chairs were—lumpy and sunken, like sitting in a torture device. Some VIP treatment. Then I went to the bathroom and realized this actually was a proper VIP lounge—because the toilets had a built-in intestinal cleanse mode. I stood there reading the sign on the wall encouraging everyone to hold it in and conserve water, and for a moment I felt actually lost.

Chapter 33: The Form of Chase's Artifact

When Chase scrambled up onto the platform and rolled frantically clear, the subway train grazed his back and screamed into the station—

The icy cold of the train's metal hull, the hard gust of wind it kicked up, felt as though it might shear every layer of flesh clean off his back; if he had reached up and found the back half of his skull missing, that would not have surprised him in the slightest.

Chase gasped and pushed himself up off the ground; the train had come to a gradual stop, and in the reflection on the carriage window, he was still in one piece.

...He had always been lucky.

The subway from this station rumbled in right on its heels, almost as if it had been arranged that way, blocking the police on the opposite platform; even if they wanted to follow Chase's example and come after him, they would have to take a long detour first, losing a good deal of time.

Through the trains, the shouts from the other platform were muffled, swaying and echoing through the station: "You two, go after him... block the other exit, check every person coming out!"

Chase couldn't help but laugh. He rolled his shoulders and neck, then tilted his head back and let out a breath.

For just one second, he allowed himself to sink into the rush of adrenaline flooding his veins, his whole body burning with the surge of his blood.

When he opened his eyes, all the subway doors were opening, and the arriving passengers were filing off the train onto the platform.

"Hey!" From the front of the train, a man in a driver's uniform stepped down and called out to Chase from a distance: "Are you out of your mind? You almost got yourself killed—"

Before the man could get a clear look at his face, Chase pivoted nimbly and melted into the stream of passengers heading for the exit. The driver muttered a few curses, then turned and walked back onto the train—at which point Chase immediately shoved aside the person next to him and, just before the carriage doors slid shut, bolted inside.

The entire train was empty. Not a single person.

He looked left and right; the carriages ahead and behind seemed to stretch on forever, the same circular handholds and plastic seats repeating endlessly. With just one element missing—people—the train became a narrow, monotonous alien corridor, like the inside of a roundworm's belly. Truly strange.

The train began to move, keeping to a low speed—it was probably heading onto the turnaround track to reverse and take on passengers again. Chase walked toward the rear of the train along the gently swaying floor, stepping into the last carriage.

Ad panels on the carriage walls, handholds, handrails, seats, graffiti, food wrappers, and a drink bottle tossed on the floor... it looked like an ordinary carriage. There were neither too many nor too few places to hide something.

...The part that required the most patience was about to begin.

That was fine.

Whether in the Nest or in the world outside, no matter what he was hunting, a good Hunter needed a great deal of patience—and Chase happened to have an abundance of it.

"If I were a clever idiot," he muttered under his breath, "...where would I hide an Artifact?"

To guess the answer to that question, he first had to know what kind of Artifact he was tracking.

Artifacts came in every conceivable form—countless shapes and manifestations, stretching beyond the limits of human imagination with no end in sight. But fortunately, he didn't need to search blindly and trust to luck; because any Hunter in Blackmoor City worth their salt had heard at least something about Wellesley's Artifacts.

What was more, Ronan Key had been a Hunter for decades, with a network of connections in Blackmoor City as deep-rooted and far-reaching as an old tree; almost any intelligence related to Artifacts would inevitably drift past his ears sooner or later.

"I need you to get your hands on the Artifacts in Wellesley's study. Even just one will do."

Ronan Key had summoned Chase the moment news of Wellesley's death arrived. Outside the window, the sky had still been a pale duck-egg blue, as though a thin haze hung over it; Chase

later learned that when he sat down at the breakfast table, Wellesley had been dead for exactly three hours.

At that moment, Mrs. Wellesley, alone in Blackmoor City, was still asleep—still unaware that she had become a widow.

And in another hour and twenty-one minutes, Ivan would leave the Wellesley Family Estate carrying the Artifacts he had stolen.

"The first Artifact—he bought it from me back in the day. It's a black cube, about ten centimeters on each side."

Ronan Key's tone was flat. It was hard to tell whether he regretted the transaction now.

The Artifacts in Wellesley's hands had laid the foundation for a business empire that stood first in the world; looking at the wealth and influence he had accumulated afterward, it was almost puzzling why anyone had been willing to sell him all four Artifacts in the first place—perhaps that was Wellesley's singular gift: the ability to see a future in something that no one else could.

If anyone had known what they were truly worth, no one would ever have sold those Artifacts to Wellesley.

"The second is a set of tailor's tools."

Ronan Key paused, then said: "I've heard this set of tailor's tools is roughly the size of a laptop—whether that's accurate, I can't say for certain. This Artifact is said to be the most precious and most important of the four. Getting your hands on it would be worth trading away an entire House Faction."

In his spare time, Chase had once tried to estimate the value of the Key House Faction.

Hunter House Factions were hard to define—they operated like criminal gangs but were structured like modern corporations, making them something of a hybrid between the two.

By corporate standards, the Key House Faction's valuation was well into the tens of millions—and yet, from the way Ronan Key spoke, trading it away sounded like getting the better end of the deal?

"What does it do?" Chase asked.

"If you manage to get your hands on it, you'll know. Before then, the less you know, the better."

Chase nodded. "He has two more. What are they?"

Ronan Key let out a sigh and set down his coffee cup.

"The later an Artifact came into his possession, the less complete my information on it... He sealed off a lot of the channels through which things leaked. The third is said to be extremely dangerous; from the time he acquired it, any opponent who couldn't be removed by money, power, law, or market forces would conveniently and neatly disappear from the world—oil merchants as far away as Yemen were no exception."

Beyond "extremely dangerous," he offered no further details—and Chase had not a single word of objection.

He was the person who solved problems for the Key House Faction; incomplete information was part of the problem he had been handed.

"And the fourth?"

Ronan Key was silent for a few seconds.

"About that one, I've only ever heard one rumor," he said quietly. "...It is a rumor that creates rumors."

Chase even forgot to chew, letting the egg just sit on his tongue for a moment.

When he finally came back to himself and swallowed, he sought confirmation: "Uncle Key, you mean—the Artifact itself exists as a 'rumor,' its function is 'creating rumors'...and all of this is itself just a rumor you heard?"

Ronan Key nodded and said: "Yes. Round and round it goes—enough to make your head spin for a while."

What would Wellesley want with a rumor that created rumors?

And for that matter, how would you even find a rumor?

But then, when it came to the Nest and Artifacts, no matter how strange or bizarre something seemed, you couldn't simply assume it didn't exist.

If the thing you were looking for was a "rumor"—invisible, intangible—it should at least make some sound, shouldn't it?

Since some Hunter had once managed to bring it back into the world, there was no reason Chase couldn't find it.

Standing in the train, he cocked his ear and listened for a while, gradually sorting and filing the ambient noise into categories in his mind: the friction of the wheels on the rail, the sound of air flowing through the vents, the material creaks of the train's moving parts... not a single one was close to a human voice.

Since no faint whispers were drifting over like something haunting the place, did that mean the fourth Artifact wasn't here?

He hadn't expected to find the Artifact right off the bat, anyway...

Chase sighed and, for the first time, found himself cursing his own height.

Like some oversized spider trying to fold up its legs, he lowered himself awkwardly to the floor and swept his gaze beneath the seats, taking in the full length of floor under the entire row at once: a forgotten shopping bag, an earbud, fire-suppression equipment, stains... and even a shoe, its owner presumably having stepped off the train with one bare foot.

It sounded like a lot, but in truth the space under most seats was empty—a single glance told him there was nothing there that could be called an Artifact. That said, even a piece of chewing gum was not something Chase could pass over lightly.

Chase pulled a short, dark baton from behind his back, snapped it open with two sharp clicks, and extended it into an arm-length, heavy rod—a T-shaped cast-iron head at one end, a threaded grip at the other.

Blackmoor State law prohibited citizens from carrying firearms in public, so sometimes being armed actually invited unnecessary trouble—who would have thought that his trusty, portable, never-leave-home-without-it weapon would find an entirely different use today.

Patient as he was, as Chase used his beloved weapon to poke through the assorted rubbish under the seats—nudging aside that foul-smelling shoe, prodding a piece of chewing gum, then straightening up and running his eyes over the carriage's ad panels—he still couldn't help feeling that this was exactly the kind of job that ought to be handed to a low-ranking rookie in the House Faction.

But a different person might not be as swift or thorough as he was; in just a few minutes, he had finished searching one entire carriage.

Chase stopped in his tracks and glanced out the train window.

The subway had not, as he had expected, headed up onto the turnaround track and looped back to the departure platform; instead, it had grown slower and slower until it stopped altogether.

Outside, the tunnel was dim, its yellowish light barely illuminating a wide expanse of ground—beneath a vault as vast as an empty cave, several tracks ran parallel and crossed one another, like a compressed bird's-eye view of a highway interchange.

This was clearly not a place meant for passengers... Where had the train taken him?

As Chase moved on to search the next carriage, he heard footsteps approaching from the other end.

As the person walked, a keychain jangled against them, and they hummed a vague tune—apparently they only knew one phrase, repeating it over and over: "baby please don't go."

Chase straightened up, T-bar in hand, and stood quietly in the center of the carriage, waiting.

A man in a subway employee's uniform walked toward the second carriage and stopped dead—it was the same train driver who had shouted at Chase moments ago.

"When did you get on?" His face immediately went stiff, barely holding down the confusion and faint fear beneath. "What are you doing here? This train is going out of service—you have to get off right now."

Out of service meant it wouldn't be taking any passengers for a while.

At his current pace, another forty minutes would be enough to search the entire train... Not looping back to take on passengers was actually more convenient for Chase; the only thing was, to stay on the train, it would be best to have the man in front of him cooperate.

Chase had a T-bar, and he also had a wallet packed with cash—in today's world of digital payments and credit cards, carrying cash in person served almost only one purpose.

Just as he was weighing which method to use to get the driver's cooperation, the driver looked at his face, then at the T-bar, and suddenly furrowed his brow—a fear he couldn't quite suppress slowly rising to the surface.

"You—you're not..." he said, stumbling back two steps. "I have a family. I have kids... please..."

Who does he think I am?

Chase was taken aback. He was always careful in what he did; outside of Hunter circles, almost no one knew who he was. How had he barely driven through a few streets before apparently having a fearsome reputation?

Wait... "fearsome reputation"?

A current shot through Chase's mind like lightning illuminating a thick bank of clouds; though the picture wasn't entirely clear, he seized on the one thought that mattered most.

The next moment, the driver murmured, "You—you're the subway serial killer from the rumors?"

Chase slowly licked his lips.

...He'd found an Artifact.

Friends, neighbors, I know some of you aren't fond of the shifting-perspective style, but this is my vision for the new story—each character's arc pieces together a larger world, a world where the characters influence and intertwine with one another, and just thinking about that gets me excited. No other approach to this story does that for me.

Compared to the traditional web novel method of following a single character's perspective straight through to the end, I will definitely lose a significant chunk of readers this way—my road just keeps getting narrower, I know, no need to remind me again. Thank you. This is the approach I chose for myself; nobody held a gun to my head. I'm the one who decided to go down this path.

Chapter 34: Chase's Logical Story

Ever since he'd started chasing the subway, Chase had been sitting with one nagging question.

Blackmoor City's subway fleet numbered at least several thousand cars, and cars could be split apart and recombined into new formations; once a train pulled away, it was like a stone sinking into the sea—the odds of encountering that exact same car again were about as good as winning the lottery—and on top of that, the trains were cleaned every single day.

How could Ivan be so certain he could get the Artifact back?

It was only when Chase watched the subway driver backing away step by step and then turning to run that the answer suddenly crystallized, taking shape in his mind.

The target Ivan needed to find again was never one of hundreds of identical, untraceable subway cars; it was a subway employee with a name, a face, and a fixed work schedule—if you couldn't track down a train, wasn't tracking down a person simple enough?

He almost wanted to laugh out loud. He'd thought Ivan was a clever idiot, yet he hadn't quite guessed where the idiocy ended and the genius began.

A priceless Artifact capable of rewriting a person's fate had truly been left by Ivan on a complete stranger—he couldn't decide whether that was stupidity or audacity; perhaps the two had never been all that different.

The truly brilliant part of Ivan's plan was that no one in the world besides Ivan himself could connect him to this fleeing subway driver—because in the vast sea of Blackmoor City's millions, the two of them were distant, randomly chosen strangers; between them, there had never been any connection whatsoever.

It seemed Ivan understood perfectly well that once someone had him in their sights, they would dig up and scrutinize even the delivery driver who'd brought him a pizza—to say nothing of anyone with an actual relationship to him.

A complete stranger, someone with whom he had never shared a single point of contact, was therefore the safest hiding place imaginable.

Once he'd placed the Artifact on the driver, he could move freely, approaching whoever he liked; in fact, the more people he contacted, the more he could mislead anyone tracking him and

drain their time and energy—hadn't Chase himself wasted no small amount of effort on that pizza delivery driver?

It appeared Ivan hadn't anticipated this angle, otherwise he wouldn't have stayed locked inside his room that day.

While he thought all this through, Chase extended one large hand and lightly grabbed the back of the driver's shirt.

When Chase's hand closed on the driver's back and yanked him down to the ground, the man looked as though he hadn't yet understood what had happened—he fell flat on his back, face blank with bewilderment, seemingly unable to figure out when Chase had appeared behind him.

It wasn't until the back of his head hit the floor with a thud that the driver snapped back to his senses; he sucked in sharp hisses of pain, and while scrambling to roll over and get up, cried out, "Please! I'm begging you, don't kill me—I haven't done anything!"

That part was probably true. But Chase had no intention of saying so aloud.

He pressed one large hand flat against the driver's chest, his long pale fingers splayed over the man's sternum like the bars of a cage.

Chase hadn't applied any force, yet the driver didn't dare move; his shadow fell over the driver's face like the canopy of a great tree.

"What—what are you going to do to me?" the driver asked, his voice trembling, propped up on his elbows, unwilling to fully rise and unable to fully lie back down.

He had, at least, asked the right question.

In truth, Chase hadn't expected that he would find the most incomprehensible Artifact of all in a manner quite like this.

He'd gotten the man in his hands—yet what came next, he found himself, unusually, at a complete loss.

To begin with, Ivan hadn't had the time or opportunity that day to fabricate a plausible excuse to trick the driver into taking something; the driver couldn't possibly know he was carrying an Artifact, and didn't look like someone who knew the passage existed or had any familiarity with the world of the Nest.

Besides, Ivan couldn't have entrusted the Artifact to anyone connected to the Nest—after all, it was only when the other party was an ordinary person with no knowledge of the Nest that he could hope to reclaim it.

Ivan must have attached the Artifact to the driver when the man wasn't paying attention.

The moment he thought of it that way, the questions multiplied.

What exactly was an Artifact that existed in the form of a "Rumor"? How did it attach to a person? What did it look like? How did you remove it?

"I—I'm still on duty; if they notice I'm not working in a bit, someone will definitely come to check on me..." the driver said softly, pleading, "Please let me go, I'm begging you. I have face blindness—I won't remember what you look like..."

Since reaching adulthood, Chase had never once met a person who, having seen him once, failed to recognize him the next time.

"No rush," he said quietly, and thought for a moment.

How do you extract the truth from a target who doesn't even know the truth himself?

He had interrogated more than a few people himself, yet he had never encountered a situation quite like this: the target clearly held the key information, yet still knew nothing at all.

Judging by Ivan's route that day, he'd had no time whatsoever for any real interaction; the Artifact must have changed hands in the space of a single passing encounter, and the driver might not even remember him.

The odds weren't good, but Chase decided to try anyway; after briefly describing Ivan's appearance, he was met, as expected, with a blank stare.

"Where did you hear about this 'subway serial killer'?" he thought it over, and decided to approach from an angle the driver might actually be able to speak to.

The driver darted a quick glance at him from the corner of his eye, then fixed his gaze hastily on a handrail in the distance.

He paused, then spoke tentatively, as if addressing the empty air: "...Well, a few nights ago, after the C Line shut down for the evening, wasn't a woman's body found? I remember it made the news."

Chase frowned.

That had indeed happened; but people dying in Blackmoor City was so commonplace that if the driver hadn't brought it up, that news item would have vanished from his memory forever.

"The subway staff thought she'd fallen asleep and forgotten to get off, but no matter how they called out she wouldn't wake up; the moment they nudged her shoulder, she rolled right off the seat onto the floor."

As he spoke, his gaze drifted to the seat beside him, as though he could see the body rolling to the ground right there. "The one who found her happened to be a colleague of mine—we sometimes play a few rounds of poker together... when he described it to me afterward, his face was as white as a sheet."

What did a person's death have to do with an Artifact—especially with "Rumor"? And how had the "subway serial killer" rumor even started?

The driver seemed to read something else into Chase's faint change of expression and hurried to explain: "Of course, the more I think about it, I'm sure I got it all wrong—you're distinguished-looking, tall and impressive, how could you possibly be a serial killer? Ah, I think it's just because I've been on edge lately, and when I'm alone on the subway I get a bit paranoid. The moment I saw you carrying that pole thing, my mind immediately jumped to the wrong place... The woman's body was slumped against the wall, so you couldn't tell anything at first—it was only after she rolled to the floor that my colleague saw the impact wound on her head..."

Some people, when seized by panic, open their mouths and can't stop—talking more and faster, as though trying to build a foundation they can stand on out of pure words; this driver was likely one of them.

Chase decided to stoke the fear higher, to burn a deeper hole in the man's composure.

He lowered his head and looked down at the driver, slowly spreading into a smile.

When Chase smiled, his lips went very thin. His teeth were white—not a bright, lustrous white, but the airless, deadened white of concrete. Teeth without any warmth of the living, packed tightly between those thin lips; when he smiled, they all showed at once, as though the lower half of his face had been unzipped.

"You see," Chase said quietly, "weaving a logically coherent story takes skill. That skill, you don't have."

"Huh? Me?" The driver jolted, as expected. "I'm not lying. That news story is real—look it up if you don't believe me! I saw the news and misunderstood you, it really was rude of me..."

The news story might be real, but it didn't explain his behavior.

"One death hardly makes for a serial killer," Chase said, like a careful editor hunting for inconsistencies. "Or rather—why did you assume the woman who died was killed by a serial killer?"

The driver's mouth fell slightly open, as if he'd been asked a question he'd never thought to ask himself.

A lump pushed up suddenly against one of his cheeks from inside, slid along the surface, and disappeared—as though he'd pressed his tongue against the inside of his cheek.

"I... you're misunderstanding, I haven't gotten to the second part yet. It's because the Brooklyn District has had bad security lately; after the woman's body was found, there was another assault. Someone got off the night shift, came up out of the subway station, and barely stuck their head out before someone hit them with a—I mean, with a club—to the head..."

He swallowed.

"The detectives who came to investigate called in quite a few people from the transit company for questioning. They didn't come out and say it, but from the way they talked, they suspected someone was committing a series of crimes..." The driver pushed his tongue against his cheek again before continuing: "That's how the rumor spread—I'm not lying to you. One of the detectives was quite pretty too, and her partner looked like a perfect match; there was a real air of something between them... All of this circulated together, everyone knows about it."

Chase was silent for a second or two.

Plenty of people talked without any filter when they were nervous, but this sudden spill of gossip still caught him off guard. "...What?"

"Quite an air of something between them,"

Under his fear and anxiety, the driver's words spilled out almost unstoppably, and he answered immediately: "The two of them were constantly trading remarks back and forth, no one else could get a word in edgewise. The man didn't seem to be a police officer—he was a criminology professor brought in from some university as a consultant, heard he'd been divorced once, don't know the details. Anyway..."

Chase released the hand pinning him down and took his phone out of his pocket.

Life was truly a strange and unpredictable thing.

For instance, this morning's version of himself could not have predicted that the midday version would be driving recklessly through Blackmoor City; and the version driving recklessly through Blackmoor City could never have predicted that thirty minutes later, he would be on a subway car, phone in hand, opening the App Store and downloading Netflix.

"What are you doing?" The driver's angle let him see Chase's phone screen, though not clearly enough to make anything out.

"You have an account," Chase said—not a question, but a statement. "...Log in."

"Wh—why?" The driver was thoroughly confused, but clearly didn't dare argue; he rapidly typed in his password and asked, "If I hand you my account, can I go?"

Chase said nothing and took back the phone.

On the home screen, under the "Continue Watching" row, several shows and films were lined up that had been played before; he scrolled through for a few seconds and had already locked onto his target.

He looked at the screen, then looked at the driver.

The man had no idea what he was doing, and still stared up with a blank face—beads of sweat faintly gleaming, mouth half-open, as though a small cavern had been cut into his face.

Unless this subway driver moonlighted as an Oscar-winning actor after his shift, it was obvious he had not the faintest awareness that the story he'd just told—about "a female detective and a male consultant jointly investigating a serial killer case"—was the plot of the first season of a crime detective series on Netflix, even though he had watched it.

Chase could no longer say his story wasn't coherent.

Hey everyone, I'm on a plane again today—not sure if I'll have time to write and post an update once I land, so here's this chapter for you first, eat up, eat up, come back for more if it's not enough. (As for when more dishes will arrive after you order—that I can't say.)

Chase's portion of the plot isn't as complex as Sydney Ginn's, but it ended up taking me the most time to research... Parts that a reader might skim past in a single glance still had to be nailed down when writing: for example, the same train at the same time on the same day—would

it be the same physical car? I searched and searched without finding an answer, and eventually went to Reddit to track down a channel run by a New York subway enthusiast (and somehow that niche hobby exists), posted a question... and finally got my answer: no, it wouldn't be the same car. Once a train pulls away, it's gone like a stone dropped into the sea.

Then there was the layout of the subway station, how spare trains turn around, this and that—plenty of research done, not much of it actually used.

Blackmoor City is fictional, but beyond that I want all the background details to be as true to life as possible—a fuller sense of reality makes for a better experience.

I'm finally heading home! My cat must have forgotten what I look like by now. No telling how many socks she's been stockpiling to ambush me with after this month away.

Chapter 35 — Folks, Grandmas, I'm Home

This whole trip absolutely wiped me out... curled up in my seat with my legs folded like a bird's, couldn't sleep properly, food was terrible, and after layovers, train transfers, subway switches, hauling luggage, and climbing stairs, I finally get home and—

Dust everywhere, like I'd stepped straight into the Sahara.

I normally use pine cat litter at home—clean and practically dustless—but it needs frequent scooping. Whenever I'm about to sit down and write, I make a point of trotting over to check: any droppings? Need scooping? Yes? Perfect, that's another ten minutes of not writing justified.

Since I had someone come over to look after the cats while I was away, I couldn't very well demand they show up three times a day on a strict scooping schedule, so I switched to regular cat litter. Good lord, the dust from that stuff—every single object in the apartment, whatever color it used to be, is now uniformly grey-white. My place looks like it got hit by a sandstorm. It's not fit to host the National People's Congress right now.

Vacuuming, mopping, wiping down the furniture—I was already half-dead—when I discovered a nest of laundry sitting in the washing machine. I'd washed it before I left... and it had been sitting in there, unremoved, this whole time. Use your imagination. Picture that smell. It's enough to cost you your life.

I ended up crouching on the floor dry-heaving out roughly half my soul.

Got everything cleaned up, but the smell wouldn't leave. In the midst of cat-poop fumes hanging over every inch of the apartment, I finally managed to make myself a cup of coffee and sit down (and let's see who can't help themselves from saying "cat poop coffee"), opened my laptop—and guess what, the screen wouldn't turn on.

I kept closing and opening the laptop over and over. Every now and then it would deign to light up for a moment; I'd type in my password, and it'd go black again—like a bashful young maiden.

AAAAAA

AAAAAAA

The beauty of the West Lake, in the month of June

The display screen is dead, so how am I typing right now? Because I have an e-ink external monitor... with extremely low resolution. Extremely blurry. Things like logging into an account and being asked to click on all the images with traffic lights—absolutely out of the question. All I can manage is typing text, where I can just barely tell which blobs are characters and which is the background.

How blurry are we talking? Anything that isn't your native language, you'd have a hard time making it out at all.

On the plane, when I was sitting there like a bird but wasn't completely exhausted yet, I wrote 980 characters. Several hours after getting home, I'm now at 1,020 characters.

Anyway, I'll post this chapter whenever I finish it. Right now my legs are shaking going up and down the stairs, my muscles have the texture of wood grain, and I have no idea why I'm this tired...

Chapter 36 — Chase Searches for the Passage Artifact

When Chase was young, Uncle Key would sometimes take him camping in the mountains.

Deep in the mountains, far from Blackmoor City's endless nocturnal noise, the world was pitch-black and still. Aside from a basin of red-glowing fire, only the stars overhead were visible; he had never seen such a pure night, as though even the forest had dissolved into outer space.

Uncle Key taught him to identify constellations, gently tracing lines between stars scattered across the sky, connecting them into the shape of a water dipper, a great bear... Mountain nights were cold, so Uncle Key always brought extra blankets. Young Chase sat beside him bundled head to toe, his gaze drifting through the universe.

Right now, in this moment, he found himself thinking again about those lines drawn between stars.

It was nowhere near as beautiful as a sky full of stars, but a few points of light seemed to be gradually surfacing on the subway driver in front of him — points that, once connected, would form a shape.

From that vague shape, he had formed a guess.

One: "A woman's body was discovered after the subway stopped running" — a fact, recent news.

Two: "Someone was attacked after finishing a night shift" — Chase wasn't yet certain whether this was true or false; it could easily be one of the hundreds of everyday news items in Blackmoor City.

Three: "A female detective and a male professor team up to investigate a serial case" — a TV drama.

That gave him the three elements that composed the Rumor.

Seen this way... Chase's appearance on the subway was like a sudden bolt of electricity, lighting up something in the driver's mind.

Before he had noticed Chase, the subway driver showed none of the so-called "paranoia" or "fear" he later described; when he was walking alone through the empty subway car, he had even been humming to himself.

Yet the moment he laid eyes on a tall man carrying a weapon, the driver clearly lost, for a brief instant, his ability to distinguish truth from fiction — the three points above were rapidly assembled and combined, and in the span of a single breath, a Rumor was created: "a serial killer has been stalking the subway lately."

What was interesting was that the moment the driver blurted the Rumor out, he himself believed wholeheartedly in what he had just created, and even grew worried for his own life over it.

...So this was how the Rumor Artifact operated?

By recombining and adapting raw information, it caused a finished Rumor to flow out of someone's mouth... but that was only the first step. What came next would probably only become clear once he had the Artifact itself in hand.

No — wait, perhaps it would be more accurate to say this was one of its operating modes.

From all the signs, the subway driver was merely an information bank stocked with enough relevant details, a mouth capable of passing the words along; he had no idea what had influenced him, and no awareness of it whatsoever. It was hard to imagine Wellesley allowing an Artifact to manipulate him rather than the other way around.

There had to be a way to use it actively, to manufacture Rumors on purpose; but that was not the most pressing question right now.

The most important question right now was getting the Artifact into his hands first.

Chase stared at the driver's cheek and watched what looked like something being pushed up by a tongue — a small bulge that slid past and vanished — it had happened several times now.

"Spit out whatever's in your mouth."

The driver stared. "My mouth? There's nothing in there."

Chase looked at him without a word.

"I mean it, there's nothing — I just have a habit of pressing my tongue against the inside of my cheek." Under Chase's gaze, the driver immediately grew flustered and said, in an appeasing tone: "If you don't believe me, I'll open up, take a look —"

Chase directed his gaze, with mild distaste, into that fleshy pink cavity.

He had seen plenty of human insides; he was used to it, yet always found them slick and unpleasant.

The inside of a person's mouth was a strange thing — stare at it long enough and it even brought to mind alien creatures: a red, trembling throat, a hairy tongue, everything perpetually sliding and rolling in a thin sheen of glistening liquid, as though it had a will of its own.

But however unappealing, they were not Artifacts; other than what should be in a person's mouth, there was nothing extra in the driver's.

Of course, Chase had never really expected the Artifact to be spat out that easily, so coming up empty didn't disappoint him — after all, if something was truly being held in the mouth, how could anyone not notice? Ivan couldn't have slipped something into someone's mouth without them knowing.

Although he still had no idea what form the Artifact took, if it was hidden inside the man's body, extracting it would likely mean drawing blood and getting his hands dirty... a subway car serving as a backup vehicle was not an ideal location for that. As the driver had said, someone might be coming soon.

Chase grabbed him by the collar and was just about to haul him up when the driver suddenly seemed to realize something and began struggling and kicking wildly, crying out: "Where are you taking me?"

He was a broad, heavy man, and anyone else might have had real trouble subduing him — but the moment Chase sensed the movement, he had already released his grip; in the same instant, his right foot swung sideways in a heavy kick directly onto the driver's ankle. The driver's cry of pain had barely left his mouth when Chase's T-bar plunged deep into his gut, driving the breath, balance, and strength all out of him at once, and he crumpled to the floor without another sound.

The driver didn't quite make it all the way down — Chase had already caught him by the back of his shirt, holding him like a bag of groceries.

Only this particular bag of groceries was rather large, and his legs were dragging limply along the floor.

"I'm very interested in this thing called Rumor," Chase said, hauling him along, his tone perfectly reasonable: "I just want to have a little chat. Whether that chat happens with all your limbs intact or not is entirely up to you."

The driver couldn't even breathe properly and could produce nothing but intermittent, indistinct groaning; Chase decided to take that as consent.

Not until he had dragged the man a few more steps did he faintly make out a few words from within the groaning — and Chase stopped.

He glanced out the window; the dark, silent subway tunnel showed no sign of anyone arriving any time soon.

"What did you say?" He bent down and prompted, in a tone that was almost gentle: "Say it more clearly."

The driver said it again, his voice thick and garbled.

Even with his imagination working at full stretch, Chase could only make out a few nonsensical syllables — something like "line," "broken," "electric" — which he couldn't assemble into any meaning at all.

He was about to ask the driver to repeat himself when something stirred in his mind.

He knew exactly how much force he had put into his own strikes, which was why he had deliberately held back just now. Besides, a single blow to the gut shouldn't leave someone unable to speak clearly more than ten seconds later.

Thinking about it that way... when the driver spoke just now, had he actually opened his mouth?

The thought seemed to prick him; he swung his arm and flung the man, who tumbled to the floor like a bundle of rags.

The driver's face flashed upward for an instant before he rolled facedown — in that brief moment, Chase had already seen clearly: the driver's face was stretched pale and taut, his lips pressed so tightly together they were barely visible; he looked as though he was fighting against something, jaw clenched hard, a tendon rising along his chin and leaping toward his temple.

His eyes had rolled back in his head, as though some deeply terrifying question was consuming him — the less he could make sense of it, the more frightened he became.

Just moments ago he had been frightened of Chase and couldn't stop talking; but now his lips were sealed tight, and he seemed to be afraid of something new entirely.

The next second, Chase understood where his fear was coming from.

The driver's head struck a handrail — just one knock, but it seemed to jar loose whatever tension he had been holding so rigidly in place.

He had not opened his mouth, yet from between his sealed lips came a human voice again, far clearer than before: "Car... electric light... wire, snapped, falling down..."

Had Chase been even a blink slower to understand, the electrical wire dropping from the ceiling might have run a current straight through his body — as it was, he only managed to throw himself clear at the last possible moment, crashing into the seats to one side, watching a shower of crackling sparks rake across the floor in front of him, the scattered embers drifting into the shape of a serpent.

Was this Artifact trying to protect itself?

The thought flared suddenly through Chase's mind.

The driver instinctively curled up and clutched his head; the wire hit the floor, missed him, bounced back up, and whipped through the air again, swinging straight toward Chase.

The car was not particularly wide, and the spot where the casing had come loose and the wire had fallen happened to be dead center; a live wire crackling and thrashing was already a serious problem — but as Chase swung his arm and drove the T-bar forward to knock the sparking end of the wire back several paces, he heard the voice from the driver's cheek again.

"Want to go home,"

Hearing it now, he realized it was a voice entirely unlike the subway driver's, speaking in rapid, blurred fragments: "Want to go home — passage — the passage through which people can enter the Nest —"

For one instant, Chase thought he had been struck by the wire.

Every pore on his body went numb and tingling; he found himself afraid to move, as though afraid of startling it, afraid it would not be able to keep speaking. The scar on the back of his right hand stirred awake, tightening and contracting the skin in waves.

Chase stood dazed before the seats, one hand still resting on the plastic backrest. Everything in the world seemed to recede from his awareness except for the voice beneath the driver's cheek, and he was back again in that dark, still mountain forest of his childhood. The difference was that in this darkness, there was only one point of starlight he could see.

"...None." The voice beneath the driver's cheek said.

The wire sprang back into the air, a string of electric sparks tracing an arc through the darkness and falling at Chase's feet.

He heard his own heart slam against his ribcage with a dull thud, unable to break free, sliding back down into the depths of the dark.

In the dead silence, he became aware that he had stepped forward, legs stiff, fingers closing around the fabric of the driver's shirt — yet his hand seemed somehow very far away from him.

This meaningless body of his also seemed very far away.

"Resident,"

As the driver was hauled upright by him, feet barely finding the floor, another sound came from between the man's closed lips. "A passage through which one can come into the human world — there is one. One Resident."

The driver's heavy panting, the rush of air from the subway car's ventilation system, the crackling of the wire... it was as though a floodgate had been lifted, and every sound and sensation came pouring back into Chase's awareness at once.

"Make it quiet," Chase said through clenched teeth, forcing four words out in the driver's direction.

After those four words, his peripheral vision told him that up ahead, a pane of black glass was bowing inward toward the car's interior, as though pressed from the outside by something enormous.

I know this might sound like I'm making excuses for myself, but yesterday when I was so exhausted my head was spinning, I actually got stuck at 1,500 words and couldn't push through — the plot felt like it had hit a dead end, and I had no idea who'd written the first 1,500 words or who was supposed to take it from there. Anyway, I couldn't do it, because my brain is a block of wood.

Didn't sleep well today either (cat noise, early morning meeting, not enough sleep), but at least I did sleep, and when I sat back down to write it was different — somehow the images and ideas were there, and somehow I finished it.

And after finishing it I'm actually a little pleased with myself? Especially pleased with the part where Chase is completely let down. (laughs)

Chapter 37: The Thing Chase Hates Most

Time — he needed time.

In the span of just twenty or thirty seconds, one unexpected twist had followed another, each one catching him off guard and defying all comprehension.

But Chase knew that given even a little time, he could connect the dots between each "point of light" and assemble them into a clear, legible picture.

The world might be chaotic and complex, but Chase believed it could always be understood this way: first, seize enough key pieces of information from the chaos and noise, then use each point to illuminate the broader picture, connecting them into a shape that brought the whole framework to the surface.

The only problem was that time was precisely what he had the least of right now.

When Chase turned his head and his gaze landed on that pitch-black pane of glass bulging high into the car's interior, he knew he had made an unavoidable mistake — there was no way he wouldn't look at the window; no one could have resisted. But the moment he looked, his attention had been stolen away.

In that split second of distraction, the wire that had just been torn free crackled and sparked behind him, whipping through the air toward the back of his head.

Even the air seemed twisted and taut with the current; he could almost smell the electric sparks, and the skin on the back of his neck felt as though a flash of blue were scorching across it.

...No matter how skilled a person was, they couldn't move faster than electricity.

Chase closed his eyes.

The moment of waiting for the shock stretched out impossibly long; memories of the electric jolts he had endured years ago in search of a passage rose to the surface, like a preview of the piercing pain about to come.

But after a single breath, Chase opened his eyes again.

The crack of current striking flesh, a pained grunt, the thud of a body hitting the floor — he heard all of it; yet the current itself, he felt nothing of it.

Someone had been electrocuted, but it wasn't him.

Chase snapped his head around, and sure enough, the driver was sprawled on the floor behind him, his complexion ashen and sickly, body curled and convulsing in waves, as though some tendon deep inside him had been seized and yanked taut — he couldn't straighten up, and he couldn't escape. The wire had lost its earlier frenzy and hung limp on the floor nearby, motionless, as if ashamed of what it had done.

Chase glanced at the car window swelling like a balloon, then glanced back at the driver lying a step behind him; for a moment, he almost laughed.

"I forgot to mention," he said, picking the T-bar up from the floor and weighing it in his hand. "I have very good luck, because I tend to drain the luck from everyone around me."

The driver couldn't speak at all; even his consciousness seemed to be fading.

"Just now, you followed my gaze and turned to look at that window too, didn't you? I was distracted at that moment, and I let go of you." Chase wasn't looking for an answer from the driver — he needed to work through everything in front of him himself. He fixed his eyes on the window and said, "You saw the window looking like that, and it terrified you. You stumbled back a step, and in doing so, you took the shock that was meant for me. Am I right?"

A low rumble rolled up from the driver's throat.

So it seemed that the Rumor Artifact couldn't control the physical movements of its host — otherwise the driver wouldn't have stumbled backward onto the wire out of sheer fear.

"I have you to thank, because you took that shock for me, and now I have a little time."

Chase gripped the T-bar and walked step by step toward the window ahead, which looked as though it were nine months pregnant. When he was two paces away, he swung the T-bar high and brought his full weight down — driving it straight into the pitch-black glass. No shattering sound came; instead, the window yielded like a sheet of rubber, caving inward and swallowing all his force without resistance.

Behind the window was most likely a Resident capable of entering the human world — it was only natural that the T-bar would have no effect on it.

"What I'm about to say isn't for you," he continued, "but for whatever is inside your mouth... Rumor, right? That's what I can call you, isn't it?"

The driver lay on the floor, drifting in and out of consciousness; the voice beneath his cheek had gone quiet too, as if in tacit agreement.

"For an Artifact, you possess a certain degree of intelligence — enough to protect yourself. That's remarkably rare. But you don't have true self-awareness, and your intelligence only goes so far; otherwise, you wouldn't be an Artifact at all. You'd be a Resident."

From the window that had swelled like a breath of air, the shape of a human hand emerged; it pressed against the glass from behind, and a five-fingered outline rose to the surface, slowly feeling its way around.

Wherever the hand groped, Chase's gaze followed.

"If your intelligence were high enough, you would have realized earlier that when I threatened the driver and went after him, it wasn't because I wanted to hurt him — it was to get to you. But that chain of cause and effect is too complex for you to grasp. You didn't understand it... you only have raw instinct.

"When the driver you're inhabiting felt his life was threatened and he fell into a state of fear and panic, your survival instinct was triggered too. I don't know what you look like, but you seem to need a person to exist within. If that person dies, you'd be in serious trouble, wouldn't you?"

The driver had stopped convulsing and lay still on the floor; a thread of consciousness still lingered in him, his eyelids half-open and faintly trembling.

From between his barely parted lips, a tiny voice was speaking rapidly: "Help, help!" — as though crying out on the driver's behalf.

Chase turned his gaze back to the window. In the swollen black glass, a distorted reflection of himself stared back; as the corner of his mouth curved up, the reflection showed half a twisted smile in return.

"Who exactly are you calling for help?"

Chase didn't know whether other people's lives were as full of ironic, dark humor as his own — if he weren't the one living it, he could almost laugh out loud.

After all, half the reason the driver was so terrified in the first place was because the Artifact had conjured the rumor of a "subway serial killer," convincing the driver he'd run into one — which also indirectly proved that Rumor didn't have a particularly high level of intelligence.

It hadn't realized that the rumors it created at random could turn around and affect its own host.

"From the 'subway killer' and the 'loose wire,' I can see that you can't conjure things out of thin air — you can't just say something and make it appear.

"Whatever you say has to be grounded in some existing reality. If no one had ever died on the subway, you couldn't have invented the rumor of a 'subway killer'; if there were no wires here, you couldn't have willed an extra wire into existence from nothing.

"The wire couldn't kill me, so you called in a Resident capable of entering the human world... but you don't truly want to return to the Nest — you just sensed that the Nest is somewhere you could hide from me."

A dark tide of ink-black surged up inside Chase, and for an instant he felt a violent urge — to close his hands around the Resident behind the window and wring it into powder and fragments.

Sometimes he wished he could use these same hands to wring his entire life into pieces.

His words fell, and the cabin sank into a brief, dead silence.

The Artifact made no sound; the driver's breathing was faint as a dying thread. The hand behind the window had finally felt its way to where the glass met the window frame, and like someone unpicking stitches, it began slowly tearing the glass downward.

"I don't know how low your intelligence really is. But if you can understand a single word I'm saying, you'd do well to send the Resident back to the Nest right now..."

If this Artifact had truly wanted to go home, it would have had countless opportunities before today.

There were bound to be Hunters around Wellesley, and every Hunter had a passage — it could have hitched a ride back with any of them. And even if it couldn't reach a Hunter, why hadn't it called on this Resident capable of entering the human world long before now?

"Help..."

The Artifact spoke again, this time slowly; after listening to Chase, it seemed to hesitate a little itself, and when it called for help again, there was a question mark at the end: "Help?"

"I'm asking you to send it back for two reasons." Chase's tone was calm. "First, once the Resident comes through, I can protect myself, but I can't guarantee your host's life."

Several grayish-white fingertips had begun to push in through the gap between the glass and the frame. Chase watched them and said quietly, "Second... you have a decent read on things. You're right that I have no passage, and I can't enter the Nest."

For a moment, both the Resident and the Artifact seemed to be waiting for him to continue.

"However, this is not the first time I've encountered a Resident."

Chase watched his own reflection and slowly rolled his shoulders and neck.

"The thing I hate most is a Resident that can enter the human world. Every time I see one, I can't help but lose my temper a little. Fortunately, they're rare, so I don't lose my temper very often.

"But today, you called one right to my door."

Chase let out a quiet sigh.

"If you truly want to protect yourself, I suggest you stop making me angry."

Rushing through it all, I finally managed to get a chapter out before the day ended!

Now that I'm slowly getting back into my regular routine, I should start thinking about bonus updates for everyone... Ugh, if I took a month off starting today but counted all the updates during that month as bonus chapters, would that be a little too sneaky? It'd be written all over my face.

P.S.: Barring anything unexpected, updates will be in the evenings from now on. I've still got my day job, and there's a mountain of work that's piled up.

Chapter 38: Chase's Second Memory

"Chase, Chase, wake up—time to go home."

A hand gently nudged his shoulder, and his dream cracked open at the seam; fragments slid away and drifted off, and Chase opened his eyes.

The horizon had already faded to a pale violet, long clouds dyed deep crimson, as though someone had dragged a finger across the sky and left streaks of rouge behind.

The shadows of palm trees stood tall beneath the sky, and in the evening parking lot, dim amber lights flickered on one by one.

"Sleeping so soundly—what were you dreaming about?"

His mother stood outside the car window; seeing him awake, she pulled her hand back from the half-open window and straightened up. Chase couldn't quite make out her expression, but he heard a trace of guilt in her voice. Her tone was very soft, because guilt is a softening agent.

Chase couldn't remember. The light in the dream had been very bright—far brighter than this western evening in the parking lot; he had been very tall, far taller than he was now.

But whatever he had actually dreamed, he had forgotten it entirely.

"No overtime today?" he asked, watching his mother open the car door and settle into the driver's seat on the other side.

"I begged my manager to let me leave early today." His mother glanced at him, and a hint of a smile surfaced, but it couldn't break through some heavy lid pressing down on it, and faded away. "I didn't even dare tell him you'd been waiting in the car for me all day..."

"Why didn't you dare?"

His mother set a plastic bag on the back seat; the smell of food inside was familiar. She always brought home leftovers from the restaurant for the two of them to eat as dinner. She started the car and said, "It's not exactly something to be proud of. If anyone found out, child protective services might come and take you away."

Chase didn't understand what was wrong with sitting in the car waiting for his mother to get off work—the window was half open, a soft breeze drifted in, his fingers were sticky with chip

crumbs, and the storybook on his knees had slid to the floor while he slept.

"I'm sorry. It won't happen again. When you grow up, don't go complaining to a therapist about me. Buckle your seatbelt."

It would happen again, of course, because the only person willing to watch Chase for next to nothing was a neighbor girl nearby, and she didn't have time every day.

Later, Chase thought that what he had truly wanted to say back then was "I like waiting for you"—but somehow, what actually came out was a complaint: "I want to go home and watch TV."

"Okay," his mother said, pulling out of the parking lot. "Not until after dinner."

By the time they got on the highway, the sky had gone completely dark; bright headlights cut through the night, sweeping past their old car one after another. The highway sat high up, with a mountain cliff on the left; looking out from the road, you could see all the way to the distant horizon.

The vast, sprawling city of Los Angeles lit up beneath the night sky with countless lights, like stars.

This was a road they had traveled countless times, as familiar as their own kitchen. Chase kept watching the L.A. nightscape through the window; his mother was listening to the radio, and the two of them chatted idly.

Everything happened before anyone could react: when a heavy freight truck ahead suddenly lurched sideways and crashed through the right guardrail at an angle, his mother was still mid-laugh.

Her sharp intake of breath made Chase snap his head around, just in time to see that long truck jackknifed across the highway ahead of them.

The shriek of the emergency brakes tore through the entire cabin, but the car still couldn't overcome its own momentum and kept hurtling straight toward the truck—Chase was pinned into his seat by the seatbelt, watching the truck grow larger and larger, like an overwhelming catastrophe bearing down on him, and in that moment he forgot whether he had screamed.

He only remembered turning his head and seeing the driver's seat empty.

The seatbelt was still buckled in its clasp, lying flat across the driver's seat as though it were protecting an empty chair; the steering wheel, freed from the hands that had held it, turned ever so

slightly.

...Huh?

The bewilderment lasted only a flash; by the time Chase came to his senses and lunged for the steering wheel, he slammed into the truck—in that instant, the front of the car crumpled and buckled upward, swallowing most of the window and his field of vision, and a moment later Chase sank into darkness and knew nothing at all.

Ah, right—Chase Monroe died in a car accident when he was five years old.

...He did die, didn't he?

Something felt off, though.

If Chase Monroe had died at age five... then who was the person now recalling this from his perspective, who believed he had died?

A small voice raised a faint objection.

Does it matter who is doing the remembering? And whether he died or not—that doesn't matter either.

What truly mattered was this: if he stopped all this pointless thinking and simply sank down through the warm, amniotic darkness, closed his eyes and drifted off to sleep, then every struggle and confusion would find comfort and answer... nothing to worry about anymore...

Nothing to... worry about...

Absolutely not.

Chase's eyes snapped open.

He was lying on the floor; the nearly blinding white light of the subway car, for just a moment, left him unable to see anything at all.

Some instinct that jolted awake from deep in his bones was the first thing to suppress his reflex to roll over and spring up; he forced himself to stay completely still, listening as a soft rustling on the floor swept past his ear and slowly receded.

His vision cleared quickly, and he found himself lying in front of a window that had lost its glass.

He still remembered how, just moments ago, the glass of that window had bulged outward like a rubber balloon, with several gray-white fingers prying at the gap between the glass and the window frame; now the window was empty, and all that remained were shards of broken glass scattered across the floor and the seats.

The Resident had already crawled in through the window, entering this human world...

But no matter how hard Chase tried, he couldn't remember why he had ended up on the floor.

When he fell, the back of his head must have struck the seat first before hitting the floor; his neck was twisted at an awkward angle now, a dull ache running through it.

He listened as the rustling came to a stop a few steps away, and from the driver's throat came a low, trembling moan—the moan had barely begun when it cut off abruptly, as though it had been strangled.

Dead?

Chase's heart sank. That Artifact—

"...So you are, con—scious," a sticky, glutinous voice said, in a deeply unnatural cadence: "Good then."

It was the Resident.

"So you're conscious—good then." That line was directed at the driver, which meant the driver wasn't dead yet, at least for now...

Chase held his breath and slowly rolled his eyes to the side, making out a blurry gray-white shadow standing not far away on the floor; it was hard to tell clearly, but it seemed as though that shadow had its back to him.

His abdominal muscles tightened inch by inch, and he silently, soundlessly lifted himself off the floor, spotting the T-bar lying by his feet. He didn't reach for it.

From the state of things, it looked as if he had gone down before he'd had the chance to do anything at all...

That hunched, curled-up figure had a very short build, barely reaching Chase's waist. Its entire body was wrapped in a gray-white robe, ragged and torn in many places, shredded into strips.

From beneath the gray-white robe, one gray-white palm—larger than a mop head—lay limp against the floor, facing upward; the other hand was raised in the air, three long fingers extended, one of which was now bending down toward the driver.

"Mem—ories that, can be, died in. Three, places."

Once the cadence went wrong, even the meaning was hard to grasp on first hearing; Chase paused slightly before understanding that it was saying "memories that can be died in—three locations."

Which meant—

Chase understood everything all at once.

He jolted with alarm and, no longer caring about concealing himself, stamped his foot down on the driver's ankle and shouted furiously, "Wake up—don't listen to it, you're not dead!"

He had effectively exposed himself—before the next thought could even form, a face swiveled around on that hunched back, spinning toward him.

The moment his gaze landed on that face, the subway car once again rapidly blurred, dissolved, and slid into darkness; Chase stumbled involuntarily backward onto the seat behind him, the Resident's sticky laughter sounding in his ears.

"Mem—ories that, can be, died in. Thir—ty-nine, places."

So that's how it was...

That faint mixture of indignation, fear, and agitation, as he tumbled back into the memory, dissipated rapidly from the edges of his consciousness like gray smoke.

If the car accident when he was five was the first memory the Resident had found—one in which he could conveniently die while reliving it—then Chase now knew what the second memory it had found was.

The second time his life had been in danger was six days after the car accident.

It was also the day his mother came back from the Nest.

Chapter 39 — The First Resident Chase Ever Saw

At first, the ward was a constant stream of people coming and going.

Unfamiliar faces drifted in and out, their features blurring together until Chase could no longer tell one from another. He remembered traffic officers, nurses, doctors, detectives, social workers... every vague, flesh-colored face would open its mouth and pour an endless torrent of questions over him.

Who is your mother?

Where did you get on the highway?

Did you notice the car door — was it closed? Did she jump out of the moving car?

What about your father? Oh, you've never met him?

Are there any other relatives at home?

Other than being able to answer "My mother's name is Daisy Monroe," Chase couldn't answer a single question.

Chase used to sometimes imagine that he actually had a father — a CIA agent, deep undercover abroad, or a top scientist working on a classified project and therefore unable to meet him. The ordinary fantasies of a child.

But during those days, Chase sat alone on the hospital bed with his arm in a cast, watching one stranger after another walk in and walk out, leaving behind snacks, empty paper coffee cups, cigarette butts, business cards, and an endless stream of questions.

Every naive fantasy he'd once held peeled away before reality, like shedding a skin he had long since outgrown.

"It's just me," he told the police officer. "There's only me left at home now."

That day, he heard a few people talking by the door — whether they were police officers or social workers or something else entirely, a child had no easy way of telling.

"I've worked this job for decades, and I've never seen a mother run off like this," the middle-aged man said, chewing tobacco. "Parents who walk out the door in the morning and never come back — that's common enough... but how did she manage to vanish from a car accident?"

"Strange, isn't it. You can't make out from the scene evidence how she disappeared at all," said another, younger-looking man. "Though it's ironic, when you think about it — if she hadn't suddenly vanished, that kid probably would have ended up with more than just a broken arm."

"Oh, right, you mentioned something about that before. Something about the direction of the front of the car?"

"Right. You've heard how, when drivers face a sudden emergency, they instinctively jerk the wheel to the left, so the passenger side takes the impact? That's not always the case — some drivers steer toward whatever has more clearance. But in this particular accident, that boy's mother had no choice but to steer left—"

Because on the right was a cliff.

That answer surfaced in Chase's mind at the same moment the middle-aged man let out a low "Oh."

"She probably hadn't finished turning the wheel yet — or had only just started — when she vanished from the driver's seat. She let go, the wheel returned to center, right? According to what the boy said, after he realized his mother was gone, he instinctively reached out and grabbed the wheel... In doing so, he nudged the car slightly to the right — but not too far right, just enough that it didn't smash through the guardrail and go over the cliff. Instead, by some perfect coincidence, the boy came away with the lightest possible injuries. It's like a miracle."

"Lucky kid," the middle-aged man said, then stopped himself. "...No, you can't really call him lucky. Five years old, and now he has neither a father nor a mother. What happens next?"

"His mother has a distant aunt living in Blackmoor City who's agreed to come and look after him for a few days," a third person cut in. "Whether she's willing to take on long-term guardianship is another question... If she's not, the boy will have to go to an orphanage or a foster family."

Chase was discharged on the third day, carrying one broken arm in a cast and a medical bill he had no idea what to do with.

His aunt was getting on in years — her glasses were always sliding down to the tip of her nose, and she started dozing off every night at eight o'clock. She and Chase had no idea how to be around each other, and the small apartment that had once been noisy and busy fell as quiet as if no one lived there at all.

On the sixth night after the accident, Chase could not sleep no matter what he tried.

The pain in his arm was one thing; once his aunt fell asleep she snored constantly, and every time he lifted his head, there was a strange, mountain-like silhouette sleeping in his mother's bed.

By midnight, Chase couldn't take the boredom and the misery any longer. He crept out of bed and made his way into the living room. There was nothing in the living room either — he thought he wanted to play with his toys, but he stared at the box for a while and didn't even reach out to open it.

Chase walked to the window and looked down at the familiar street below, empty of people.

If only Mom could come back, he thought. Right now — walking back up the street, wearing the clothes she had on the day she disappeared, carrying the snacks and breakfast she'd bought for him, her keys jangling with every step...

Though he was only five, Chase already understood that his imaginings would not come true.

So when he truly saw his mother walking up the street toward him, step by step, the shock made him lurch forward — thunk — and bang his face against the glass.

"...Mom?" he called softly.

The apartment was on the second floor, still a good distance from his mother, yet she looked up at him as if she'd heard.

In that instant, Chase didn't move, his forehead pressed against the cold glass.

Half of his mother's face was covered in blood.

In the darkness, the blood was blacker than the night itself, making half her face look as though it had been swallowed by nothingness. One eye couldn't open; only the eye sunken in that dark, bloodied ruin was looking at him, its pupil faintly gleaming.

But it was unmistakably his mother.

The moment their eyes met, his mother stretched out her hand and waved at him hard, the way she used to when she came to pick him up from kindergarten; then she kept on limping and stumbling toward the apartment, nearly tripping once in her hurry.

In a moment like this he should have gone and woken his aunt at once, but in that instant Chase didn't even remember there was an aunt in the apartment; he ran straight to the door, threw it open, and clattered down the stairs.

"Mom!"

Chase ran toward her as fast as he could, and if his mother hadn't quickly reached out to steady him, he would have thrown himself — cast and all — right into her arms. "Mom, what happened to you?"

"I tripped and fell," his mother said, gasping, bent half over, managing a small laugh. "It hurts so much. Your arm—"

"Where did you go?"

His mother looked him over for a moment before she said, "A... a very strange place. But it doesn't matter. I'm back now. Don't worry — I'll never go there again..."

At those words, whatever force had been holding her up and carrying her home seemed to give way all at once; she collapsed on the roadside like a stack of building blocks someone had suddenly kicked over.

"Mom?" Chase was startled and rushed to support her.

In truth he couldn't really support her — it was more like he threw his arms around hers and tumbled down to the ground alongside her.

But his mother waved her hand, signaling that she was all right. "I'm just tired... let me rest a moment... is it just you at home?"

"Aunt came from Blackmoor City," Chase answered.

"Go home... have her call an ambulance..."

Chase looked down and found that the front of his body, his arm, and his cast were all stained with blood.

"Go... go on." His mother's voice was faint, as if a breath of wind could scatter it.

Chase nodded hard, over and over. Before he got up, somehow his hand began to tremble, and he reached out and gently touched his mother's side.

Perhaps he wanted to find where she was hurt and how badly, but what he touched was something strange.

"Mom," Chase said, startled. "What is this wrapped around you?"

In that moment, his mother's face went still.

In his entire life, Chase had never seen a face so terrifying — because the person that face belonged to had herself been swallowed whole by bottomless fear.

A fear as dense and suffocating as cement slowly pressed the air flat. For one fleeting instant, Chase had the sudden urge to make himself very small, invisible to everyone — including his mother.

His mother didn't look down at her waist, as if by not looking she could keep her fear from becoming real. That one eye that could still open was locked on Chase, and whether tears had gathered in it or not, it shone with a frightening brightness.

"Wh... what? There's something wrapped around me... what is it?"

Chase didn't realize until now that he had been crying, tears crawling down his face in a steady, itchy stream.

"I... I don't know," he said, not understanding what he was so afraid of, unable even to pull his hand away — it still rested at his mother's waist, trembling. "It... it feels like a thin rope..."

Just then, he felt the rope stir faintly beneath his hand.

As if the other end had been given a tug.

The other end...

Chase dimly realized that the rope around his mother's waist must have another end.

"Don't look,"

he heard his mother say, pleading, "don't look behind you, Chase... go home, run..."

But Chase couldn't hear her. His body seemed to have been taken over by another version of himself; he rose to his feet without meaning to, stepped to the side, and let his gaze fall on the ground behind his mother.

A rope lay slack there, stretching back into the night, disappearing gradually into a darkness no streetlight could reach.

...Strange. Who had tied a rope to his mother?

The rope moved again.

"Chase! Come back!"

Chase startled, and only then realized that he had been walking forward along the rope without knowing it, several steps already. He looked back at his mother, then turned again — and this time, ahead of him was not only darkness, a street, and a long rope.

The massive dark shape holding the other end of the rope was standing before him, and he had no idea when it had appeared.

"Run!" His mother's cry, nearly a shriek, jolted Chase sharply back to himself.

He had no time to make out the shape of that shadow. He spun and ran. He thought he screamed — or maybe he didn't; he thought a neighbor's light came on — or maybe it didn't.

In that moment, the world suddenly dropped the facade of rational order and exposed the dark, murky nightmare churning beneath, and nothing felt real anymore.

He heard the shadow speak.

Its voice stretched across the night, drifting through the air.

At the time he couldn't understand the words, yet every single one was carved deep into his bones; later Chase came to understand what they meant, but by then so much time had passed, everything was too late, and he simply never let himself think about it again.

Only once — while interrogating a traitor — did those words the Resident had spoken leap unbidden into his mind.

By the time Chase came back to himself, someone was holding him around the waist, begging him to stop; the traitor had already been beaten by his fists into a pulp of flesh, barely more human in shape than a heap of mud.

"Thank you so much,"

the Resident had said. "The only way I can enter the human world is to find a dog, tie a rope to it, and have it lead me in. You didn't really think you escaped from me, did you? You really thought you could come back and be reunited with your son? Oh, let me have a taste... I've heard that a human being's shattered hope is the most delicious thing there is."

I thought about it for a while, and in the end I've settled on Daisy for Chase's mother's name.

Chapter 40: Chase Is Very, Very, Very Simple

Had he been wrong?

When five-year-old Chase bolted madly forward a few steps, he suddenly remembered that his injured mother was still lying at the roadside.

In that moment, instinct stopped him cold, and without a second thought he spun around and lunged back toward her, wanting to help her up and run with her—was he not supposed to do that? Had he been wrong?

"I told you to run!"

His mother's shriek in that moment was sharp and piercing, almost nothing like the heavily wounded woman who had been unable to speak just moments before.

"Mom—"

He grabbed his mother's arm and only managed to cry out that single word.

The next second, he watched his own feet dangling in midair, swaying and drifting away from the ground.

His mother tilted up a face half-blackened with blood, frozen for a split second in shock and terror, then suddenly screamed: "Let him go!"

The thing had not gripped Chase, nor had it lifted him by the collar.

He realized, belatedly, that a long black shadow had pierced through his chest and stretched out into the air—like a blade run clean through him—holding him suspended in midair. But Chase felt no pain, and he wasn't bleeding; he had only lost all strength in his body, and his head hung heavy, too weak to lift.

"No rush," the Resident hummed from behind him. "I don't think you've fully grasped the beauty of the situation before you. Let me explain it carefully."

His mother's voice drifted through its words like a whimpering howl.

"The flavor I most love to savor and appreciate is 'irony.' That kind of thing only flourishes in humans—the Nest has none of it.

"The disappointment of a person who buys a lottery ticket and doesn't win is still disappointment, yet it tastes plain and dull, like a cup of instant noodles—it fills you up, but that's all. Your disappointment right now, however, is an exquisite delicacy. Why? Because your hope has been dashed with irony. A losing lottery ticket lacks that particular flavor. I must make you understand this beauty completely, or I'll be driven half-mad with longing."

The Resident jostled Chase up and down a few times and let out a satisfied sigh.

"First of all, your passage simply delights me to no end. Only in a car accident can you enter the Nest—no wonder you're thirty-six years old and only now opening your passage for the first time... But if this car accident had happened a few months earlier, none of tonight would exist. Do you know why?"

His mother's gaze was fixed on Chase, swaying gently with him in the air.

"Because the residential population of your region of Los Angeles only surpassed ten million this year. Look at you—if the accident had happened earlier, it would have just been ordinary bad luck; and if you had moved away this year, the way you'd always planned, you would never have entered the Nest for the rest of your life... Isn't the timing of the accident especially ironic? Especially delicious?"

Chase dimly recalled that his mother had indeed once asked him whether he'd be willing to move back to her hometown.

It was just that at the time, he still couldn't understand what moving or not moving had to do with any of this.

"You thought you escaped, never knowing you became my guide dog and led me into the human world—already quite good. If you had called the police for help the moment you arrived and been sent to a hospital, wouldn't that have been dreadfully dull? I would naturally have left then and gone to find another human.

"But you didn't go to a hospital. Your first thought was to go home and check on your child, to make sure he was safe—and in doing so, you exposed him directly to me... How wonderful.

"If you didn't love him so much, he wouldn't be dying tonight."

Chase knew he was crying, and he also knew he wasn't crying for himself.

His mother's whimpering and wailing from the ground terrified him far more than the black shadow piercing through his chest.

He used to think he had a superpower—whenever his mother was unhappy, he could always make her laugh with just a few words—but tonight, that superpower seemed like the conceited dream of some other five-year-old child.

"Don't bother calling for help—who could save you?"

"Haven't you noticed that the neighbor who just opened their window to look has already closed it again and gone back to sleep? Ordinary humans with no passage and no prior contact with a Resident simply cannot see me... nor can they see the child I've skewered in midair. Right now, you're nothing but a madwoman sitting by the road in the middle of the night, crying."

In the Resident's grasp, Chase was like a piece of meat on a skewer.

With a sudden swoosh, it swung him through the air in a wide arc past his mother's face—as she lunged forward and grabbed at nothing—then hoisted Chase high once more.

"Oh my, the two of you crying together, mother and child—you've even made me sad. Don't be like this; I do have a shred of mercy. How about this: I'll give you a choice."

His mother stared blankly upward, a glimmer of wetness bright in one eye—though it was not the gleam of hope.

"Residents who can cross into the human world are very, very, very rare—not even one in ten years. Far fewer than the humans who have passages. Isn't that unfair?"

The Resident clicked its tongue—if it had a tongue.

"The conditions for crossing over are hard to meet, extremely demanding, and after all that effort, one careless misstep and you fall right back into the Nest. Now, I'm going to tell you how to send me back."

His mother went completely still. She murmured: "Wha... what?"

"Very, very, very simple. You still have a rope around your waist, don't you? It's actually a part of me. All you have to do is cut it, and the passage I used to enter the human world will be severed—I'll naturally return to the Nest. You don't believe me, do you?"

"Well, there's nothing I can do about that. All I can say is that for us Residents who've crossed into the human world, once our passage is cut, we fall right back into the Nest. It's that simple. If you don't believe me, try it."

"The choice," his mother pressed one hand to her waist, breathing hard as she asked: "You said you'd give me... a choice. What is it?"

"Oh, just whether or not to cut the rope."

The moment those words landed, the air went quiet for a second or two in bewilderment. Chase couldn't see clearly, but his mother had certainly furrowed her brow.

"I... why would I... not cut it? You have... a trap..."

"Wrong—there's no trap." The Resident said matter-of-factly: "I am a very, very, very trustworthy person. If I allow you to cut the rope, I will absolutely not stop you. The rope can grow back anyway. But you'd better think carefully before you cut it."

Chase felt himself being lifted, hanging high beside a vast, flat black shadow; the Resident seemed to rub Chase against what served as its face a few times, almost affectionately.

"Your little one, I won't be letting go.

"So your choices are: one, don't cut the rope—I stay, and I kill both you and your child; two, cut the rope—I take your child's corpse back to the Nest with me, and you keep your own life."

Chase felt the flat black shadow that was its face swell outward in a bulge, pushing his body up a little—the Resident was laughing.

"I promise, your child will die tonight without fail. The only difference is whether you want to die alongside him."

That sharp, anguished shriek his mother let out—even after all these years—still lodged in Chase's chest like a blade.

He had died after all, it seemed—no matter what his mother had chosen that night, he had been killed by the Resident without a doubt...

A voice in his mind that did not belong to Chase kept persuading him: that's right, you died that night. Don't you remember? That small body in a cast, hitting the ground with a thud, falling right before your mother's eyes...

Residents who could cross into the human world—were they really so rare?

One had come when he was five. Now another had come.

...He had not, of course, died that night.

Chase refused to die in the moment of the car accident, because if he had died then, he would never be able to see his mother one last time.

He still remembered, to this day, the warmth of his mother's arms around his shoulders that night.

Chase equally refused to die at the Resident's hands, for reasons somewhat more complex: first, the Resident had been badly wounded that night and driven back to the Nest, so the last remnant of reason buried deep in his mind would not allow him to believe the Resident had killed him then; second, if five-year-old him had died that night, he would never have been lifted from a pool of blood by Uncle Key.

He strained to lift his neck, his mind hazy, wanting to turn and look at his mother one last time—but Ronan Key's hand covered his eyes.

"Listen... listen to him, go quickly," his mother's last broken words rose from the warm darkness of that palm. "From now on, Mom... is leaving you in his care."

If he had never met Uncle Key, he would never have known what had truly happened to his mother that night, and there would be no place left in the world to hold the remnants of his soul.

Chase's consciousness returned to the subway car—this time, he did not open his eyes.

He sat up soundlessly, and in deep focus, his five senses sharpened and amplified severalfold: he traced the faint rustling sounds, the faint raw-flesh scent from the Resident's body, the subway driver's breathing... and mapped out the layout of the car in his mind.

To drive the Resident back into the Nest—"very, very, very simple."

All he had to do was cut off the path by which it had come.

Lately, after finishing each chapter, I write a few hundred extra words to save up for bonus updates... The idea is good, but the pace is really a bit too slow.

Chapter 41: Chase, Did You Think the Rumor Had Stopped Spreading?

"Hm? Hmm hmm hmm?"

A long, sharp sound of bewilderment rose from the Resident's throat, as though it couldn't fathom why Chase simply refused to die inside a memory and kept dragging himself up off the ground again and again.

"Can die, go to memo, ry thir, ty-eight——"

It had just said "thirty-nine" a moment ago, Chase thought. So it's counting down.

A memory that had already been used once couldn't be used to attack him again, could it?

Good. He was thoroughly sick of that helpless, useless, five-year-old child who could do nothing but wail.

His contempt for weakness far surpassed even what he felt for the Resident.

Chase shut his eyes tight and drew a long, deep breath.

"Hmm hmm hmm hmm hmm?" Seeing him still standing, the Resident seemed deeply displeased; its voice turned far more grating: "Thir, ty-eight——"

"Stop that," Chase said quietly. "As long as I can't see your face, I won't black out. That's how it works."

Every time his gaze landed on its face, he immediately toppled over and sank into a memory. Even a fool could draw a line between cause and effect.

"By any Resident's standard, you're a crude, inferior thing." Chase spoke as he stepped back. "You've hardly any new tricks, but your weaknesses are plentiful——"

Before he could finish, a gust of wind swept toward him head-on.

The soft smack of bare feet against the floor, the faint current of air stirred by countless shredded strips of cloth swaying, and the thick, viscous, bloody smell that grew dense all at once

With his eyes closed, his other senses sharpened.

Chase stepped back again; his shoe crunched onto broken glass with a grating creak, and he knew he had reached the window the Resident had crawled through.

He suddenly dropped into a crouch, reached forward and grabbed — his hand plunged into what felt like a sticky, pestilential fog — and sure enough closed around a fistful of fabric. The nauseating, familiar electric shock of physical contact with a Resident jolted from his palm all the way up to the crown of his head — his chest was seized in return, and the Resident let out a short, triumphant laugh.

Chase knew why it laughed.

It probably assumed Chase would be too overwhelmed to move; most people, during their first few encounters of physical contact with a Resident, were hit so hard by the physiological effects that they couldn't even stay on their feet.

But it didn't know that compared to the Resident from when he was five, it was nothing more than cheap merchandise.

Chase gritted his teeth against the trembling in his muscles, closed all five fingers tight around the Resident's chest robe, swung his arm, and hurled it hard through the broken window beside them.

The Resident only managed a single "Huh?" — the next instant it had already slammed down onto the tracks outside the window with a distant, heavy thud.

Now came the real question — what was the passage this Resident had used to enter the human world?

It had crawled in through "a pitch-black train window," but that surely wasn't the only condition.

Otherwise, there was no shortage of "pitch-black windows" in everyday life — it could have entered the human world long ago. Why would it have waited until now?

Beyond the condition of "a pitch-black train window," at least one other condition must also have been met for it to crawl into the human world — no matter how he turned it over in his mind, Chase could only think of one.

In a flash he had already opened his eyes, broken into a sprint across the carriage, swept his arm down midway to scoop up the T-bar, and skidded to a stop beside the half-unconscious train driver.

"Rumor — send it back."

Chase could already hear rustling from outside the window behind him, as though the Resident was trying to crawl back in. He raised the T-bar high and said, "Otherwise I'll turn your host into pulp right now."

He never made empty threats.

The instant the T-bar bit into the train driver's shoulder, the tiny voice inside the driver's cheek shrieked in rapid succession: "Cancel the invitation to 'Nostalgia Attack'! Cancel the invitation to 'Nostalgia Attack'!"

.....What a terrible name.

Chase exhaled sharply and lifted the T-bar free from the driver's shoulder bone. He stood there and waited a second or two; the carriage was bright with white light, utterly silent.

Slowly, he turned to look at the window the Resident had crawled through.

He had actually braced himself to see a human body hanging half out of the window, to see a face smiling back at him — but the window was empty, with only a few fragments of broken glass still standing in the frame, oblivious to the fact that they had become useless.

Chase carried the T-bar and walked toward the window step by step; he was careful, and didn't look directly with his own eyes — he simply opened his phone camera and swept it across the view outside through the screen.

If the other party was a Resident, it would naturally be fond of playing mind games, and might well be crouching just outside the carriage, both hands pressed over its mouth, snickering and waiting to see him disappointed.

But outside was nothing more than a dim subway tunnel, empty and quiet.

He walked back across the floor of broken glass and the driver's pained groaning, and returned to stand before Rumor.

A single blow to the shoulder had jolted the driver out of near-unconsciousness; now, seeing Chase approach, he was whimpering and trying to inch backward — Chase pressed the tip of the T-bar against his chest and said, "Don't move."

The driver went still, his face all fear and cold sweat. "Jus— just now, that was....."

"A dream," Chase said flatly. "You had a nightmare."

If the expression on the driver's face could be rendered in words, it would be roughly: "Even if you're going to lie to me, you could at least put some effort into it."

But Chase had never liked dealing with loose ends and cleanup, and had no patience for finding reasonable explanations for everything that had just happened. He was considering how to retrieve the Rumor Artifact when the driver spoke again.

"Something in my mouth……what's in my mouth?" the driver said, dazed and disoriented. "You just called it Rumor……why Rumor again……"

Chase's attention snapped upright like a dog's ear catching an unfamiliar sound.

"Again?" He leaned in, startling a hiccup out of the driver. "Who else said the word 'Rumor'?"

Whether from physical pain or sheer terror, the driver's lower lip was wet and trembling. "A few days ago, someone said they'd lost their glasses and couldn't see clearly, and asked me to read a couple of lines for them……"

Chase froze, and didn't interrupt.

"He asked me whether what was written said 'I have a Rumor to tell you.' I looked at his phone and said no — it said 'I heard a Rumor'……It was a strange thing, and nobody knew who had sent him that nonsensical message, so I remembered it."

"What did he look like?" Chase asked immediately.

"I don't know……" the driver said, trembling. "He was wearing a mask. All I could tell was that he was a man, somewhere in his twenties or thirties."

No wonder the driver had shown no reaction when describing Ivan's appearance earlier — for a moment, Chase almost wanted to burst out laughing.

He understood everything now.

The answer turned out to be this simple; knowing it, and then looking back, it was almost strange that he hadn't thought of it himself.

Since the Artifact in question was a "Rumor," the way to pass it along was of course through "words," wasn't it?

The person who had asked the driver to read a message that day was, without question, Ivan.

Ivan's purpose wasn't merely to have the driver read a message — he had been tricking him into completing a conversation:

"Now say it once: 'I have a Rumor to tell you.'"

Chase watched the small bulge in the driver's cheek, pushed up by a tongue, slide away again. "Once you say that, I'll leave immediately and won't touch you again."

"Rea— really?" The driver blanked for a moment, then latched onto this lifeline. "I— I have a Rumor to tell you!"

Chase drew a long, slow breath.

".....I heard a Rumor," he answered quietly.

The exchange was complete.

The carriage fell into silence. Chase looked at the driver's cheek; his face showed not a flicker of movement.

Chase suddenly felt his own tongue, beyond his control, lick the inside of his mouth — and then settle back into place.

He slowly broke into a grin.

"You.....you said you'd leave....." the driver trembled and propped himself up, inching backward, eyes fixed on Chase. "You can't....."

"Relax."

Chase stood up and pulled a wallet from his inner jacket pocket. He drew out the entire thick stack of bills and tossed them onto the driver. "Consider it my compensation for the undeserved ordeal. When you call the police, mind what you say."

When the driver's eyes fell on the money, Chase turned and left.

He would certainly call the police at the first opportunity — Chase couldn't care less.

"Rumor," Chase murmured as he stepped onto the platform. "How much time do you have left?"

He waited patiently, and sure enough heard a small voice from inside his own cheek:

"'Rumor,' countdown: 3,405 days, 16 hours, 15 minutes."

Chase did a rough calculation. Worthy of being Wellesley's Artifact — first-rate in every respect, with nearly nine years and four months of remaining use — worth noting that many Artifacts, when they first left the Nest, didn't come with nearly that much time.

It must have been in Wellesley's hands for quite a few years already. After Wellesley died, how had it passed from a dead man's mouth into Ivan's?

Chase couldn't work out the answer for the moment.

The officers pursuing him seemed to have assumed he'd long since slipped in among the disembarking passengers and left.

He reached up and roughed up his own hair, letting his bangs fall down to cover his forehead, then stripped off his jacket and dress shirt and discarded them, keeping only the white short-sleeve underneath, and walked out of the subway station more or less openly — there were a few officers stationed to watch the exits, and one called out: "Hey!"

Chase stopped and asked in a mild, cooperative tone: "Officer, what is it?"

The officer looked him up and down.

When he had crossed the tracks earlier, all the officers had caught was a suited figure from behind, and with the dim lighting in the tunnel, Chase was confident they couldn't recognize him. He was tall, but that wasn't uncommon.

"Where are you coming from?"

"Ninth Street."

"When did you get off?"

"Just now. I used the restroom and it took a little while."

The officer thought for a moment, waved a hand, and said, "Understood, thanks for your cooperation. You're free to go."

As Chase was about to leave, he suddenly found himself asking without quite meaning to: ".....I heard there's a serial killer targeting the subway. Is that right?"

The officer paused.

"Oh.....right," he said, as though slowly surfacing from a memory; he glanced at his colleague beside him first, then said: "Yeah, there is that Rumor.....but the person we're after

today isn't him. Or, well — probably not."

"Good luck, Officer." Chase smiled, turned, and walked out of the subway station.

Honestly, I'm pretty pleased with the part about Chase's childhood — let me have a little moment. His arc wraps up in one more chapter!

Chapter 42: The Root of the Chase-Sydney Enigma

Chase sat on a park bench, staring straight ahead with an unfocused gaze.

His elbows rested on his knees, his upper body hunched forward; both hands hung loosely, and a T-bar was tucked into the back of his waistband.

Everyone who passed along the path in front of him made a point of quietly stepping back a few paces and giving him a wide berth; the space within several meters of Chase was completely empty.

A moment ago, two young women had been walking over from a distance, chatting and giggling softly to each other as they glanced his way, but the moment they got close, their expressions changed, their eyes fixed straight ahead, and they hurried past with quickened steps.

When people spotted a madman, their reaction was always more or less the same: they had to sneak sidelong glances to track where the madman was, what he was doing, and how far away he was—yet at the same time had to keep a blank face, look right through him, and put distance between themselves as fast as possible.

In truth, this wasn't the first time in Chase's life that people had taken him for a madman; he'd even been called one to his face more than a few times.

But in the past it had always been because he came across as vicious and brutal, heavy-handed enough to kill—never, not once, for a reason like today's.

Leaving the subway station had been some ten-odd minutes ago.

By rights, his first move should have been to return to Key House Faction, hand the "Rumor" Artifact over to Uncle Key, then contact Kingsley and bring her back from police custody—but before he could even flag down a cab, Chase had been forced to abandon his original plan and duck into a small park first.

...Because the "Rumor" Artifact was using his lips, teeth, and tongue—his own voice—to speak, sentence after sentence, without pause.

He had lost control of his own tongue; no matter how hard he tried to press it down, it kept springing back up, shaping new words inside his mouth.

Whether it was the struggle against the Artifact that had twisted his expression, or whether it was the unstoppable muttering to himself, either way he had drawn stares from everyone along the way, and people were going out of their way to avoid him.

Being stared at by strangers didn't bother Chase.

But the Artifact spoke at a tremendous speed, and whenever a car horn blared on the road or a jackhammer started up at a construction site, he'd miss whatever it had just said—words that came out of his own mouth, yet even Chase had no idea what they would be before he heard them.

He had been so close to handing it over to Uncle Key, yet he was forced to suppress that urgency and sit patiently through every last sentence the Artifact spoke, hoping to understand as much as he could about how it operated and what hidden dangers it might carry.

Because he had to make sure that every Artifact he placed in Uncle Key's hands was, at the very minimum, safe.

"After you create a rumor and spread it, what happens next?" he had asked as he walked out of the subway station.

Who could have guessed that the "Rumor" Artifact would turn out to be such a chatterbox?

A single question seemed to open the floodgates.

The subway driver had certainly never asked his own mouth that question, never activating the Artifact, so he'd had no idea that something like this was even possible: the Artifact lacked the ability to say so much all at once on its own, so it had conscripted Chase's tongue and had been rattling on ever since, with no sign of stopping.

Its intelligence might not be high, but the sheer volume of information it contained was absolutely enormous.

"...This breaks down into four aspects. One, the generation of a rumor; two, the spread of a rumor; three, changes in a rumor's credibility; four, the consequences of a rumor. Each aspect is further subdivided into several sub-categories according to various different situations. I will now begin with the first aspect..."

How to describe this feeling?

It was like someone staring at a PDF that was several hundred pages long and should have been printed as reading material, then reading it aloud to you at a furious speed—using your own

mouth—the sensation was bizarre, the information overwhelming, and the moment your attention slipped for even an instant you lost track of what had been said, with no way to ask for a repeat, because your mouth had been commandeered.

And so Chase sat on the park bench, the upper half of his face blank, the lower half very busy.

"...Under ideal conditions, a rumor constructed from a blend of real information can spread rapidly through an environment and population that suits it. It is worth noting, however, that at this stage a rumor may be circulating without necessarily being believed by everyone, and at this point everyone still knows it is merely a rumor, with the possibility of being disproven.

"The shorter a rumor is, the less distortion it undergoes in the course of transmission. Once it reaches a sufficient number of people in its original form—that is, the first variable—the rumor acquires a certain degree of credibility...We can treat the environment in which a rumor exists as a system; once credibility reaches the second variable, the rumor, as a 'macro-theme' within the system, generates quantum responses with multiple 'butterfly effects.'"

Chase desperately wished he could tell it to speak plainly, but he couldn't say a word himself.

"Let's use an example," the Artifact finally produced from Chase's mouth the words he had been waiting to hear.

"Suppose you release a rumor that reads: 'Nest Elementary's Xiao Ming gets diarrhea after eating people.'

"Assume the real materials composing this rumor are: one, Xiao Ming does indeed exist; two, Residents in the Nest do occasionally eat people; three, Xiao Ming sometimes gets diarrhea."

...Right, note to self: remind the House Faction Hunters to bathe regularly.

"...The rumor is relatively short, and the Nest is an environment conducive to transmission... Let us assume it successfully reaches both the 'number of transmissions' and 'credibility' variables. What happens next?

"Multiple seemingly unrelated factors already present in the Nest will at this point become 'butterfly effects.' What is a 'butterfly effect'? It is precisely the initial condition that causes change in a chaotic system, as in the butterfly effect.

"For example, Xiao Ming has a younger sister, Xiao Mei. Xiao Mei normally eats Xiao Ming every Wednesday evening, but after hearing the rumor, she decides he isn't very clean, so this

Wednesday she does not eat him."

...Never mind the passersby—Chase, listening to the voice coming out of his own mouth, felt very much like he himself had gone mad.

"'Hungry Xiao Mei' becomes the first 'butterfly effect.'

"The second 'butterfly effect': assume there is a Hunter who has been captured. The Hunter suggests to the Resident who caught him that they not kill him, and in exchange, he designs that Resident a battle-royale arena."

Chase's mouth and tongue had gone completely dry, but the Artifact paid no mind.

"After all, this is only an example, so for simplicity's sake, let's keep it to two 'butterfly effects.'

"Hungry Xiao Mei ventures out to find food and eats one of the arena's contestants. To compensate the arena's owner, she hands Xiao Ming over to him.

"The arena owner wants to select the most outstanding children, and inspired by the recent rumor, names the arena 'Nest Elementary'...And so the result of this rumor is that a 'Nest Elementary' truly comes to exist within the Nest."

Chase was taken aback.

He had assumed the rumor's consequence would be that "Xiao Ming gets diarrhea from eating people" would come true—the feeling was like stepping on empty air.

"You see, the part of this rumor that can come true might be 'Xiao Ming gets diarrhea from eating people,' or it might be 'Xiao Ming eats people,' or it might be 'a Nest Elementary exists'... The reason the last outcome appeared is that the 'butterfly effects' in the Nest's environment steered the result toward 'Nest Elementary.'

"If we substituted different 'butterfly effects,' then the part that comes true could be 'Xiao Ming gets diarrhea from eating people.'"

Sure enough, the Artifact then went on at length about another example.

With different "butterfly effects" in play, the result was that Xiao Ming started getting diarrhea when he ate people.

In short, its operating pattern was: create a rumor—people hear the rumor—people believe the rumor—"butterfly effects" (if any) begin to interact with the rumor—and finally, the rumor comes true, or it does not.

...So in order to make a rumor come true in the way you wanted, you had to narrow down the range of possible outcomes it might produce—was that it?

By the time Chase arrived at this conclusion, his own mouth had already finished saying several more sentences.

If, before spreading the rumor, one were to set up appropriate "butterfly effects" in the environment in advance—like planting foreshadowing—it might be possible to steer the rumor toward a desired outcome...

He had only been thinking for a few seconds, but his mouth had already moved on to a different direction, shifting from theoretical function to concrete application. Chase quickly pulled his attention back and kept listening for a while, until he suddenly heard himself say: "...In that case, the rumors previously created by all prior hosts of 'Rumor' can serve as operational references for the new host."

...Wait, did it mean that he could look up the rumors Wellesley had previously created?

"As long as the host does not delete them, every rumor is recorded for later retrieval."

The Artifact paused for the first time at that point, as if waiting for Chase's response.

"Tell me,"

Chase was finally able to speak with his own tongue: "what was the rumor before the 'Subway Serial Killer'?"

Given the command, the Artifact answered quickly—fast enough that he nearly bit his own tongue.

"The 'Vulture' in the Nest can copy a target human and become a second version of that person, then use their passage to enter the human world."

Chase's hands suddenly clenched together, fingers twisting tight.

Another Resident trying to enter the human world...

No, no—that wasn't the point.

The point was: why create this rumor in the first place? Even if it came completely true, what would that accomplish?

"Who created this rumor?" Chase confirmed during another pause from the Artifact.

"Wellesley."

It seemed Wellesley had wanted to conjure a Resident capable of entering the human world out of thin air. What was his purpose?

"And the date it was created?"

The date the Artifact reported was over three months ago.

Considering that each rumor had to run its full course and reach its conclusion before a new one could be created, this was very likely the last rumor Wellesley had created before his death.

A rumor's conclusion could only end one of two ways: either it came true, or it simply faded away into nothing.

"Did this rumor come true?" Chase asked again.

"It came true on November 17th," the Artifact answered.

That was...the day after Wellesley died.

The reason I said earlier that writing this story with an ensemble perspective gets me excited is because I love the feeling of storylines interweaving and influencing each other...

Think about it—if I were writing strictly from Sydney Ginn's single perspective, would discovering the contents of the rumor be anywhere near as interesting? (She'd have a much harder time finding out in the first place—what grounds would a solo operator Hunter have for learning what's inside a Key House Faction Artifact?)

Chapter 43: Sydney Ginn's Original Plan for the Artifact

Of course... of course it was me.

There was never any reason to doubt it—the real Sydney Ginn was me, all along—

The moment that thought surfaced, it was as though something that had been cinched tight around Sydney Ginn suddenly came loose.

She sank to the floor without meaning to, buried her face in both hands, and wept aloud.

It wasn't grief, and it wasn't fear—this crying was closer to release: the unease and suspicion from moments ago, the near-death memory of struggling and fighting, the pain and terror of having her throat torn open and her shoulder hacked through... all of it seemed to flow out of her body, little by little, with each sob, leaving behind nothing but an exhausted, hollowed-out Sydney Ginn.

By the time she stopped, the last echoes faded from the exhibition hall, and silence settled back over everything.

Everything that had happened in those memories left not a single trace now.

No blood on the floor, no fire axe, no gouges bitten into the ground by its blade. The artwork made of long wooden strips still sat exactly where it had been, intact and undamaged, and naturally there were no splinters of it embedded in her face, hands, or feet.

Her trail pack was tossed in a corner of the hall. Sydney Ginn walked over to it, dug out the long towel from inside—dry and soft, never once soaked through by another version of herself's saliva.

In this world, no one but Sydney Ginn herself knew that she had died once tonight.

If the Resident, after killing her, had never gone to melt the candle—had never altered the history of their encounter with Anthony—then she would have remained on the cold floor of the underground exhibition hall forever, slowly becoming part of the Nest.

As though something thick and black seized her bones and gave them a shake, Sydney Ginn shuddered faintly.

She walked toward the candle, step by step, her sneakers making soft, faint sounds against the floor.

Since none of the history the Resident had copied had ever taken place, the candle before her had naturally never been touched—it was cool and firm beneath her fingers; in the shadow it cast, the fire groove stayed silent.

2026.5.19—a row of small characters rose from the surface of the candle.

Sydney Ginn yanked her hand back as though she'd been shocked.

After a pause, she let out a bitter laugh. Those two lines of memory had really done a number on her nerves.

Even though the only reason she was alive today was this very candle, the Resident's reckless melting and rewriting of history had shaken her deeply—after all, the Resident hadn't melted the candle in order to save her; if Sydney Ginn were to rashly thrust her own hand into history, who could say what unintended consequences might follow?

Which meant the candle was something she could neither take away nor use without anxiety...

Sydney Ginn sighed and, after thinking it over for a moment, decided to leave it alone for now.

Honestly, looking at the candle inevitably called to mind the Resident who had copied her form; it was better to let her feelings settle first and figure out what to do with it later.

Besides, a candle that size wasn't going anywhere—if someone truly managed to move a several-dozen-meter-long candle out of a windowless underground exhibition hall with narrow stairs, then Sydney Ginn would simply have to admit defeat.

She picked up her trail pack from the floor, patted the phone in her pocket, and confirmed everything was there except the hunting knife.

In this current timeline, the hunting knife had been in Anthony's hands all along; and after watching it sink into "her own" throat, Sydney Ginn no longer had much desire to take it back.

Anthony...

Only her hatred for him had grown sharper and more solid—she wanted it to become a weapon and drive it straight through his gut. The Resident was already gone; all of Sydney Ginn's

fury now locked onto the stalker.

Before she stepped into the elevator, she glanced back at the enormous candle in the distance.

"...That little detour is over," she murmured to herself.

Now it was back to the original plan—head to Ninety-Ninth Street, get the Artifact there, and then deal with Anthony swiftly and cleanly once she was back. This time, Sydney Ginn was not going to let herself get distracted halfway and wander off course again.

Once she was out of the Museum of Modern Art, she realized that being copied by a Resident hadn't been entirely a loss.

She had originally braced herself for nearly two days of walking before she would reach Ninety-Ninth Street.

That two-day journey was, when you stripped it down, only fifteen kilometers—it was just that the roads in the Nest were treacherous, full of unexpected dangers at every turn, and Hopscotch was a prime example of that.

But now, because she had hitched a ride in the taxi, she had cut a large portion of that distance and avoided the dangers and traps along the way; and with a bit of luck thrown in to balance out the misfortune, Sydney Ginn found herself, half an hour later, already standing at Ninety-Ninth Street.

Standing beneath the street sign, she scanned her surroundings first, then pulled out her phone for a quick check.

November 17th, 2:12 AM.

She had entered the Nest the evening of the 16th, before ten o'clock.

After listening to the full broadcast, she had been stuck on Colorado Avenue by Hopscotch for quite some time—roughly estimating, she must have been copied by the "Vulture" Resident sometime after midnight.

By rights, a Vulture Resident should only be able to take on someone's form after that person had died, yet tonight Hopscotch had seemed to hand it an opportunity on a platter, somehow letting it copy her while she was still alive...

No, no—that was all from the previous memory line. In the current timeline, she had escaped the fate of being copied.

The Vulture Resident had lost its target; for all she knew, it was still wandering Colorado Avenue right now.

Let it go—it was done—Sydney Ginn pushed down the unsettling images rising in her mind and pulled her attention back to the present.

Beneath the dim black sky, a staircase descended without a sound into the earth, swallowed by a pool of darkness.

At the top of the staircase stood a sign printed with the letter "D," marking this as the entrance to a D Line subway station. Looking down from the sidewalk, the darkness below looked like solidified ink—your gaze would simply snap at its surface.

Sydney Ginn remembered how, the first time she had seen this staircase leading down to the subway station, she had hesitated for quite a while before she could bring herself to go down.

She took out her phone, turned on the flashlight, and shone it against the side wall of the staircase first.

Where the name of the station should have been written, there were only large, uneven black characters slanting across the wall: "Go down for a surprise."

Yes—those were still the words.

Good. Those words meant it was safe.

November was an odd-numbered month; in every odd-numbered month, the characters at this subway entrance read "Go down for a surprise," and in every even-numbered month, they changed to "Go down for a hug."

When it said "surprise," you could go down into the station—it was not only safe, but you could also retrieve an Artifact. The Nest could be unexpectedly honest at times. But when it said "hug," you must never go down under any circumstances.

Sydney Ginn still had no idea what would happen if you went down when it said "hug," and she hoped she would never find out.

She held up her flashlight and descended the stairs step by step, passed through the broken and damaged fare gates, and arrived on a platform lit by only a handful of scattered white lights.

Most of the platform was dim and murky—a wall on one side, and a wall on the other.

Sydney Ginn had only ever been to this one subway station inside the Nest, so she didn't know whether all Nest subway stations were like this—no tracks, no trains, both sides of the platform sealed off by walls.

In the middle of the platform, several people turned their heads toward her.

"Hunter," said one of them, a person wearing a baseball cap, before losing interest and looking away again.

"Yes," Sydney Ginn answered, lowering her phone's flashlight slightly so it wouldn't shine in anyone's face. "Why are there so many people here today?"

There were four people in the middle of the platform, all Hunters; judging by the distance between them, they seemed to be in two separate pairs.

Sydney Ginn had come here several times and knew this place wasn't exactly unknown among Hunters—quite a few people made periodic trips here to retrieve Artifacts.

Because of the regular traffic, an order had naturally formed: Hunters typically went by first-come-first-served, took what they came for, and left without interfering with each other. Even so, this was her first time seeing four people gathered here at once.

"Look," said a woman with a gentle face, tilting her chin forward. "Your timing is perfect—you caught the vending machine restocking."

Every transition chapter has to cost me a layer of skin; you wouldn't believe how long this one took me...

I'll say something a little shameless: I feel like the Artifact Report isn't the kind of story you can skim through at speed, because I'm burying information in every single chapter... which is also why I write it so, so slowly.

Chapter 44: Sydney Ginn Buys Things and Of Course She Pays for Them

Beneath a mop of unruly short hair, a smooth expanse of bare skin looked up to meet Sydney Ginn's gaze.

She managed to suppress the urge to suck in a sharp breath just in time.

Slight, smooth hollows beneath the brow seemed to serve as its eye sockets; it had no nostrils and no mouth. As it spoke, beneath the seamless expanse where a nose should have been, a bulge of skin kept pushing outward with each word — always making her worry that it would balloon too high, then snap back and crumple into folds, and from the center of those folds a dark hole would cave inward.

Sydney Ginn sometimes really disliked her own imagination.

"So many customers today," the skin-bulge pulsed rhythmically as it spoke, "no rush, it'll be loaded up in just a moment. Got quite a few new items in today."

As it spoke, it was slotting several cans of drinks into the dim interior of the vending machine.

When the soft-featured female Hunter had said "the vending machine is being restocked," Sydney Ginn hadn't imagined it would be a Resident doing the restocking.

The four of them had formed a semicircle that happened to block from view the Resident crouched on the ground — which was what had startled her. Now that Sydney Ginn stepped closer for a better look, she found the restocking process actually resembled the real thing quite well: several boxes were arranged beside the Resident, some empty, some still half-full; it was loading cans into the vending machine one by one.

Sometimes the Nest really did insist on "realism" in the strangest places — rather than fussing over loading drinks one can at a time, shouldn't it first do something about that face?

The baseball-cap wearer's companion was a girl chewing gum, who at this moment had even struck up a conversation with the Resident: "How often do you restock? How come I've never seen you before?"

"Depends on how well things sell," the Resident answered every question without hesitation. "The last few months' stock wasn't moving, so there was no need to restock, which is why I haven't been here."

The last few months... Sydney Ginn thought about it — she had come by and checked, and the selection really had been mediocre, pretty useless stuff.

Inside the vending machine at this subway station, every so often, Artifacts with different functions would appear — every can of drink, every packet of snacks, was an Artifact with its own distinct function and varying expiration date. Whether you could find something suitable was largely a matter of luck.

"What new stock do you have today?" the soft-featured female Hunter asked.

"Oh, quite a lot," the Resident said warmly. "The supplier changed — more than half are new products! I've put up the new product descriptions too, have a look and you'll know what's what."

The product descriptions it had just posted covered an entire wall.

The five of them exchanged glances; the baseball-cap wearer stepped forward first, announced "we got here first," and walked over to shine a flashlight on the product descriptions, reading carefully.

The gum-chewing girl stood right beside the vending machine, also holding her spot at the front; the other three maintained a few paces' distance from the two of them, as was the custom when buying soda Artifacts.

"All done,"

Under the expectant gaze of all five, the Resident finally closed the vending machine — not only producing a key to lock it, but picking up the empty cardboard boxes from the ground as well. "I'm off."

The gum-chewing girl smiled sweetly and gave it a wave: "Thank you, bye-bye."

Such a cordial exchange between Resident and Hunter — Sydney Ginn hadn't seen one of those in quite a while.

That thought had barely settled when the Resident, halfway out the door, stopped in its tracks, cardboard boxes in hand, and turned to look back at the group.

It was still standing there even after the baseball-cap wearer finished reading the descriptions and the gum-chewing girl took her turn.

When Sydney Ginn couldn't help herself and stole a quick glance at it, the skin on the Resident's face gave a single pulse.

"...Oh, I just remembered — the company is running a promotion, inviting lucky customers to try out new products. You can take a free sample."

Sydney Ginn quickly looked away and shifted one step closer to the soft-featured female Hunter.

The gum-chewing girl seemed to suddenly lose her hearing, studying the product descriptions with complete focus; not one person turned their head toward the Resident.

"Anyone want to come?"

No one moved, no one looked at it, no one spoke.

"No one?"

All five Hunters seemed to hold their breath; the baseball-cap wearer stood before the vending machine, shoulders drawn up tight.

"Really no one? You know, opportunity knocks but once—"

The skin on the Resident's face gave a soft *pop* and bulged outward right next to Sydney Ginn's ear. "—and never knocks twice."

She swallowed back a scream rising in her throat, eyes fixed hard on the floor, with no idea when the Resident had gotten so close.

You cannot respond — any competent Artifact Hunter would realize, in that moment, that responding was absolutely out of the question.

The other four, like Sydney Ginn, had presumably never encountered a "restocking Resident" before and didn't know how to handle it.

But in those brief few exchanges, everyone had clearly reached the same conclusion and taken the same course of action — because Hunters, drawing on experience and instinct, must probe and judge within a split second.

After its first invitation, the five of them falling silent without any prior agreement was itself a "probe."

Wait and watch — in most situations, that is the safest way to probe.

Its next line, "No one?", made it clear that the restocking Resident interpreted no answer as a refusal — and all five Hunters picked up on that immediately.

Conversely, if its next line had been "Everyone's interested?", the five Hunters would have instantly realized it interpreted no answer as consent; in that case, staying silent would of course be out of the question, and an immediate denial would be necessary.

The Nest and its Residents, for all their treachery and unpredictability, still left open a sliver of possibility for analysis, judgment, and action — and it was precisely that sliver which had kept the profession of Artifact Hunter alive for so long.

"Ah, what a pity."

The words seeped out through that expanse of skin and settled deep into the hair at the back of the gum-chewing girl's head.

From Sydney Ginn's angle, she could see the Resident standing right behind her; that featureless face was craning forward, pressing into the girl's hair. She still had no idea when it had moved there.

"Alright then, I really am leaving this time. Anyone want to exchange phone numbers with me?"

Within a single Resident, there is often a consistent internal logic to its behavior.

A Resident that treats silence as a refusal on one question is unlikely to suddenly treat silence as consent on the very next — and in the breathless silence of all five, the restocking Resident seemed to leave with some reluctance, disappearing step by step into the shadows of the subway station entrance.

Several seconds passed before Sydney Ginn finally let out the long breath she had been holding in her chest.

"That scared me,"

The other four relaxed as well; the girl started chewing her gum again and said, "I actually thought it was one of the harmless Residents."

"How long have you been doing this?" the man who had said nothing until now immediately lectured her. "Don't you know Residents can be dangerous at any moment? It only comes down to whether they feel like coming after you or not. You were just chatting away with it!"

"And how long have you been at it? Have you even hit a year?"

The girl walked back from the product descriptions and stood beside her tall, slender companion, looking at him out of the corner of her eye. "Do you know why I thought it was a harmless Resident? Do you know what the characteristics of harmless Residents are? Always eager to teach — is there a school paying you a salary for this?"

"Hold on, no need to argue," the soft-featured female Hunter, seeing the two of them on the verge of a fight, quickly raised both hands to placate them: "It's not a matter of principle, and besides, the danger has passed. Didn't I talk to it too?"

"You did, and you were wrong too." The man wasn't buying his companion's mediation.

"Who died and made you judge?" The girl flicked her hand, and suddenly layers of massive muscle swelled up along her left arm, filling her sleeve to bursting. "Watch your mouth next time."

"M&M Beans?" The man glanced at her arm and let out a cold laugh. "Which House Faction are you from? You think you're the only one who's bought M&M Beans?"

M&M Beans were one of the vending machine's products — the name was an abbreviation, the full name being "Machine Muscle." The purpose was self-evident from the name alone; simple, but effective.

They were popular among Hunters, especially female Hunters, though stock was rarely available. The most inconvenient part was that once taken out of the Nest, they would expire within twenty-four hours.

The fact that the girl had M&M Beans on her indicated at least one thing: she had a place within the Nest to stash belongings — not particularly surprising, as most House Factions had a hiding spot.

"Listen to me,"

Sydney Ginn stepped forward and positioned herself between the two of them, feeling she had no choice but to smooth things over — these two had only clashed over a few words, with no real grudge between them; all they needed was a way to back down gracefully. Actually coming to blows in a place like this would do neither of them any good.

"Actually, neither of you is wrong. I just noticed tonight that the Residents have been acting a bit strange lately."

Everyone looked at her.

The baseball-cap wearer finished choosing, pressed in the product number, and asked, "What do you mean?"

"You all know the 'Vulture' Resident, right? I just ran into it."

She wanted to smooth things over, but that was perhaps just a pretext; what Sydney Ginn truly wanted was to use the Vulture incident to gauge the other Hunters' reactions and see if anyone had additional information to add.

What she wanted most of all was to pour out everything she had been through to companions who were flesh and blood and could understand what she had experienced — but she couldn't expose the existence of the Candlefall Artifact, and she feared drawing suspicion onto herself.

"Impossible,"

The moment Sydney Ginn finished speaking, the man rendered his verdict immediately. "You can't die, so the Vulture can't take your form — that's common knowledge."

"Which is exactly why I said their behavior is abnormal." Sydney Ginn was getting a little irritated too. "If you don't believe me, go check Colorado Avenue and see if there's a chalk-drawn hopscotch grid."

The man said nothing, brow furrowed.

"The changes and anomalies appearing in the Nest recently have been more numerous and more frequent than before."

It was the first time the baseball-cap wearer had said anything that long, and only then did Sydney Ginn suddenly realize that the person was a woman.

She stood at least six feet tall, with broad, level shoulders and a head of short hair; her appearance wasn't easy to read at a glance, and her voice was a full register lower than that of most women.

"I imagine this isn't any of your first times buying from the vending machine."

The baseball-cap wearer gently tossed the soda in her hand into the air and caught it again. "Generally speaking, what do you all think this Artifact is worth?"

"Five hundred dollars?" Sydney Ginn guessed.

Things from the vending machine tended to be like that: you paid for them with real-world money, the price was never cheap, the function was singular, the power modest, and the expiration

date startlingly short.

That was precisely why Artifact Hunters hadn't turned into soda couriers shuttling between Blackmoor City and the Nest.

"That was roughly the price before." The baseball-cap wearer smiled, and a long, narrow dimple sank into the clean lower half of her face. "I just paid by credit card — this one can of soda ran me over nine thousand dollars. But it was worth it."

The moment she finished speaking, the soft-featured female Hunter immediately strode over to the product descriptions; her flashlight swept two circles across the wall, and she drew in a low, sharp breath.

Since getting home, she hadn't slept a single good night, surviving each day purely on coffee and tea. Without caffeine, there would be no way to gather fake money in the world. Caffeine is my father, caffeine is my mother, without caffeine, there would be no ne—

That was a close one, damn.

Oh, speaking of which, there's something I keep forgetting to mention—friends, I've finally figured out what flavor of chips the Puppeteer is! (Yes, the reason I didn't say before is because I didn't think any flavor suited him.)

Want to know? To find out, please call our hotline at 25115222. Free consultation, five yuan per minute. Remember: 25115222.

Chapter 45: Sydney Ginn Pays Taxes and Launderers Money

The two groups who had already finished their purchases still hadn't left, each standing far apart on the dim platform, talking in low voices.

Even without hearing what they were saying, Sydney Ginn could guess the gist of it.

They were all House Faction Hunters; for a House Faction, this product description sheet had completely changed the meaning of the vending machine.

Artifact Hunters risked their lives to enter the Nest — when you stripped it down, it was all for one thing: money.

The vending machine had been overlooked before because its products had weak effects and heavy restrictions, with little potential profit to speak of — take M&M Beans, for instance: they expired twenty-four hours after leaving the Nest, so who would pay a fortune for something essentially disposable? Even selling it at cost price meant you had connections to spare and a circle full of suckers desperate enough to bite.

The vending machine's product restrictions still existed now — if anything, they were even more absurd than before — but even Sydney Ginn, with no House Faction to her name, could see at a glance that the potential returns were in a completely different league.

What a shame, though — that only held true for House Factions.

She swept her flashlight over the product descriptions twice and found the image of a blue plastic-bottle drink.

The soft-featured female Hunter had finished reading the description and, without a word, bought a bottle of water right then and there, immediately smothering it and shoving it into her backpack; it was only Sydney Ginn's sharp eyes that let her track that flash of blue and identify what the woman had bought.

Gatorade sports drink 500ml

Everyone knows that the threshold between life and death is like a door — on this side is the human world / the Nest, and once you step through, you either go up to heaven or down to hell.

(Just kidding — how could humans possibly go to heaven, hahaha)

In real life, people don't always march cleanly through that door between life and death — all kinds of unexpected things can happen that leave a person hovering on the edge. For example, getting hit by a car, a sudden stroke, a gunshot wound... in situations like these, you might find that between life and death, there's actually a precious window of time for emergency treatment.

Think of it as one foot in the door and one foot out — surely you'd want the human-world side to hold on to you just a little longer?

If that window is longer, it gives doctors more time to fight for you, and you might just make it; if it's too short and that window closes, you're destined to end up with lividity spots.

This sports drink is specially suited for those hovering on the edge of life and death — it's like launching an assault on death's door! Remarkable! It can't bring the dead back to life, but it can buy you a little extra emergency time — as long as fluid can still be safely administered, every 1ml consumed adds 3 seconds.

Disclaimer: This product has the effect of extending emergency response time, but does not guarantee that resuscitation will succeed. Please defer to the attending emergency physician or surgeon for specific assessments.

Post-Nest expiry: 4 hours

Price: \$38,000

Flavor: Blue-Green Lividity

Thirty-eight thousand dollars for an Artifact with only a four-hour shelf life — for a solo operator or a small House Faction, it was a guaranteed losing venture. Without the network, intelligence, manpower, and logistical support of a major House Faction, simply finding a client willing to trust you completely was already next to impossible, and beyond that lay an even bigger problem.

How would you even deliver it?

Say a client found themselves in mortal danger, and their representative urgently contacted you at that moment, demanding the Gatorade Artifact within ten minutes.

A solo operator would first have to enter the Nest through their passage, rush to a cache or the vending machine, retrieve the Artifact, then open a passage back to Blackmoor City — by the time they got back, the client would already be in the ground.

But for a major House Faction, it was a different story entirely.

Sydney Ginn didn't know the specific operational procedures and methods; but she had heard bits and pieces that might offer a glimpse of the whole picture — when major House Factions ran into time-critical situations, they dispatched helicopters.

The thought made Sydney Ginn glance back involuntarily at the two shadows still bent in whispered conversation at the far end of the platform. They had bought so decisively — the House Faction behind them must be sizable, with no trouble moving product; the cards they used to pay were almost certainly the House Faction's.

Ah, how nice, she thought, turning back with a glum expression.

Her own credit card didn't even have a limit of thirty-six thousand — though Sydney Ginn had earned decent money from her broadcasts, when it came to this particular problem, she couldn't help but envy the advantages of a House Faction: all her income was under the table, nothing she could put on the books, nothing that could become a personal asset, nothing that did a thing for her credit score.

House Faction Hunters were a different matter, though.

Their income came from the House Faction itself and could be labeled as wages, bonuses, dividends, commissions, allowances, reimbursements — not only completely above board, but they could even pay a token amount of taxes, just enough to keep the IRS off their backs.

And what about the House Faction's income?

"As for me," Amber had explained to Sydney Ginn once, plainly and matter-of-factly, "aside from doing accounting and finance, I also have to handle money laundering for the House Faction."

Sydney Ginn let out another long sigh.

She had spotted what she wanted to buy long ago.

But the reason she hadn't rushed over to buy it yet — standing here like a fool, turning over the problems of money laundering and tax filing in her head — was, apart from her own tendency to zone out and let her thoughts wander, one critical thing: her credit card limit was maxed out.

Sydney Ginn looked left and right, her gaze settling on the soft-featured female Hunter, then, after two seconds, drifting back to the two with the baseball caps, who were sitting on the stairs

talking.

Worth a try, she told herself, steeling her nerves — asking doesn't cost anything. The worst they can say is no, right?

As she walked to the foot of the stairs, one of the baseball caps looked up.

"Something you need?"

Sydney Ginn had a nagging suspicion she might be making a fool of herself right now. "Um... if you don't mind me asking, are you two House Faction Hunters?"

The gum-chewing girl gave a nod and said, "Yeah, why?"

She seemed quite fond of the baseball cap one — now that her left arm had recovered, the two of them were sitting shoulder to shoulder, and they looked considerably closer than the other pair.

"I'm a solo operator, no House Faction." Sydney Ginn cleared her throat and said, "Um... the vending machine — I haven't bought anything yet. I've got my eye on something that would be really useful to me, and I can't afford to wait; I need to get my hands on it right away."

The two looked at her, waiting for her to continue.

Backed into a corner, she steeled herself and pressed on: "But I don't have enough credit left on my card... would you be willing to swipe yours for me? I have money in my debit account, but the card doesn't have a contactless chip — the vending machine can't read it..."

Here they were, deep inside the Nest — a place about as far from reality as you could get — and yet the problem she was describing was about as mundane and petty as it gets. Sydney Ginn had the distinct sense that something about this was off.

Afraid they'd misunderstand, she quickly added: "I do have cash — I'm not flat broke!"

In the shadow of the baseball cap, a long, narrow dimple suddenly appeared on that half-visible face. "You have cash on you?"

Sydney Ginn was overcome with despair. "No, the cash is in Blackmoor City..."

"So you're asking to borrow money?" The baseball cap's grin widened further, a flash of white teeth gleaming in the dimness.

"When you put it that way... yeah, it, it does seem like that..."

The gum-chewing girl stopped chewing, mouth half open as she stared at Sydney Ginn — she had probably never been asked to lend money to a stranger inside the Nest before.

Sydney Ginn felt the situation was getting a bit out of hand, and stammered, "I mean, of course, I could always come back in again, but my passage — ah, that's not convenient to explain..."

The baseball cap suddenly burst into laughter.

When the laughter died down, she lifted off her cap, reached up, and ran her hand through her wavy short hair, tilting her face upward into the dim platform light.

This was the first time Sydney Ginn had gotten a clear look at her face, and she was briefly, momentarily transfixed.

Though she was probably also in her twenties, she had the look of a youth of indeterminate gender; behind the tousled waves of hair were a pair of deep-set, narrow blue eyes — clear as the sky reflected between Arctic icebergs.

The gum-chewing girl glanced at Sydney Ginn, shrugged, and murmured the expression on her face into words: "I knew it."

"What?" Sydney Ginn snapped back to reality, her embarrassment doubled. "Never mind, it's fine — I'll just come back in again. I mean, if it were me, I wouldn't lend money to a stranger so easily either..."

The baseball cap one — she had taken the cap off now, but Sydney Ginn still didn't know her name — stood up and pulled a wallet from her back pocket.

"My driver's license and my card," she said, holding up two cards and addressing Sydney Ginn: "Give me your driver's license, your credit card, and your phone."

"Oh? You need the phone too?"

"Of course. How do I know the ID you're carrying is real?"

The gum-chewing girl nodded vigorously in agreement: "These days, the only things you absolutely have to get back — besides your own kid — is your phone."

The baseball cap's demands were reasonable: the driver's license went without saying, of course she needed to know who she was lending money to. The credit card served as extra

collateral, in case Sydney Ginn didn't pay her back or ended up dead in the Nest; and besides, she was asking for the phone, not the passcode.

Sydney Ginn hesitated for a long moment before she finally handed over her phone as well.

The baseball cap looked down at the phone screen as it lit up, and in the glow of the screen, that clean face paused. She looked at the hundred-odd filthy messages still frozen on the screen, expression blank, said nothing, and slipped the phone into her trouser pocket.

For some reason, Sydney Ginn felt a shame like being stripped of her clothes.

"This is my address and number," she said, seeming to have already forgotten about the messages — she wrote Sydney Ginn a note, then asked, "Is there anything on your phone you need to write down? Like a phone number?"

Anthony's number was already engraved in her memory; Sydney Ginn shook her head.

"Sydney Ginn, right?" The baseball cap looked at the driver's license, then looked at her, and smiled. "Not often you see an ID photo that actually looks as good as the person."

Sydney Ginn thanked the two of them repeatedly for a while, and they exchanged a few necessary details. Throughout the whole process, she felt as though she were drifting through clouds in a daze, unable to believe she had actually borrowed a card from strangers — strangers, in the Nest of all places?

She couldn't bring herself to look at the baseball cap's driver's license the whole time; it wasn't until Sydney Ginn had walked back to the vending machine that she quietly snuck a glance at it.

London Moon — even the name was androgynous.

Sydney Ginn took a deep breath, dragged her attention back to the vending machine, punched in a few numbers, then pressed the credit card against the reader.

A notification flashed on the screen confirming a successful charge of \$12,000; with a thunk, a can of soda tumbled into the dispensing slot below.

Sydney Ginn reached in and picked it up, tucking it into her backpack.

She straightened up and turned her head — and found herself meeting London Moon's gaze.

She hadn't hidden the can of soda, and it was the only purple item; under the light of the vending machine, the purple was vivid and unmistakable. Anyone who had read the product

descriptions would know that the purple soda had only one function.

Killing.

How did I discover Puppeteer Master chips? A coworker in Shenzhen told me there was an imported chip at the Oley supermarket — the best chips she'd ever eaten in her life. Of course I was curious, so she gave me two bags.

They really were good. Whether they're the best is still up for debate, but one of the flavors — when you ate it — actually had the texture of popping candy in your mouth!

I looked it up: it was the "bubbly serrano chilli" flavor. Translated, isn't that basically "bouncy little spicy pepper"?!

I still have the photo on my phone — I'm wondering if I should post it in the comments section of Doomsday...

Chapter 46: Sydney Ginn's Grape Soda

The most precious thing in the world is whatever can pull a life back from the edge of death.

Even if it costs millions, there's never a shortage of people willing to pay; even the slightest increase in the chance of survival draws people rushing over—like that bottle of sports drink.

But erasing a person's life is cheap.

The things that kill people are rarely worth much.

Sydney Ginn glanced once more at the purple can of soda in her hand.

If all she wanted was to kill someone, a knife would do just fine—and if she couldn't do it herself, twelve thousand dollars was more than enough to hire someone who would.

But using methods from the real world meant bearing the real world's risks and consequences, and Blackmoor City was, after all, a society with rules and laws. What if someone traced Anthony's death or disappearance back to her?

Not even the Nest's Residents had managed to catch her—it would be rather too ironic if she ended up in a real-world prison.

She needed to handle this cleanly, without leaving so much as a trace of suspicion on herself—she still had plenty of money and plenty of life left to enjoy.

The true reason this can of soda was so valuable wasn't simply that it could cause a person's death—if she were being honest, she wasn't even certain whether what it caused could really be called death.

But she was certain of one thing: using an Artifact to deal with Anthony would leave her with no loose ends.

As Sydney stared at the soda in a daze, the small print on the bottom ticked from "Countdown: 6 hours 25 minutes" to "Countdown: 6 hours 24 minutes."

It had a total effective window of only eight hours, and she'd already burned through an hour and a half; what annoyed her most was that after those first few calls, she'd spent the rest of the time doing nothing but waiting.

Had Anthony been thrown off, not expecting her to reach out to him on her own?

Just as that thought crossed her mind, the disposable phone she'd bought earlier buzzed to life on the table. Sydney swept a glance at the screen and snatched it up immediately. "Anthony?"

There was a second of silence on the other end.

Then the voice spoke, casual as if nothing were the matter: "Ah, it really is you."

"Of course it's me—didn't I leave you a voicemail?"

"You suddenly said your phone was lost and told me to call this number—that's pretty suspicious." Anthony's speech was unhurried, but his voice and tone carried something like a rodent sniffing the air in the shadows. "...When did you lose it?"

Sydney thought for a moment and named a time before he'd plastered her number all over those adult websites. "Yesterday morning."

Anthony paused.

When he spoke again, his tone had warmed a degree: "What made you suddenly reach out to me? It's been so long..."

"Can we meet in person?" Sydney asked, cutting straight to it. "At the bar where we first met?"

Choosing a public place was to put Anthony at ease about showing up—he'd almost certainly worry she'd brought people along to rough him up.

"Is something the matter?" The harasser was, predictably, fairly cautious.

In that moment, Sydney summoned the spirit of every female lead from every romance film she'd ever seen in her life and mimicked their light, earnest voices: "I... I didn't like how we ended things. I feel like there's still some room between us—it doesn't have to come to this. Whatever you want, we can sit down and talk it over..."

Could there really be women that foolish in this world?

After being bombarded with calls in the dead of night, subjected to endless insults and curses, and threatened with "I'll have you killed," could anyone truly be dim enough to sit down and have a civilized talk with her harasser?

Sydney didn't think so—but Anthony seemed to think otherwise. Or at the very least, he hoped Sydney was.

"Right now?" There was something restless and eager in Anthony's voice that made her skin crawl even through the phone. "I'd need at least an hour before I could get away..."

Sydney said through her teeth, "No problem. I'll wait for you."

She hung up, set the phone and the purple can of soda side by side on the table in front of her, and stared at them for a long moment.

From the table next to hers, a group of men and women drinkers suddenly erupted in loud laughter; they seemed to be colleagues out for a drink after work, and they raised their glasses, clinking them together in midair.

The waitress came over to the table with a smile. "How's it going? Is the person you're waiting for on their way?"

"Still a little while." Sydney pulled a few Franklin-faced bills from her wallet and handed them over along with the purple can of soda. "Just like we discussed—when he gets here, I'll leave it in your hands."

The waitress stared at the cash, clearly startled by the size of the tip, and looked almost like she didn't believe it. "Are you sure?"

Sydney leaned slowly back against her chair and smiled at her.

"...I'm sure."

It was nearing nine o'clock, and the bar was gradually filling up.

The smell of alcohol in the air mingled with perfume and the tobacco smoke that drifted in every time the door opened, diffusing in the haze of the lights.

When the countdown had dwindled to 3 hours and 41 minutes and Sydney was starting to consider whether to fall back on her contingency plan, Anthony finally pushed open the bar door—his gaze swept the room, found his target quickly, but he didn't come over right away.

He stood at the entrance, looking over every customer in the place first, then sauntered over at his own pace and dropped into the seat across from Sydney.

"You look exhausted," he said, opening with what appeared to be concern. "Things not going well lately? I haven't been sleeping either—I think about you all the time."

Sydney considered herself reasonably worldly, but faced with this kind of shamelessness that was completely without self-awareness, she was still too astonished to find any words.

"You know," Anthony said, knocking on the table with one hand, "I called your lost phone before I came."

Before Sydney could react, he had already said with righteous conviction: "Just like I thought—someone picked it up. If you pick up someone else's phone, how can you not return it?"

"Wait—someone answered?" Sydney asked quickly.

"Yeah, a guy," Anthony said.

London Moon's voice was lower than most women's, which had apparently led him to that conclusion. Still, the fact that she'd answered the phone meant that London Moon and the others had made it back to Blackmoor City.

"I told him, 'How much do you want to give my girlfriend's phone back?'"

The feeling Sydney had at that moment was like visiting a socialite's home, taking off her shoes at the door, and discovering she was wearing a sock with a hole in the toe.

"She—he, what did he say?" She scrubbed her face with her hand and asked.

She had come here today to kill someone, and yet right now she wanted nothing more than to hang herself from the ceiling first.

"You wouldn't believe how greedy he was!" Anthony was indignant. "'Twelve thousand, and I'll give it back to her'—can you believe that? I got angry right then and wanted to threaten him a little, scare him..."

"...And then?"

"The guy laughed and hung up." Anthony leaned in as he said it, as if to reassure her: "Don't worry—if you need me to, I'll keep calling to get your phone back."

Sydney lowered her head, paused for a few seconds, then sat up straight again.

Before responding, she raised her hand toward the waitress in a brief signal, then let her gaze settle on Anthony's face.

Like examining some newly discovered insect, she watched him and said quietly, "Right—calling people relentlessly really is your specialty, isn't it."

If Anthony had pushed back or flared up in embarrassed rage, that would at least have shown he had some sense of shame.

He only blinked, then smiled and said, "I knew you'd hold a grudge. I'll admit—I did go too far... because I've never cared this much about anyone before."

The waitress came over carrying a tray and set a glass filled with ice in front of each of them.

With a hiss, she pulled the tab on the soda can and poured half of it into the glass in front of Sydney; thick white foam floated on top of the purple liquid.

Just as she was about to pour some for Anthony as well, he reached out and covered his glass with his hand.

"Your soda?" Anthony looked at the purple can on the tray and gestured for the waitress to set it down. He picked it up and turned it over in his hands a few times, then said to Sydney, "I've never seen this brand before... you always have the strangest things."

Though he was reluctant to admit it, Anthony had a kind of instinct—and it was precisely that instinct that had let him single Sydney out from a whole bar full of people.

"It's imported," Sydney said, not wanting the Artifact in his hands any longer than necessary. She held out her hand and said, "It's quite good—want to try?"

"No thanks, you have it." Anthony pushed the can back toward her, then turned to the waitress. "A gin and tonic for me."

Sydney kept her expression neutral and nudged the can to one side, as if it were nothing important.

When the gin and tonic arrived, Anthony finally spoke again. "You came to find me today..."

"There are a few things I wanted to say to you."

Anthony took a sip of his drink and made no move to ask what she wanted to say. He glanced at the glass of soda and said, "Go ahead and drink—didn't you say you liked it?"

Sydney looked down at the soda and raised the glass to her lips.

Anthony held his own glass, watching her over the rim; she parted her lips and let the cold liquid slide down her throat and into her stomach.

The moment she swallowed, Anthony seemed to relax. He watched the level in the glass drop and smiled. "I'll try some in a bit—haven't seen this brand. What did you want to say?"

Sydney set down the glass and said slowly, "You have a mental disorder."

Anthony's face went cold in an instant.

"I don't know whether it's a genetic defect you were born with, or whether the circumstances you grew up in made you into a deviant. Maybe no one has ever said this to you before—but I'm going to tell you today: you are scum.

"You think the world owes you something—women especially. You think it's unfair, that others have taken what's rightfully yours. Why do I have money when you don't? Why won't I be with you? For someone as narcissistic as you, rejection is the gravest of insults... and so you do everything in your power to harass and retaliate against me—but you're too cowardly and pathetic to do anything more than post my number on some website."

Anthony stiffened, his face flushing red.

Sydney smiled slightly, lifted her glass, and drained the soda in one go. "What you get today is exactly what you deserve."

"What?" he asked blankly.

"I'm leaving," Sydney said, rising and stepping out from her side of the table.

"Wait," Anthony immediately jumped to his feet and reached out to grab her arm. "Finish what you were—"

In the moment he drew close, Sydney gently blew a breath of air into his face.

A rich, heavy scent of grape billowed between them.

"People are watching," she said softly. "What do you think you're doing?"

Anthony let go reluctantly, as expected. His eyes drifted to Sydney's seat and landed on the handbag left there; his cheek muscles twitched into a smile, and he sat back down.

He'd misread the situation—Sydney was only going to the restroom.

She stood by the sink, neither using the toilet nor washing her hands, which drew the eye of a blonde woman nearby. The woman was a little drunk; she looked Sydney over and suddenly asked with a smile, "Why are you wearing rain boots?"

Sydney was in a good mood; she tapped the toes of her boots on the floor a few times like a tap dancer showing off a step, and answered with a smile, "The forecast says rain."

When she judged enough time had passed, she walked back out and returned to her table. The chair beside the table was empty—no one there.

The seat was soaking wet, a large patch of purple liquid dripping, dripping down onto the floor. A puddle had already collected on the ground, as if someone had accidentally knocked over a can of soda—or perhaps two.

Sydney Ginn stepped into the puddle, liquid splashing up onto her shoes. She bent down to pick up her bag, then grabbed the soda can from the table.

On her way out, she waved goodbye to the waitress.

"My friend had to head out early," she said with an apologetic smile. "I accidentally knocked over a drink just now..."

"No worries, don't give it a second thought!" the waitress said cheerfully. "I'll go mop it right up."

The part I was most proud of in yesterday's chapter, besides London Moon's name, was the gate-raid — has anyone figured out who its real-world counterpart is? It's Gatorade!

Ah, I need someone to play straight man to my jokes.

Chapter 47: The Strange Detail Sydney Ginn Had Overlooked

The last time she had seen London Moon was no more than a day ago; Sydney Ginn hadn't expected them to meet again so soon—in fact, it was barely half an hour after Anthony dissolved into soda.

Why?

Because, as the girl named Joy Jo had said, the only things worth ransoming these days were your own children—and your phone.

Sydney Ginn had no children, so all she could say was that without her phone, she felt like she'd truly lost a piece of her soul.

"Oh, you're calling in person this time?" London Moon laughed when the call connected.

There was no need to keep reminding her about the embarrassing thing, whether openly or in passing. Even without anyone reminding her, she could carry every cringeworthy memory for at least ten years—and they always came barging into her mind in the middle of the night, chasing away all sleep.

"I can pay you back now. Are you free tonight?"

London Moon was quiet for a second. "Where?"

Sydney Ginn gave her the address of the Between the Backlights bar, and heard London Moon say, "Not far from me."

She wanted to ask whether the other woman lived nearby, but was afraid she might take it as prying for intelligence on a Hunter, so she held back—and before she could say anything, London Moon added, "Just finished handing off with a client. I'll head over."

How nice—one trip into the Nest and they came back with money; meanwhile she'd done the same and come out twelve thousand in the hole.

Perhaps it was that thought hanging over her head like a storm cloud, occupying most of her attention; or perhaps it was knowing she was back in Blackmoor City and didn't need to stay on high alert anymore—whatever the reason, when she walked into Between the Backlights, she still hadn't realized she'd made a serious mistake.

"Don't move!"

A sharp shout hit her the moment she stepped through the door, jolting Sydney Ginn out of her skin.

She looked up to find that every Hunter in the bar had risen to their feet, every one of them staring at her with drawn, razor-edged tension; a few had even pressed a hand to their hip, clearly ready to draw.

"Wh—what's going on?"

Sydney Ginn froze mid-step, not daring to move, and swept her gaze around the bar in bewilderment. "What's wrong with all of you? What's wrong with me?"

It wasn't entirely true that everyone had stood—there was one person in the whole bar who remained seated at the counter, pulling her cap down low to muffle the soft laughter underneath it.

"What do you think you're doing?" The shar-pei-faced bartender raised a bottle, seemingly ready to hurl it as a weapon at any moment. "You walked in here with an Artifact in an active state. What's that supposed to mean?"

Sydney Ginn looked at the crowd, then looked down at the half-empty soda can in her hand, then looked back at the crowd, and the penny dropped.

"Oh, this—no—"

She panicked, started to put the soda down, and was immediately barked at with another "Don't move," so of course she froze again, and could only explain: "I wasn't going to hurt anyone with it—I did use it—but it has nothing to do with any of you, I wasn't going to use it on anyone here! I just forgot I was holding it. I've been carrying it the whole way."

Even though Artifacts look much like ordinary objects on the surface, when placed in front of experienced Hunters they would stir something like a sixth sense—especially an Artifact in an active state.

Only now did Sydney Ginn realize, belatedly, that what she'd just done probably carried the same energy as charging through an airport with a gun.

"...She's a regular," the bartender said hesitantly, lowering the bottle and addressing the room.

"Someone forgot they were carrying an Artifact?" A middle-aged man looked less than convinced.

London Moon finally saw fit to offer her support.

She slowly swiveled her stool around and said, "It's true. When she was buying the Artifact, she ran out of money and asked a complete stranger standing nearby to lend her some."

"How would you know?" A woman slowly moved her hand away from her hip, still not sitting back down.

"I was that stranger." London Moon gave Sydney Ginn a loose, unhurried wave. "Come on—pay me back."

Under the eyes of an entire bar full of Hunters, Sydney Ginn slunk over to the counter in a few quick, shame-faced steps—but the matter wasn't over yet.

Several Hunters who still weren't satisfied closed in from various distances, studying her and the soda can. "So how does that Artifact work? What does it do?"

It wasn't out of the question that they already knew and were just testing whether she'd tell the truth.

Not that Sydney Ginn had any intention of lying.

"After a few big mouthfuls, while you've got enough grape flavor in your mouth, blow a breath at the target's face as fast as you can."

"And then?"

"The target turns into grape soda." Sydney Ginn answered honestly, sitting down on a barstool. She lifted one rubber-boot-clad foot and pointed at it. "I thought for sure there'd be a huge volume of liquid—I even wore rain boots on purpose, see? Turns out it's only about a can or two worth."

"You just...killed someone?" a stranger Hunter asked.

"Watch what you say." Even in a room full of Hunters, Sydney Ginn wasn't about to admit that out loud. "All I said was I blew breath at the target. I never said anything about killing anyone."

At that, a few of the other Hunters actually seemed to relax somewhat; a few pairs of eyes drifted toward the soda can, with a faint glimmer in them.

"If someone turns into soda, other people would see it happen, wouldn't they?" an old man asked.

Sydney Ginn raised one finger. "No. After the breath is blown, it takes effect the first moment the target isn't being watched by any human eyes. It happens in an instant."

Clothes, shoes, phone—nothing is left behind—but that detail wasn't something she could say outright.

"How much is left?" Someone stepped two paces closer. "What's the expiration?"

"About half left, and the expiration—" Sydney Ginn suddenly realized what was happening. "Are you interested in buying it?"

Everyone present was a professional; even though the purple soda was an Artifact appearing for the first time, it took only about ten minutes to assess its value and function.

Considering the expiration was less than three hours away—the longer she waited, the less it would sell for—Sydney Ginn simply sold the remaining half-can to the first Hunter who made up their mind, and whatever else could be said about it, this trip had at least cut her losses by three or four thousand.

"I never drank from it directly," she said warmly, pocketing the money. "Drink up with confidence! It's pretty good—might be a little flat by now, though."

The Hunter gave her a look, his expression unreadable, and walked out the door quickly with the soda in hand.

"I hope you're not planning to scrape together the rest of what you owe me on the spot," London Moon said beside her.

"Of course not," Sydney Ginn turned around, but couldn't bring herself to meet her eyes, and rummaged in her bag with her head down before producing an envelope. "Twelve thousand. Count it."

The hand that took the envelope had slender, lean fingers with short, round, clear nails.

"...Do you have a strong objection to electronic transfers?" London Moon asked lightly, tapping the envelope.

"I haven't found anyone willing to launder money for me yet, so I keep cash at home." Sydney Ginn watched her seemingly capable hand and said, "If you know someone suitable, introduce

them to me."

For some reason, London Moon was always on the verge of laughing—when they first met, Sydney Ginn had thought she was a woman of few words.

Sydney Ginn had also assumed London Moon was the type to pocket the money without a glance, but to her surprise London Moon upended the bills onto the counter and slowly slipped them back into the envelope one by one.

"What are you doing?"

London Moon, without her cap, suddenly turned those eyes on her—eyes that were a startling blue, like a sky locked in Arctic ice, like a sea burning with polar cold, so clear they seemed as though they had never once fallen to earth.

All earthly things, even gender itself, seemed as though they should have nothing to do with London Moon; and yet there she sat with a banknote held between her fingers.

She looked at it carefully, tucked it away, and only then said, "...Seven. Of course I have to look properly. How would I know you haven't slipped in a counterfeit?"

Where would anyone even get counterfeit bills these days.

Sydney Ginn simply ordered her a drink and let her carry on as a human bill-counter in peace; London Moon smiled and said to the shar-pei-faced bartender, "By the way—it's her. She's the one who had a firsthand encounter with the Vulture."

Huh? The Vulture?

The bartender nodded and turned to Sydney Ginn, whose attention had immediately sharpened. "Just a few hours ago, I got word from a House Faction looking for information about the Vulture. You can call and tell him yourself—whatever compensation you want, that's negotiable too."

He wrote something on a slip of paper and handed it to Sydney Ginn.

"Chase Monroe?" She thought for a moment and said, "Never heard of him. Is he a Hunter? Which House Faction?"

The bartender stared at her for a second or two. "No, he's not a Hunter... You don't know who Chase Monroe is?"

"Should I?" Sydney Ginn was even more blank than he was.

"Never mind—you're not with any House Faction," the bartender volunteered the explanation on her behalf, waving a hand. "No need to know the people inside them. Just make sure you speak properly when the time comes and don't get on his bad side. If Chase Monroe is handling this personally, it must be important—otherwise it's usually Key House Faction Hunters who contact me."

"Key House Faction," London Moon interjected, though her tone gave nothing away. "...Thirty-one."

Important... Sydney Ginn turned that word over in her mind.

The Vulture Resident's behavior had been very abnormal, and it had grown dangerous—but in terms of importance, it didn't quite seem to rise to the level of needing a major figure from a House Faction to personally come asking around, especially given that, by the bartender's implication, this person was the second-in-command of Key House Faction.

What factor had made the Vulture so important?

Sydney Ginn glanced at the time on her phone—those hundred-plus messages had long since been cleared away, vanishing along with any trace of Anthony's existence—it was now November 18th, 10:23 PM.

She had encountered the Vulture Resident in the early hours of yesterday morning, and a House Faction was already asking about it today.

Marveling at just how well-informed a large House Faction could be, she thought: there was definitely more to the Vulture than she knew.

Had something happened recently in Hunter circles?

Sydney Ginn mulled it over for a while, then probed the bartender with a few indirect questions—but everything he could tell her was something she already knew. "Anything recent? Nothing particularly worth mentioning. The biggest thing has been Wellesley dying. The day it made the news, weren't you sitting right here?"

...Wellesley?

Sydney Ginn sat there with both hands wrapped around a plain cola she'd just ordered, mouth half-open, momentarily unable to believe she had managed to overlook something so glaring.

No, no—at that time she had just barely survived the ordeal of the real-and-fake Sydney Ginn crisis, her nerves still raw and her mind still scattered; it was perfectly normal to have missed it...

When she woke up on the museum floor, the Resident had been watching history inside the candle.

More precisely, it had been watching the history inside the candle that pertained to Wellesley.

But after it had copied her form, when it touched the candle, what appeared should have been Sydney Ginn's history—so why had Wellesley appeared?

And it had clearly been important; the Resident had watched with total absorption.

What connection did she have to Wellesley? What could Wellesley possibly have to do with her?

She would have to go back and look at the candle to find out, wouldn't she?

"What's wrong?" London Moon glanced at her. "You suddenly look very defeated."

"I... I might have to go back to the Nest again," Sydney Ginn said, and even just thinking about jumping off a building again, she could hear the blood draining from her face.

Wasn't there any way to do this without going back into the Nest, she thought, pressing her fingers hard against her temples.

The history that Resident had been watching at the time... it seemed to be from May.

Right—she remembered a long section of candle having melted into a lake-like pool of Candlefall; and in that "lake" not far from the Resident, there happened to be a fragment from the night she met Anthony, a clip of a bodyguard ramming a car into the back door of the bar.

That was a new piece of history—one the Resident itself had created—and the only version of events that had truly taken place.

Sydney Ginn jerked her head up.

She grabbed her phone and quickly found Amber in her contacts. After a few rings, Amber picked up on the other end: "Hello, Sydney?"

"The incident in May, when the car crashed into the bar—do you still remember?" Sydney Ginn cut straight to the point. "Did you ever hear anything afterward about that bodyguard

motorcade?"

Amber paused, not answering immediately. "Why are you suddenly asking about this?"

"...You know something," Sydney Ginn realized.

"No—I wouldn't say I know anything." Amber sounded somewhat reluctant. "Well... I wasn't trying to hide it from you forever. I mentioned what happened that night to the House Faction, just briefly—I didn't think it was anything significant myself. But after a while, the Hunter Director from our faction came to find me."

Amber drew a breath and continued: "He told me to keep that night's events confidential and not to speak of it to anyone. Even though I didn't know much and couldn't see any real need for secrecy... but it was the House Faction's wishes, so I had no choice but to comply."

This was the most important reason Sydney Ginn had no desire to join a House Faction: her own actions would be decided by others. On what grounds?

She didn't even know who the Key House Faction's second-in-command was, let alone who the Morgan House Faction's Hunter Director might be, so she simply asked: "Who's your Hunter Director?"

"Taylor Ford," Amber said.

Her tone was completely flat, which for a moment left Sydney Ginn unable to tell whether Amber had simply grown used to it or truly didn't know how illustrious those words—"Taylor Ford"—were in Hunter circles.

...Since when had Taylor Ford joined Morgan House Faction?

While Sydney Ginn was still stunned, Amber seemed to misread her silence and said, "You're not thinking of going to Taylor Ford to ask about this, are you? He won't tell you anything. Besides, our faction is in total chaos today—everyone's rushed off their feet. He'll be leading a team into the Nest very soon..."

"What happened?" Sydney Ginn instinctively asked, following the thread.

"A squad we sent into the Nest last week seems to have been completely wiped out somehow—not a single one has come back. The squad leader, a man named Jonah, is only known to still be alive, but he needs emergency rescue and there's no time to waste... A woman who had just come out of the Nest reported it to us. I forget her name."

Friends, this chapter is going up early today because I need to take my cat to the vet in a bit—she's been losing fur in a strange way lately, which has me worried...

Didn't expect that before I could squeeze out a bonus chapter, it would be time to go paid already—yes, tomorrow, the 29th. I really do drag my feet...

I humbly ask all you dear readers to spread the happy news (?) of the launch! I'm aiming to try my best and get at least 20 first-day subscriptions. Our greatest virtue is not being greedy.

I'll subscribe one myself, rally my editor into subscribing one too, plus family and close friends—hmm, that still leaves 17 people to win over...

Once I get back from the vet (?) later, I'll write a launch post. Oh my, I really do have quite a bit of nonsense I want to ziang about.

Chapter 48 — It's on the shelves, and here I am perched on them with a few words to say

Think about it — it's only been forty-some days since Artifact launched, just over a month.

I truly never expected I'd be riding such a rollercoaster...

Ensemble writing is at least three times harder (I calculated this by repeatedly pouring green liquid back and forth in a lab while wearing a white coat), and the audience is three times smaller (same method — very scientific). I'd mentally prepared myself for all of that.

Or rather, I thought I had mentally prepared myself.

When I first started, I was still carrying the illusions and momentum left over from my last novel, and if I looked out far enough, I could almost still see a garden in full bloom — ghostly as it was.

(I know that one wasn't all that popular either — it's just that, comparatively speaking, it had a much broader appeal.)

Aside from the initial burst of support when I launched — when things were, for a brief moment, actually in full bloom — after that, as the story unfolded, I started facing the cold hard reality: wait, I knew you were niche, but I didn't think **this** niche?

It felt like all my readers had followed me over from the last novel, and were dropping off one by one along the way — my reserves were shrinking fast. Who wouldn't panic? Watching the backend numbers fall lower and lower, I went through a pretty anxious stretch.

See, no matter how resolved you are when you make a decision, you still feel it when you walk headfirst into reality. Hit it hard enough, and you end up in a cast.

Head wrapped in plaster, I watched (don't ask me how — I could see it anyway) my new novel grow quieter and quieter, and I slowly ground my way forward, writing Chase at the time — an unpopular character in an already niche story. But somewhere in that grinding, my mindset suddenly settled.

Hard to explain — it was just this sudden feeling of, **oh, this is actually the state I should be in.**

When I started this book, I came into it with the mindset of writing as if I'd never written anything before — as if this were the first novel of my life. So when the outside world wasn't buzzing, wasn't flying flags, wasn't putting on a show — wasn't that exactly right?

The more niche and obscure a story, the more it needs a niche, quiet environment to be written in — otherwise it's too easy to lose your eye to other things. "Environment" counts here in both senses: internal and external.

So when I said I'd aim for twenty first-day subscribers — yes, it was a joke, but thinking back on it now, if it really were just twenty, that wouldn't be so hard to accept. You go back to where you came from — and that's not saying the road was walked for nothing. It's more like... the mountain is a mountain again, and the water is water again.

I chose a path few others walk, so naturally I should take it step by step in silence, watching the mountain ranges shift through pale smoke and cloud, and every now and then, the veil lifts — and I glimpse the hidden landscape I've been searching for.

All of that to say: thank you, all of you, for being willing to walk this road with me all the way to the end of the dark — because for the record, I didn't bring a flashlight (。

PS: Oh right! My editor reminded me to mention the Wild Deer Convenience Store every so often, in case anyone still doesn't know I've been keeping a short-story side piece (not really). My editor has been incredibly good to me — practically one step away from going out masked to drag people in to read — so I have to shout it out a couple more times: Wild Deer Convenience Store, Wild Deer Convenience Store!

Short reads to go with your meals — with a sweetness that lingers!

After reading Wild Deer Convenience Store, kids' test scores improved, grandma's knees stopped aching — so says citizen Ms. Liu.

"Wild Deer Convenience Store is a shop I'd be happy to visit again and again," — excerpt from a Wall Street Journal review, totally made up for the sake of clout.

Chapter 49: The Secret Behind a Qidian Author's Fake Gathering-Money-and-Being-Unfilial Act for Over a Month

Hello, my dear readers — my leave note got taken down by Qidian, and I'm not sure if it's because I said j* or because I said m*le.

Perfectly normal words, and yet the moment they get turned into **, the evil energy doubles, doesn't it? Truly picking up a rock just to drop it on everyone's feet.

Anyway, it got taken down. My chapters are limited-edition — read them while you can, because poof, they're gone (。

Now the leave note is just a dream in a rearview mirror growing smaller in the distance. But those of you who did see it are blessed — you should run downstairs right now and buy a lottery ticket (click the little tree icon in the bottom right, there's a chestnut tree).

The last time I posted a thank-you chapter was back on May 7th — just five days after the death of the Bronx Brothers.

Going over a month without thanking my dear readers — what an act of filial impiety. What on earth was the reason behind it?

First, because I've been using every scrap of author's-note real estate for my own rambling nonsense; and second, because saving them all up and thanking everyone at once makes for a very long list — which creates the illusion that the Artifact report is wildly popular (。

Though it might well be the same crowd of readers every month, sponsoring me the way you'd hand over allowance money to a kid (。

First up, I'd like to invite to the stage: Your Dad Laughs Openly, Chalk-the-Frame, Nine-Five, Yaoyao and Linlin, Don't Ask How Many Flowers Bloom, and Pangxiaoya — six high-shine readers. Let me lie down on the floor and be your red carpet...

Oh my dear readers, what are you all doing — your tips are truly too generous, it's gotten to the point where I'm too embarrassed to just give you a stage appearance and have no choice but to add extra chapters instead... We know each other so well at this point, so next time save it and just give a m*le vote, okay?

(I'm right there on the edge of violating the rules, what are you gonna do about it)

But honestly, quite a few of you tipped around the time I posted my frustrated rant, and I think you were trying to comfort me — I looked at the dates and nearly teared up. Leave me a message? Extra chapter or a stage appearance, or if you want something else just tell me — I promise I didn't say s*usage, Qidian please don't ban me.

Sure, our reader count isn't huge, but the hearts you all use to support me are real and true, and I do love living off your generosity (。

Next up are the regulars who show up almost every month: Haynes and Iron-Armor Baitang... what can I say, honestly — you might as well leave a secondary card on file with me — no wait, that's not what I meant — it's just, I feel a little bashful.

Into the Artifact Report Field Research Fund, thanks to: BookFriend20190620111919738 (let's get you a real name — you've tipped twice, and I typed out this whole string of numbers both times only to realize it was the same person), Jiuri Little Monster (a new reader perhaps? No? Yes?), and Mòyuān Pronounced as Black Bird (your username has practically brainwashed me to the point where I no longer recognize the characters 墨鸢),

as well as b1111111111 (hold onto your subway ticket — do they have a three-day pass to save money?), Murakami's Kafka (awfully polite of you?), Joiiii (tipping while watching the game — a spirit that moves the heart), and Twenty-Four's QD (I feel like if I keep saving these up I'll be able to sign over my entire self).

Let me add it all up — not counting accommodation, I think this should be enough to keep me alive for three days of field research? I've never actually experienced New York prices myself; I've heard even a breakfast roll costs seven kuai, though luckily I don't eat breakfast.

Next up, first tier of the rolling thank-you list: Does Sanjiu Love Red Bean Cake (yes, the one shaking down first-years for protection money, that's me), Sanjiu's Doggo, Non-Edible Little Cat Gummy (you tip more punctually than I update), Always on the Side of the Egg (I get it), and vitang (oh hey, we meet again).

New line, so everyone's eyes can catch a breath: thanks to Drunk Uproot a Willow (put him down for a sec would you), Jinjiang Qinshui, Emmy-chan, Zookeeper K, Ciel Mò, Ahhhh What Is Happening, Yinglóng Wants Herbal Jelly (eat it), Mia'ao (meow), and Fujin of Mumbai (what are you up to).

Continuing the line: thanks to Wu Ya, Yingyou, I Am Ayun's Puppet Wuwuwuwu (how does that username not get banned?!), Shèjiāng Is Away (I feel like you and Jinjiang Qinshui are part of

the same series), Dongxie (reader, you're in remarkably good health?), and Medea's Little Sheep.

This next row I know every single one of: MARGINAL Fish, Cloud Alliance Little Angel, Fox Baby, Yuèzhuó Likes Adventure Stories (excellent in both comments and tips), Shandong Runaway Excavator (thanks — I'm definitely not telling Lanxiang), A Cup of Daydream No Sugar, and Ten Thousand Volts i — see, this is the advantage of having a small readership: I know every one of you.

Business is booming though, and I still have more to thank: Erikakoo, Little Sun Takes You Flying, DStorm, Spring Jingzhe, Little Wine Cup, Fallen Plum Treading Snow to Come (unfamiliar face — possibly a new reader, don't dare say for sure), A-Qi's Little Girl, Du Ziruò, Jīnwú, _E_Stella_, BookFriend20230503221938575 (see, there's just no getting to know someone by their numbers), and Good Luck Seven Treasures.

Looking at all this, it turned out to be quite a grand sweeping chapter of thanks — anyone who didn't know better might think I'm a top-three tipper myself.

But a person can't live in delusion forever. Going forward I really do need to thank my readers in a timely manner — I can't afford to be this unfilial for so long again.

Chapter 50 — Some Q&A on the World-Building Behind the Artifact Reports

Since I've seen similar questions come up a few times in the VIP chapters at the back, I've decided to open a separate chapter to address them before the paid content begins.

If this makes sense to you, feel free to read on — subscribing will be worth it. (Of course, if the plot turns out to be no good... well, there are no refunds.)

The main question is: why hasn't the government gotten involved in Hunter affairs — or in other words, why isn't there any government oversight?

I'd like to break this question into two parts: first, whether it's possible; and second, whether anyone would want to.

1. Whether It's Possible

The passage is something entirely random, rare, and demanding in its conditions.

Whether a person ever discovers they have a passage comes down entirely to luck — government power has absolutely no role to play here.

Because the government can't very well mobilize the citizens of a major city and have them try jumping off buildings or ramming into televisions one by one... The very nature of the passage fundamentally ensures that no government can form a national team, because it is an intensely personal trait that cannot be controlled by any outside force.

Without a national team, there's no way to enter the Nest; you're shut out at the source. If you have no idea what's being brought into the human world, you have no way to regulate the circulation of Artifacts. (This doesn't rule out the occasional Artifact falling into official hands.)

So what about organizing or overseeing the Hunters who already exist?

First of all, the Artifact Report world draws on the American political environment — any kind of oversight would require a whole chain of steps: introducing a bill in Congress, voting to pass legislation, securing congressional funding, establishing a regulatory body, submitting to public scrutiny...

But 99.9% of humanity has no idea that the Nest, Artifacts, or Hunters exist.

If you were a senator, how would you explain to your constituents why you voted in favor of a proposal that sounds like complete nonsense, and why you spent enormous amounts of tax money on "something that doesn't exist"?

How would you keep your political opponents from using that against you?

You might say that intelligence agencies could quietly move to arrest or surveil Hunters — and technically speaking, yes, that could be done.

But only on the premise that you already know who the Hunters are.

The randomness of passage discovery means that as the regulatory authority, you never know who might become a Hunter tomorrow, and there's never any warning in advance.

Not to mention that Hunters aren't stupid — the moment that kind of operation began, Hunters would go deeper underground to protect themselves, or even fight back using the power of Artifacts. So where's the benefit? (This gets into the question of whether anyone would want to, which I'll cover in part two.)

And from the Hunter's perspective — when you've risked your life to obtain an Artifact and you can sell it for a high price, how likely are you to turn it over to the government, get absorbed into the system, and take home a few thousand dollars a month as a civil servant?

On top of that, the Nest is a realm beyond the reach of any law. Once you're inside, only the people who come out alive know what happened in there. What if a government team went in and never came back?

Government power is ultimately made up of people, and when over 99% of people are shut out from the Nest and Artifacts, that means the government is shut out too.

2. Whether Anyone Would Want To

Short answer: no.

Suppose the government did have the ability to regulate Hunters and the Nest: Party A gets elected, establishes a Bureau of Artifacts, nearly eliminates Artifacts from civilian hands, and consolidates all Artifacts under government control.

Then Party A fails to win re-election, and Party B takes power.

Once Party A becomes the opposition with no access to Artifacts whatsoever — would they feel like they'd shot themselves in the foot? (This kind of competition plays out within parties too.)

What if, at that moment, an Artifact suddenly appeared that could keep the ruling party in power forever — or keep the opposition in opposition forever? Would Party A be willing to exit the stage of history for good?

And given that the political environment this story draws on is the United States, the ultimate goal of dark-money politics still comes down to money.

Would the donors behind those senators want them to pass regulations? Once things are regulated, their own access to Artifacts shrinks and becomes less convenient. Even if the candidate they back is willing to leave the back door open for them, would that candidate's opponents?

As a major donor, would you fund a candidate who, once elected, raises your taxes?

If not, then you certainly wouldn't fund a candidate who, once elected, makes it impossible for you to buy Artifacts.

Would a candidate even bother pushing something this thankless — even just to keep the campaign contributions coming?

Look at the real-world example: American commercial health insurance doesn't just profit off people's misery — it profits by consuming people outright. So why won't either party touch commercial health insurance, even to win votes? Because those companies are major donors.

So, to summarize:

1. The vast majority of people are kept in the dark;
2. Regulation would face enormous obstacles;
3. Hunters are just in it for the money — pay them enough, and you can buy the Artifacts right out of their hands;
4. Letting Hunters come and go from the Nest as they please benefits everyone, including high-ranking government officials themselves;
5. The consequence of regulation might be losing your political donations and doing all the hard work for your opponents.

Something that is basically all hardship and downsides with no benefit to speak of — if you were in power, why would you bother?

Chapter 51: Mai Minghe Has No Home to Return To

Mai Minghe had no home to return to.

She walked barefoot through the streets of Blackmoor City in the small hours of the morning, chilled to the bone—especially her toes, which felt as though they'd been glued on and might drop off at any moment.

At first, she could still feel the layer of grime on the soles of her feet, and whenever she stepped on something suspiciously sticky, she would scrape and slap her feet hard against the ground. But after a while, Mai Minghe gave up caring—the streets of Blackmoor City were hardly clean, and fussing over it was like trying to put out a fire by spitting on it; if she worried about that, she'd never make it home before dawn.

Just before she'd hit the screen, Jonah had grabbed her by the shoulder at the last second, and it still burned and ached; for all that the young man had been taken over by some parasite, his grip was something else.

She had thought that the hardest part of getting home from the Nest would be shaking Jonah off.

She had slammed into the screen just ahead of Jonah's grasp and had indeed made it back to the real world—but the place she'd tumbled out into was not her own home.

All these years lived, and yet here she was, old as she was, still finding new ways to suffer.

Mai Minghe sighed inwardly as she walked, stone-faced, past a cluster of drunks on the roadside who whistled and called out—"Hey, sweetheart! What are you doing walking around in your pajamas? Did your boyfriend kick you out for the night?"

Rationally, she knew that being a young woman alone on the streets of Blackmoor City at this hour was actually dangerous.

But emotionally, Mai Minghe couldn't quite summon the will to be afraid.

"Hey!" One of the drunks actually came after her, reaching out to grab her arm, slurring, "We were calling you... don't go, walking around barefoot must hurt. Come with us... we'll give you money."

Mai Minghe stopped, her gaze drifting past him to the building behind.

"Where's the pharmacy?" she couldn't help asking. "It's been there for decades—when did they tear it down? When did it turn into a real estate agency? I don't even recognize this building..."

The drunk turned around in a daze. "...Huh?"

"The old man who ran that pharmacy, raising his granddaughter on his own—life wasn't easy for them. He's probably long gone by now..." Mai Minghe shook her head and kept walking. "I haven't walked this far in seven or eight years. I've lived here my whole life, and now I can barely recognize the place..."

The drunk stood rooted to the spot, watching her walk away, and didn't follow.

If he had actually followed her, Mai Minghe would have been happy to chat with him—she always felt that talking things out was the only way to sort them through properly, one by one.

For instance, as she walked and reflected, she'd worked out that the rules for entering and leaving the Nest went something like this: she had hit the screen and fallen into the Nest; then, inside the Nest, she had hit the screen again and fallen back into Blackmoor City.

But where she came out wasn't necessarily where she'd gone in, and it didn't have to be through the screen either—just now she had dropped out of nowhere onto the lid of a trash can outside a residential building, and when she'd rolled off and looked around, she was still a kilometer from home.

It seemed the passage wasn't particularly precise; getting you back roughly in the right area was apparently good enough.

During this walk home, she couldn't help wondering—how was that young man named Jonah doing? How could a perfectly good kid be allowed to stay taken over by some parasite?

Besides, a person couldn't stay in the Nest for more than seven days, and Jonah didn't have much time left.

She'd have to find a way to track down the Morgan House Faction... they had that thing now, oh right, the internet—or else she could go to the library and ask the librarian to help her look it up online.

She was deep in thought, walking along, when she caught sight of the run-down apartment building she'd lived in for decades—and came to a sudden stop.

A police car was parked in front of the building, its lights casting alternating flashes of red and blue across the wall.

Late as it was, a small scattering of onlookers had gathered around—some were neighbors from her building, others were idle passersby from the surrounding area.

This neighborhood had poor public safety: a lot of immigrants, a lot of low-income residents. A police car in the middle of the night was nothing unusual. But among the crowd, Mai Minghe immediately spotted one familiar face: the middle-aged woman who lived below her, an incorrigible busybody—though, to her credit, also actually warm-hearted.

"...The two of them climbed down the fire escape in the dead of night, groping around outside the windows—scared me half to death!" Mrs. Smith had latched onto a police officer's arm and refused to let him go. "They said they were looking for someone, but I don't buy it. I know that old woman on the second floor—she hasn't gotten out of bed or left the apartment in years. She doesn't sprout wings and fly away in the middle of the night!"

"What is that supposed to mean?"

The female nurse aide's face had gone white with anger. "We're proper nurses—you think we came here to steal from you? We came because we received an emergency alert, but the old woman suddenly disappeared on her own. How could we not look for her?"

The male nurse aide, for his part, was focused on an entirely different concern.

He had boxed in the officer from the other side and kept repeating his account of the situation: "...This matter is absolutely not a failure on our part—please make sure to note that down carefully, and be sure to make it clear to our hospital as well. At the time, her grandson was watching her; we were already getting ready to leave. In terms of supervision, it was no longer our responsibility. If you find that the old woman actually fell off the building..."

Right—it was only now that Mai Minghe realized something she'd been slow to consider.

The thief was without a doubt an Artifact Hunter, or at the very least, someone connected to the Hunter trade.

He knew she had entered the Nest through her passage; but the other two nurse aides on the scene were ordinary people who knew nothing about the Nest—just as she herself had been until not long ago.

All they knew was that there had been an old woman in the room, and then in the blink of an eye, she was gone. How was anyone supposed to handle a situation like that?

Thinking about it that way, it was actually rather remarkable: so many Artifact Hunters, so many of their clients, and yet they managed to keep the existence of the Nest and its Artifacts sealed tight—not a whisper of it reaching the wider world.

Tens of millions of ordinary people went about their daily lives, toiling away at survival in the real world, entirely unaware that beyond the everyday, there existed a world of dark and fantastical things.

"Alright, alright, Mrs. Smith, is it? Go on back inside—it was all a misunderstanding, nobody's here to steal anything from you."

The officer finally managed to extract himself from the crowd, pulled open the car door, and turned to the male nurse aide: "The family member has already said they won't be pressing any charges against you—see how he gets in touch with you to handle things from here. A living person doesn't just vanish into thin air; my guess is the old woman got confused and wandered off somewhere. We've already filed a report, and more officers will be here shortly to do another sweep of the area... alright, alright, everyone go home."

"Family member"—that would be the thief, then?

Mai Minghe thought of her convenient grandson, craned her neck to look around, but saw no sign of the thief.

She watched the officer get back in his car, and the rest of the crowd gradually dispersed; in no time at all, only Mai Minghe remained on the street.

The police car drove past her, and the officer inside glanced at her briefly—her heart lurched for a moment, as though she were the guilty party—but she watched the officer's gaze shift away almost immediately as he picked up his phone and pressed it to his ear.

Mai Minghe let out a slow breath.

Of course. There was no way they could know that this young woman who looked to be in her twenties was the very old lady they couldn't find no matter how hard they searched...

When she passed Mrs. Smith's door, she moved with careful deliberateness, making no sound, and turned to head up the stairs.

Mai Minghe was focused on one thing: getting home as fast as possible, washing her feet first, then changing her clothes—rescuing Jonah would have to wait until daylight, when she could ask someone to help her find information; at this hour, the library wouldn't even be open.

But her path home came to a halt just a few steps short of her own door.

Her front door, which had been pried open, was now half-ajar, not fully shut.

Through the gap in the door, she heard footsteps moving around inside, occasionally hitting the wooden floorboards in front of the kitchen with a creak; and amid the sound of those footsteps, the thief's voice came through clearly with a low "mm-hm."

Mai Minghe froze where she stood, caught between advancing and retreating.

"They left?"

The thief's voice carried through the door, clear in the quiet of the night. "The nurse aides went home too? What did you tell them?"

Who was he on the phone with?

The room went silent for a few seconds; then the thief let out a breath. "I owe you one for handling this so quickly. Yeah, right—my main concern was those two nurse aides..."

Mai Minghe's curiosity and instinct to investigate surged all at once, and she silently edged one step forward.

Whatever the person on the phone had said put the thief at ease; his voice relaxed somewhat: "You're right. If it hadn't been for that woman downstairs insisting on calling the police, I think those two nurse aides would've preferred to keep it quiet too—they probably wouldn't have dug any deeper. Yeah, your people are really professional at cleaning things up... it was exactly like the real thing. If I weren't the one who'd made the call myself, I'd have been worried."

A wave of goosebumps broke across Mai Minghe's skin, and she suddenly understood who was on the other end of the line—just a moment ago, she had seen that person herself.

"Yes, just send the bill to our House Faction..."

The thief seemed to have heard a tricky question, because he paused before continuing: "Hm? No, I don't know how that old woman could have suddenly discovered her passage out of nowhere either..."

He was lying.

The moment he'd pressed that tube against a person, it let them see the vision of opening their own passage.

Mai Minghe thought back to the scene and felt everything fall into place: the thief had intended to use the vacuum device to take her passage from her, but while the vacuum device was working, it had also let her see, for the first time, how her own passage could be opened.

As if drawn by a summons, she had been called to the television set by her passage, and had tumbled into the Nest.

While she was turning this over in her mind, the thief's next words came half a beat late, breaking through her thoughts and reaching her.

"...Wait, there's someone outside my door."

Mai Minghe jolted with a start and instinctively looked down, seeing in the corridor light that her own shadow fell in a vague, blurry patch—right in front of the door.

She had to move—

But before she could even turn around, the door was already pulled open by the thief; she looked up and found herself face to face with him.

Apart from the faint sound of traffic coming through his phone, there was complete silence between them.

In that split second, Mai Minghe felt as though another version of herself had taken over her reactions: she stared at him blankly for a moment, then seemed to collect herself, and smiled at him.

"I just took out some trash," she said quietly. "Did you move in recently?"

The thief's brow furrowed slightly as his gaze swept across her face twice.

Having said her piece, giving him no chance to think further, Mai Minghe turned and walked on, as if her own apartment were somewhere further down the corridor.

Even though she looked decades younger and had shed her pajama jacket, she still didn't dare let the thief's eyes linger on her any longer than necessary—as she passed her own front door, she could almost tangibly feel his gaze slide over her bare, filth-streaked feet.

Two steps on, and she still hadn't heard the thief go back inside; she glanced back, and sure enough, met those eyes again.

"Something wrong?" She frowned too. "Oh, and your door wasn't shut just now."

"Hm? Oh, thanks."

The thief startled slightly, and seemed to realize that standing in a corridor in the middle of the night staring at a young woman was, indeed, a bit improper; a trace of suspicion remained on his face, but under Mai Minghe's unflinching gaze, he finally drew back—and this time, he closed the door.

The moment it clicked shut, Mai Minghe turned and ran.

She had no thought to spare for whether her footsteps might wake Mrs. Smith—she thundered down the stairs; and just as she reached the landing at the foot of the staircase, she heard a door upstairs slam open with a bang, crashing against the wall.

Immediately after, a second set of footsteps rang out in the hallway.

The thief might not yet realize he had grown young again, but he had certainly noticed enough telltale signs to arouse his suspicion—this home, it seemed, was somewhere he could not return to for the time being.

Mai Minghe burst out through the building's front door, but did not keep running along the street; she ducked sideways and slipped into the narrow alley behind the building, crouching down behind a waist-high trash bin.

After about ten seconds, she heard the footsteps, just as she had expected; peeking carefully from behind the trash bin, she caught the thief's retreating silhouette scanning back and forth along the street, before he picked a direction and walked away.

Several more minutes passed, and the street was empty again.

Not daring to make a single sound, Mai Minghe slowly rose, hunched at the waist, and retreated step by step under the cover of the trash bins. She was afraid the thief might still be close by; once she stepped on a fragment of cracked hard plastic, the pain made her bite down hard on her lip, but she did not make a sound.

Following the alley behind the building, she finally put distance between herself and her home, inch by inch.

When the sky began to lighten to a pale gray, Mai Minghe stood dazed in the street, at a loss for where to go.

As long as she waited patiently, the thief would give up sooner or later—he could hardly move into her home permanently. But in the time before he left, where was she supposed to go?

The goal of finding the Morgan House Faction seemed to have grown even more distant.

The most pressing matter right now seemed to be finding herself a pair of shoes first.

Come to think of it, there was one place that would suit her perfectly: she could not only find shoes there, but also get a piece of clothing and a few slices of bread—near Brooklyn Community College, there was a charity relief station where homeless vagrants often came to collect aid supplies.

Wasn't that exactly what she was right now—a homeless vagrant?

The relief station was not close, but Mai Minghe had no other choice and could only push her bare feet forward.

She had no watch and no way of knowing the time, but by the time she finally drew near the place, daylight had long since broken fully, and the heavy rush-hour traffic had thinned out again and returned to its usual flow.

Mai Minghe did not see the moment the black Mercedes suddenly swung its door open.

By the time she registered that a tall figure had leapt up in the street and was striding in large steps toward the subway station across the road, the black Mercedes, now without its driver, had already lost control—it veered crookedly up onto the sidewalk and, with a thunderous crash, slammed headlong into a tree just a few steps in front of her.

A woman inside the car, her hair in purple dreadlocks, appeared to have taken a hard hit from the impact; struggling to push the door open, she muttered furiously to herself: "...When I get back to the House Faction, I am absolutely renegotiating my contract!"

Today's chapter ran quite long—even I didn't expect to write this much. Consider it a celebration of the official launch!

Truly, I couldn't save a single extra word...

The timelines of the three (current) main characters are finally about to converge!

P.S.: My cat is fine!

The vet asked me whether my cat had fleas. I said, with full confidence, no—she never goes outside. Then the vet took a little comb and ran it through her fur a few times, and the fleas on

that comb outnumbered my confidence by a wide margin...

No wonder my poor girl has been losing fur so badly—turns out she's allergic to fleas!!!

I've got a major project ahead of me when I get home—spray everywhere, strip all the fabric and wash it, mop the floors with a steam mop...

Truly, there's never a shortage of things to keep me busy...

Chapter 52: Mai Minghe Cannot Be Found by the Morgan House Faction

What happened next swept in like a tornado—fast enough to catch everyone off guard.

In the blink of an eye, more than ten police cars came screaming onto the scene and surrounded the crash site; onlookers sprouted up from nowhere like mushrooms after rain, standing at a distance on the nearby streets—and on the upper floors of the buildings alongside, window after window swung open, vague faces peering out.

Did they really have to be this efficient?

Couldn't they have at least left her two minutes to ask the purple-haired woman about the House Factions?

In over eighty years of living, this was the first time Mai Minghe had ever complained that the police arrived too quickly—she watched as the purple-haired woman was already surrounded by officers, unable to ask her anything, yet unwilling to leave; what surprised her was that after a few words exchanged with the purple-haired woman, several of the officers holstered their guns.

"The ambulance is almost here," one of the officers said. "Can you stand?"

Wedged in among the crowd of onlookers, Mai Minghe caught fragments of conversation drifting past her—things like "came barreling through in a car," "kidnapped a woman," "suspect not yet apprehended"...

Kidnapped? How was she kidnapped?

That purple-haired woman seemed to have some connection to Artifact Hunters, and Hunters were supposed to be capable people; and judging by her tone just now, she seemed to know the man who had been driving.

Mai Minghe couldn't make sense of it. She tried several times to strike up a conversation and ask what was going on, but the moment anyone caught a glimpse of how she looked, they all pretended not to see her and casually stepped away.

She couldn't blame them—she really did look quite a sight right now.

Her bare feet were so dirty that the original color of her skin was unrecognizable, and here she was in the middle of the morning, still wearing her pajamas.

Years of being bedridden had left her hair uncut; now that it had grown thick again, it was an even wilder tangle—and when she touched her face, she found a dried layer of vomit still crusted on it.

Mai Minghe picked out a kind-looking woman and, no matter how many steps back the woman took, she kept closing the distance with unwavering persistence—until the woman finally shoved two folded banknotes into her hands and made a hasty escape.

...Well then. She'd discovered a side hustle.

Being someone everyone avoided did have its advantages: working off the single edge that nobody would go near a vagrant, Mai Minghe clutched her two banknotes and made her way smoothly to the very front of the crowd, watching the entire process of the police escorting the purple-haired woman away with perfect clarity.

"Y-yes, he held a gun to me and forced me into the car... The pickup location? Hmm, I can't quite remember, my head hurts so much..."

The purple-haired woman's steps were unsteady and faltering, supported on either side by an officer as they walked toward the ambulance that had just arrived.

Her hands were bound in front of her with zip ties, and she said in a slurred voice, "He tied me up, but then had me read the map for him... Oh, no, he didn't hurt me. But I'm very dizzy, a little nauseous..."

Watching her, Mai Minghe couldn't shake the feeling that the moment the police arrived, the purple-haired woman had suddenly grown considerably weaker, her mind considerably more muddled—when just moments ago she had been shouting curses with a perfectly clear, sharp voice.

Could this somehow be connected to the Nest or to Artifacts as well?

Well, never mind—whatever she and her companion were planning, one thing was perfectly clear: if she wanted information about the Morgan House Faction, the best way was to ask a Hunter.

But the only person in front of Mai Minghe right now who had any connection to Hunters was being helped along and walking away, climbing into the ambulance, which then swung its doors shut with a heavy thud.

She watched the Mercedes get towed away, and then the ambulance drove off in a grand procession accompanied by a fleet of police cars. Mai Minghe looked down at her feet and let out a long sigh.

She was exhausted, hungry, and aching all over; it felt like the soles of her feet had been cut open too.

"I'm sorry for putting you both through this," she said to these hard-won young bare feet of hers. "We've lost our shoes, so we'll have to walk a little further."

In all her years, she had encountered no shortage of uncomfortable, miserable, and unpleasant situations; Mai Minghe had long since developed her own way of absorbing and adapting to them—for instance, she had just given her two feet names in her head: one was called Little Left, and the other Little Right.

To add a touch of fun, she decided that Little Left was the right foot, and Little Right was the left foot.

Mai Minghe had company now; Little Left and Little Right led the way, the three of them setting off together toward the nearest hospital.

When they passed by the charity relief station, Little Left wanted to turn in and get a bite to eat, maybe ask for a pair of shoes; but Little Right had a better grasp of the bigger picture and explained the situation:

The purple-haired woman looked like she had, at most, a mild concussion—and it was quite possibly faked.

She didn't need a large, fully-equipped hospital, so the ambulance would certainly take her to the nearest Clayton Hospital emergency room. Under normal circumstances, the police would also follow to take an immediate statement; so for the next hour or so, the purple-haired woman would be staying at Clayton Hospital.

And since she appeared not to be a suspect and didn't seem to be facing detention, all Mai Minghe had to do was walk over to Clayton Hospital and wait at the entrance for a while—she should be able to catch the purple-haired woman on her way out.

But if Mai Minghe went to the relief station now and lost time over a meal, she had no idea how she would ever find another Hunter in the vast expanse of Blackmoor City.

Compared to a meal and a pair of shoes, one person's life was more important, wasn't it?

Little Left was convinced, and together with Little Right, the two of them dragged the utterly spent Mai Minghe all the way to Clayton Hospital.

The moment she caught sight of the hospital entrance, Mai Minghe nearly crumpled to the ground like a collapsing building—since fleeing her apartment, she had been walking nonstop for at least four or five hours, and on top of that, since the previous night, she had not had a single drop of water nor a single bite of food; even a young person would have been unable to bear it.

"Thank you," she said to Little Left and Little Right. "Rest a while—from here, all we have to do is wait."

Mai Minghe was very patient.

She thought of not long ago, when she had lain in bed day after day. Back then, Mai Minghe had already lost much interest in the news, always feeling it belonged to another world—one she had no part in, one she was about to be left behind by.

She was fonder of a lively reality show about a household of over a dozen people—she would lie in bed, motionless, watching the daylight shift outside the window, waiting amid the murmur of the news for the reality show to begin, her mind drifting in and out of clarity.

Life felt like a pearl necklace, moments that could easily slip away strung one by one along a long, long thread of waiting.

Mai Minghe was too exhausted and nearly missed the purple-haired woman walking out through the main doors.

It wasn't until the woman was already standing at the roadside with her phone, waiting for a ride, that Mai Minghe jolted awake and rushed over, calling out to her: "Hey, hello there."

The purple-haired woman turned around, revealing a face that was pleasant and approachable, yet wore an expression of exhaustion.

Understandably—anyone who had been through what she had that morning would be exhausted.

"Hmm? Oh, hold on," the purple-haired woman patted the pockets of her jacket, "I think I have some change..."

"I'm not asking for money," Mai Minghe clarified.

The purple-haired woman stopped her hand and looked at her.

To look at her, you would never have guessed she was a Hunter—except for the taut muscle on her frame and the practical ease of her clothes.

At this critical moment, Mai Minghe found herself suddenly less certain, but with no other option, she steeled herself and went straight to the point: "Could you tell me how to find the Morgan House Faction?"

"You're asking for directions? Morgan—"

The purple-haired woman glanced off to the side, then suddenly caught herself and fixed her eyes back on Mai Minghe, asking slowly, "...You mean the Morgan House Faction?"

Surely Artifact Hunters wouldn't kill off every person who knew about them just to keep them quiet?

The thought actually startled Mai Minghe herself.

If knowing about them meant danger, then naturally there was only one most reasonable course of action.

"Yes, I'm a Hunter too. But I've always gone into the Nest on my own—I've never joined a House Faction, so I don't know anything about any of this." Mai Minghe said it while silently hoping that there were indeed Hunters in the world who operated without joining a House Faction. "I want to join the Morgan House Faction now... Do you know how to find them?"

The moment the word "Nest" left her mouth, a subtle shift crossed the purple-haired woman's expression; as though "Nest" were a key that unlocked the surface she wore as an ordinary citizen, revealing beneath it something tougher, more removed from the everyday world.

"You... how did you end up like this?" She looked Mai Minghe up and down. "I've never seen a Hunter who's had it this rough. And how did you know I was one too?"

"I was right there when your car crashed," Mai Minghe said, herself a little embarrassed, rubbing her hand vigorously through her hair.

"Oh, you saw Chase. He's pretty hard to miss." The purple-haired woman nodded, seeming satisfied with that explanation.

If "Chase" was the tall silhouette, then Mai Minghe had only ever seen a "Ch"—though she was rather pleased with herself for thinking up that joke, she kept it to herself.

"You can't just join a House Faction whenever you feel like it, you know—there are screening standards you have to meet first..."

The purple-haired woman said it, then looked again at Mai Minghe's sorry state, and something like sympathy stirred in her. "Well, but when you're truly out of options, it's not a bad thing to try... At the very least, they should be able to give you a meal."

"So how should I..."

"You're in luck—I was just recruited into the Key House Faction," the purple-haired woman said with a smile, as though speaking of something she was proud of. "Before I joined, I'd saved contact information for several House Faction HRs. Morgan House Faction's happened to be one of them."

...HR?

Hunter House Factions had a Human Resources department?

It was Human Resources, right? Not some new term the young people were using?

Mai Minghe kept her face carefully blank and watched as the purple-haired woman took out her phone; the woman looked up and met her eyes.

The two of them stared at each other in silence for a few seconds until the purple-haired woman finally spoke: "Why are you staring at me? Get out your phone and take down the number."

Mai Minghe rummaged through her pockets and produced two crumpled banknotes. "Do you have a pen?" she said, with some awkwardness. "This is all I have... I'll write it down on this..."

"You don't have a phone?"

She only had a landline—a single elderly-model phone that she hadn't used in years. But Mai Minghe sensed that this was better left unsaid.

"In the Nest... I lost it." She said haltingly.

The look the purple-haired woman gave Mai Minghe had shifted from sympathy to something closer to the expression one wore at a funeral.

"Ah," she wiped her nose, as though there was something she wanted to say but couldn't quite bring herself to. "Well... I mean, no wonder you want to join a House Faction. You need to

remember going forward—personal belongings must not be left in the Nest. You should always, always try to avoid that."

Her expression all but added: if you have a going forward, that is.

The purple-haired woman really did have a remarkably kind heart.

"Now that I've joined the Key House Faction, it wouldn't be appropriate for me to contact other House Faction HRs anymore. You have to keep up appearances in the workplace. Here's what you do—find a... find a payphone, give them a call, and say Kingsley Roselyn referred you."

She fished a pen from her bag and wrote a phone number on the banknote. "Keep this money—once they give you the address, take a ride over."

If Jonah could truly be saved, at least half of that would be owed to a moment of kindness from Kingsley Roselyn.

Mai Minghe thanked her again and again, and even after Kingsley got into her car, she waved hard several times, watching her go—who said young people today were cold-hearted? Hadn't she just run into a good kid?

But what Mai Minghe hadn't anticipated was that even after she'd managed, just barely, to get the Hunter House Faction's contact information, her next goal would turn out to be even harder to find than the Morgan House Faction itself: a public payphone booth.

Hadn't they been everywhere once upon a time?

But nowadays you could walk for half a day and not spot a single public phone booth; and when you finally did find one, you'd step inside only to find no telephone at all—just the word "WI-FI" written there, with a little umbrella shape drawn beside it in three curved arcs.

What on earth was that even for?

Mai Minghe spent at least thirty minutes wandering the streets before she finally accepted the truth: public phone booths had apparently been rendered obsolete by the times.

She rested for a bit, feeling truly at her wit's end, and with nothing to lose, stepped into a small Chinese restaurant that looked like it had been around for years—sure enough, behind the counter she spotted a familiar old-fashioned telephone.

"Could I borrow your phone for a moment?"

Mai Minghe was almost giddy with relief; she also knew she looked absolutely wretched, and terrified of being thrown out, she hastily added, "I'll order a plate of chow mein too."

"You got money to pay for the chow mein?" The owner eyed her with suspicion. "One dollar a minute."

Thank goodness for Kingsley Roselyn's money... she'd have to find that kid afterward and pay her back, then write a thank-you note.

Mai Minghe pressed her ear to the receiver, listening to the dial tone ring, and felt as though the past day and night had been some strange, shadowy stage play that was slowly drifting toward its final act, the curtain nearly ready to fall.

She reached through her clothes and felt the Serpent Band wrapped around her body.

She had long since grown used to its presence—if she didn't touch it, she could almost forget it was still coiled around her at all.

She had not forgotten, of course, that the Serpent Band was the Morgan House Faction's target.

So Mai Minghe had no intention whatsoever of showing her face; keeping herself out of the Morgan House Faction's sight was the safest option.

"Hello?" A woman's voice came from the other end of the line.

"Hello," Mai Minghe glanced at the owner not far away, turned her back, covered the receiver with her hand, and said quietly: "Is this the Morgan House Faction?"

"Who are you?"

"Someone just gave me some money and asked me to call you, to pass along a message."

The person on the other end immediately grew wary. "Who exactly are you?"

Mai Minghe paid no attention and continued: "She told me she had just come back from a place called the Nest, and that she saw one of your people there—a young man named Jonah... a man named Jonah. She asked me to tell you—are you listening?"

The other end of the line stayed silent; yet somehow Mai Minghe couldn't help feeling that the silence was taut, as though it were smothering a great deal of movement and noise beneath it—unnatural.

"I'm listening," the woman's voice came through, and the background noise surged up along with it; the moment those words were spoken, the line went dead quiet again.

Had Mai Minghe been more experienced with mobile phones, she would have known that the person on the other end had pressed mute.

But she lacked that experience.

"She asked me to tell you—Jonah is at St. Louis Hospital and needs emergency rescue."

Just saying that one line might not be enough; perhaps she should explain a bit more about Jonah's condition... otherwise, what if they brought that worm back with him?

While Mai Minghe was thinking it over, the woman on the other end asked a few more questions—none of them particularly important; Mai Minghe noticed nothing unusual and answered them one by one.

But the woman's next words made every hair on her body stand on end.

"I know where you are now," the woman said, and then—click—she hung up.

Why are both of these chapters so long! If I can keep this up, maybe I have a shot at full attendance after all?

Thank you all for coming out to support me on launch day—even the readers who had been saving it up came out, I'm truly moved! It really did beat 20-something (you all didn't slack off dragging people in off the street, heh heh heh)! The friends who said first-day subscriptions could hit a thousand were being a bit too optimistic, but that's alright—numbers are essentially just noise; what matters is that I write the story the way I want to write it.

As promised, as a thank-you, first-day subscribers get a cat—specifically, the fleas on it. Come on, everyone line up, collect your fleas one by one.

PS: There's a writer who, at the end of a letter to a friend, included an apology that went something like: I'm sorry, I was pressed for time—I didn't manage to write you a short letter, so I could only write a long one.

I actually share that feeling. If I had more time to update, I think I could trim the word count down a bit further...

Chapter 53: Mai Minghe Between a Rock and a Hard Place

And just like that, they'd found out where she was?

Had caller ID gotten so advanced that it could show your address now?

Mai Minghe's heart hammered like a drum, and she fell into a momentary panic: if the Morgan House Faction found her, the only thing standing between the Serpent Band Artifact and their Hunters would be the thin shirt on her back.

Once they realized she was the last person to have had any dealings with Jonah...

No — she had to run.

Unless she was unlucky enough that the Morgan House Faction happened to live right above this Chinese restaurant, they'd need some time to get here. Right — she had to get out before they arrived.

Mai Minghe quickly slammed the receiver down, slapped some bills on the counter, and turned to walk out the door — but to her surprise, her foot didn't move.

Because someone had grabbed her by the back of her collar.

"And where do you think you're going?"

Before she could react, she heard the restaurant owner hollering behind her: "Your fried noodles are already in the wok — you haven't paid yet and now you want to walk out on me? I've had my eye on you this whole time, good thing I stayed sharp!"

She'd completely forgotten about that — her mind had been so wrapped up in Artifacts and Hunters that the fried noodles had slipped it entirely.

Mai Minghe was flustered and annoyed and half-amused all at once, and the collar was digging into her throat hard enough to make her cough twice; she hurried to say: "Let go — I'll pay you, won't I?"

The owner had half his body leaning out over the register, like a bald owl eyeing a mouse, and he didn't trust Mai Minghe one bit.

"Sixteen fifty," he said flatly. "Card or cash?"

"That much? It's just fried noodles!" She was taken aback, and shot a glance at the menu, full of regret. "Prices have gone up that much?"

"Do you even have the money?"

Mai Minghe's scalp was practically crawling: these precious minutes she should have been using to flee before the Morgan House Faction arrived, and here she was scraping together change one bill at a time for a plate of noodles.

She finally managed to pull the money together; the owner took it and still had complaints: "Took you that long to come up with sixteen fifty? Aiya, fine, fine — you want this to go or are you eating here?"

The person on the phone had said they knew her address — for all she knew, they'd be here any minute — what was she thinking, sitting down to eat—

Mai Minghe had just opened her mouth when she paused.

She stared at the owner's bald head for a moment, then changed her answer: "...To go."

The owner had no interest in a person who looked like a vagrant eating in his restaurant anyway; that was probably the first thing she'd said that suited him, and he turned and headed straight back to the kitchen.

Mai Minghe stood by the register, standing there in a daze, lost in thought. The little restaurant was empty and business was dead — just her, the drone of the TV news in the corner, and the dim, greasy smell of years of cooked meals.

...Why had the Morgan House Faction person said "I know your address" before hanging up?

Thinking about it now — this was a matter of life and death, and the Morgan House Faction would never just take some unknown caller's word over the phone and head straight into the Nest to rescue someone. They would have to verify the source first...

If they suspected she had something to do with Jonah's accident and were coming to grab her, they certainly wouldn't warn her ahead of time — that would be the same as telling her to run.

If she were the one from Morgan House Faction, would her first instinct be to suspect the caller of having something to do with Jonah's accident?

Maybe. Maybe not.

"I know your address" was, in itself, a perfectly neutral statement.

The other party hadn't said what they intended to do — only implied that someone was coming to find her.

If Mai Minghe had a guilty conscience and bolted the moment she heard those words, she would be sending the Morgan House Faction an unmistakable signal: I'm involved — come get me.

In her current state, she'd never outrun a House Faction Hunter search party.

But what if she truly was just a vagrant who'd taken someone's money to pass along a message? Would a person like that even take those words to heart?

The other party was testing her — and Mai Minghe had no choice but to play along, even if it meant showing her face to the Morgan House Faction.

She'd only come to realize it this late in life: life was strange — things that came without the slightest risk were rarely worth having; and now it seemed that keeping the Serpent Band Artifact meant taking a risk too.

She had the restaurant owner to thank for that — if he hadn't held her up, she never would have had the chance to think it through, and she'd have already bolted.

Not to mention, if he hadn't stopped her, who knows how much longer she'd have gone hungry, right?

Mai Minghe thought with something close to contentment as she sat on the ground along the outer wall of the Chinese restaurant, shoveling fried noodles into her mouth.

Her appetite had been ruined for years — couldn't chew, couldn't swallow, food had lost all taste; but here, at this moment with the storm about to break, the hot, fragrant, oil-rich noodles in her hands seemed to truly root her in this second youth of hers.

Whatever came next, she had food in her belly right now, and nothing could feel better than that.

That was just the kind of person she was — no matter what happened, she could always find something good in it.

A sleek gray car pulled up in front of the Chinese restaurant while Mai Minghe was picking bean sprouts out of her noodles.

She hated bean sprouts most of all — when she'd been starving a moment ago she'd shoveled everything in without a second thought; but now that her stomach was no longer empty, the bean sprouts were suddenly insufferable, as if they'd taken advantage of her hunger.

Mai Minghe glanced up at the car, steadied her heartbeat, kept her expression as neutral as she could, and looked back down to keep picking.

A man and a woman got out of the car and had just walked up to the entrance when the Chinese restaurant owner poked his head out first. He pointed over at Mai Minghe by the wall, said "that's her," and retreated back behind the door.

Mai Minghe wasn't surprised in the least.

When she'd been wolfing down her noodles a moment ago, she'd heard the phone ring inside the restaurant.

"Was it you who called?" the man asked; his gaze, sure enough, dropped to the pair of dirty bare feet she had deliberately stretched out, and one eyebrow gave a slight twitch.

"Yes," said Mai Minghe, wiping her mouth with the back of her hand — and leaving it dirtier than before. "Which one of you is Morgan?"

Nobody answered — but the woman had already pulled out her phone and called someone, and said into it: "We found her. Stand by where you are for now."

The moment she spoke, Mai Minghe recognized her — she was the one who had answered the phone earlier.

Which meant... besides these two, there were others nearby, weren't there? The Morgan House Faction probably had eyes on every street in the area — if she'd run just now, she wouldn't have gotten far.

The woman hung up and turned to Mai Minghe: "What did the person who asked you to deliver the message look like?"

Her guess had been right — they didn't seem to suspect her.

"Aiya—"

Mai Minghe lowered her head and scratched vigorously at her scalp, as though she had fleas — the man stepped back half a pace. "Talked funny, didn't make much sense, strange... I can't really say how old, somewhere in the twenties or thirties, maybe thirties or forties, not yet fifty.

Wore a hat and glasses, had a scarf wrapped around the whole lower half of the face, couldn't make out much."

The two exchanged a glance.

"How tall?"

"I was sitting on the ground — couldn't tell."

"...What ethnicity?"

"Either a light-skinned person of color, or a very tanned white person."

"Accent?"

"Oh, very standard," Mai Minghe said admiringly, "like someone who could read the news on the radio."

The woman's jaw tightened.

"What else did she say?"

"Strange stuff — see if you can make sense of it." Mai Minghe cleared her throat, set the takeout container down on the pavement, and said: "She said: 'Jonah looks normal on the outside, but a Resident has already gotten inside his body.'"

Both of their expressions shifted ever so slightly.

Good — so they understood... That meant when they went into the Nest to rescue him, they'd also know what to watch out for.

Mai Minghe let out a small, quiet breath of relief.

From the looks of things, the Morgan House Faction seemed like quite a formidable House Faction.

She still didn't know exactly what a House Faction was, but then again there were plenty of new words she didn't understand — it wasn't as if this one made a difference; and if they were truly that formidable, they ought to be able to bring the person back safely, right?

"What are you smiling about?" the man asked, catching her off guard.

Mai Minghe started, and realized she must have let a small smile show.

Being able to help someone — how good did that feel? How could she not smile?

People usually thought the one receiving help should be the happy one, but there was actually a warm, tingling kind of pleasure in being the one who helped — someone had explained it to her once, something about human evolution — but unfortunately, she couldn't say any of that out loud.

"She gave me money and I got to eat," Mai Minghe said, holding up her noodles. "That kind of thing doesn't happen every day."

"Watch her," the woman said to her partner, "I'm going to call Taylor Ford."

She stepped to one side and waited for the other end to pick up. After a few seconds, she said quietly: "Taylor? We found the one who made the call — it's a vagrant who got paid to do it."

Mai Minghe listened to her own fabricated story being gravely repeated back, word for word, from that woman's mouth.

But every word about Jonah's condition was the truth; and as the woman's expression grew more and more serious, Mai Minghe felt her heart rise higher and higher in her chest.

By the time she hung up and came back, even her partner looked somewhat tense, watching her in silence.

"This is serious. He may personally lead a team into the Nest," the woman said to her partner, then gestured toward Mai Minghe with her chin. "But before that, Taylor Ford wants to meet her first."

She crouched down then, as though speaking to a small child, and smiled at Mai Minghe in a pleasant, easy manner: "Our director has some questions for you. Come with us — we'll take good care of you. You can ask for whatever you want."

This time, it was Mai Minghe's turn to be at a loss.

For a vagrant, this was an extraordinary stroke of luck — there was no reason to refuse; but how could she dare go back to the Morgan House Faction with these two?

"Um — I — " She couldn't think of an excuse, and finally blurted out: "It's not that I don't want to — it's just that I have fleas—"

"That's fine," the woman said, her expression not entirely pleasant but entirely firm. "You can come to our — to our company and take a shower."

The man stepped forward, looking thoroughly reluctant, and planted himself right beside Mai Minghe.

He bent down and said: "You getting in yourself, or do you want my help?"

See, this is proof that I write every chapter from scratch with no stockpile — I mentioned fleas just two days ago and now the fleas have shown up with a pretty substantial role...

How about this — those of you who've been tipping, choose between a bonus chapter and an on-screen appearance; a bonus chapter would take a while, but if you appear in the story I'll definitely give the fleas proper treatment...

P.S.: Wrote pretty fast today, but I have a feeling tomorrow I'm going to hit a wall.

Chapter 54: The Correct Response of a Vagrant Named Mai Minghe

The play was already halfway through—it was too late to back out now.

There was no other way but to brazen it out and keep up the "vagrant" act to the end...

Mai Minghe reviewed her words and actions from just now and felt she probably hadn't given herself away.

For one thing, the pitiful, filthy state she was in wasn't something anyone could fake on short notice; and beyond that, she had carefully weighed what to say and what not to say, and was fairly certain she hadn't let anything slip.

Morgan House Faction's people wouldn't suspect a vagrant without reason, would they?

Whatever they asked about anything she hadn't already told them, she would simply answer that she didn't know—it wasn't as if they could read minds.

There was just one thing: they absolutely could not find out she had an Artifact on her.

That was exactly what Mai Minghe was worried about right now.

Sitting in the backseat, she kept fearing that her clothes might bunch up or press against her body and reveal traces of the Serpent Band Artifact; so every now and then she would adjust her posture and tug at her clothes.

The more she fidgeted, the more unsettled the two people in front became.

"Itchy?" The woman glanced at Mai Minghe in the rearview mirror and slid her seat forward a little. "Our company has a shower room—you can go clean up properly when we get there."

It sounded like Taylor Ford was quite an important figure, and the two of them didn't want to bring him a bag of fleas.

A shower was out of the question—at most she could wash her feet; even if someone poured blood over her she still couldn't take off her clothes—but of course Mai Minghe said none of this aloud.

"Why does a company have a shower room?" she asked offhandedly.

The man driving muttered, "...Minding a lot of business, aren't you."

Mai Minghe had assumed they simply didn't want to say "House Faction" and were calling the place a company instead—a manor having a shower room made perfect sense, didn't it?

But she hadn't expected that the car would ultimately pull into the underground parking garage of an actual office building—and not just any office building, but a modern one with full security and complete facilities, where the man and woman had to swipe their keycards before they could press the button for the elevator going up.

When the elevator doors opened, Mai Minghe was led into a bright, clean, cream-white reception area.

Several sofas were scattered across a round rug; in one corner stood a potted plant, its great clusters of glossy dark-green leaves brushing the ceiling. A screen on one wall was playing a promotional advertisement; on the wall behind the reception desk, a company name in clean, simple lettering read—"Morgan & Morgan."

What surprised Mai Minghe most was the line of small text printed beneath the company name: Financial Consulting & Property Management.

What was going on?

Wasn't "Morgan" a Hunter House Faction?

Her own side hustle was begging—theirs was financial consulting?

A young woman sitting at the front desk looked up the moment she saw the group step off the elevator, immediately bent down to pick up a paper bag, and came over in a few quick steps. "Jane, I just went and got everything—it's all here."

The woman addressed as "Jane" didn't even look at the bag and gestured for Mai Minghe to take it, then instructed, "Take her to get cleaned up first."

It was a brown bag printed with "ZARA." Mai Minghe thought she had seen the brand before; she opened it with curiosity and found a set of clothes and a pair of shoes inside.

When they had asked her shoe size earlier, she had already guessed as much—now she couldn't help but think that Morgan House Faction was rather thoughtful. Of course, no matter how thoughtful they were, the Artifact was still not theirs to have.

"That brand name's not one you see every day," she said after thanking them, running a hand over the bag. "Is it expensive? You really didn't have to spend money on my account."

The others glanced at her, and nobody spoke.

"Um, Jane..."

The receptionist didn't move; instead, she gestured to the man and woman and they stepped a few paces to the side with her, where she said something in a low voice—faint and indistinct, though the name "Taylor Ford" seemed to be buried somewhere in it.

Mai Minghe pretended to look at the clothes while her ears were pricked up higher than a satellite dish.

"...What?"

Jane's voice was kept very low too, and only a few words pushed forward by emotion were barely caught by Mai Minghe. "About to... at such a critical time... who gave him..."

...Great—not a single word with any real information.

The receptionist said something quietly, and Jane stopped talking.

After a few seconds, Jane let out a helpless sigh and returned to her normal volume. "Anyway, take her to get cleaned up first. Taylor Ford just said he wants to ask her some questions, but he can't have her show up looking like this... honestly, no wonder he insisted I bring a filthy person over here."

What was going on? What did any of this have to do with her?

Mai Minghe had only caught bits and pieces of it, which made her even more anxious; but she knew that even if she asked, no one would take her seriously, so for now she had no choice but to play dumb and follow the receptionist.

A financial services and property management company that truly had a shower room inside it.

It was a single-occupancy shower room partitioned into two sections—the inner part had a showerhead, and the outer part had a changing area.

Mai Minghe set the bag on the chair in the changing area and pushed open the shower room door—the next second, she lurched back half a step as if she'd been punched.

The sharp smell of sodium hypochlorite disinfectant nearly made her think she'd walked back into a hospital. No—it was even stronger than a hospital.

Standing in the shower room, Mai Minghe understood.

She turned, and it was as though she could see a blood-soaked Hunter walking in, turning on the faucet; mucus, fluid, blood—all the indescribable things brought out of the Nest—rushing down into the drain of the human world.

Morgan truly was a Hunter House Faction.

A Hunter House Faction had no qualms about blood.

Even a fool knew how precious an Artifact that could restore youth was—at the very least, far more precious than the life of a dying old woman.

...If she never walked out of this office building again, there was not a single person in the world who would come looking for her.

Mai Minghe leaned against the tiled wall, both arms wrapped tightly around her abdomen; through her clothes, the Serpent Band raised a slight ridge, pressing against her arms.

This was her lifeline.

The moment she walked out of that shower room, a silent battle to defend that lifeline would begin.

In this battle, her greatest advantage was that Morgan House Faction did not know the person standing before them was their adversary. Which meant she didn't need to strike—she only needed to not make mistakes.

...If I were Taylor Ford—a Hunter House Faction director—what would I ask?

How would I probe the other person and extract information?

Lost in concentrated thought, Mai Minghe washed her hands, feet, face, and neck without noticing. She stuffed her weary, cold, aching feet into the shoes and then pulled the new clothes on directly over her pajamas.

It was an autumn-winter hoodie. Adding another thick layer of cover over the Artifact put her somewhat more at ease.

She also borrowed a comb from the receptionist and carefully combed her hair straight before stepping out—like a warrior fully armed and ready to take the field.

"Oh no, don't bother returning it—"

The receptionist waved both hands frantically, wanting to keep the comb at several arm's lengths away. "Keep it, really—you keep it."

She paused, looking Mai Minghe over. "You actually look quite nice once you're cleaned up. How did you end up on the streets?"

"Bad luck, I guess," Mai Minghe smiled at her and tucked the comb into her pants pocket. "Who am I going to see next?"

"One moment," the receptionist picked up the phone. "Jane? She's done... Yes, yes. Oh? Alright, I'll bring her over now."

It was entirely ordinary content—just a matter of bringing someone to meet a superior—and yet that "Oh?" seemed to carry a hint of surprise that didn't quite fit.

Was it related to their whispering from before?

Mai Minghe licked her lips, steadied herself, and followed the receptionist with as neutral an expression as she could manage, winding through four or five turns before arriving at the door of a private office.

"Mr. Ford?" She knocked.

"Come in," a steady male voice answered.

As Mai Minghe walked in, she happened to see a man standing before the floor-to-ceiling window, turning his head toward her.

She had no idea what an important figure in a Hunter House Faction was supposed to look like, but seeing him now, she felt he was exactly as one should be.

The man wore a sleek, immaculately pressed suit, his face square and austere; though he was already middle-aged, it was still easy to see that this had once been a rather striking face in his youth—only time had won out in the end, his jawline softening and sagging, giving him a slightly weary look. Just slightly—not much.

"Sit," Taylor Ford instructed, taking his own seat on the other side of the desk.

Mai Minghe sat down in the visitor's chair.

This office looked like it was rarely used—almost no personal belongings, as stark as a showroom display—which made sense; a Hunter shouldn't be sitting in an office all day.

The only proof that someone used it was a few small dishes of snacks on the desk—Taylor Ford tilted his chin toward them and said, "Help yourself."

Mai Minghe was full, but she had to keep up the vagrant act properly.

The moment he finished speaking, she immediately popped a grape into her mouth; then, thinking it over, she simply picked up the dish and swept the few pieces of cheese and all the thin crackers into her coat pocket, and the small bunch of grapes that wouldn't fit she grabbed in her hand as well.

Pretty good acting, she commended herself inwardly. It was clear that Taylor Ford was holding back from frowning.

"When did you see that woman?" he asked, getting straight to the point.

"This morning," Mai Minghe had already rehearsed answers to many questions he might ask. "I don't have a watch, so I don't know what time."

"Where?"

Mai Minghe gave a location quite far from the Chinese restaurant.

"I know you said she had her face covered. But think back—was there anything about her you remember?"

"Hmm... well..." Mai Minghe furrowed her brow and pretended to think for a moment. "She was very generous with money."

Taylor Ford stared at her, his expression growing even more severe—clearly he didn't find it funny at all.

"You remember everything she said to you pretty clearly, don't you." He slowly leaned back in his chair, fingers tapping the desk one after another—tap, tap.

"Ah, don't remind me." Mai Minghe had prepared for this. "I didn't know if those strange things she said were some kind of code or what—I didn't catch them the first time. She made me memorize them, repeat them back twice, before she'd give me the money."

"And she just trusted that you'd definitely make the call?"

This was a question Mai Minghe had also thought through how to answer.

"She said it was a matter of life and death. Either way, she paid me and asked me to make the call—she'd done her part. If I didn't call and someone died, that death would be on my hands, and she'd have a clear conscience."

She said this and then tapped a few times on her face and chest, making the sign of the cross. "I'm not about to take on a death debt—God is watching. If I didn't make that call, I'd never get into heaven."

Taylor Ford fell silent, mulling it over, but Mai Minghe still couldn't relax.

The conversation had stayed focused on the "mysterious woman" the whole time, which meant he was suspicious of whoever had provided the information and wanted to know who the source really was.

He kept pressing about a person who didn't exist—even though she'd come prepared, she couldn't afford to let her guard down, terrified of letting something slip somewhere, her palms growing a little damp.

It was truly maddening—they already knew where Jonah was, so why not hurry up and rescue him—if she weren't afraid of blowing her cover, Mai Minghe would have loved to give them a proper talking-to.

"You can sit in our company for a while," Taylor Ford said with a low, flat laugh. "You leave when I say you can leave."

Mai Minghe's heart lurched, but she kept her expression carefully neutral.

"Why?" She scratched her head with one hand and asked, "I want to leave and I can't? That's kidnapping."

"Legally speaking, yes, it is kidnapping. So what?"

Taylor Ford was entirely unbothered. "I can also tell you why—if you'll sit tight and behave, all the better. That place you mentioned should have surveillance cameras nearby. Even if there aren't any, we can find the people in the area.

"A woman bundled up head to toe, standing on a busy street corner talking to a homeless person for that long—that naturally draws attention. All we have to do is pull the security footage, or find a witness, and confirm your story checks out. Then you're free to go. I'll even personally give you money and see you out the door."

Mai Minghe didn't hear that last part at all—she sat frozen in her chair, her mind completely blank.

Right, it seemed like so many places had installed those cameras nowadays...

She simply hadn't thought of that.

It wasn't her fault. For most of her life, "surveillance cameras" hadn't even been a concept to her.

She'd forgotten how old she was when she first heard the term; she only remembered the last time she'd noticed a camera—she'd been in the hospital, her body already in steep decline.

"No problem with that?" Taylor Ford kept his eyes fixed on her as he asked.

What else could she do but nod?

Get through this obstacle first—she could look for a chance to run later.

"Good. I'll have—"

Before Taylor Ford could finish the sentence, someone knocked urgently on the door—deep, rapid thuds. This time, without waiting for him to say anything, the door was pushed straight open, and Jane Lynch strode into the room.

"Mr. Ford, there's an emergency," she said, without sparing a glance at Mai Minghe. She walked up to Taylor Ford and lowered her voice: "Jonah—"

Jonah?

Mai Minghe jolted; but in the instant she looked up toward Jane Lynch, she suddenly realized something.

While Jane Lynch was speaking, Taylor Ford's eyes had remained fixed on her the entire time.

...As if he were waiting to see her reaction.

You see, I've been posting long updates every day lately, and earlier than before—not like the old days when I'd moan and groan with every word I typed...

It's because I truly love ensemble stories, and I love the world of Blackmoor City and the Nest even more, so every day I write with real joy, practically glued to my computer; even when I'm not writing, I'm always thinking about it.

That kind of state makes me happy. Writing (when it's going well) is a actually fascinating, absorbing process.

Honestly, I started writing because I loved it in the first place—I never thought about making a living from it.

Of course, that mindset has its downside too: when I'm not in that happy place, updates can't be guaranteed. No amount of money could drag me to the millstone then.

What can I say—I'm not a professional web novelist. I write for the joy of it.

Chapter 55: Mai Minghe and Taylor Ford's Interrogation

In the space of a heartbeat, Mai Minghe knew she could no longer hide it.

The only option was to keep playing along.

"...Jonah?"

A cold sweat had broken out across her back, and her face felt heavy. Mai Minghe had no idea whether she'd managed to pull off a "curious" expression—but she tried.

"The same Jonah you mentioned when you passed along the message?"

She pretended not to notice Taylor Ford's gaze, keeping her eyes on Jane Lynch. "The one whose life was in danger? What happened to him—he's not hurt, is he?"

Without waiting for either of them to answer, Mai Minghe made the sign of the cross in front of her.

"God bless him," she murmured. "It wasn't because I called too late, was it? God wouldn't blame me for that..."

Jane Lynch glanced at her superior; Taylor Ford furrowed his brow, waved a hand, muttered "she's religious," and at last moved his gaze away from Mai Minghe's face.

Mai Minghe quietly let out a breath of relief.

Of course she'd reacted to the name Jonah—that was perfectly normal, seeing as it was a name she herself had spoken aloud more than once...

So it seemed she'd managed to slip through for now.

"This doesn't concern you," Jane Lynch said to Mai Minghe first, then didn't continue in front of her. She picked up a pen and paper from the desk, quickly wrote something, and handed it to her superior.

The muscles in his face gave a visible twitch.

"Understood."

He rose abruptly from behind the desk, crumpled the note into a ball in one hand, and without sparing Mai Minghe another glance, strode toward the office door. As he left, he threw

back a single line: "I'll handle it. Get her out of here fast—out the back."

What had happened?

What Jane Lynch had come in to say hadn't only been meant as a test—something had truly gone wrong?

Mai Minghe was full of questions, but one thing became clear: because of this sudden development, the Morgan House Faction's attitude had shifted on a dime; she was free to go now.

Whatever the sudden development was, if she could leave, why would she hesitate even half a second?

She shot to her feet and immediately followed Jane Lynch out; they took an entirely different route than the one she'd come by, and she had no idea what was happening at the other end of the company floor.

Jane Lynch was preoccupied, and had not a single thought to spare for Mai Minghe—no matter what Mai Minghe asked, she answered only with "it doesn't concern you."

She led Mai Minghe through two quick turns across the sprawling office floor, then stopped, jutted her chin toward the corridor ahead, and said: "Take the stairs down from over there. Once you're down, have security let you out. Don't wander around—it's not safe. Get out quickly."

With that, she turned and hurried off, nearly breaking into a run.

In just moments, Mai Minghe was alone again.

The short corridor was perfectly quiet; the Morgan House Faction's offices were well-soundproofed, and straining her ears here, she couldn't make out what was happening up ahead.

All right—whatever was going on, she should get out of there fast.

There didn't seem to be a single soul nearby, only the sound of her own footsteps bouncing back and forth off the corridor walls—so when that voice dropped into the air, Mai Minghe gave a small start.

"Hey, big sis?"

Oh, that couldn't be for her; the last time someone called her "big sis," her parents had still been alive.

...Mai Minghe took another step forward before it occurred to her that "big sis" might in fact be meant for her.

She followed the sound and looked. At the far left end of the short corridor, a doorway opened into a bright, tidy break room. The break room was spacious, with a scattering of long tables, chairs, and sofas, and curled up softly on one of the sofas was a kid.

A teenager who looked at most seventeen or eighteen—wasn't that a kid?

The teenager seemed boneless, draped lazily over the sofa back, half his face buried in the crook of his arm.

One hand hung down at his side, a rolled cigarette nestled between his long fingers, thin white smoke curling around them like silk.

His eyelids were half-lowered, and when he spoke, his voice was light and drifting, like a white cloud high in the autumn sky, liable to scatter at the slightest snip. "...Big sis, are you good at chemistry?"

Mai Minghe paused. "What?"

"I don't like chemistry," the teenager said in that same cloud-soft voice, its edges tinged with a smile, languidly indistinct. "Help me look at my homework, will you?"

Sure enough, there were papers and a pen on the table. But this was hardly the moment to help anyone with homework—what kind of Hunter had such nerve, bringing a kid to the office?

"I'm in a hurry, I have to go. Sorry about that," said Mai Minghe, already moving away from the break room doorway.

A moment later, she turned back and poked her head in.

"Um... do you know where the stairs are?" Mai Minghe asked, a little sheepish, lowering her voice. "The person from this company just told me to take the stairs from around here..."

In the few minutes she'd been looking for the stairs, the teenager appeared not to have moved at all; only now did he slowly raise his head, revealing a face with a hazy, unfocused look; through the fog, his lips were red—moist and vivid, like a sunset reflected on still water.

Even having lived through a long lifetime, she rarely encountered a child this beautiful.

In that moment of distraction, Mai Minghe caught a faint yet heavy scent hanging in the room. She glanced at the cigarette in his hand and understood. "Wait—are you smoking—"

"What about it? It's not illegal." The teenager said it carelessly, taking a long drag. The white smoke curled out, hazy, as though blurring the edges of reality.

It was legal now?

The last time Mai Minghe had been in her twenties, hippie culture had been at its height, and she was long past being surprised by such things—yet she was surprised all the same.

But right now, what mattered was getting out of the Morgan House Faction's building.

"Well... I can show you to the stairs."

Seeming to sense her urgency, the teenager rose from the sofa and came toward her. It was as though his body were made only of smoke or cloud—he moved as silently as a cat. "I'm Taylor. What's your name?"

"...Mai Minghe."

Facing him, she felt there was no real need for a false name; real or fake, it was a name no one in this world would recognize either way.

The teenager's eyes were a waterlogged red; if not for the cigarette in his hand, Mai Minghe might have thought he'd been crying. Thinking of how she'd just refused to help him with his homework and yet he was still willing to show her the way, she felt a pang of guilt and said, "Thank you. Don't worry—I won't tell anyone."

"Oh? This?" The teenager seemed only then to remember the cigarette between his fingers. He glanced at it and gave her a smile. "It's fine. No one cares what I do."

This kid, when he grows up, is going to break so many girls' hearts, Mai Minghe thought to herself. The way he'd looked at that cigarette had inexplicably made her feel that even the cigarette had been worth coming into this world for.

"Let's go, then," she said, thinking of leaving as soon as possible. "I'm in a hurry."

"Why? Do you have a date?"

Was this how kids talked these days?

"Something's come up at home," Mai Minghe deflected. "Which direction are the stairs?"

The teenager tilted his head, eyes hazy, baring a small red mole on his neck. He looked at Mai Minghe for a few seconds, and she couldn't tell what he was thinking; just as she was growing

impatient, he smiled again all of a sudden. "Oh, I almost forgot. There's lots of food in the break room, and drinks too, you know?"

"How about you just point me to the stairs and I'll head over myself."

Mai Minghe knew there was no use getting impatient with someone in this state—they were always half a beat behind. "I really am in a hurry."

"Don't be so quick to ditch me," the teenager said with a laugh, and casually took hold of her wrist. "Come on, the stairs are over there—you went past them. You really don't want to look at my homework?"

"I really don't have time," said Mai Minghe.

"Everyone else says they don't have time either." The teenager pouted slightly. "Because Jonah just came back from the Nest with a Resident, and they ended up right here in the building."

Before Mai Minghe could process this—before she had a chance to stop herself—she had already jerked to a halt, her face flooding with shock.

Every mystery from before lit up at once, blindingly clear, solved.

A Resident had gotten in? No wonder Jane Lynch had been in such a panic, and no wonder they'd stopped letting her stay; with that thing in tow, Jonah had—

No. Wait.

This boy...

When she turned her head, she found the teenager looking at her with another soft smile.

Still that hazy, weightless smile—but watching him, Mai Minghe felt a prickling cold sweat rise along her spine.

Even time seemed to have been poured full of mercury, slowly suffocating in the space between them.

Perhaps he'd seen her in the Morgan House Faction's building and assumed she was a Hunter, which was why he'd spoken so freely...

"I'm sorry, big sis."

The teenager lowered his head, one hand still holding hers, the other raising the cigarette for a drag. "I'm someone who lies a lot. Girls tend not to like that about me."

Mai Minghe felt as though she were watching a car crash—powerless to stop it, able only to stare.

"Jonah hasn't come back," he said, as if to reassure her. "I haven't gone to the Nest yet. No one's brought him back, so how would a Resident end up in the building? Don't be afraid—there are no Residents here."

Mai Minghe thought she heard faint footsteps somewhere far beyond the bend in the corridor.

Were they coming for her?

"Big sis, you're not a vagrant at all. You put in a lot of effort to look like one... When you came in, I saw you, and I thought to myself: odds are there's nothing to get out of her."

His voice was indistinct and soft, barely above a murmur.

"So why not just tell us—that you're a Hunter?"

The teenager paused, then gave a quiet laugh.

"My guess is, either you're caught up in what happened to Jonah and afraid the Morgan House Faction will hold you accountable; or you're mixed up with whatever Jonah was chasing when he got into trouble, and afraid you'd be walking into a trap."

Mai Minghe had the strange sensation that the Serpent Band had already left her—she felt the pain of it pulling away, like skin being stripped off.

His fingers lay lightly around her wrist, as though they could be withdrawn at any moment.

But what then, after she pulled away?

In the Morgan House Faction's building, full of Hunters—where would she go? What could she do?

Mai Minghe's voice came out hoarse. "You're..."

"I didn't give you my real name just now. Please don't hold it against me."

The teenager's eyes remained half-lidded, his expression still dreamy and unawakened. "My last name is Ford... My name is Taylor Ford. Hunter Director of the Morgan House Faction."

Heh heh heh heh, heh heh heh heh heh, heh heh heh heh heh heh heh.

rubs hands So, how's everyone doing? Did you all have cake for Children's Day?

Why do I love writing beautiful characters so much? Because I am
the number-one looks-obsessed person of this century.

If the main characters aren't beautiful, writing them is just dull, because what I do is translate
the images in my head into words.

If the people in my head aren't good-looking, what's the point of writing them?

Anyway—beautiful people, regardless of gender, the moment they smile, I lose my soul.

Can you imagine what I'm like when I see Li Xiaoran and Zhang Yuqi?

That feeling—I suddenly understood King You of Zhou completely. King You of Zhou is
back on the job. I'm going to go light the signal fires right now. So what if the lords have to make a
few trips? Let the beauty smile!

Chapter 56 — Taylor Ford and the Morgan House Faction Contract

For most students, school was a place they would avoid whenever possible; for Taylor Ford, it was the closest thing he had to a vacation.

He still lounged lazily in his seat, long after everyone from the previous class had left.

He had no idea where his next classroom was, because he had no idea what his next class even was.

This winter had been unusually long. March was almost here, yet the trees outside — pale or pitch-dark against the sky — still stretched their bare branches into the grey overcast, each one dusted with a thin coat of snow.

He could sit here in perfect silence all morning, watching the desolate colors of the world outside. Even if the next class began, no one would come to hurry him along.

The whole school knew he was nothing more than a spectator on the shore, standing apart from rules, coursework, and ordinary life — that when the bell rang, it might shatter the reflection he'd cast into this still pool.

He was already in eleventh grade, yet he never thought about his GPA, and had never once looked at a single college brochure.

As for attending class — he could take it or leave it. His father had already had a word with the school: whenever Taylor felt like it, he could stand up and walk out, and no one would ask a single question.

Taylor had never asked exactly how that arrangement had been made, and had no interest in knowing.

Even completing enough credits to graduate was something he'd decided to do on a whim; if Taylor chose to stop coming to school altogether, his father would never object in the slightest — if anything, he would be all the more pleased.

How did he put it again?

Oh, right.

"The world has its favorites. Some people are born with gifts that ordinary people couldn't reach in a lifetime of effort," his father had told him more than once. "Tai Lan, you are exactly that kind of lucky soul — no, you are the best of the lucky ones. Your time and energy should be spent on things with the highest returns, so as not to waste your talents."

Taylor couldn't be bothered to sit through the rest of the day's classes, but as if in a kind of protest, he stayed at school through the entire day anyway.

He walked down the front steps with the crowd of students leaving school and, unsurprisingly, spotted that familiar SUV — and quietly sighed to himself.

"Tai Lan, is your dad picking you up again? Why does he worry about you so much?" A girl waved at him with a smile. "Bye — make sure you come to school tomorrow, okay?"

There weren't even three people in the entire school whose names Taylor could recall. But that didn't stop people from noticing him and striking up conversation; all he needed to do was be polite — nod, say "hi" or "bye" — and that was enough.

It wasn't that he was arrogant.

The more time you spent in the Nest, the more the outside world seemed thin and sparse when you returned — even its colors looked grey.

Especially right after coming back: people with no connection to the Nest barely registered any facial features to him, impossible to remember; whatever happened around him felt distant. It was almost wrong to call this place "reality," because everything felt weightless and scattered, without any solidity.

He sometimes thought that the center of gravity in his life was the Nest — and the Nest was a black hole.

Usually, after spending some time back in the outside world, the normal feeling would slowly return.

But even when the feeling came back, the mental habits he'd developed refused to change. Even when he could see colors again and recognize faces, none of it had anything to do with him.

Taylor walked around to the right side of the car, opened the rear door, and tossed in a limp, empty backpack.

"How was your day?" His father turned and smiled at him. "Did you have a good time at school?"

His father had a square, stern face — probably not bad-looking in his youth. But middle age had softened his jawline into a loose, drooping line, giving him an air of flabbiness and weakness, and at last his looks had caught up with his character.

It was a good thing Taylor didn't look much like his father.

"Drive," Taylor said as he got in, too lazy to answer him, tilting his chin toward the front. "Why do you keep coming to pick me up?"

Even before his father answered, he had already guessed.

"Today we got two new offers."

Han Ford drove and explained earnestly: "You haven't entered the Nest in almost half a year. At first I didn't understand why, but I think I get it now. The biggest House Factions in Blackmoor City don't just need talent — they're afraid of someone like you ending up with the competition. They're all fighting over you. Without you, they don't know what to do with themselves.

"The terms look pretty good to me now. How about it — want to pick one you like and take it? If you keep holding out, they might give up, and that would be a huge missed opportunity..."

Taylor pulled out a cigarette and clicked his lighter — snap; he leaned into the flame and drew a long drag.

His father considerably cracked a window, and the cool March air rushed in — he liked cold air, the colder the better.

Taylor waited until that soft, warm current smoothed out the creases in his mind and cleared away his thoughts, then asked, in a drifting, absent tone, "...Who is it this time? What's the contract?"

"One of them is a per-mission contract — Dad knows you like that kind, more freedom."

"Don't talk in half-sentences," Taylor said, his voice going low and soft, draining the words of their edge. "Keep it short. Be clear."

"Ahem, you really are impatient, kid. I read that contract carefully — the per-mission pay isn't bad, but outside the pay, there's nothing else. No cut from the Artifact, no coverage or death benefits — not that Dad thinks anything will happen to you, so that part doesn't matter — and as

for perks, subsidies, equity, don't even think about it. It's basically the same as hiring some ordinary solo operator Hunter."

Han Ford gave the steering wheel a light slap, visibly displeased. "Do they know who they're negotiating with? How rude."

Taylor smiled silently. "How much per trip into the Nest?"

Han Ford hesitated, then admitted it himself: "The price isn't terrible... five hundred thousand per trip."

"How many trips?"

"Four."

"Is there a time limit?"

"...No."

That was the crux of the matter.

A House Faction that contracted Taylor on a per-mission basis would never send him on tasks that an ordinary Hunter could handle.

Only when they received confirmed intelligence on a rare Artifact and lacked the confidence to retrieve it themselves would they deploy Taylor into the Nest — chances to pull chestnuts out of the fire like that were naturally few and far between.

His father understood perfectly: if Taylor took this four-mission contract, he would not enter the Nest even once more before it was fulfilled.

In other words, if the other House Faction took five years to use up all four opportunities, Taylor would bring in not a single yuan beyond two million in the next five years.

"Artifacts keep emerging, it's true — but truly rare, truly powerful ones are very few," said his father,

a man who had never once set foot in the Nest, now explaining the situation to him.

"While you're not going in, those Artifacts could be found and taken by other Hunters. Isn't that a waste of your talents? Letting people with less ability than you carry off the Artifacts — fine, they make the money — but it builds up their names, as if they could compete with you!"

Taylor extended the half-smoked cigarette forward; his father, mid-sentence, reached back to offer an ashtray.

He didn't take it — he just stubbed out the ember inside the ashtray, pressing down again and again so that Han Ford's hand dipped with each press.

"What about the other contract?"

"It's from Morgan House Faction," his father's face visibly brightened in the rearview mirror. "Their terms are truly impressive. Looking across all of Blackmoor City, I can say there has never been a Hunter who received an offer like this. As your agent, I'm actually proud to have negotiated these conditions..."

In truth, this kind of conversation was far from their first.

Taylor had long known where these conversations always ended up, and he found the back-and-forth tiresome — but he simply refused to let Han Ford get what he wanted without a fight. Even when he didn't actually mind entering the Nest, he would still say: "Not signing."

"You haven't even heard their terms—"

"House Factions aren't free."

This time, his father didn't rush to argue back. Instead, he smiled in a rather shrewd way.

"You're wrong — this contract is different. The position they're signing you for is Hunter Director. Aside from reporting to the board, all the House Faction Hunters answer to you. You have final say on how every mission is run. The so-called CEO who handles operations carries no weight in front of the Hunter Director. If that's not freedom, what is?"

He paused, then added: "You're still young. You don't understand yet. Only power brings freedom."

Every so often, his father would say something that gave Taylor pause.

"And you don't even know the annual salary they're offering."

The number his father named next made even Taylor blink — it was so outrageous that for a moment he thought he'd misheard.

"No, that's the right number,"

Han Ford said, in a tone that nearly lifted him out of the driver's seat: "And that's just the base salary — the most basic part. There are also all kinds of incentive structures, profit-sharing, equity, and other terms... After this ten-year contract ends, the two of us can retire!"

Taylor felt like a bucket of cold water had been dumped over him. "How many years?"

"I know — ten years sounds like a long time. But if you don't take this contract and just do ordinary work, ten years from now you could still be running into the Nest over and over."

At that, his father suddenly let out a long sigh.

"Do you think I can just watch my own child walk into that dangerous place again and again with any peace of mind? Every time you're in the Nest, I don't sleep a single night — the agony of it, I wish I could go in your place. Ten years, and then we're done for good. Your mother is gone. In this world, it's just the two of us, father and son. I don't want to be burying my child before I go."

Taylor sat in silence in the back seat for a moment.

"...Their terms are too good. It doesn't make sense."

After a long pause, he said quietly: "I don't have three heads and six arms, and I'm not a superhero. If it's just entering the Nest and finding Artifacts, there isn't a single Hunter in the world worth that price. Morgan House Faction must have other intentions."

"What else did they say — outside the contract?"

Han Ford had looked ready to argue back, but faltered at those last words.

"They did say one thing — if you're interested in accepting the contract, they'd want to speak with you privately, one-on-one. Whatever they'd be discussing would have to be kept confidential, of course... I didn't think much of it at the time. Why don't you go talk to them?"

Even with one's own father, there were certain matters involving Hunters that a House Faction would only disclose to Taylor directly.

Taylor thought it over.

"Set up a time with Carter Morgan," he told his father. "Whatever can't be put in the contract — have him say it to my face."

When the timelines of all four characters converge, that is when the main plot finally surfaces.

Chapter 57: What Taylor Ford and Wellesley Know

Carter Morgan was pushing fifty, his crown of brown curls thinning imperceptibly, yet still combed smooth and neat, coiling against his pink scalp.

Just as Taylor Ford had anticipated, his every move carried the easy unhurried air of a man who had long since turned privilege into habit—and he knew it himself: his standing was different.

Perhaps it was precisely that self-awareness that gave Carter's warmth and charm a slightly unanchored, slippery quality—as though that easy familiarity, when performed by him, fit a little too loosely and yet a little too well at the same time.

"I've heard a great deal about you," he said.

When he first laid eyes on Taylor Ford, he didn't falter the way most people did; rising to his feet, Carter wore only a measured look of appreciation: "I've long wanted to meet the finest Hunter in Blackmoor City today, and now that I have, I'd say the trip was worth it."

Taylor glanced at the extended hand, then lazily sank into the sofa before lifting his own hand toward the empty air between them.

"Say things like that and I'll start believing them. Last time I checked a mirror, I wasn't Superman."

Carter Morgan took no offense; he bent down to shake the half-raised hand and laughed instead: "To an ordinary man like me with no passage, you're close enough."

Taylor gave him a sidelong glance.

Carter was the second generation of the Morgan House Faction—unlike the founder before him, he had no passage.

But he had no desire for one either; he was perfectly content to exist in the human world as a director and major shareholder of a Hunter house faction—Taylor knew full well that behind all the polite words, whether the money flowing into Carter's pockets came from Hunters, financial analysts, or horse and dog racing made very little difference to Carter Morgan.

A passage was valued only because it could generate profit, like everything else in the world.

If you were born already sitting in the rentier class, who in their right mind would open a passage, enter the Nest, and hang their life by a thread in the dark and the blood?

"I've already seen the contract—Han Ford showed it to me."

Taylor curled his legs up on the sofa and said unhurriedly, "I told him the same thing: under normal circumstances, there isn't a Hunter alive worth the price you're offering. I'm curious—once you sign me, what exactly do you intend to use me for?"

"I love talking to someone who gets straight to the point."

Carter Morgan said this while pouring him a glass of whisky. "Your father told me you've already decided to sign, you just need a few things clarified first—is that right?"

At this stage, going back and forth over whether to sign seemed pointless anyway.

Even if he turned down the Morgan House Faction, Han Ford would just bring him the next one—the Roselyn family, the Martin family, the pig-cow-sheep-dog family—forget it, it was only ten years.

Ten years from now, at twenty-seven, he would never have to enter the Nest again.

Taylor looked at the clear amber liquor in his glass and felt a faint urge to laugh.

He was seventeen now, not yet the legal drinking age, yet no one would bat an eye at that, let alone have any opinion about what he smoked or what he did—simply because compared to the average seventeen-year-old, he was worth money.

Money was the unit by which everything was measured.

Even power—the kind that could buy freedom—when people possessed it, they would inevitably trade it for money. How much more so everything else in the world?

Taylor drained the glass in one go, then said: "Right."

Carter Morgan's expression brightened a little.

"Good, then we're on the same side." He took a sip of his drink, worked it slowly around his palate, and then said: "...What I'm about to tell you is known only to you, me, and Wellesley himself."

Taylor tilted his head—he hadn't expected to hear that name. "Wellesley? The one on the wealth rankings? What does he have to do with this?"

Carter turned toward the floor-to-ceiling windows of the high floor, taking in the unobstructed nightscape of Blackmoor City and the distant sea still faintly tinged with a deep crimson, and weighed his words for a moment before finally speaking.

"Wellesley has a piece of critical intelligence in his hands.

"He's kept every Hunter in Blackmoor City in the dark. As for me—I've only sensed that this intelligence exists, but I don't know what it actually contains."

"Then how do you know he has it?"

"A man with motives takes action."

Carter Morgan smiled, showing a row of closely set teeth. "It was precisely his movements growing more and more frequent lately that made me curious, so I looked into it a little...and that's how I arrived at this conclusion."

Taylor turned the words over in his mind and asked, "What did you find out?"

"You know that Wellesley himself has no passage, right?" Carter asked, catching him off guard.

Seeing Taylor nod, he continued: "He and I are the same kind of person—I know perfectly well that neither of us is cut out to be a Hunter. But I've heard that he recently plans to quietly put out an anonymous request into Hunter circles through a proxy—he wants a passage.

"The first time I heard about it, I was taken aback. Isn't a passage something you're born with? Either you have it or you don't. And on top of that, he doesn't want anyone to know that the one asking for a passage is him personally...I actually don't know how to make sense of it."

Carter shook his head and said, "But the fact that Wellesley conceived this idea at all perhaps suggests that acquiring a passage after birth isn't entirely impossible."

"What does he want a passage for?" Taylor asked.

Truthfully, whether the richest man in the city wanted a passage or not had nothing to do with him.

But when facing a future employer, he had to ask a question or two, just to show he was listening.

Carter smiled and said, "I don't know. That alone is strange enough—Wellesley entering the Nest would be walking into his own death, wouldn't it? But beyond that, there's something even

stranger."

Before responding, Taylor first reached into his pocket and pulled out a small plastic resealable bag.

He tapped the curled green leaf wrapped around crystal fragments out of the bag bit by bit onto rolling paper and said, "Don't mind me—I like the rolling process."

Carter nodded and smiled.

"When I was your age, I had to sneak around to smoke. Times were different back then—not like now, with weed shops on every corner. Getting it was a real hassle; you had to ask a friend to find someone, and after paying through the nose, you'd open it and find shredded newspaper mixed in."

Taylor laughed for the first time that day, feeling that Carter actually had something of an ordinary person's quality to him after all.

He lit the rolled cigarette, took a drag, and asked, "...What's the even stranger thing?"

Carter shifted his posture and said, "He recently placed a commission with the Morgan House Faction. Once you're on board, it'll be your job—there's no harm in telling you now in advance..."

"Wellesley has commissioned us to enter the Nest on the 13th of every month and search for an Artifact related to 'time' in St. Louis Hospital, Broom Street, and the area corresponding to Blackmoor University Law Department."

Taylor slowly raised his head and stared at Carter, as though his vision had only now finally come into focus.

"...That's impossible," he said quietly, then paused. "How does he know that?"

"Exactly."

Carter seemed actually pleased to have finally piqued his interest: "You're a Hunter—you know better than anyone that once you enter the Nest, where you go and what Artifacts you encounter is beyond human control or prediction."

"And yet Wellesley behaves as though he knows exactly when and where certain things will appear in the Nest, and he only needs a Hunter to follow the map and bring them back for him."

"He's not a Hunter himself—he once tried to build his own Hunter team, but it didn't go well, and eventually the whole thing fizzled out with nothing to show for it."

"So you've hit on exactly the right question: this intelligence of his—how did he come by it?"

Carter hadn't finished speaking.

"And the commission he placed with the Morgan House Faction isn't the only one. From what I know, he previously placed another commission with someone else as well...but I don't know specifically what that one was for. What on earth does he want these two things for?"

Taylor sat in silence for a moment, thinking.

The information Carter had provided was still very vague—enough only to let one glimpse a rough outline—but even that outline was sufficient to convince anyone that Wellesley truly knew something no one else did.

"Taking a logical approach, I can assume Wellesley has in his possession a certain...let's call it 'intelligence.' Having obtained this intelligence, he formed a goal.

"To achieve that goal, he needs a passage and at least two Artifacts. He has learned through some means when and where these two Artifacts will appear in the Nest...correct?"

"Looking at it that way, the crux of the matter is what a passage and those Artifacts could possibly give him—and that, for now, no one in the world knows except him."

"Talking with you is so easy," Carter said, refilling both their glasses.

"So what do you want me to do?"

"Why, satisfy Mr. Wellesley's wishes, of course," Carter said with a loud laugh.

Then he leaned his body forward and, looking Taylor Ford in the eyes, said slowly: "...And then get whatever his true objective really is into our hands."

This was not something that could be done without the most capable Hunter available.

That was what Carter said while patting him on the shoulder and singing his praises; but Taylor honestly didn't know whether he counted as a capable Hunter, let alone the "most" capable.

It was just that sometimes the world seemed to have been scripted and arranged by some unknowable force—and the role written for him was that of a "star Hunter."

For instance, right now: less than two months after Taylor Ford had taken over the Morgan House Faction's Hunter operations, he hadn't expected the next lead about Wellesley to come from

a finance employee with no passage—and he hadn't even been looking for one.

"Yes, it just happened. I came here with a friend for drinks..."

The finance employee was a young woman named Amber, who, upon meeting Taylor Ford for the first time, likewise couldn't help freezing for a moment. Even with the conversation already started, she seemed unable to believe it and asked again to confirm: "You...you're really the new Hunter Director our house faction just hired?"

"Why would I lie to you? I never lie to girls."

Taylor sat on the street outside the bar, tilted his head back, and smiled up at her. "Do you usually like to drink?"

"Not really," Amber said, still faintly flushed from the alcohol. "We were celebrating...my friend likes drinking even less than I do, so she came outside for some air partway through. In those few minutes, the last SUV in a motorcade suddenly lost control—it was almost like someone had shoved it—and plowed straight into the back door, nearly hitting my friend. Look, the door's still bent out of shape and won't close properly."

Taylor glanced over at the bar's back door.

By the time he arrived at the scene, the car had already been towed away; but judging from the marks left behind, the way it had lost control was indeed very unnatural.

"Who's your friend?"

"Oh, she's not a Hunter from our house faction—she goes into the Nest on her own, picking up small jobs. Her name is Sydney Ginn. She's still inside the bar right now, probably chatting with someone—she ran into a guy who seems to like her."

Women, regardless of age, always seemed unable to stop themselves from saying a few extra words when facing Taylor Ford—though he wasn't sure how useful it might be, he filed away the name "Sydney Ginn."

"The person who got out of the car was a bodyguard."

Amber recounted the motorcade's initial reaction and the details of the bodyguard one by one, then added: "I felt like I'd seen him somewhere before, and after a moment it came to me—he'd come to our company once before, as Wellesley's personal bodyguard."

When Wellesley placed the commission with the Morgan House Faction, he came in person—at the time, Taylor Ford had not yet taken over as Hunter Director, but she was already in the know.

Amber tucked her short hair behind her ear, revealing a pointed, slightly elfin ear.

"I recognized him, but he didn't recognize me—he never noticed me standing nearby watching the commotion. Later, one of his colleagues came to meet him, and I heard that colleague say with my own ears, 'The boss is going to pick something up.' Right then I thought, no wonder that motorcade was so heavily guarded—was Wellesley about to receive an Artifact? If so, maybe I should say something to Jane Lynch..."

Taylor Ford glanced at the time on her phone screen.

According to Amber, the crash had happened twenty minutes ago—fortunately she had a good relationship with Jane Lynch, and Jane Lynch's instincts happened to be sharp enough that she'd notified her in time.

There was still time...

The motorcade, having been given a scare not long ago, would need to verify whether the situation had truly changed; they shouldn't have been able to complete their original plan in such a short window.

"This matter... have you told your friend about it?"

Amber shook her head.

Taylor Ford rose quietly to her feet and gave a slight lift of her chin toward Jane Lynch, who was waiting nearby; she understood immediately, turned at once, and went to bring the car around.

"Sister Amber," he said lazily, giving Amber a smile, his voice low: "Do me a favor, will you?"

The very tips of Amber's ears turned red. "What favor?"

"Just head home tonight—give your friend a chance to chat more with that guy."

Taylor Ford said this, then tilted his head and thought for a moment.

"This matter is a little sensitive where the House Faction is concerned. If your friend asks, just tell her I'm the one who told you not to say anything... and that I came to you for details after you

got to work Monday, and only then told you not to tell anyone else. Say it that way—is that alright?"

Amber glanced toward the bar.

"Since you're the House Faction's Hunter Director, that makes this the House Faction's call... I understand." She nodded and added: "Sydney probably doesn't know yet that this motorcade has anything to do with Wellesley."

Ah, whenever I'm writing there's so much rambling I want to share, but by the time I actually post, I've forgotten it all...

Wait! One piece of rambling just came back to me.

Throughout the writing process, I've been racking my brain trying to keep the "realism" dialed all the way up. It's not that I'm padding the text—I just feel that if a world is too fantastical at every turn, money and banknotes lose their sense of weight...

But money is the main driving force of the Artifact-report world, which means I need to do my best to make everyone feel the magic of cash (as if that's something I even need to remind anyone of).

So here's the problem:

How does a broke person write about a life of extravagance?

I'm hoping we can crowdfund some life experiences for the author, so I don't end up writing a scene where some CEO points at the clothes on a rack and says, "Take down both of these rows for me."

Chapter 58: Taylor Ford Isn't the Only One Lying in Wait

Jane Lynch rested one hand on the steering wheel, and as Taylor Ford got into the car, she gave him a sidelong glance from the corner of her eye.

That faint trace of cool disdain vanished without a trace the moment she lowered her eyelids—she was a consummate professional, and even if she had her doubts and reservations, she wasn't about to let them show on her face in front of a new superior.

Jane Lynch simply leaned forward to peer at the road ahead and said, "Mr. Ford, there are no surveillance cameras in this area. With no cameras, how are we supposed to know which way they went?"

"Don't call me Mr. Ford. I'm not him."

Taylor Ford opened the map on his phone and replied, "Even if there were cameras, by the time we pulled the footage it'd already be too late—we were never counting on that anyway."

"Then may I call you Taylor?" Jane Lynch paused, and in the end couldn't hold back the barb, adding: "...and reserve 'Mr. Ford' for your father?"

An eleventh-grader who had swooped in and landed the Hunter Director position on the strength of a name alone—and on top of that, had come into the House Faction with a father in tow. Taylor Ford was young, not stupid; he knew perfectly well what people said behind his back.

"Call him whatever you like. It doesn't matter."

Every second passing was precious, yet Jane Lynch made no move to drive, instead dropping a question at his feet first: "So where are we going?"

Though not much time had passed since the incident, tracking down Wellesley to intercept the Artifact handoff was still an enormously thorny task—to say nothing else, the moment trouble had erupted, the motorcade had instantly scattered in all directions, precisely to prevent anyone from tailing them.

What's more, beyond knowing that "Wellesley had been on the road twenty minutes ago," they had zero other intelligence. Where would they even begin?

"We don't know his destination, we don't know who he's meeting or when..."

Jane Lynch listed the disadvantages one by one, stopping just short of saying outright that catching up with them was impossible. "I don't understand why we have to follow him to the Artifact pickup at all. If we're discovered, it could seriously offend him."

Carter Morgan's plan was naturally not something to be broadcast throughout the House Faction—what was remarkable was that Jane Lynch, without any knowledge of Carter's intentions, had still managed to tip Taylor Ford off about tonight's events in time.

She was a capable and sharp woman—no wonder she had risen to Hunter HR without being a Hunter herself; and no wonder she had been watching Taylor Ford with such cool scrutiny all along.

Taylor Ford looked at the map.

Jane Lynch wasn't wrong, really; by any ordinary means, there was simply no way to determine which direction Wellesley might have headed.

"Didn't you recently interview a Hunter who can detect Artifacts?" he asked, catching her off guard.

Jane Lynch startled and glanced at him.

"Yes—her name is Kingsley Roselyn. Her detection range is too wide and far too imprecise, so I met with her once but haven't made a decision yet."

"A wide range has its advantages," Taylor Ford closed the map and said. "Call her. Whatever conditions she asks for, it doesn't matter—have her come over right now."

Jane Lynch frowned and didn't move.

"Tay—that is, Taylor, we can't possibly drive her around street by street looking for Artifacts. Without knowing the destination, that's no different from searching for a needle in a haystack."

"Who said anything about going street by street?"

Taylor Ford didn't press her to make the call; instead he picked up his own phone and glanced at a text message that had just come in—it was from Carter Morgan.

"Finding out where Wellesley is— isn't that simple enough?"

"How?" Jane Lynch stared at him fixedly.

Taylor Ford had already pressed the phone to his ear; when the call connected, he flashed Jane Lynch a smile, gesturing for her to listen in.

"...Mr. Green?"

He reclined his seat, half-lying with his legs drawn up, and said into the phone: "This is Taylor Ford, Hunter Director of the Morgan House Faction. Mr. Morgan should have already given you a heads-up just now. Could you transfer me to your employer? I have an urgent situation that requires immediate communication with Mr. Wellesley."

Jane Lynch's eyes went wide—Taylor Ford had put the call on speaker.

"What situation?" The secretary, Green, on the other end of the line sounded somewhat hesitant, but notably did not say he wasn't with Wellesley.

"Tell him it's about 'time,'" Taylor Ford added: "It's urgent."

While waiting for Secretary Green to connect the call, the moment he muted the line, Jane Lynch immediately asked, "What are you planning? Is the approach you're talking about—"

"Exactly—if we don't know where he's going, why not just ask him?" Taylor Ford said, as though it were the most natural thing in the world.

Wellesley had no idea that Carter Morgan was quietly plotting to swoop in from behind.

Jane Lynch stared at him blankly. "That's...completely reckless, isn't it? What information do we even have about a 'time' Artifact?"

She was quite straightforward about it—but sometimes the truth wasn't the most convenient thing to say; making up some so-called urgent intelligence was entirely a matter of letting his imagination run wild, wasn't it?

Wellesley couldn't very well go into the Nest himself to verify it.

If Taylor Ford had any particular talent, he reckoned it was his ability to make something with no basis in reality sound extraordinarily convincing and detailed. Even Wellesley—who was at this very moment on his way to collect an Artifact—couldn't help but be stirred into hesitation after hearing him out: "...Right now? I'm on the road. It's not convenient."

"That's fine,"

Taylor Ford said, with impeccable consideration: "Why don't you give me a location, and I'll wait for you there. As long as Mr. Wellesley can make a brief stop on the way back—just five

minutes—that would be enough for us to confirm our next move."

That last half-sentence, at least, wasn't a lie.

Wellesley proved to be very cautious—even with a House Faction he was working with, he didn't let slip his current location; perhaps the earlier inexplicable attack on one of his escort vehicles had put him on high alert.

Yet even after being rattled once, he was still dead set on completing this transaction tonight—which said everything about how important that Artifact was.

"I'll have Green send you an address. Thirty minutes from now—"

Wellesley got that far before someone nearby seemed to murmur something in a low voice, prompting him to correct himself: "No. One to two hours from now, I'll be there."

Taylor Ford thought the person in the background had said something like "need to verify."

Verify what?

The only thing that would need verifying seemed to be the Artifact he was about to get his hands on.

In other words, he hadn't yet taken possession of the Artifact, so he needed to leave time for the verification—and the time required to verify it would very likely end up being much longer than Wellesley had initially estimated.

Once they had an address, the rest wouldn't be hard.

"With this address as the center and a thirty-minute driving radius, dispatch a helicopter immediately to sweep a few circles around the area—look for his security motorcade, look for heavy security presence. We'll drive over as well."

Taylor Ford's instructions this time were swiftly carried out by Jane Lynch—even though she still had no clear idea why the Hunter Director wanted to tail a client.

"And what about Kingsley Roselyn?" After dispatching the helicopter, Jane Lynch this time proactively picked up her phone and asked, "I'll call her now. How should we arrange things with her?"

"She's only a backup. Just have her come."

As Taylor Ford said this, he had not yet foreseen that he was making a mistake. "Even if we don't need her tonight, the House Faction will need someone like her going forward."

Jane Lynch quickly got through to the call and relayed Taylor Ford's instructions precisely, even taking the trouble to add, "It's our House Faction's Hunter Director—he thinks very highly of you"—as the saying goes, flattery never wears thin.

"Mm? Yes, the terms you named—we can meet all of them...right. We can double it."

At that, Jane Lynch stressed: "But our requirement is that you get here within thirty minutes. There's a situation, and we may need you."

Through the car's speaker, the voice of Kingsley Roselyn—seemingly always cheerful—rang out. "What's the address?"

Jane Lynch glanced at Taylor Ford; he thought for a moment, then nodded.

She gave the location, and two seconds of silence followed before Kingsley spoke up. "Ah, sorry—I can't make it over there."

Jane Lynch immediately frowned—she leaned hard on the horn at the car ahead before turning back to the phone. "Where are you right now? I can send a helicopter to pick you up."

"Ah, I'm sorry, I really can't get away right now," Kingsley paused, sounding actually regretful. "...Does my coming on board have to be tied to tonight specifically?"

Before Jane Lynch could respond, Taylor Ford pressed a hand on her arm.

She turned her head; Taylor Ford shook his and mouthed silently: "Hang up."

"What is it?" Jane Lynch quickly ended the call and asked.

Any Hunter who had survived the Nest had to possess the ability to pick up warnings and hints from the faintest of clues—an ability that, starting from deliberate analysis, had long since been distilled into something closer to instinct; the more skilled the Hunter, the less likely they were to ignore even the slightest hair-thin sense of something being off.

"Someone's with her." Taylor Ford spoke with near certainty.

Jane Lynch paused. "...How do you know?"

That was hard to explain.

A feeling is something elusive and vague—like mist, it scatters the moment you reach for it, and it's difficult to pin down in words and then analyze strand by strand.

It might have been that Kingsley had paused both times before answering; it might have been that she hesitated for a moment instead of stating her location.

It could also have been that Taylor Ford had caught the faint rustle of her collar as she turned her head—as if she were looking at someone—and all such phantom-like clues might have been seized unconsciously, yet the moment he tried to surface them and articulate them, they seemed almost too tenuous to hold.

"...Because I'm very good at lying," he finally offered as his answer. "So I could tell she wasn't telling the truth either."

Whether that persuaded Jane Lynch, he didn't know; but she accepted the explanation for the time being.

"So what do we do next...?"

"Don't worry—keep going."

Taylor Ford still lounged in his seat like a large cat, his voice unhurried and drifting: "Having someone else there doesn't necessarily mean anything. Never mind people in our line of work—anyone living in this world never knows what might be unfolding out there in the wide world, or what might come knocking at the door and turn their life upside down. But it doesn't matter. Deal with soldiers when soldiers come, dam the water when water flows."

Jane Lynch was quiet for a moment, then gave a wry smile. "You...really don't seem like someone your age."

"Is that so?"

Taylor Ford raised his head and smiled at her profile. "They say the brain doesn't fully develop until you're twenty-five—maybe I'm still an idiot right now. Do you want to see what I'm like at twenty-five? If you do, you can't quit on me."

In the nearly two months since she had started, it was the first time he had seen Jane Lynch laugh from the heart.

"You know," she said, eyes on the road as she drove, "I have a passage too."

"Oh?"

Jane Lynch spoke in the easy tone of friends chatting: "But I'm different from you. I took one look at the Nest, and I knew—I couldn't be a Hunter. I feared the Nest, I despised it, and I had no confidence I'd make it back alive the next time. That's why I chose to only work within Blackmoor City.

"...This world is truly strange." She mused: "Something like a passage doesn't necessarily go to someone who matches it."

Taylor Ford couldn't help but think of Wellesley—and the offer he hadn't yet put out, the bounty he'd been considering posting for passages.

Whatever Carter Morgan's plans were, Wellesley remained Morgan House Faction's most important client—and in Blackmoor City, he was the last person anyone should think of provoking.

Even if he located Wellesley, it didn't mean Taylor Ford could move against the deal or cut in on it—the timing was far from right.

But simply finding out what he had purchased, and what that item was for, was not an impossible task.

Getting the answer didn't even require disturbing Wellesley himself.

After all, in any deal, there are two people who know.

"Found him,"

the helicopter pilot's reply reached Taylor Ford's earpiece a little over ten minutes later—fast enough to catch him off guard. "Where Wellesley went is a private dock where his cruise ship is moored."

If not for the fact that tonight's deal had leaked in a way that seemed almost as though someone had given it a push, this meeting spot was actually quite safe and convenient—he'd nearly forgotten: billionaires live in a world of their own.

"No need to follow," Taylor Ford glanced at the time on his phone and said, "His meeting spot should be on the cruise ship. Station a few people on the road outside the dock and see who goes in after him—give me the license plates and vehicle types."

Barring any surprises, the other party to the deal should be the first to leave the cruise ship a little while from now.

That meant that as long as Taylor Ford lay in wait outside the dock, he would be able to see the Hunter who left after completing the deal with Wellesley—and once he confirmed the other party's identity, he could get there ahead of them, to the location Wellesley had arranged, and keep spinning stories for the billionaire to enjoy.

Taylor Ford stepped out of the car, pulled up the hood of his hoodie, the shadow falling across half his face.

He sat on the hood of the engine, gazing across the water at the rolling skyline and city lights of Blackmoor City on the other shore, wisps of white smoke curling from between his fingers and dissolving into the night.

Now it was just a matter of waiting.

But Taylor Ford hadn't expected that the first person to appear would not be the one he was anticipating.

When another black Mercedes slowly pulled to a stop in the middle of the road alongside him, Taylor Ford only turned to glance over—he hadn't even had time to make out the person who had just pushed open the car door—yet something like a physiological instinct of revulsion, like an electric current, made his eyebrow twitch.

A tall figure in a suit straightened up outside the car door and slammed it shut with a bang.

Chase Monroe stood in the darkness, gazing toward the distant dock, not sparing Taylor Ford so much as a glance, and quietly cracked a smile.

Today's chapter went up pretty early, right! That's because I was hunched over writing until midnight last night. I have no idea how people manage daily updates of over ten thousand characters—four thousand is already killing me...

Yesterday's author's note got me some subway fare and milk tea money, and I'm planning to save it all up into an "Artifact Report Field Research Fund," so that by the time the story wraps up, I can actually go out and gather some inspiration (not really).

Chapter 59 — Taylor Ford's Stakeout for Two

Taylor Ford was still sitting on the car hood. He glanced at the newcomer, turned his head back, and didn't get down.

"...Don't tell me the people on that boat are yours?"

"Don't say stupid things."

Chase Monroe seemed entirely unbothered by the fact that his car was parked in the middle of the road—though the stretch leading to the private dock ahead had little traffic to speak of, let alone at this hour of the night. Taylor Ford's fleeting hope that a patrol car might happen to pass and ticket him quietly died.

"If we were the ones dealing with Wellesley, do you think I'd let you sit here?"

"Then where would you have me sit? In Ronan Key's chair?"

Taylor Ford shot back with his mouth, but inside he couldn't stop the irritation gnawing at him.

...How on earth did he know?

Wellesley's deal tonight had been kept from the entirety of Blackmoor City.

Taylor Ford himself had only learned of it less than an hour ago through a piece of intel that had fallen into his hands by accident, and had improvised his moves step by step on the fly—he had barely arrived here himself. So where had this man caught the scent, that he came tracking along like a hyena?

He very much wanted to know. But he wanted even less to ask.

He kept his face stiff and sat in silence for a moment before letting out a cold laugh. "...So it was Kingsley Roselyn. Someone was actually willing to board that sinking ship of yours? She'd better not think about switching sides later."

"Oh? Figured that out yourself?" Chase asked. "No tutoring needed?"

There was still one piece he hadn't worked out—such as how, even if Kingsley Roselyn knew their location, Chase would know that Wellesley was dealing with a third party—but no matter what, Taylor Ford could not bring himself to ask.

Anyway, that man was the type to clamp down the moment he got even a single clue and never let go. He'd gone into the wrong line of work entirely—he should've been a snapping turtle.

Taylor Ford only asked one thing: "Still happy being a godfather's dog?"

Chase didn't take the bait. He smiled, a flash of white teeth in the dark.

"Happier than having a dog for a real father."

"...Hunter business has nothing to do with you. You don't understand it. Go home."

"That won't do. Someone has to be the adult when you make a mess of things." Chase fixed him with a look, then dropped his gaze with a small laugh. "...You're used to that by now, aren't you."

Taylor Ford had never paid any attention to the color of Chase's eyes—but right now, in the darkness, Chase's eyes looked like a pair of obsidian stones reflecting a hard sheen, sunk deep beneath his brow, as if swallowing the surrounding night whole.

Compared to humans, he sometimes seemed closer to a Resident—clearly Chase standing in Blackmoor City, yet appearing to cast a long Resident's shadow on the ground.

Perhaps it was that feeling lodged in his chest that made Taylor Ford notice his own body gradually tensing as Chase walked toward him, step by step.

Without consciously deciding to, he had almost imperceptibly shifted his angle, angling as much of his front toward Chase as possible, every muscle coiled and ready to spring at the first touch.

Jane Lynch was behind him on the road, managing personnel deployment and surveillance. He was the only one here.

If a confrontation broke out with Chase here...

"Relax. If I wanted to move on you, your guard wouldn't help." Chase tipped his chin toward Taylor Ford's hands. "Just need a light."

"No light."

Taylor Ford cursed under his breath and looked at the burning paper roll in his hand—go rub two sticks together if you're so determined. "You should get out of here."

"Oh?"

"The person dealing with Wellesley hasn't come off the boat yet,"

Taylor Ford flung the paper roll to the ground. It was, in every sense, a violation of his youthful temperament—he had spent every last reserve of patience he possessed to say: "Your car is sitting in the middle of the road, sticking out like the Loch Ness Monster. What do you need a light for—to send them a flare so they know to stay on board?"

Most Hunters in Blackmoor City knew trouble was coming if they were driving at midnight and their headlights suddenly picked out a Chase standing in the road ahead.

"Worried I'll ruin your plans?" Chase turned to look toward the road leading to the dock. "I'm a very reasonable person."

Taylor Ford swallowed back a retort.

"If I knew what plans I might be ruining, I certainly wouldn't still be standing in the middle of the road."

...As much as he was loath to admit it, Chase Monroe had no passage, yet had risen to his current standing in the Hunter world—not entirely because he was willing to be a foster father's dog.

As Carter Morgan had said, "Where there is desire, there is action"; and once a person acts, they leave traces.

Chase had used every last bit of that snapping-turtle talent of his to catch a scent from the Morgan House Faction's movements tonight that was different from their usual pattern—in other words, his target was not only Wellesley's trading partner, but also the intentions and plans of the Morgan House Faction itself.

Thinking further, he might even have had his eye on the Morgan House Faction for some time now.

He truly would have made a good Hunter.

Which was exactly why he could never have a passage.

"This has nothing to do with the Key House Faction."

Taylor Ford's expression went cold. "Someone's been poaching Morgan House Faction business. We're cleaning up the garbage—it's an internal matter. Think carefully: does the Key House Faction really want to stick its hand in tonight?"

"Nonsense."

Chase looked out toward the distant dock. "When you first saw me just now, didn't you ask whether the people on the boat were from the Key House Faction? That means you don't know who's on the boat either."

There was no way Taylor Ford would be caught on such an obvious slip.

"Is this your first day out here? If someone dares to cross us, there's backing behind them. The moment I followed this lead, you showed up right here." He let out a cold laugh. "Nothing is ever that much of a coincidence. Of course I had to ask."

Chase looked at Taylor Ford with a blank expression—as if even he was now a little uncertain.

"That's a fair point."

Yet Chase thought for a moment, and his next words were: "Too bad—even if you told me you were human, I'd need to see the autopsy report before I believed it."

Taylor Ford immediately jumped down from the hood, walked around Chase, and yanked the driver's door open.

"Then stand there all you like," he said. "I'll see what you manage to accomplish."

The car door slammed shut with a bang, cutting off whatever Chase's response might have been.

Though Chase was now an added variable, tonight's situation remained under the Morgan House Faction's control.

First, with Taylor Ford watching from the side, Chase wouldn't be able to take the trading partner away.

Second, even if the trading partner spotted Chase and turned back, the Hunters and helicopter Taylor Ford had deployed nearby could continue to trail him and identify who he was—more complications, but it would also draw things away from the dock, making it less likely to alert Wellesley.

Even if Wellesley grew suspicious later, everything could be pinned on the Key House Faction...even the trading partner himself would assume it was the Key House Faction chasing him.

So from another angle, Chase's appearance was actually a good thing: he had become the Morgan House Faction's camouflage.

That said, asking a seventeen-year-old to swallow that suffocating frustration quietly was still asking a great deal of Taylor Ford.

He looked out through the half-lowered car window.

Chase had walked back to the middle of the road. His tall silhouette was leaning against the hood of the black Mercedes, arms folded, seemingly resolved to turn the whole night into a scrambled deck of cards.

Whatever he planned to do next, right now both of them could only wait.

The night settled back into silence, the distant lights on the sea glimmering far away.

After a while, Taylor Ford reached instinctively for his trouser pocket, then remembered—the last paper roll, he'd thrown it on the ground just now.

He hesitated, which was rare for him: going out to pick it up felt somewhat like losing face.

But not going—sitting stiffly in the car without moving a muscle, not even able to check his phone—felt actually unbearable. However you looked at it, he was still seventeen. Even knowing that in a short while things would probably come to a head, boredom in the present moment was still boredom.

Taylor Ford leaned forward and peered out the window again.

Did that mean middle-aged people didn't get bored?

If Chase didn't move soon, he was about to wonder whether the man had fallen asleep—and at precisely that moment, Chase stood up, circled to the side of the car, and bent down to reach a hand through the window.

When he straightened back up, he had in his hand what looked like a heavy rod with a T-shaped top. At the same moment, music started playing from inside the black Mercedes.

Chase smiled silently at Taylor Ford—like a wound torn open through the dim nothingness.

Swinging the T-bar loosely in one hand, he walked step by step back to the car hood, treading on the singing voice that spread through the night like mist, and leaned against it once more.

The night paused—then a gust slammed through like a highway wind, hard enough to feel like it could stir someone's bangs.

I've been dreamin' about the West Coast

Where the people take it real slow

Chase's silhouette remained motionless as ever, like a frozen statue—only if you looked carefully would you notice the tip of his shoe tapping along, ever so slightly, in quiet agreement with the beat.

Taylor Ford held back, then didn't—a short huff of laughter escaped through his nose, half mockery, half amusement.

If even the middle-aged were listening to music, what was the harm in picking up a paper roll?

Taylor Ford pushed the car door open and put one foot on the road—and at that exact moment, a car came around the bend ahead, its headlights cutting sharply through the dark.

...Here they come?

Taylor Ford swept a hand across the car roof and grabbed the length of chain he'd placed there earlier. He didn't turn his head—just heard a dull thud, and out of the corner of his eye the tall silhouette leaped up onto a car hood.

The incoming car had barely finished rounding the bend when it lurched violently off to the side as if startled. Amid a piercing shriek of tires that seemed to scrape sparks from the dark, the car veered wildly off the road in a panic—Taylor Ford's mind had just flashed "could it have seen Chase?" when he immediately realized something was wrong.

Too far away—the driver shouldn't have been able to make out Chase clearly, and wouldn't have been frightened enough to bolt like that.

They must have spotted something else—

The thought hadn't finished forming when, from a squat, dark building by the roadside, a deafening cannon-blast tore through it, the night caved in, and a ball of fire bloomed.

The next second, the car was flung into the sky like a toy hurled by a child's hand, riding the fireball and the shockwave high up into the dark above.

All I wanna do is fly

Take me where the sun shines

Sleep has been rough lately—staying up past midnight every night, it's been rough...

I think I finally understand why I write so slowly. I'm just an amateur web novel hobbyist, but somewhere along the way I got the delusion that I'm a film director—I'll be writing along and then absolutely have to pick a background track, spend half an hour scrolling through playlists, finally decide "West Coast" is perfect, and it has to go in the chapter.

The lyrics fit perfectly, there's something nicely ironic about them, and they suit Chase's background. The tempo is a touch fast, but it works—this scene isn't long, just a few shots (lol).

Went to the gym yesterday and saw a familiar-looking ridiculously handsome guy. I barely came up to his shoulder—he must have been at least 2.1 meters? I couldn't help sneaking a few extra glances, got caught, and it was mortifying. I immediately told myself: anyone that good-looking is definitely gay, and just like that my heart was calm, my expression serene, and all the awkwardness was gone.

What's wrong with a girl checking out a fellow cutie, honestly.

Chapter 60: Taylor Ford, This Matter, and Its Connection to Key House Faction

...Should it be said that he was shocked just then?

Yes, startled he certainly was—the person who should by now have fallen into his hands had suddenly gone airborne, car and all, launched high into the sky. Anyone would have been startled.

But Taylor Ford found that alongside his shock, there was also a kind of calm that felt almost unsurprised: the jolt surged up and then crashed back down together with the distant car, and once it had, everything was simply fact.

Because when he thought about it carefully, this was almost destined to happen, wasn't it?

He just hadn't expected it to happen so fast, so violently, so recklessly.

As though whoever had made the decision to kill understood perfectly well that the laws and rules governing Blackmoor City were not meant for him—and he had no intention of letting them constrain him.

The weapon that had flipped the car was something Taylor Ford had witnessed before with his own eyes.

A single kiss from a bazooka rocket launcher, and the car exploded on the spot—like a steel firework blooming in midair; the flames fed on the spilled gasoline, burning half the road a lurid red. After a hit like that, no one inside could have survived. It was already too late.

The person who had fired the rocket from inside the building—limited by the angle of the road and the resulting blind spots—likely hadn't spotted the two cars further back on the street just now.

So the most important thing right now was to evacuate the scene immediately...

He had only just thought that far when, from the small building beneath the night sky, a rapid succession of shots rang out—bang, bang, bang—far sharper and cleaner than the bazooka had been, seemingly from a rifle.

Strange—

In that instant, Taylor Ford suddenly understood.

The moment he spun around and bolted off the road, a dark figure came charging up from behind him at the same time.

"...Is it Wellesley?"

In the blink of an eye, Chase had already closed the gap and was running at his side—despite having been half a block further away just moments ago—and his breathing, by the sound of it, was still completely unhurried.

So this one had figured it out too, Taylor Ford cursed inwardly. A bastard through and through.

A direct hit from a bazooka would turn the car and driver alike into smoldering wreckage—not even the gods could escape that. Yet the sniper had still switched to a rifle and fired several rounds into the darkness, and there was only one explanation for that.

Someone had jumped from the car before the bazooka hit.

Which meant that if he got there right now, he might still find someone alive—or at the very least, a clue to identify the dead—but running toward where the car had crashed and burned also meant running straight into the sniper's scope.

To be safe in case the sniper hadn't yet left, the two of them wordlessly agreed to close the distance crouching low, weaving through whatever cover they could find among the nearby walls, warehouses, and other man-made structures.

Taylor Ford considered his own skills respectable, but Chase's were nearly inhuman—to keep Chase from reaching the spot ahead of him, Taylor Ford had to squeeze out the breath to speak as he ran: "...If it's not him, does that mean it's you?"

"Interesting," Chase returned, nothing more.

He dropped low and waited two seconds behind a short wall; when the small building across the road remained silent, he suddenly sprang up and lunged forward.

Taylor Ford was shorter, with a smaller stride, but running slower had its advantage: as long as he followed in Chase's wake and mirrored his path, he could stay out of the sniper's line of sight across the road. A minute or two later, the two of them arrived one behind the other at the stretch of road burning fiercely ahead.

The night flickered with uneven light; the buildings around the docks were dragged into dim visibility by the firelight one moment and pushed back into darkness the next, as though taking turns watching the spectacle.

Even the air was warped by the heat. Taylor Ford stood behind cover and swept his gaze again and again across the shifting light and shadows, until at last, in the darkness cast by a stretch of eaves, he spotted a pair of legs lying completely limp and motionless. He had barely leapt toward them when he saw Chase lunge forward at the exact same moment.

The person lay face-up on the ground, covered in blood, impossible to tell where exactly the bullets had hit.

One look was really all it took to see that he didn't have much time left, that there was no saving him: his eyes were welling with tears, his mouth half-open, and as the shadows of the two men fell across his face, his throat produced a wet, gurgling sound—blood and air bubbles churning together.

"You just made a deal with Wellesley, didn't you?" Taylor Ford crouched beside the man and said quietly, "The ambulance is on its way. Hold on and answer me."

Chase lifted his eyes and looked at him.

Taylor Ford leaned closer and called to the injured man again: "Hey, listen to my voice—don't close your eyes. Did you just make a deal with Wellesley?"

The man seemed to be barely held to the world by the sound of a voice; from between his half-parted lips, a breath escaped, and it sounded like it could be a single word: "Yeah..."

"What did you sell him?"

Even with Chase right there listening, he had to get this information into his own hands—because the Hunter dying before him was likely the only person in Blackmoor City, apart from Wellesley himself, who knew what had been exchanged tonight.

It wasn't the first time Wellesley had done business with a Hunter, but it was the first time he had killed to silence one afterward.

What Artifact could have driven him to move against a Hunter?

Wellesley had also filed a commission with Morgan House Faction, but he couldn't possibly silence one of Blackmoor City's largest House Factions after the fact—the fallout from that would

be enormous, tantamount to a localized war.

That meant the Artifact traded tonight had one fundamental difference from every other Artifact that had ever been traded or was about to be traded. What was it?

Why was Wellesley unafraid of people knowing he possessed other Artifacts, yet unwilling to let anyone know he possessed this one?

The dying Hunter's mind seemed to have already scattered. Taylor Ford had no way of knowing whether the man had understood him at all.

His eyes, unmoving, rested on Chase's face; from deep within a throat full of blood, he murmured: "Key... Key House..."

Taylor Ford jolted, and immediately shot a glance at Chase.

Unexpectedly, Chase's expression looked as though he had just been slapped—caught completely off guard, he instinctively asked: "What?"

That momentary blankness left Taylor Ford equally stunned.

Chase looked even more astonished than he was, as though he had never anticipated the words "Key House" emerging from the mouth of a dying Hunter.

The world truly was strange—always twisting and turning, one thing threading into another. Originally, Taylor Ford had thought Chase's appearance here tonight was an infuriating complication; if he could turn back time, he would never have made that call to Kingsley Roselyn.

But right now, at this very moment, it was precisely because Chase was here in person that Taylor Ford had caught his first unguarded, unmasked reaction—and turned it into a crucial clue.

"Key... Key House..."

The dying Hunter seemed only to want to release that last word from his chest back into the world; he could not hear their surprise, and had no strength left to explain.

But how could this have anything to do with Key House Faction?

If it did, why was even Chase unaware?

Wait—Key—

Taylor Ford's heart suddenly lurched, and his mind went blazingly clear in an instant. He immediately bit down hard on his lip and dropped his gaze to the dying man on the ground,

careful not to let Chase read anything in his face.

He understood now what the man meant.

What he had said was not "Key House" (Keys), but "key" (key).

It was only because he was at death's door, blood flooding his airway, that his voice had come out slurred and rasping—the two sounded almost indistinguishable.

If Taylor Ford hadn't already known in his own mind that Key House Faction had no business being part of this, he might have been misled as well.

But Chase had not caught onto this—not yet.

As the saying goes, the anxious mind stumbles—he was embedded in Key House Faction, and when he suddenly heard its name spoken by a dying man, it was obvious his thoughts had been led off in the wrong direction. He was pressing forward: "What about Key House? What does it have to do with your deal?"

But the Hunter gave no further answer.

He stared wide-eyed, unseeing of the two men before him, as though he had already looked past them and was gazing into a vast and infinite sky.

Taylor Ford stood up.

He had lingered here long enough. Wellesley's people would be arriving soon to clean up, and he needed to leave this trouble spot as quickly as possible.

But before he left, there was one more thing he had to do: he couldn't let Chase keep thinking, couldn't let him have the chance to work it out.

Because once the answer was unraveled, it was actually quite simple—the only thing he could rely on was a misunderstanding.

So Taylor Ford needed to distract Chase, and at the same time drive that misunderstanding firmly into his mind, so that it would cloud his judgment and take root as a first impression—that way, even if Chase eventually figured it out later, he would already have the advantage.

"Just as I thought... I always knew tonight's business couldn't be untangled from your Key House Faction. What are you surprised about? Don't tell me even you didn't know what was going on behind the scenes? Well, fair enough—after all, you're not his biological son."

He knew he was walking a tightrope right now.

The best way to lower someone's intelligence was to infuriate them. But the person in question was someone who had every physical advantage over him—height, speed, strength...

Taylor Ford tightened his grip on the iron chain in his hand and smiled. "When I keep a dog, I don't go reporting family matters to it either."

From within the blazing red night, Chase's shadow slowly rose, cutting off the wall of fire behind him.

Chase turned his face, and his gaze settled on Taylor Ford.

That gaze had texture—like silt, like a dry and hollow wind, like something filtering through from an old black-and-white photograph, drained of life; it seemed as though neither the one looking nor the one being looked at belonged to this world.

The moment Taylor Ford knew he had successfully enraged Chase, something like a savage beast tore a chunk from his left chest—for an instant, he lost all sensation there, as though a black void had opened just beside his heart.

Had a piece of flesh been ripped away?

The thought flickered through him, but he didn't dare look down, because Chase would never give him the chance to raise his head again.

If Taylor Ford hadn't managed to twist sideways just in time, the place now screaming with pain so sharp it had gone nearly numb—that black void with the cold air pouring through—would have been his heart.

"Han Ford ought to spend less time selling you out and more time teaching you some manners."

Only then did Taylor Ford see clearly: what had just struck him in the chest was the T-bar, which had somehow found its way back into Chase's hand and was hanging loosely at his side.

He should have brought a gun tonight—

Taylor Ford leapt sideways, swinging the iron chain at Chase's midsection in a wide sweep, the links ringing loudly through the air like a rigid, bone-hard whip. Chase neither dodged nor sidestepped; instead he dropped slightly forward, raised his arm to block, and when the chain

landed with a heavy crack across his back and arm, he seized it and twisted his hand back—the chain coiled around him loop by loop, like an obedient snake.

This was bad.

The words had barely formed when Taylor Ford, before he could even let go of the chain, was yanked sideways by Chase and lifted clean off the ground.

"No decent weapon tonight?"

Chase grabbed him by the chest, slammed him to the ground, and looked down at Taylor Ford with a grin splitting his face. "Don't worry—when you're dead, I'll send your dad a little condolence money."

Taylor Ford had hit the back of his head hard on the ground and was seeing stars, but he still managed to prop himself up on his knuckles and swing a fist at Chase's eye; before it could connect, Chase caught him and heaved, tossing Taylor Ford like he was shaking out a folded blanket.

Taylor Ford tumbled out several steps; when he pushed his arms down to get up, his hands met something wet and soft. He looked back and found he had braced himself on top of the corpse.

The moment he realized he shouldn't have looked back, he also understood clearly that unless he rolled over a corpse, there was no avoiding the blow now sweeping in from behind his head.

Taylor Ford's judgment was timely—by the time he was gasping and pushing himself up from the ground, he was soaked in the dead man's blood, but at least none of it was his own; the back of his skull was still intact.

From the distant sky came a vast roar that twisted and coiled through the night, and within a few breaths it had closed in from afar, bearing down over the two of them; sand and gravel flew, and the wind churned wildly.

"When it comes to brute force, I can't match you,"

He kept his eyes on Chase, who stepped over the corpse in a single stride, and smiled as he backed away slowly: "...which is perfectly normal—how could a man possibly beat a gorilla? But look, you don't have time to kill me tonight."

The bright column of light beaming down from the helicopter swept back and forth over the two of them several times; the fuselage door slid open, and someone shouted something indistinct downward through the deafening roar of the rotors.

There was no need to make out exactly what was said, and no need to look at the gun leveled in that person's hands—the tone and sharpness alone were enough to convey the warning. Chase glanced back at the helicopter, then raised one hand and gathered his wind-tossed black hair back behind his head.

"Calling in the adults to take you home already?" he said, almost calmly. "Go on. Next time you head out, don't forget to bring a babysitter."

Chase didn't seem at all worried that whoever was in the helicopter would shoot him in the back as he turned and walked away—though Taylor Ford truly could not suppress the temptation to do exactly that.

But in the end he still didn't give Jane Lynch the order: too many unexpected turns had already occurred tonight, and Wellesley must have spotted this helicopter as well—he couldn't afford to stir up any more trouble.

"I heard the sound of a shell and knew something had gone wrong. Thankfully I didn't arrive too late."

Jane Lynch slid the helicopter door shut again, and as they gained altitude and left the scene, she watched Taylor Ford and asked, "What happened? Are you hurt?"

"Jane, I'm in so much pain I could die."

Taylor Ford pointed at his own chest, his face creased with misery, and said, "Got hit with a rod, smacked my head on the ground, and rolled around in a pile of blood. Still, it's not all bad news."

As he spoke, he pulled a blood-soaked wallet from the pocket of his hoodie.

"Look—that guy who was making deals with Wellesley was pretty thoughtful. He left a wallet on him, just for me."